How to Quit You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/20775374.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Various Others (all minor/background)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Western, Western, Past Relationship(s), Past Violence, Technically Fit in the Romantic Comedy Cliche of Exs, Glitra Week 2019, no editing we die like meh, Fluff, Drama, Drama & Romance, Blood and Violence, Angst, Eventual Happy Ending, Happy Ending, Catra is lacking a sense of self worth but what else is new, Glimmer is the Rail Road Heiress, Catra is the reformed gang member, More tags to be added, Suicidal Thoughts, Whump, Fluff and Angst, world's longest engagement, Gun Violence, Set over about 60 years or so, Written Accent, Hordak is a lot more like Prime in this fic, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Past Child Abuse, Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Torture, Anxiety Attacks, Panic Attacks, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Tenderness, Romantic Fluff, Semi-beta read, sort of a slowburn, Glimmer is 3 ounces of whoop ass, Angry Small, Angry Floof, deeply in love, Woman-Loving-Woman, Queer Character, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Hordak's A+ Parenting, Healing isn't linear, Healing, Started Pre S5, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Glitra Week 2019, Part 1 of How To Quit You

Stats:
Published: 2019-09-25 Completed: 2026-05-14 Words: 138,602 Chapters: 25/25

How to Quit You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/20775374.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Various Others (all minor/background)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Western, Western, Past Relationship(s), Past Violence, Technically Fit in the Romantic Comedy Cliche of Exs, Glitra Week 2019, no editing we die like meh, Fluff, Drama, Drama & Romance, Blood and Violence, Angst, Eventual Happy Ending, Happy Ending, Catra is lacking a sense of self worth but what else is new, Glimmer is the Rail Road Heiress, Catra is the reformed gang member, More tags to be added, Suicidal Thoughts, Whump, Fluff and Angst, world's longest engagement, Gun Violence, Set over about 60 years or so, Written Accent, Hordak is a lot more like Prime in this fic, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Past Child Abuse, Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Torture, Anxiety Attacks, Panic Attacks, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Tenderness, Romantic Fluff, Semi-beta read, sort of a slowburn, Glimmer is 3 ounces of whoop ass, Angry Small, Angry Floof, deeply in love, Woman-

Loving-Woman, Queer Character, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Hordak's A+ Parenting, Healing isn't linear, Healing, Started Pre S5, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Glitra Week 2019, Part 1 of How To Quit You

Stats:
Published: 2019-09-25 Completed: 2026-05-14 Words: 138,602 Chapters: 25/25

How to Quit You

by Nny11

Summary

It was only a matter of time before Catra's number came up, she's just not sure whether it was good or bad luck that lead Deputy Moon to find her.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1: I Don't Want to Let You Go

Catra stared at the ground as it passed underneath the horses hooves. *Dirt, dirt, rock, grass, dirt, rock, dirt, dirt.* She didn't really have many options besides naming things to keep herself sane. She was literally tied up on the rump of the damned creature and each cantering step made her chest and stomach ache worse.

She knew, logically, that she should just be grateful to be alive after a fall like that. Bruised and nothing broken, and again, for emphasis here, not **dead**.

"Tell me you're still kickin'," Deputy Moon called over her shoulder.

Catra grunted, "Good t'know you still care!"

"I don't."

Yeah. That was the problem there wasn't it?

Deputy Glimmer Moon. Recently (when the hell did that even happen?) deputized Glimmer Moon. Glimmer as in the woman Catra had been madly in love with. Glimmer as in the woman who punched her as a parting gift when she found out about her old criminal past. A past which was just that. In the *past*. And besides all her crimes had happened a whole two states over. Too bad that was where Glimmer's family was living at the time. There was something horribly humiliating about having been arrested by her own damn ex-fiancé, even if she was the one who ultimately allowed it.

Them's the breaks she supposed. And nothing ever really broke right for Catra.

"You sure?" She shouted, fighting off a wave of nausea as her head pounded. "You're going through a lotta trouble for lil old me!"

"Shut your mouth or I'll shut it for you."

Catra twisted just enough to see Glimmer's leg and arm. "Kinda doubt it."

Glimmer didn't actually punch her that hard, but with her core muscles pitching a fit her head still bounced painfully off the horse's flank.

"Woman, I am literally tied up right now! Jesus!"

"Yeah, w-well," Glimmer's voice faded as she mumbled her reply.

Catra wouldn't have even minded this so bad if it weren't for the fact that it was *Glimmer*. She'd come to terms with her violent actions back when she'd been learning how the hell to settle down. She'd even gotten some mastery over her temper when Mrs. Angella Moon had helped her get a job with the railway. She'd known she was a bad person, but she'd fully intended to turn over a new leaf. Hells, she HAD turned over her new leaf!

She'd just forgotten that Shadow Weaver was a right old hag who could literally haunt her every step. Even from beyond the grave.

Had she burned that barn to the ground in a righteous fury? Hell yeah, and she'd do it again long as Weaver was still tied up and trapped under several crates. Too bad she wasn't the one and only casualty the way Catra had planned. She'd had no idea that the one dumbass who'd gone rushing into the burning building, the very one who died from the smoke before getting burned up...well, turned out Micah Moon had been a self sacrificial idiot whose brain and heart were in inverted sizes. She wouldn't even entertain the other option if that weren't true. Catra had shouted at him not to do it, that the building was gonna collapse, but he'd gone in anyways. *"There's someone in there!"* He'd cried out and Catra shouted one more time before he'd jumped into the flames.

Never approach a bull from the front, a horse from the rear, or a fool from any direction.

Catra had fled the state determined to make a new life for herself without a gang to drag her down. Willing to sacrifice one innocent

man to escape her mistakes.

She shoulda known better.

The horse slowed to a stop, and Glimmer dismounted. Catra lifted her head a little to look around before being unceremoniously pulled off the horse's ass and dropped by a copse of withered pinon trees. She couldn't help the one weary chuckle as Deputy Moon secured her to the trees.

"Got something more to say?"

"Naw, just picturing myself tryin' to hop away tied up like this." Catra grinned. "You gotta admit that's a little bit funny."

Glimmer's face twisted for a moment, a mix of amusement and bitterness before she turned and started setting up the camp properly. By the fifth time she shifted her weight around trying to keep feeling in her feet, which incidentally was the fifth time Glimmer had jerked or twitched, any plans to be calm and rational went out the window. She'd had a *hell* of a day anyways.

She laughed, doubled over as far as she could with so much rope tied around her middle. "Sorry-jesus fuck-sorry, I-I just, girl! You're nervous as a long tailed cat in a room full a rocking chairs!"

Glimmer growled, but she was blushing as she turned away to focus on her task. "I'm being vigilant!"

"You're bein' twitchy like."

"You need another punch? I'm happy to oblige!"

"Naw, naw, c'mon now ain't that big a thing is it? Letting me have a laugh?"

The kindling snapped in Glimmer's hands as she threw it on the unlit fire pit. "You don't deserve a laugh Catra. Not now. Not ever. You hear me?"

Glimmer had always said she loved the way Catra could find humor in any situation. That she could listen to Catra laughing endlessly. That she always appreciated hearing her so happy. That hearing Catra laugh was more than enough to set her off into a fit of giggles and brighten her day right up.

“Yeah,” Catra said, heart aching all over again, “Yeah, I hear you. You mind if I try and find a little bit a good left in what’s left of my life?”

Glimmer didn’t answer as she tried to get the fire going. Her attention furiously focused on each step. That hurt more than she'd expected. It was funny she already knew that Glimmer hated her. She'd come to terms with it, or, well, something like that at least. This hurt like quiet mornings alone and late nights creeping into bed. Fuck.

“‘Cause when you deliver me there, you know I’ve got a quick drop and short stop right? Rather find a little peace somewhere.”

Despite the fire not quite being ready, Glimmer threw her flint on the ground before stalking over and kicking Catra in the side shooting stars off in her blurry vision. “Sure, the way you let my dad find a little peace too huh!?”

“God dammit woman, I told you I didn’t mean to hurt him! I told him not to go into a burning building Glim!”

Another kick and another, and one more before Catra was gasping for air as her side went white hot. Glimmer glared down at her before she spoke again, “You’re a liar Catra D’riluth. A liar and a killer. You don’t get to talk about my daddy. Understood?”

She scoffed, “You got it Deputy.”

“Shut up before I make that drop for you myself.”

There was a long beat of silence between them, both evaluating the other before Catra broke it again. “You really want me dead that badly?”

“Yes.” Glimmer hissed, eyes filling with unshed tears before she went back to the unlit fire.

This time Catra waited, she waited and watched as Glimmer made herself a dinner and drank some water. She waited as the sun went down, watching the moon rise over the mountain. She waited until the words had torn her heart into little shreds, trying her best to do this one last thing. But she’d always been just dumb enough to open her mouth, no matter the consequences.

“Glimmer, I really didn’t mean for him to get caught in the cross hairs. It was supposed to be an empty barn,” Well, that was the story she’d run with. Burning the barn for insurance money instead of violently and viciously killing one old woman. “I don’t know what you want me to say, I can’t just go back and change what happened.”

“Why’d you run?” The question was so short and sudden that Catra stared for a moment too long at Glimmer’s back. “Oh now you ran outta breath?”

“Naw, you know me better than that. I-heh. I ran because half a damn town saw me, a stranger, warning him away before he went in. They’d know I’d set the blaze so I booked it. I **was** in a gang and they weren’t exactly pleased by the attention it drew to us when my face showed up on wanted signs for murder.” That had been an unpleasant shock, watching her mug get plastered up at the train station. Somehow one little case of major murder had become two. She’d been almost numb afterwards realizing that she really couldn’t go back. Catra tore her gaze away from Glimmer’s blurry form and let the night blindness turn the world black. “Couldn’t exactly stay after that.”

“So that’s it? What, you just made a mistake? A little whoopsie daisy is that it?”

“Didn’t know warning someone about danger was gonna be a mistake!”

Catra had expected Glimmer to yell, shout, hell maybe even to kick her again. She hadn't expected the quiet soft tone. "So you were close enough for him to hear but not close enough to stop him? Don't bullshit me."

"I'm not. Glimmer, please look at me."

When she finally did Catra could see the tear tracks on her face, the miserable lost look that had no right to be on someone so beautiful.

"I swear to you, Glimmer, I'm swearing it to you. The only thing I coulda done was run in after him and gotten us both killed."

"Then you're a coward."

Her soul hurt, but she sighed, "...of death? Yeah. I'm a coward."

Glimmer snorted, "Please, you always ran head first into danger."

She had. When they'd run into that mountain lion, Catra had run at it screaming praying that she could buy Glimmer time. When that bandit had held them up at the bank, Catra had stabbed him when his gun pointed at Glimmer. When her horse had spooked and thrown her, Catra had stumbled through the dark to get to Glimmer's house; only worried that she'd worry her and not caring about her concussion. She'd shimmied into nooks and crannies with rattlesnakes and black widows to get little rocks and things she thought Glimmer would like. She'd gone diving so deep in the lake she'd blacked out right before she'd surfaced to retrieve Glimmer's beloved bracelet. Catra had always been reckless with her life when it came to Glimmer Moon. She hadn't expected to enjoy her life until she'd met the woman who could shoot riding side saddle, the one with endless hope and a thirst for adventure. A woman quick to anger and quicker to forgive. The woman whose smile seemed just that much brighter for her, who looked at her and saw someone worthwhile.

"For you? Always." Catra smiled sadly as Glimmer's eyes snapped to her. "I hated it, I was always scared of it. But if I thought for

even one moment it'd make you smile, I'd a done just about anything."

"Like hell." But her voice was soft and her shoulders had hunched. As if knowing Catra's feelings had run so deep was a horrible burden. Maybe it was.

"Just so! I'm here aren't I? Didn't fight when you arrested me. Didn't fight on the horse. Ain't tried once to get away once. I don't want to go, but you want me to. So I'm doing it." Catra sniffed hard, refused to let the tears fall, and turned her head to spit harshly. "I made you a promise."

"Damn you D'riluth." Glimmer huffed, wiping at her eyes before grabbing her travel pack. "You-you just want me to let you go!"

That was the furthest thing from the truth, she'd barely been surviving these years without her. Literally let herself get caught just to be near her. "No. Glim, I want you to do whatever you got to do. You can only do what you can do."

She'd said that so many times over the years. Holding Glimmer back from fights and joining her in the brawls. Over heartbreaking letters and animals not so cleanly killed when hunting. She hoped that someday Glimmer might actually believe her, understand her, listen to her. It'd been almost fifteen years since they'd met, but it seemed that one lesson still wasn't sticking.

"Don't lecture me, when I don't see you givin' it your all." Glimmer said, kneeling down with her pack just inches from Catra. Searching for something.

"Grab my boot." Catra made sure to give back the steady level stare she received. "I mean it."

Glimmer reached out, resting her hand on top of Catra's boot just below the ropes. She was trembling. It was a warm night, her voice was steady as always. But Catra had long since learned to make her voice sound in opposition to her feelings. She'd never learned how to stop shaking when her nerves got the best of her.

Glimmer waited in silence. One minute. Then two before she pulled her hand back.

"I **am** giving it my all darlin'." Catra laughed without a trace of humor in it. Hollow and awful. "I really am."

Glimmer swallowed hard before finding her hunting knife, and Catra felt her whole body start shaking worse as icy cold water rushed through her veins.

Well. Alright then.

She closed her eyes and waited, it felt like an eternity before a hand roughly grabbed the rope around her chest and dragged her forward but there wasn't any pain. Catra's eyes flew open as Glimmer cut the bindings away one at a time. Even once they'd all been cut away she didn't move. Staring instead at the woman who was glaring hard at the knife in her hands.

"Go on." Glimmer nodded out towards the inky black just outside the ring of light. "Just...get out of here. Nobody gotta know nothing."

Catra slowly pulled herself up, using the rough bark of the trees to ground herself. "You sure?"

Glimmer stood, looking her over as if seeing her for the first time before she leaned forward and kissed her. Catra would never describe herself as a delicate lady. She didn't go fainting at blood or screaming at indecency. She still had to hold on tighter than hell to the stupid scraggly tree branch nearest to her or she would have collapsed right back to the ground to never walk again.

When Glimmer broke away, her stern tone was undercut by the soft worry in her face. "Don't make me regret this."

Catra took one limping step away. Then another. And finally turned her back to stumble away. Back towards the road. Heading not to the nearest town, but instead limping to the train tracks and following those. Quicker way back, maybe she'd even get

lucky enough to hop a freighter. She walked numbly for a few hours until she found a little way station with a strong lock and a weak door frame. Kicking it in hurt like hell, but some shelter sounded nice.

Settled in best she could, the pain a buzzing sort of background noise, Catra slumped to the floor by the entrance. She looked up one more time at the full moon, maybe the only thing she'd have left of Glimmer, and let its light soak gently into her skin before going to sleep.

Chapter 2: No Good Deed Goes Unpunished

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer inched over and lightly kicked the woman's boot, jumping back startled even though nothing happened. "Lord have mercy."
>
> Okay. So the body was definitely dead as a door nail.
>
> "We can't just leave her here Glimmer, what if her family's looking?" Bow's voice floated through her head.
>
> "Damn you Beauregard Archer and your good heart!" Glimmer scrubbed at her face. Guilt tripped by a man not even present. Typical.

Chapter Notes

> Prompt - Fluff: Horseback Riding
>
> Thanks for the suggestion TypoShifter !

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fifteen Years Earlier

Glimmer had been riding for less than an hour and already felt horribly guilty. Had her mother been too controlling? Yes. Had her mother not listened? Of course. But had her mother also done it from a genuine and good place in her heart? Unfortunately for her conscious, yes. Angella Moon was not a cold and distance woman with no mind for anyone but herself.

She just wanted Glimmer to have a good life.

Wrapped in the softest of wools.

Surrounded by feather pillows.

Inside of a *fortress* where she'd never, ever be hurt.

Glimmer sighed dolefully and patted Star Wind's neck. With hindsight, she wished she'd at least swung by Bow's home or gotten Adora from Razz's ranch. Flying off in a righteous fury was never that much fun when she was alone after all. But now that she had, Glimmer refused to turn around. Nothing but more scolding waited for her at home and there was little worse that getting a scolding when they were right and you were wrong.

Desperately trying to find a way to enjoy the dregs of her escape, she was lost in thought escape when Star Wind startled. Glimmer shifted, ready to bolt as she looked for the disturbance. It could be anything. A snake, a lynx, a-a- A boot.

Glimmer glared at her mare before dismounting. A boot, honestly. She loved her horse dearly, but Star Wind was still a creature startled by her own damn shadow. Oh well, maybe she could burn off the last of her frustrations this way. So Glimmer reached to grab it, fully intent to throw it as far and as hard as she could, when she finally noticed that it was in fact not just a boot. It was a boot with someone's foot. She blanched, stomach roiling with nerves as she quietly made her way around the juniper bush to find a woman.

She was a lanky thing, curly hair barely restrained in a messy bun, and her face covered in freckles. She wore sturdy work clothes, and her straw hat had fallen into the dirt. She was pretty.

Or would have been very pretty if she didn't have dried drool covering her chin, and reeking of alcohol and sweat.

"Lord, sweet Jesus…" Glimmer pinched her nose as she stood up and frantically looked around. There was no one out here. No people, no smoke, not even a horse. No signs of how the woman got here, and if anyone had been with her they'd left her for...*oh*

no. She looked at the woman again. *Oh no, is she dead?* The woman's chest wasn't moving. "Oh hell!"

This was not the adventure Glimmer had planned on! What was she even supposed to do with a dead body!? A heavy stone fell in her stomach as she looked over at her pearl quarter horse and then back at the body. If she was going to help her, then she needed to get her up on Star Wind and ride to town. "Alright, slow down Glimmer, maybe...maybe she's not dead?"

Glimmer inched over and lightly kicked the woman's boot, still startling hard enough to literally jump back even though nothing happened. "Lord have **mercy**."

Okay. So the body was definitely *dead* as a door nail. Oh she did not want to touch a corpse! Glimmer winced. Maybe, maybe she could leave it here, no harm no foul.

"We can't just leave her here Glimmer, what if her family's looking?" Bow's voice floated through her head.

"Damn you Beauregard Archer and your good heart!" Glimmer scrubbed at her face. Guilt tripped by a man not even present. Typical.

It took several minutes for her to calm down enough before she was able to convince Star Wind to stand still near the body. Then another few to get herself ready to do the deed. Two aborted attempts from the smell and one failed attempt because *she was touching a dead body* later, and glimmer had manhandled the poor soul onto Star Wind's back. She was catching her breath when the body snored.

Glimmer would love to say she didn't scream, but scream and stumble behind the juniper bush she did. She stared wide eyed at the woman before letting out a string of curses he mother would never forgive her for.

"You motherfucking son of a bitch, I thought you were dead! Oh Christ's sake, how drunk off your ass were you? You- you dumb

bastard! Shit, get drunk like a normal degenerate. In town! Where it’s at least a little safer, hell's bells!” She was still shaking but felt exponentially better about the whole affair.

Glimmer Moon, heiress of the railroad, once doer of good deeds now reduced to carrying drunkards around. Her good will thoroughly used up she stomped around to glare at the woman’s face, only to find her unfocused eyes looking around. One greenish brown, one blue with brown speckles. The most beautiful eyes she’d ever seen.

“Oh,” Glimmer whispered and flinched as the woman’s gaze suddenly went hard and focused on her.

There was a pause before she smiled, eyes crinkling merrily, and slurred, “M’ello!”

And then she passed back out.

Glimmer stared at her before slowly walking forward. It didn’t look like the woman was breathing, but she wasn’t falling for that trick twice. Holding her hand in front of the woman’s face she could feel short, soft puffs of warm air and that was enough. Glimmer glanced at Star Wind one more time before gingerly mounting up behind the woman. The stench was enough to make her gag but she wasn’t sure her passenger would stay on the horse if Glimmer wasn’t holding her on.

“Bow,” she hissed as she tried to breath with only her mouth, “you'd better appreciate what I do for you.”

They’d only gotten halfway back before Glimmer thought to wonder what the townsfolk would say about this, and more importantly what the actual hell she was going to do with the drunkard. Somehow the task had been easier when Glimmer thought she was doing a good turn to a departed soul, getting her a proper burial and closure. Now it was somewhat embarrassing.

What would Bow do? Bow would take her home and nurse her back to health while helping his father’s preach about the dangers

and evils of alcohol. That was too much time. Too much effort. And her mother would say no, no matter how nice the woman might be able to clean up.

Okay, what would Adora do? Adora...Adora was such a rule follower at times, she'd turn her into the sheriff's office. Well that sounded reasonable didn't it? She could just bring the woman there to sleep it off and-

"Thas a **very** purdy brace-klet. Let. Very-very...it's nice!" The woman mumbled and slurred causing Glimmer to jerk in the saddle behind her. The stranger had the gall to laugh. "Woah there girl, it's fiiiiine. Yer alright girl."

"Excuse me?" Glimmer huffed, she was not some nag that needed a pat and an apple!

"Hm?" The woman tried to turn around, only succeeding in almost taking them both right off poor Star Wind.

"Stop it!" She didn't stop, in fact, she almost tried harder for having been told no. "Would you please stop that!?"

"Stop whut?"

"You're gonna get us thrown!" Glimmer lied, not wanting to try and explain to a drunk woman why what she was doing was annoying, rude, and dangerous. She'd probably find it easier to tell a rock to move.

"Naw, no-whu I won't! I'm, uh, I'm very good at this!"

"Sure," Glimmer groaned, but her moment of annoyed distraction was enough for the woman to somehow flip around and be facing her. "Hell!"

She laughed. It was squeaky and higher pitched then Glimmer had expected. Her eyes squeezed shut as she did so, mouth wide open and showing her oddly sharp looking canines. To Glimmer's surprise she was able to hold two opposing thoughts at the

moment. *She's beautiful and I love that laugh.* But also: *WHAT DIED IN HER MOUTH, LORDY LOU!*

"Tol' you!" The woman crowed. "I kin do all, all sorts a tricksy stuff."

Glimmer choked back her gag, and leaned as far back as possible. "I can see that."

"Yup. Oh, I like yer dress. Very nice."

Glimmer was wearing a plain and frumpy yellow thing, and the bodice was on inside out since she'd thrown it on it a rage filled huff. "...thank you."

"Mmm-hm. Purdy brace-a-klet and pretty purdy dress. Makes sense! You're very nice yourself." The woman nodded sagely before moving like water. Glimmer suddenly found the woman behind her, leaning heavily on her back, without any sense of how she'd done it. "Imma get s'more sleep."

And then she went out like a light.

"What in the world just happened?" Glimmer pleaded towards the sky as if that would make a difference.

It was a long, long ride to the sheriff's office.

With the burden behind her and the woman safe off, Glimmer had quite a tale to tell anyone curious to hear it. And that thought managed to float her through sneaking back into her own home to change into some cleaner clothes. She weathered her mother's doting, and Bow's chastising, and Adora's grumbling about being excluded from the adventure. In fact, Glimmer had made it a whole three days before running into the stranger again.

This time the woman was sober, and showing off some rather fancy rodeo moves to a few cowhands at the auction house.

With the sun pouring down on her and the confident smirk as she danced with that rope, Glimmer had to admit the woman had talent. She joined the small crowd gathering around the auction pen to watch as one of the men said something, and the woman's face went hard. There was a short argument and onto a horse she went, a riding demonstration more impressive than anything Glimmer had ever seen began.

Adora whistled softly, "Well she's got talent! Wonder who that is?"

"Uh," Glimmer eloquently started, "that's the woman I found."

"What?" Adora looked back up before turning towards her, "I call bullshit!"

"Well I ain't lyin', that's her!" Glimmer puffed herself up, feeling somehow affronted on the woman's behalf despite being the one who had described her rather unflatteringly the last few days.

"Oh yeah?" Adora's grin turned evilly mischievous and Glimmer got a bad feeling she'd played right into a trap. "Then go say hi."

The smart thing was to refuse. The smart thing was to call Adora on her tomfoolery. The smart thing was to explain that just because the woman had called her pretty and Glimmer had felt the same didn't mean they were in love. Because Adora was a hopeless, helpless romantic who's many failed attempts at getting her friends together were infamous.

"Well maybe I will!" Is what Glimmer said instead. Stomping over until she was standing on the outside of the wooden fence.

The woman rode right past her, pulled the horse to a hard stop and quickly backed it up.

Glimmer just about swallowed her tongue as those piercing eyes met her own. "Hello."

The woman smiled, "Hello properly this time Miss. I, uh, didn't have a chance to say thank you. So...thank you."

“It weren’t nothing,” Glimmer winced and cleared her throat. Way to sound impressive. “I’m sure you would have done the same.”

The woman shrugged, the corner of her mouth twitching like she wanted to frown. “Still, a right good thing you did. I owe you.”

“No you don’t, where would we be if we didn’t help one another?” Glimmer waved a hand dismissively.

“Well I, for one, would be dead and no one woulda found my bones.” The woman’s tone was hard and offered no room to fight. “I say again Miss, thank you. I owe you my life for what little that’s worth.”

“You can’t owe someone who’s name you don’t know.”

She smirked and it was so dazzling it almost hurt. “Watch me.”

Glimmer laughed nervously, wiping sweat off her brow and hoping her blush looked like heat flush. “Alright, alright! I concede Miss Mysterious Stranger!”

The woman tipped her hat, “Name’s Catra D’riluth Miss.”

“Alright then Catra D’riluth, my name is Glimmer Moon.” Glimmer reached her hand out and was absolutely gratified by the dumbstruck look on Catra’s face.

There was a pause before Catra gingerly took her hand and shook it. “Pleasure’s all mine Miss Moon. Stick around would ya? Got a blow hard who might want his horse back. N' I wouldn't mind gettin' to know ya more.”

“Sure, and don’t call me Miss Moon, D’riluth.”

Catra had already started riding back when she shouted over her shoulder, “Sure thing Miss!”

Damn you Adora Gray, what have you done? Glimmer couldn’t stop grinning even as her heart started hammering away. Oh no.

Oh no, oh no, he mother would not approve of this! *Lord take pity on your foolish child!*

Instead of taking pity, Glimmer soon found herself walking with Catra since Adora had all but vanished (the *traitor*). And a walk lead to some talk, and the talk lead to some interesting business ideas, and before Glimmer knew it, she had managed to convince her mother to hire her a new riding instructor. No matter how much she protested to both her so called friends that she could use the help, no matter how many times she pointed out Catra's skills, they didn't give her the time of day. Both laughing harder and harder as Glimmer hunted Catra down and told her about the sudden job offer.

"'N Who are they?" Catra almost growled, glaring at the two idiots leaning on one another for support.

"Allegedly my friends, but I'm thinking they might just be two little fools!"

"Sounds 'bout right."

"R-riding lessons!" Adora wheezed between snorting laughter. "Don't, now, d-don't let us stop you two!"

Not that she'd needed the encouragement, but Glimmer decided to take that advice. She grabbed Catra's hand and tugged her along. "We won't, stay here and laugh till your jaws fall off. Don't let me catch you following."

Bow collapsed completely and Adora doubled over.

But Catra held her hand the whole way back to the stable, so Glimmer decided that was a win.

Chapter End Notes

I do love me some parallels!

Fun Fact: In the 1985 animated She-Ra Swiftwind has a mate named Star Wind and they have a baby that Hordak tries to kidnap. Fun times. :D

Chapter 3: All Aboard!

Chapter Summary

> Catra spends another day on the railroad trying to survive her new job, Glimmer decides to have a little more adventure in her life. Lonnie is just so, so very tired.

Chapter Notes

> So, y'all wanna know what's crazy? THIS AMAZING FAN ART FROM THERODRIGATOR6!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra leaned forward into the wind as she jumped over the gap in the cars, heart twisting in panic as her foot slipped. For a brief moment she was sure she was gonna get thrown right under the heavy wheels of the train before her knee hit the roof and she didn't slide away. Shakily getting up, she quickly jammed her club into the brake wheel and heaved. Holding on tight as possible as the train rocked side to side, before getting the brakes engaged. It took a moment to free her club up before she ran to the next car.

It turned out the life of a brakeman was far less romantic than she'd envisioned.

Sure she'd seen the people up top, she'd seen them flipping switches, hopping on and off the moving train as needed. She'd never thought much about it beyond wondering why the hell someone would ever work a job like that. Getting shot at was one thing, willingly risking your hands and fingers for a job where you couldn't even get some damn insurance? Well that was right stupid!

Why, why did she always feel a need to open her big mouth and prove herself a fool?

“So yer firing me?” Catra had asked, trying to keep her hands still by death gripping her own belt. Her ears were ringing a little as she struggled to keep her temper in check. She'd been doing a crack job for once, she'd really been trying harder than hell and it didn't even fucking matter. Never mattered if she tried or not, you'd think she'd have learned her damn lesson by now.

She'd have to practically sneak into the spare room the Archer's had been lending her the last few months, and probably sneak out to avoid them. Catra was ***not*** *a charity case and no job meant no income. Hell, maybe she should hit the bank on her way out. Was gonna need to steal a horse anyways.*

Angella Moon was an imposing figure who Catra had done her level best to avoid. They'd talked on occasion, had to since she was technically a tutor or some other hogwash. But the woman held herself rigid and cool, and she hadn't gotten rid of one powerful bitch to trade for another she knew jack all about.

“Yes and no.” Mrs. Moon smiled, and it was probably the most emotive Catra had ever seen her. “I’d like to offer you a position with me, on the Bright Moon Rail Line. You’d have to work your way up from brakeman, but I think you could make a mighty fine conductor myself. Better pay and even some benefits if you are interested.”

Catra got the last brake turned and sat down panting to get her breath back. “Why...do I...let women...trick me?” Ha! Ask a dumb question...

The bell started to go and Catra groaned as she hauled herself to the side of the car and climbed onto the ladder, waiting until they were a little closer to the station before dropping down to wait for the back car. She smiled and waved to a little boy who looked over the moon to see her, before turning sharply to hide her scowl. Kids were always thrilled to see her jumping around the trains but seeing them always set of a flash of something rotten in her.

“Catra, I don’t know your past and I couldn’t care less. You work hard. You're dedicated and smart. And if that’s all we needed at Bright Moon, you’d be set for life.”

Catra swallowed thickly, doing her best to not scream in Mrs. Moon’s face. It was even her fault! She hadn't started anything, and if the bastard hadn't wanted to have their nose flattened they should've kept their mouth shut and hands to themself. But no. No, of course no one cared who actually started it. Apparently her getting snippy was enough to make her the bad guy. Her heart was racing with anger and fear. She couldn't lose this job, she didn't know what she'd do if she was fired. Something stupid no doubt.

Not that anyone cared about that either.

“You can’t just go hauling off on every idiot you meet, you hear?”

She waited and once she realized she wasn't being fired, her jaw ached as she forced it open. “Yes ma’am.”

Her anger almost boiled all the way over when Mrs. Moon gently gripped her shoulders, the soft smile she flashed, the warmth to her tone like she actually gave a flying rat's ass. She was sick of being manipulated, she was sick of it! “See you make that change.”

Catra had been trying to, at least she was getting reported less but apparently her "attitude" was enough to prevent her from getting the promotion Mrs. Moon had promised her. *Probably lied about that to fill a spot and line her damn pockets.* She didn’t want to be trapped as a brakeman forever! If she didn’t just slip and fall, or die from exposure, the hours might get her before the smoke did. Catra scrubbed at her face. Maybe she should’ve joined the union? She snorted at the thought. Probably woulda gotten sacked sooner if she had, bunch a lily livered babies would've pitch a fit about their image. God she could just picture it now, getting dragged like an unruly beast in front of the Moons.

“Catra!”

Yeah, that’s the sort of tone Glimmer would’ve started with at least. Her and her mother both, too damned **nice** at times. Wouldn't last though, nothing good ever did.

“D’riluth, God as my witness, if you are just ignoring me!”

“Whu?” Catra finally turned around and immediately burst into peals of laughter.

Glimmer, with the skirts of her blue and purple tea dress hiked up high enough to show the frills of her drawers, was hustling over either unaware or uncaring of the looks she got. Her hair was piled high and held in place with some sort of ribbon, but it had already fallen out and begun framing her face. Her once cream satin gloves were covered in dust and dirt, her shawl was a mangled mess. All in all, it was...good lord, it was just so very *her*. Hilarious and endearing all in one go.

“Don’t you laugh at me D’riluth!”

“Sorry miss! I am- a HEM- I am mighty sorry if I caused you any offense.” Catra sniggered, coughed, wiped her eyes with the back of her hand, and hoped she wouldn’t start laughing again. Hard to do when Miss Moon was turning shades and stomping a foot like that.

“No you ain’t.” Glimmer laughed, her frown quickly changing into a bright smile.

Glimmer was nothing but a bunch of contradictions someone managed to jam into far too small a frame for how big her personality was. But she had a good sense of humor and was willing to laugh at her own expense, which was more than most people were able to do. It was completely disarming, far too charming, and that made it dangerous on principle.

“No ma’am, I ain’t.” Catra glanced over her shoulder, there were already plenty of men hauling out the goods but it certainly

wouldn’t take long. So she cast about for something to do before they were rolling again. “Now what in the world are you doing this far out North?”

Glimmer huffed, rolling her eyes before grumbling, “If you must know Miss D'riluth, I was invited to Frosta Mackenzie’s cotillon.”

“Mmm, I can see that now, shoulda known from the- now is that dirt or manure?”

Glimmer wasted no time smacking her a few times on the shoulder. “You are a beast!”

“Just so!” The whistle blew and Catra froze, desperately wishing she could just stay here and ride home with Glimmer. But that would mean passing up her paycheck, and worse, disappointing Mrs. Moon. She needed that damn promotion more than she wanted a lazy afternoon. “Well I’m afraid this is where we part.”

“Catra, don’t you dare- Catra!”

But the trains don’t wait, so up she scampered quickly releasing the brakes in reverse until she made it to the caboose. Hanging off the side of the car she signaled her all clear to the front brakeman, and waved to the kids as the rolled past. This time she didn’t have to force a smile for propriety’s sake. Glimmer just had that effect on her. Catra felt her grin get a little dopey but didn’t pay it no never mind, instead watching the train station grow further and further away with a sigh. Damn. She was really gonna have to do something about that, wasn’t she? Probably wouldn’t do to get a bounty put on her head for angering Angella Moon, already had one a those anyways.

“Gracious! How in the hell do you make this look so easy?” Glimmer called from just a few feet above.

Catra gripped the ladder tightly before turning to look up at Glimmer’s red face. The woman folded her hands under her chin and laughed breathlessly. “I almost fell off at least a few times!”

“The hell are you doing!?” Catra hissed, then smacked her forehead into the ladder before shouting the question instead.

“Well that’s a fine how do you do!”

“God damn it woman, what the hell do you think you’re doing!?” Catra scurried a few rungs up to see if the head brakeman had noticed, but it looked all clear. “You’re gonna get yerself killed!” Or her fired!

“Pfft, not if you tell me what I need to look out for.”

Catra glared and pulled herself up high enough to be nearly nose to nose as her blood boiled. “Get. Off. The. Roof. Else you’ll be looking out for my damn fist.”

Glimmer shimmied herself forward just enough that they *did* bump noses. “You know, when a young woman dotes on you, most civilized people would say thank you.”

“I’d **thank you** if you’d get off my roof!” Catra growled. “So get down or I knock you off and let you walk back to town.”

Glimmer screamed wordlessly before pulling herself back. Catra got up just in time to see her disappear down the back ladder. And just in time to watch Glimmer’s boots go flying off the train.

“Land’s sake, you better get me a new pair wherever we’re going!”

“That weren’t me!”

“Well you won’t spend time with me, won’t explain the work, and now you’re mad at me for goodness knows. The least you can do is buy me a new pair of boots.” Glimmer hissed.

“The-the damn job is watching for signals so I know when to switch the tracks, and listenin’ for the whistle to turn on the brakes. There you go, now we can be baked and bored together!” Catra yelped as the car rocked violently, gripping the top rung for

dear life and looking up to the front of the train in case she'd missed something.

"Are you even listening to me?" Glimmer shrieked from the very top of the back ladder. The one she'd just climbed down. The one Catra swore she was going to snap off with her bare hands if Glimmer got herself hurt.

"If I do will you shut up?"

The whistle gave a sharp blow and Catra scrambled. "Stay here!"

Half speed to get through the tunnel, oh lord Glimmer was going to go into the tunnel? Catra had jumped to the second car only to find Glimmer already tugging on the brake wheel with her bare hands. "What did I just say!?"

Glimmer smirked over her shoulder, her skirts now tied up around her waist and her bustle missing as she made a run for the next car. Catra started after her, before doubling back to make sure the wheel had been turned only part way, and then took off. That was about the way the whole affair went until she met with the Conductor, who had (apparently) taken on the shift of the head brakeman. Lonnie glared at her and Catra's vision almost went black.

Of course, of course this was gonna get blamed on her when she'd done nothing!

"Well howdy! Pleasure to meet you ma'am, I'm Glimmer Moon." Glimmer smiled brightly, giving a slight curtsey as Lonnie's mouth dropped wide open.

And just like that Catra wasn't angry anymore. When Lonnie looked desperately at her, as if she had an answer, Catra just smiled and swung her club a little. She respected Lonnie well enough, but certainly couldn't claim to like the hard ass. The two of them had butted heads enough times that they normally didn't work together to spare the schedule.

Lonnie tipped the tiny brim of her hat. “I would much prefer if this meeting took place inside one of the cars Miss Moon, we are about to go through the Northern Reach Tunnel. Ain’t no place for a lady such as yourself.”

Oh if it had been anyone else, that might have sounded flattering. As it was Catra did her best to not laugh in Lonnie’s face.

“No I don’t think so.” Glimmer said, tone harsh and clipped. “In fact Miss D’riluth was just showing me what sort of work she does here. You know how dangerous this all is Miss?”

It was a miracle that Lonnie’s teeth didn’t crack. Oh yeah. Catra's day had suddenly gotten infinitely better.

“And to think, she’s been working hard for, what, nearly a year now and still doing this?” Glimmer laughed, waving one hand as if this was a simple conversation over tea and cake. “Now that don’t seem right do it?”

“Ma’am, the Apprentice here-”

“Catra.” Glimmer corrected.

Lonnie let out a long suffering sigh, “Yes ma’am, Apprentice Catra is still a greenhorn. She’ll advance when I say so.”

“Well I suppose that makes sense. I’ll just have to speak with my mother then Miss…?”

Catra cut in before the other woman could speak, “Miss Glimmer, may I introduce the conductor, Lonnie Gary. She’s Mr. Turron’s daughter.”

“Oh, and how is Mr. Turron? We were awful sad to hear he couldn’t make it to our thanksgiving dance. But a broken leg wouldn’t find no peace I fear!”

There it was. The exact moment that Catra could watch the life and hope drain out of Lonnie’s eyes. Catra held her arm out and

Glimmer looped her hand through it as if they were made for it. Whoo boy that was a thought to jam down and never let see the light of day again.

"Well as can be expected Miss. Thank you kindly." Lonnie looked at her pocket watch before glaring at Catra. "Alright then, enjoy your...day Miss Moon. D'riluth, get those breaks open."

"Oh yes ma'am, right away." Catra still waited until Lonnie turned and began opening the breaks on her half of the freight train. Then she let herself laugh as she fumbled the wheel back open. "Alright, alright, I ain't mad atchyou no more. That was worth its weight in gold!"

"Thank you kindly," Glimmer said, mocking Lonnie's tone as she curtsied again.

"Oh hush, alright back this way then, get 'em opened up and then get something to cover your face with. Tunnels are 'bout the worst damn part of this job with all that soot."

Glimmer was already running and jumping back to the next car though. "Sure, only if'n you can beat me there!"

"Cheater!" Catra laughed as she ran and made her way back as fast as possible.

She only beat Glimmer by a hair, and had insisted on helping to tie her shawl around her mouth and nose. Ultimately, Catra decided, she got to touch Glimmer's neck so it was a damn good day. Having an excuse to hold onto her waist, crushed together on the back ladder as they traveled through the inky black of the tunnel, was probably the best thing that had ever happened in her life. Catra could say with confidence that Mrs. Moon was going to kill her and throw her body to the hogs.

Oh, but it had been worth it. Very worth the trouble indeed!

Chapter End Notes

Check out the choo choo I saw today! It's the AT&SF 2926 steam locomotive that's being restored!



Chapter 4: You Heard the One About the Horse's Face? Ah, never mind, it's too long!

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer is fed up with Catra trying to pass the buck, Catra is trying to not admit anything, and the horses are missing.
>
> And then there's the mountain lion...

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to TypoShifter and dragonesdepapel for helping me out with this chapter! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer could not believe it. After a half year of private riding lessons she'd long since assumed there was nothing Catra *couldn't* do in regards to horses. She'd watched the impressive woman ride in several styles, calm them down without fear of a kick, and even convince the shier ones to get used to touch. Glimmer's crush had become something more, and her admiration had gone from an appreciation of physical attributes to those sorts of inner workings. She was patient and calm and sweet and funny...at least when things were right as rain. Catra was gruff, sure, but there was a softness in there when they weren't fighting; an easy excitement and a gentle smile when she was proud of you that more than outweighed any sneer when you failed. Glimmer had decided it was truly unfair how nearly perfect Catra D'riluth could be given just the slightest chance. But oh, oh! Soon as things weren't going her way the woman became a damned child. Surly and sullen, picking fights right and left, and then having the gall to be surprised when folks didn't like her. And right now?

Well, things weren't right as rain that was for sure!

"How in the hell did this happen?" Catra moaned, mopping at her sweaty face with a handkerchief. "Did'n ya tie them up?"

Glimmer did her best to not grind her teeth. This was at least the fifth time she'd been asked, and it hadn't gotten any cuter as her patience had frayed under the heat of the sun. "You know that I did! *You* checked the knots."

Catra grumbled something unintelligible but kept trudging forward. Glimmer growled, dragging her hands down her face just to force the energy out somewhere. *I'm gonna kill her! I'm gonna kill her* ***dead***.

Unwilling to let Catra get away with anything after all her harassing, Glimmer practically spit, "It's considered rude round these parts to mumble Miss D'riluth."

Let's hear her talk her way out of that!

"How am I the one in trouble?" Catra huffed, eyes flashing dangerously as she stopped to whirl on the other woman. One thing Glimmer had learned about Catra was that she was a spring ready to shoot forward at any given moment. Apparently she'd decided that Glimmer asking for just the barest minimum of common decency was too much! The nerve! When Glimmer only glared back, Catra snarled, snapping at her, "I didn't get the horses lost!"

"YOU-mmmmm, how **can** I put this for your sensibilities?" Glimmer asked with as much sarcasm as she possibly could.

"Sensibilities!" Catra gasped, looking a split second away from throwing punches.

Lord just take me now, I've made my peace and I am quickly losing it! Glimmer took a second to take a deep breath and then smiled as charmingly as she could force herself to. "Why Miss D'riluth, while I know I tied them horses, I also asked you to check my knot to make sure they were secure. Which you said

you did. And now they're GONE. Much as you want to shift the blame, you were the last one with hands on that rope. So how about you stop trying to act like I'm the only one who made a mistake, when you sure as **hell** didn't check nothing! At least I ain't moping around being *worthless* on this here fine afternoon!"

Catra stood frozen, her face went blank and Glimmer smirked victoriously. About time someone took the words out of her mouth! But when she didn't come out of it, Glimmer swallowed hard trying to keep her nerves in check. "Uh, Catra?"

Land's sake, she'd meant to be harsh but maybe...maybe not that harsh? Goodness gracious, she sure could dish it out but couldn't take it. Glimmer took a tentative step forward and when her companion didn't react she got just close enough to wave a hand in front of her face.

Nothing. Her eyes were trained on the spot Glimmer had been in, instead of where she was. When she looked over her shoulder there was nothing to see. An icy chill went down her spine as Glimmer cautiously inched closer. Caught halfway between furious and frightened she called out, "Catra? God as my witness, if this is a joke it ain't funny! Are you- hmph! ...Catra?"

This close Glimmer could see just how fast her friend was breathing. One last look into her eyes changed her tune right quick. What little good it would do to go from steaming mad to shaking scared, she couldn't say. But Glimmer had never seen Catra afraid before. *Don't panic Moon, maybe it's heatstroke. Heatstroke!? Don't be stupid! S*he'd half called Catra's name again, hands gently wrapping around her biceps when Catra startled.

She jerked her arms free, stumbling backwards in a panic. Her face twisting into some demon's before she growled, "I don't need the help of some pathetic little girl!"

Glimmer flinched, hand pulled back to her chest. She stared for a moment at all that rage that was boiling out of her seams. It

weren't normal for someone to just...not be there like that. Despite wanting to snap back about how she was only being a concerned friend, Glimmer only needed to remember that vacant scared look to keep her head. "Are you-"

"Get this through your damn skull," Catra didn't shout, didn't need to shout when she stalked forward and leaned into Glimmer's space, one finger jabbing sharply into her chest, "your mommy ain't here to save you from this fine mess you made, and I don't need no one's help. Especially not when they're too stupid to understand they ain't wanted! You got no problem pretending you can be responsible, but first chance you get you blame it on everyone but yourself. You're a right child Moon, and I'm done fixing everything you break, you hear me?"

Glimmer's heart pulled tight even as she was sure it musta been breaking. Desperate to make sure she didn't start crying, Glimmer shoved Catra back as hard as she could. She needed the space, she needed to breath! Catra hated her, didn't need to say it in so many words though. Maybe she'd always hated her, just humoring her as long as Glimmer bent to her will. Well then. Well then… Glimmer locked herself down tight before answering, "I hear you loud and clear D'riluth."

Her temper only flared up worse when Catra finally seemed to snap out of it. "I...shit, Glim-"

"I understand." Glimmer hissed, knocking their shoulders together as she passed. At least one of them needed to find the horses before something came along and found them first, and it certainly wouldn't be one unstable Catra D'riluth. "You are free to leave if that's what you want, town's still a half day walk."

She didn't turn around but made sure to snatch her hand up right quick when Catra tried to grab it.

Catra still had the gall to speak, "Will you just wait a moment...please?"

Glimmer didn't respond, instead focusing back onto the tracks they'd been following. After her mother had agreed to promote Catra to an office position, Glimmer had been ecstatic to spend more time with her friend. That had been proving to be a mistake. In the half year since she'd been working in town it seemed like all they'd done was fight. Glimmer could suddenly slot all the time she'd thought they'd been happy together right into place. Sure they'd spend a little time together in peace, often when her mother was around, outside of that Catra had simply gotten mean. Or maybe she'd always been mean and Glimmer had been too foolish to notice, too caught up in the dazzling performance to notice the stage.

Or worse, perhaps Catra had only ever been interested in what Glimmer could do for her financial prospects.

"Glimmer? I- okay, look, okay we don't have to stop, but I... Look, I just-"

She almost laughed at that. How pathetic? The woman couldn't even apologize for losing her temper. Glimmer wiped at her eyes as she marched forwards. Fine. Fine then, Glimmer had other friends. Real friends! Who needed stupid, angry Catra D'riluth? Who would want her anyways?

"Glimmer?"

Certainly not her!

"Glimmer!?"

Lord please , Glimmer begged silently, *give me the strength to survive this too.* They'd find the horses and say goodbye to one another and she'd find someone who would appreciate-

"GLIMMER!"

"What!?" Glimmer finally looked up and froze.

There, not twenty feet away, was a mountain lion. It stood at least half as tall as she was, tail swishing slowly back and forth. For one moment her brain sputtered, forgetting everything she'd been taught about what to do in this situation, simple white noise before she snapped back to.

Back away slowly, look big, and make noise.

"YO CAT, YEAH! GET, NOW I SAID GET!" Catra was, luckily, already working on the make noise portion, waving her arms with her hat in one hand.

Glimmer took a half step back, but when the lion hunched in on itself the world froze. Was it going to bolt or spring? She couldn't tell.

"Glimmer, run!" Catra apparently didn't care. Screaming wordlessly she charged full speed ahead at the beast. The exact opposite of what you were supposed to do.

"CATRA!"

The lion turned, fleeing as Catra *chased it* further down the trail. Glimmer found herself chasing after the fool of a woman who had apparently decided that running towards danger was a good idea. It was like being up on one of the trains again, knowing they could both die any moment but still desperate to make her way to her. And then Catra went around a bend out of sight. Her mind had always enjoyed jumping to awful conclusions, and in that eternity, as Glimmer pushed herself forward, she could only picture this woman she'd been falling for bleeding to death on the path, too far from town to save her life. Bleeding out in Glimmer's arms with their last words to one another being a stupid fight.

She couldn't lose someone she loved like that again. She couldn't. She couldn't!

Between one heartbeat and the next she was trapped remembering the pain of losing her father. Watching her mother turn cold and turn away. What would she even do if Catra died

because *Glimmer* had been so dang angry with someone she loved so much that she wouldn't listen? If Catra died because of her...she couldn't survive that. Glimmer screamed, pushing all the memories away, pushing all the feelings away, as she poured her very soul into her legs. *Just run!*

But, just as quickly as the whole debacle started, it ended. Her eternal moment of terror coming to an end too abruptly to do anything about it. Catra had stopped running and Glimmer crashed into her back. With her heart still in her throat and breathing wildly out of control; the two quickly tumbled to the ground. Glimmer pushed herself up just far enough to glare as Catra flipped around onto her back.

"Glimmer, what the hell?" Catra scowled and tried to sit up, but Glimmer grabbed her shoulders to push her back down roughly, dropping her weight to straddle her lap.

"No! You listen to me Catra D'riluth! You listen good! I did not get you outta that death trap of a job just for you to throw your life away!" Glimmer all but screamed, tears filling her eyes now that the danger had passed.

Catra stared at her wide eyed and mouth open, before scoffing softly. "It's mine to throw away."

Glimmer slapped her. She hadn't meant to, but hearing those words made the whole world disappear in a haze of fear. *Not again, not again, never again!*

Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut to try and stop herself from crying to no avail. "Don't you dare! Don't you **dare**!"

"Whoa, hang on, hang on no need to get like that!" Catra's calloused hands cupped her cheeks, thumbs swiping her tears gently. When Glimmer finally opened her eyes, breathing shaky and harsh as she looked down, Catra was looking at her so softly. "None of that. I'm alright! We are both alright."

“No we ain’t!” She sniffled, but this time when Catra started to sit up, Glimmer let her. “No we ain’t, good lord, we’re in the middle of nowhere, the damn horses ran ‘cause I didn’t-I didn’t tie them r-right-”

Catra hugged her. “Shush! Look, damn, I shouldn’t a said that alright? You were *right*, I was the last one that touched the rope and that means it’s on me. I just...look, I was just a bit distracted and didn’t want to admit it.”

“Distracted?” She mumbled into Catra’s shoulder, hands wound tight in the back of the other woman’s waist coat. She didn't even care that she'd been right, didn't care that Catra had lashed out at her to protect herself over something as silly as being distracted. Catra was alive and okay and cared about her, and that was all that mattered anymore. “By what, the cactus? A rock?”

“Never you mind!” Catra tried to pull back but Glimmer refused and simply waited until Catra sighed, “You ain’t letting me up till I tell huh?”

“Even got it in one.”

“You sure you ain’t evil?” Catra chuckled when Glimmer slapped her back a little. “Fine! I...those are just some very, uh, well fitted pants is all.”

“What?”

Glimmer pulled back to look at her riding trousers. She’d gotten them made with extra reinforcement to make up for all the extra hours she’d been spending in the saddle trying to impress the woman trapped under her. Side saddle had been well and good but didn't feel like much knowing all the tricks her instructor knew. They were nothing special, in fact, Glimmer was a bit upset when she’d got them the night before as they were tighter than she’d expected them to be. She’d been mortified to have anyone in town see her thighs and backside that well, and had scrambled to get on Star Wind before Catra would notice and make fun of her.

"...oh bless your heart." Catra weakly snickered.

Oh. *OH!*

Glimmer turned beat red and scrubbed at her face. "Are you telling me you didn't check on the horses because you were looking at my-"

"In my defense it is a mighty fine ass!"

"Heaven's to Betsy," Glimmer laughed, quickly standing before glaring down at Catra's smiling face. She still held a hand out to help pull her up. "What a fine thing to say to a young lady!"

"Almost as fine as your assets" Catra's grin was only a little awkward and unsure, but she accepted the hand up.

"Shush!" Glimmer grumbled looking at their hands.

Catra didn't let go, in fact she covered their still joined hands with her free one. Her voice was soft and filled to breaking with a nervous energy only equaled by the thickness of her emotions. "Glimmer? I shouldn't have snapped at you. What I said was...well, it's not true. I said it to hurt you."

"It worked." Glimmer refused to let her go when Catra tried to pull back. Their eyes locked and even though it scared her, she pushed forward. "You cain't do that again Catra. Next time you break my heart, it'll be for good."

Catra nodded mutely, eyes watering.

"When you moved into town, I was so excited to get to see you. And when you're happy? It's like a sun shower. You can be so wonderful that I forget what you're like when you aren't. 'Cause when you ain't happy? ...I can't keep ignoring that forever. You gotta promise you'll try. Just, at least promise me you'll try?"

Catra had dropped her gaze halfway through, but when she looked back up there was fire there again. "I will. I promise I will."

“Okay.” Glimmer felt a trembling in her hand before realizing it was Catra shaking like a leaf. Yeah, yeah that seemed about right considering the day they'd had. “Okay, thank you. Now let’s find those damn horses and go home.”

This time, when Catra tried to let go, Glimmer held tight and pulled her gently by the hand. Leading her back to the trail where they’d been following two sets of horse tracks. They didn’t speak as they searched once more. Catra’s trembling eventually stopped, and Glimmer was almost grateful when her heartbeat slowed enough for her to be annoyed once more by the heat.

In the end, it turned out their horses had managed to find a small bit of shade and a tiny little trickle of water. Star Wind had been lazily attempting to graze on some buffalo grass while Tao, Catra’s brute of a quarter horse she'd won off some poor soul, had jammed his nose as deep into the water as he could.

“If you managed to drown yourself in the damned mesa I would have killed you myself,” Catra huffed as they mounted up and began the ride back towards home.

“Was that gonna be before or after you let that cat maul you?” Glimmer snickered as her companion groaned. When she only burst into a full laugh, Catra spurred Tao into a canter. Glimmer tried to catch up, delighted to shout, “Or were you gonna kill him after you died from staring at me? Not that I’m complaining. Much. You coulda said something earlier!”

Harassing Catra all the way back into town was almost worth the rest of the emotional mess they’d barely managed to walk away from. Glimmer had to admit what made it worth it was seeing her two dusty hand prints on the small of Catra’s back.

Chapter End Notes

> Up Next: It all goes horribly wrong at a bank robbery, and after years of restraint Catra lets loose.

Chapter 5: Bank Robbery

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer finally gets a look at the darkness Catra's been hiding, and it ain't pretty. She comes to a few realizations, stops taking her relationships for granted, and reaches out to start fixing her mistakes.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you again to my editor/beta TypoShifter!
>
> There is a very good reason this fic is tagged for graphic depictions of violence. It's this chapter! (Plus a few other things not to be mentioned here, don't you pay that no never mind anyhow.)
>
> To skip the violence, jump forward when the bank robbery starts at "THIS IS A HOLD UP" and jump to "Already there was a buzz of people outside", feel free to use the search function to jump or look for the extra space between paragraphs. General description of what happened will be in the end note.
>
> Also, this was supposed to be Catra's PoV, Glimmer sparkle fist of friendship punched me so it's her instead.
>
> This chapter is fluff, whump/angst, fluff I swear!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Laying in bed that night, Glimmer was unable to sleep thanks to her emotions being all snarled up. Like tangled lace. Like a pit of vipers. Her heart clenched painfully as she fisted her sheets tightly. Maybe she should have taken her mother up on that shot of tequila, God knew she wasn’t doing better without it.

Catra killed a man. She’d killed him.

For good reason. Glimmer sighed at her cracked ceiling.

It had started when her mother had asked her to withdraw a rather hefty sum of money at the bank. Catra had been staring almost dead eyed at a ledger of numbers until she'd heard that, and had so gallantly offered to walk her there and back.

"Dangerous thing to be seen walking outta bank Miss, who knows what could happen without someone there?" Catra had been smirking, hip cocked out as she rolled her sleeves back down, confident Glimmer would agree and, therefore, unworried about ink getting on them. Completely unaware that she'd already smeared some on the side of her neck.

Glimmer had laughed, "Oh? Pray tell what would some nefarious ne'er-do-well be doing out here in this little place? I think you just want to escape your readings Miss D'riluth."

Catra had clutched dramatically at her heart. "Now you done gone and wounded me."

Ultimately her mother had intervened with an eye roll. "Catra, take a break and get her home safe."

"Mother!" Glimmer had blushed, mortified at the assistance.

"Have an enjoyable stroll with some enjoyable companionship won't you?" Angella said with a smile and a kiss to her cheek. "Besides, no daughter of mine would be so rude as to turn down such a kind offer."

Her mother had relaxed her iron grip over the past few years, but only when she knew someone would be with her precious daughter. With Catra working in the same office and Adora finally working on getting deputized, she had found herself spending even more awkward time with a woman she loved and didn't know what in the Sam Hill to do about.

Catra, as she always did when Mrs. Moon gave her orders, had sobered up right quick, "Yes ma'am."

It hadn’t stopped her from bowing deeply when she opened the front door, and hadn’t stopped her from offering her arm as they strolled. Generally it hadn’t stopped Catra from doing much more than walking out with her spin stiff as a board until they rounded the first corner.

The walk had been pleasant enough, with fall settling in the temperature had begun going up and down in rapid swings. The thermometer at the general store showing a chilly 43 in the morning and 75 by the afternoon. But right now, at mid morning, it was still cool enough to be pleasant without being cold. As they walked, she’d only been concerned about having to pull out her winter coat to beat the dust out of it, and had been thoroughly enjoying the heat from Catra’s body pressed into hers.

The start of their walk was picture perfect. Almost a caricature compared to what a living hell it had become.

Desperate as she was, Glimmer found that even with the quiet and dark of night she couldn’t quite remember walking into the bank itself. It’s odd, she thought, to forget something that wasn’t even bad but to remember so much of the fight. She does remember waiting at the window, catching some secret, and some not so secret, looks at Catra in the shiny brass panel.

It was the sound of someone screaming that hit first, then a loud banging before a man hollered, “EVERYONE THIS IS A STICK UP. STAY CALM AND NO ONE GOTTA GET HURT!”

Time seemed to move too slow and yet too fast as she’d turned around, shaking with adrenaline she saw the four robbers blocking the door. One had a bag which they were menacing folks with for valuables, another was running into the back gun trained on the poor teller to get to the safe.

She’d felt Catra press against her side, leaning in to whisper, “It’s a’right. It’s a’right, just give em what he wants. We’re alright.”

The large man who had shouted earlier, trained his shotgun on them. “No need to be so cozy ladies.”

Catra, for all that she’d seemed calm a moment before suddenly snarled and moved in front of her. “No need to be so stupid mister. We’re cooperatin’.”

Ice had run through Glimmer’s veins when the muzzle of the gun came towards them. It was like the world became unreal. The light too golden and bright. The sounds distant but loud. She was floating an inch off the ground, her arms held up by a million invisible strings as Catra did what she did best.

Being a brave fool.

“Are you serious?” The man cackled, cocking the gun and holding it to his shoulder. The muzzle moving to point directly at Glimmer’s face. “Move aside love bird, I think that fat little bitch got jus’ what I need.”

It happened so fast.

Catra, whose hands had been tucked into her belt, dashed forward and knocked the shotgun up towards the ceiling. There was a horrendous bang as plaster rained down on them, the man screaming before he gurgled. The blood spray went further than Glimmer thought it could when Catra pulled her knife out of his neck. There was a second weaker spray as he collapsed. Glimmer was still staring when she realized everyone was shouting. People were fleeing the bank, the other two cronies had turned to face their attacker but Catra had pulled the empty shotgun from his hands and used it to club one of the women dropping her like a sack of potatoes. The other woman dropped her gun and put her hands up when Catra had turned to face her.

She laughed nervously as she dropped to her knees, “H-hey, no, no worries boss! I’m, uh, I’m done!”

Catra stalked forwards and snatched her abandoned gun up off the floor, quickly checking how many shots she had.

"WHAT THE-" The last member of the crew had just come out in time to have Catra fire the discarded revolver at him. The man dove aside, crashing into the counter as he tried to return the favor only to run as Catra fired another round. He didn't run to leave, oh no, that would have been better Glimmer thought. If he'd run, he probably would of made it, and the rest of the awful experience would have been over and done long before it'd even begun.

No. He ran to her, and Glimmer could only remember in a haze every time her mother had warned her that as a wealthy heir she could be kidnapped at any time. It had seemed so ridiculous, but as he came at her Glimmer wished more fervently that she'd take some sort of lessons in shooting or fighting or whatever the hell would've helped her there.

He went down hard when Catra tackled him, the two slamming into the teller windows before falling to the dusty floor. There was a scuffle as they fought, and the man managed to over power Catra. Landing several punches to her face and arms.

She had to do something, that was *Catra* he was trying to kill! Glimmer had looked around for anything she could hit him with when she saw it. His pistol dropped when Catra had jumped him. She could get it. Right as she started to move, there was a split second where the man had looked up at her and they made eye contact. Then his gaze flicked down and Glimmer scrambled to grab the gun before him. She scooped it up and with shaking hands backed away with it pointed at the man. He chuckled, still having to hold Catra down as he spoke.

"Now, now, don't look like you know how to shoot that. Don't want to hit your friend here right? Now here's what-"

With the man distracted, and Glimmer covering, Catra had stabbed him in his side. He howled as he collapsed and Glimmer froze up when she saw the unhinged look in her friend's eyes. Like she had enjoyed sinking her blade into him. Like this was the best thing she'd ever done.

Catra was panting as she got up, gulping for air before bellowing, "Anyone else wanna try it!? ...No?"

The woman who surrendered shook her head, hands going further up in the air as if to show she was done. The few people left in the bank were dead silent, as afraid of her as they'd been the would be robbers. And Glimmer herself lowered the pistol, her arms feeling almost leadened as if she'd been holding it up for hours instead of a few minutes. She let it drop from numb fingers and had so foolishly thought to herself, *Thank the good Lord this is over. We can leave and just go home!*

"Good. Now, you," Catra viciously stomped the man groaning on the floor before continuing, "That weren't a very nice thing you just did tryin' to kidnap a lady. I don't appreciate it. Not one bit."

When he said nothing, Catra kicked him again. "You hear me boy!?"

"Yesmmm, I-ha-I hear you! I swear I hear you!"

Catra smiled, an awful oily thing. She swiped at the blood rolling down her chin, her split lip pulling painfully before squatting down. "Then you know what you gotta do, hmm? ... What do you do when you **fuck up** ."

"Catra-" Glimmer started, only to stop again at the glare she got. Not because it was so cruel, but because it was so damn familiar even though she'd never seen it. *Was this her? Always existing just under the surface?* Hundreds of flashes over the years of moments when Catra had just barely kept her temper. Shaking her hands out after gripping her belt too hard and eyes flashing dangerously at those who'd made any unasked for advances at Glimmer.

Faintly she remembered her mother, back when they'd only known Catra a few months, telling her not to get her hopes up too high over Miss D'riluth. "*You haven't seen the reports Glimmer, unless she finds a reason to change I don't believe she'll be with us*

long." Glimmer had been furious, assuming her mother was threatening to fire Catra. Now she could see it. Her mother warning her not to get attached to someone who was insisting on drowning themselves in two inches of water. She should have read those reports. *What the hell was in those reports?*

Catra pulled a fist full of the man's hair as she yanked his bandanna down, painfully craning his neck to look at her. "When you done gone and fucked up, you apologize. Now apologize to this nice young lady."

As soon as she let go, the man nodded furiously, shuffling awkwardly with a hand still pressed to his side to get up when Catra kicked him in the head. Already off balance, he twisted hard and the crack as his skull hit the floor made Glimmer jump.

"You know," Catra said, her voice as eerily light and easy as her grin, "call me old fashioned, but I do believe that when someone is **groveling for forgiveness** ...it's best done on hands and knees."

Glimmer didn't think she'd ever forget the way that man looked up at her from the floor. Eyes hazy, blood sluggishly pouring out his nose, and a trail of spit connecting his lips to the floor. The way the sunlight glinted off his sweaty face as he struggled onto hands and knees before looking up and into her eyes. It made her stomach turn.

"I," he croaked, coughed, and tried again, "Miss, I am awful sorry for my, uh, for my behavior. I am, I am very sorry ma'am. P-please forgive me miss. Please."

Glimmer stared at him for a moment before shakily responding, "I accept your apology."

Not because she did. Not for him. Not to make him feel better. But because for the first time in her life she was terrified of Catra. Because she didn't know what the other woman would do if she

refused it. Catra who had always been mean but safe, who had become a near monster in the mid morning light.

“Good boy!” Catra cheered before roughly shoving him back to the ground. “Now why don’t you just sit a spell and wait for the law hmm? Ain’t no need to cause more trouble is there son?”

“No, no ma’am.” He wheezed, not even trying to lift himself up again. Simply curling around his injury.

“Too right.” Catra chuckled before spitting on him. She slowly stood up and turned, extending her arm out for Glimmer to take. “Let’s get you home.”

Numbly Glimmer looped their arms together her gaze catching one last time of the unmoving body of the behemoth of a man who had threatened her first. The pool of blood he lay in, face down, bandanna still obscuring his identity. His sightless eyes seemed to follow her as Catra walked them both outside.

The scrawny woman who’d surrendered quickly threw herself onto her stomach, hands stretched above her head as Catra got close. Glimmer watched her step to avoid her hands before exiting into the light.

Already there was a buzz of people outside.

She didn’t see her friends, and as if her thoughts had summoned them Adora and Bow rounded the corner, with a rifle and hunting bow respectively. But it was Adora who moved towards them first, “Glimmer-Jesus H. Christ Catra what the hell happened to you?”

“Nothin’ much.” Catra chuckled, “Suppose you two are about to see the other guys anyhow. Now, if you’ll excuse us. Miss Moon needs to go home. She’s fine, just a little stunned.”

Was she stunned? Glimmer waited to feel something and when the void almost swallowed her whole decided perhaps she was. *She killed him.* Glimmer looked up at Catra's swelling face as the thought played over and over in her head. How was she acting so damn normal after having killed a man? After what she'd done to the rest? Like it was...normal to her.

Bow's arms gently circled her shoulders, jerking her out of her thoughts. He sniffled but wasn't crying.

"I'm alright Bow." She was pretty sure she sounded confident. Glimmer smiled at her two friends. "I'm alright."

Adora's gaze was piercing but she still nodded before pulling Bow into the bank. Even as she was led away Glimmer couldn't help but wonder what the two of them would make of it.

Every step away brought her back to the ground. To soil and earth and reality. Until she was no longer a mess of warring emotions. Like she'd woken up from a nightmare, Glimmer tried to process what had happened. As with most things she didn't know, this one started with a single inferno of an emotion coming to the front.

What a damnably foolish thing to have done!

Catra hadn't needed to do that, she hadn't needed to put herself in danger, and she certainly hadn't needed to kill a man! Glimmer would have happily handed over what little jewelry she was wearing, and she would have happily told her mother their local funds had been stolen. Instead she'd just frozen up like a child as Catra had gone batty as a bell tower. Glimmer was furious. Angry with herself for freezing up at the start and angry with Catra for her reckless violence. Angry with the dead man and angry with the woman who'd surrendered so quickly. Angry that Adora and Bow couldn't have come quicker than that. Angry that no one else had tried to help at all.

"You okay?" Catra asked, and she sounded so genuinely concerned that Glimmer wanted to punch her. *How dare she ask*

after all that?

She yanked her arm free, stopping them on the dirt road back to her house, only half a mind available to be grateful for the relative solitude. “No! No I am not okay Catra D’riluth! What the hell was that!?”

Catra seemed confused and surprised, and that just made her madder. “What are you-”

“God save your soul, you didn’t need to do that! You didn’t need to hurt no one like that, and-and- you killed that man and now, what, it’s okay to kill people now?! How are you acting like this ain’t some big deal when you just-” Glimmer whirled to motion back towards town, her breathing coming far too quickly and her heart pounding away. “I don’t even know who you were in there but it weren’t you!”

“It weren’t half as dangerous as some of the shit I used to get up to! I had it under control, and I wasn’t about to let them get away with it.” Catra had clearly tried to aim for a soft tone, but had failed miserably as it grated and escalated. Her jaw going tense, hands curling into fists. Well look at that, she was finally starting to look mad herself.

Good.

“No, you can’t just hand wave this away. There ain’t no explanation you can give that’ll make what you just did even vaguely okay!”

“Well excuse me for not wanting you to get hurt!”

“I will not pardon you!” Glimmer stomped her foot, throwing her hands out wide. “I will not excuse you from overreacting and killing a man dead!”

“I weren’t over reacting he was going to KILL you!”

“He was **tryin’** ta scare us!”

“Well it worked!” Catra screamed, they both froze as she began panting for breath. Eyes wild and watering as she finally put some cards down on the table. “You ain’t the only one who cares you know! I care! Is that what you wanted to hear? I care about you alright! I think I lo-and he-I couldn’t-if-”

Catra’s mouth clicked shut as she began to pace, agitated. Hands clenched tight around her upper arms in a half hug as she tried to figure out how to explain herself.

It was in that moment that Glimmer found clarity through the storm. In all the years she’d known Catra, the other woman had never once been good with her words. Half threatening and shouting, and generally vulgar when Glimmer did something foolish. But while she’d held to her promise to be better, Catra could still be mean. Hands always soft and warm, eyes always wild and wide, the way she’d loosen like an old coil when she realized Glimmer was safe. The way she’d developed a staring habit. She’d been trying to show how much she cared by being there. By showing up and shutting up. Catra had started to hold doors open and was always ready to help her up or down from a single small step to getting on her horse. Glimmer had taken their new found flirting to be more friendly than anything when Catra hadn’t done a thing more after that fateful day in the canyon. Assuming that her strange new habits of arriving early and leaving late were because of the job and not because Glimmer was there. Assuming her now growing collection of geodes and feathers was something small when clearly Catra’s gifts weren’t small at all.

Glimmer mumbled, dumbly saying the first thought that came to mind as the pieces suddenly snapped together, “That’s why you’re scared of my mother. I get it now.”

Catra laughed, not a happy laugh by any stretch, before turning to face her. Hunched in as she asked, “What?”

“I said…” Glimmer paused, changing her mind at the last moment. Catra D’riluth could be more skittish then a rabbit in a field when confronted directly. Accusing her point blank of being in love, well,

that was sure to send her running out of town faster than fast could be.

And Glimmer didn't want that.

"I said, well, I said I understand but you can't just...go off. Catra, you *scared me* in there." Glimmer made sure to keep eye contact as she started shaking again. With the anger cut off that deep fear had come back. " **You** scared me more than they did."

Two tone eyes went wide, her mouth dropping open but no sound came out before a single weak, "I didn't mean to."

"That don't make it right."

"I…"

There was a long pause where neither spoke, both of them just trembling away under the heat of the sun.

Catra slowly began to close the distance, stopping just a few feet short before going to one knee. It was like Glimmer was still trapped in the bank again, staring down at that man's face. She felt like she could vomit right there and then, everything screaming how wrong this was. She didn't remember moving but she did remember standing with Catra in her arms as she cried.

"Don't! Don't do that! Don't do that!"

"I'm sorry," Catra whispered into her hair, voice straining as more and more tears rolled down her cheeks. "I'm sorry."

That's how they were still standing when her mother found them. Catra tried to disengage, her knees shaking so bad that Glimmer could feel them against her legs. She wasn't ready to give up the only support keeping her upright, so Glimmer kept her grip tight on Catra's hand, twisting to face her mother who looked panicked by the tablou.

It was a halting explanation as they made their way home, neither sure what to say.

As they talked, her mother gently wiped the dust and small amount of blood off of her face. No, she didn't think she'd ever forget the look in her mother's eyes as she'd cleaned off the blood.

"It's a good thing Catra was there," Glimmer tacks on at the very end of the story, already sitting heavily on the settee and feeling exhausted. "...she saved me."

Is that a lie, I don't know. Didn't she?

Catra, face washed and cleaned, stared at her like a deer dazzled by a flash of light.

Within minutes of that she'd been drooping low. Between the adrenaline dip and the emotional exhaustion, Glimmer had felt ready to sleep for years. She'd barely been tracking as she had gone upstairs, stripping her clothes down to her nightgown and all but collapsing into bed. Now on the other end of several sleepless hours, and with the sun having long since set, Glimmer still couldn't sleep. She had reflexively faked it when her mother had come to check on her at supper time, and once more when she'd come before going to sleep herself.

Everything was just tied up so badly in her she didn't know what to do. *Catra killed a man and she loves me.* Glimmer rolled onto her side and looked out her window to the endless expanse of stars. *She killed a man and I love her. I still love her? How can I still love her?*

How was it she was just as hamstrung by the idea that perhaps their ever deepening relationship could actually go somewhere beyond her dreams as she had been while being held up in the damn bank? A few tears pricked at her eyes as she finally sat up. Glimmer stayed there until she noticed her own smell too much and then she had to stifle her horribly inappropriate laughter.

What a time to be concerned about body odor! Still, if she couldn't sleep the least she could do was actually wash up properly.

Despite the chill in the air, Glimmer was not about to risk warming any water with the kettle. She quickly sponged the most important spots, eyes averted from the small mirror over her basin. When finished she fumbled around in the dark to get her toothbrush and her tin of tooth powder opened. The gritty feel of the powder turning into paste never failed to disappoint, but she tried to focus more on the minty flavor. At least that was still a delight after all these years. She'd barely gargled some water to get the whole affair finished before there was a light knocking at her door. Her mother was sound asleep, and even if she wasn't, Angella Brightmoon did not believe in knocking.

Did...did Catra not go home? Glimmer wouldn't blame her. Company housing was on the other side of town, and her mother had surely offered.

"Glimmer? You awake?" Catra whisper shouted.

Glimmer only paused a moment before opening the door and letting her in. Propriety be damned, she'd had a hell of a day and deserved to do whatever she so pleased!

Catra shuffled in and when Glimmer got a good look at her she snorted, hands coming up to stop her giggling to no avail.

Catra's face was a complete mess, and so swollen that her scowling really made no difference. It was the borrowed chemise which reached her mother's ankles hanging so awkwardly off Catra's much shorter frame that did it. The whole thing was rolled up at the bottom and tied part way up her thighs to keep her from tripping on it.

"L-like a lil child!" Glimmer wheezed.

"An' here I was coming to see if you was alright." Catra groused but her one visible eye held nothing but relief. "I see how it is."

Even though she was the one laughing, Glimmer shushed Catra as best she could. Almost rushing to grab her arm when she made a big show of turning to leave. *She killed-hush yourself!* She was tired and lonely and still a little scared, and she just wanted Catra for a little bit. *What does that make me?*

Catra was easy to tug, willing to go with her over to the bed even if her face goes bright red. By the time they're both sitting Glimmer's managed to stop her giggles, it was so unfortunate she couldn't figure out what to say.

Eventually, with Glimmer alternating between playing with her fingers and opening her mouth without anything coming out, Catra was the one who broke the silence. "I did mean it. Are you alright?"

"It's a'right, we're a'right." It played in her mind as Glimmer frowned. Slowly she shook her head.

"Okay, that, yeah." Catra sighed, looking down at their hands again. "...is it me?"

Glimmer wanted nothing more than to deny that. That it wasn't Catra, it was never Catra, that **thing** in the bank was not her Catra. But damn if that weren't a lie. "You scared me."

Catra winced, but seemed resigned. "I can leave."

"Please don't." Glimmer begged, the idea of being alone again was God awful. She looked up and prayed that the tears in her eyes wouldn't be seen in the dark as unlikely as it was. Based on the blank look she could see it didn't matter much. She gripped Catra's hand tighter. "Are you, are you there?"

Catra's head tilted as she squinted in confusion. "Yeah?"

"Oh thank the Lord," Glimmer mumbled, she hadn't forgotten that episode in the canyon either. The idea of Catra disappearing for the second time in the day was too much to handle. "You listen to

me right now. You...you scared me but I don't want ya to leave. Not tonight. Not tomorrow. Not...not ever, you understand me?"

When Catra just stared like she'd never spoken a lick of English in her life, Glimmer tried again. "You know that I care about you right? This, this was- ha, this was a lot today. A lot."

In the pause where she tried to figure out how to properly express herself Catra squeezed her hands. "Yeah, suppose it was."

This wasn't how she pictured trying to explain she was in love. Hell this wasn't how she'd pictured a damn thing in her life. Was this how she wanted to handle this? A declaration of love after a rebuke and fear? No. Glimmer looked carefully at their joined hands, pressed into the warmth of the quilt on her bed. This wasn't the right time. Not to say those words, not to ask about it, not to follow that line at all. She deserved better- Catra deserved better! As much as Glimmer hated to think it, it weren't right. Not yet. Not here.Not when their edges were so frayed. Not when they were going to have to learn who each other were again.

The idea sat wrong, and Glimmer bit at her lip. Why? Why? Because...because...When Glimmer looked up again she realized that she didn't really know Catra at all. Sure she knew who Catra was here. But before she'd found Catra half dead from alcohol poisoning out on the mesa, she'd never talked about that. What did Glimmer even really know? She kept reasoning that Catra wasn't one way and something kept coming up to prove otherwise. Four years into their friendship and Glimmer finally realized that Catra was still a near stranger.

She could fix that. Glimmer could fix that. Into the too long silence she finally took a step she needed to, had needed to for a while.

"What did you use to do?"

"What?" Catra looked nervous, spooked.

“You said today weren’t half as dangerous as what you used to do. I know you didn’t mean brakeman.” When there wasn’t an answer Glimmer hastened to explain. “I just, I realized I don't know that much about you and we’ve been thick as thieves for years now. It’s been awful rude of me to not ask after you ‘t all.”

Catra doesn’t answer though. Instead her breathing goes fast and she tugs at her hair painfully hard, she’s starting to cry even though it’s obvious she was trying not to.

Glimmer wrapped her up in a hug. “Hey, you don’t have to do nothing you don’t want to!”

Catra swallowed thickly, having a few false starts before saying, “Thank you. I, uh, I will. I’ll tell you someday. I swear it, but I just, I can’t. Not right now. Ya understand?”

“Alright. That’s alright. How about this? Just...tell me about yourself?”

Catra laughed, trying to sit up and get out of the hug.

Confound it all woman! Glimmer just held on tighter.

Catra’s resigned when she asks, “What’s there to know?”

“Plenty, you ain’t some mysterious stranger no more. You’re my friend. Is it so bad that I want to know you more?” Oh this is a dangerous game to play. They are nearly naked, alone and unsupervised in Glimmer’s room. And she’s making half a pass at this woman.

“...maybe. Maybe not. Sure I can’t dissuade you?”

With Glimmer’s glare cutting through the darkness, Catra starts talking. And Glimmer listened. She listened close as she could and soaked up each new fact with relish. Catra is an orphan, had no siblings, but she found a family. Then things went sour and she left. She likes the heat, she enjoys feeling the sun on her face. She doesn’t like snow one bit. Catra less moved and more ran

away from her problems. It goes on and on. Turning into rambles about anything she can apparently think of. She likes the color red the most. She enjoys drinking but doesn't actually like getting drunk. Catra has an undeniable soft spot for small animals. She likes smoking, but doesn't since Angella doesn't like it. She tried chew but it tasted like 'sad old miner shoes'.

And as she talks, Glimmer also understand something else too. Catra seems almost desperate to talk, like every little thing has been building up for four whole years and waiting to explode. She doesn't like asking for help and looking weak or foolish. But here she is. Telling Glimmer just because she'd asked. Catra might be heart shy, but it don't mean she's stone.

It hits like a train coming off the tracks. It's not that she's been a bad friend, but Glimmer also hadn't given nearly as much back as she'd thought. Waiting endlessly for the confident seemingly mysterious woman to make a move or take a chance. Catra was never going to take that chance. How many times had they missed an opportunity because Glimmer thought she should be wooed and Catra thought she had no right to try?

Yes, Catra killed a man today, and Glimmer doesn't know what to do with that yet. But she does know that she loves her. Watching Catra's grin in the moonlight was a balm she hadn't known she'd needed. Oh yes, Glimmer knew she loved her regardless. And she'd almost lost the chance to try today. She'd almost been shot and Catra had nearly had her skull beaten in. *I have to try. Lord help me, I need to at least try.*

Now she just needed a way to make the first move.

"Hey."

Catra stops almost immediately, shrinking a little as if afraid she's said too much.

"Can you teach me to fight? Like, hold a gun and such?" Glimmer huffs. "Oh that came out sounding all wrong. You know what I

mean! If anything happens I don't want to feel so...helpless…"

"I ain't gonna go easy on ya just because yer pretty. You know that right?"

"Why Miss D'riluth, you think I'm pretty?" Glimmer batted her eyes, trying her hardest to act like the most spoiled awful socialite she could think of. "Well heaven's to Betsy, what will we ever do? I suppose we could have a winter wedding, but I hear that's bad luck."

Catra groaned, shoving at her to emphasize herself. "I do not! Now stop that!"

"Oh! I've been spurred by my beloved!" Glimmer fake wailed, draping herself over the mattress.

Catra was snickering, and doing her damndest to keep up. "Beloved!? Woman, I don't even like you!"

"Oh woe! Oh woe is me! My tender lil' heart is just broken in twine. Twain? Twine? Twain. Broken in twain! But I suppose I'll live if she teaches me how to shoot a gun."

"I'm gonna regret this aren't I?"

Glimmer paused for a moment, trying to picture which kind of weapon would feel best in her hands without ever having touched them. Eventually the image of many a trick rider came to mind. People riding side saddle, standing up right, and shooting beautiful looking rifles at incredibly small targets. "I want to shoot a rifle."

"Oh yeah, I already regret this. I will teach you, but we start with a pistol you hear?"

"Mmm-hmm, a pistol then a rifle."

"No, a pistol then a heavier caliber revolver."

Knowing full well she’ll be denied, Glimmer cheerfully adds, “And then a shotgun.”

The idea alone fills her with a sense of calm. This won’t ever happen again because Glimmer will be the one toting a gun. She won’t use it, but it’ll deter even the most vile of gangsters if they’re target isn’t easy pickings. And if it’s a grand excuse to have Catra close, well that’s just a bonus.

And if that’s just an excuse for Glimmer to figure out how to get this woman to say three little words, well, that’s the damn plan.

Chapter End Notes

> For those who skipped, as you have probably pieced together there was a bank robbery where Catra reacted /very/ poorly to Glimmer's life being threatened during and she let loose on all that anger that's been building in her. She takes the robbers out (why hello Kyle 2 and her lizard girlfriend making a cameo) after killing the man who threatened Glimmer (Tung Lashor you fool of a man). Glimmer dissociates basically the whole time before saving Catra's life by grabbing a gun. They both leave afterwards.
>
> Alternate Chapter Titles:
>
> I wouldn't say 'stab' when I stab someone with the knife!
>
> Stick Ups and Buttercups
>
> Glimmer Get Your Gun
>
> Up Next: Catra is running unusually late which wouldn't be a problem if it weren't midnight, moonless, and generally a bad time to get injured. After five years of mutual pining someone will finally make a move!

Chapter 6: Home, Home on the Range

Chapter Summary

> When Catra doesn't come home on time, Glimmer may get a might bit nervous about her. And rightfully so!

Chapter Notes

> The one where Catra gets a concussion and somehow still made it to Glimmer's house.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After living under her mother’s roof for 24 years Glimmer had fully expected living on her own to be exciting. She’d pictured being able to do whatever she wanted, however she wanted. She’d thought, once, what in the world she would do if her roof collapsed (the answer to that one had been go to Bow and beg for help). She’d imagined warm summer days fanning herself on the porch and cold winter nights in front of the stove. She envisioned decorations and room layout, and even the location the house would be in. Despite not having a home nor, for most of her life, a desire to live alone it had all been idle fancy.

Never in all her daydreaming had Glimmer once considered re-arranging her house so she could pace nervously in circles in comfort.

When she’d first purchased the old house, it had been a wreck. Sold at auction cheap after being abandoned for several years. Adora had stared at her in dismay when they’d arrived to see the property. The house itself looked decent on the outside, but inside was a lot of woodwork in need of repair and cleaning to be done. There was a small fenced area in the back with a dilapidated barn and rusted buckets all over. Glimmer had never felt more proud in her *life* .

Adora snorted with one brow smugly raised, “You, you actually bought this?”

“Hush,” Glimmer chirped, far too wrapped up in visions of what her home would look like eventually to sneer anything back. “I needed a change any hows.”

Adora’s grin faltered, before she turned back to the house with a frown. “Suppose.”

Adora had been by the day after the robbery, determined and wanting to help if there was any way to do it. Adora had been almost overly pleasant in her attempts too, until Catra had stumbled down stairs. The two had looked at one another before Catra grunted a single hello and limped to the nearest chair. Before they’d seemed friendly, friendly enough that first year that Glimmer sometimes wondered what they had done alone. She understood though. Seeing that sort of awful bloody mess and gathering witness accounts, she understood if Adora was cautious around their friend.

So Adora had kept coming by to check in on her, as often as her new Deputy duties would allow.

It went from sweet to smothering quicker than Glimmer had expected. While Catra was recovering in their home, Adora arrived to walk Glimmer to and from work, the general store, the barber for goodness sake. She’d taken to following Glimmer during rides, and when she couldn’t often Glimmer would simply turn around to find her other friend far less subtly following.

“Beauregard Archer you come out this instant!”

“Heeeeeeeeeello Glimmer, fancy running into you out here!”

By itself it could have been tolerable, at least for a little longer. The three of them had long since fine tuned how far to take their overly protective streaks before a fight broke out. But it had been coupled with her mother’s hovering and Catra’s probing questions, which had already made Glimmer twitchy for freedom.

And that didn’t even include the letters that had poured in!

To My Most Stalwart of Friends,

Adora wrote and explained what happened, how awful that must have been! I can not imagine the bravery you found to assist in stopping a robbery. Do write and let me know who your shooting instructor is, perhaps I can convince mother and father to finally allow me a speck of freedom.

Yours Expectantly,

Frosta

My Dearest Glimmer,

I spoke with Frosta Mackenzie at the Plumerian Harvest Dance, which I was rather worried when you did not attend, and have just heard of your ordeal. It is a terrible thing that drives people to such violent and desperate acts. I have the earth and her kindness for your safety during your ordeal. Even as I write I can hear the band striking in to one of your favorites and I can feel myself nearly faint with the thrill of it! If there is anything I can do for you, you need only request and I shall make my way to you post haste!

If I do not hear from you before, I shall endeavor to seek you out at Mermista’s dance in the spring. Stay safe and stay strong.

With Love and Harmony Bestowed Upon You,

Perfuma

It was sweet of Adora to have written to so many (although Glimmer had noted she had chosen those known best for their gossip and connections).

Glimmer was about ready to drown the girl.

Adora had, in her most memorable attempt, scared both her and Catra witless by jumping over the little ridge her mother's home was nestled next to, with her gun already drawn. Glimmer and Catra had stared at her and Adora stared back in confusion as Swift Wind nickered and began searching for apples. Apparently there had been reports of gunshots heard by the towns folks and she had come afraid of the worst. Instead, she found Glimmer poorly aiming a pistol and a very exasperated Catra trying to correct her form with one eye still squinted from the bruising instead of something much worse. Glimmer had been mortified by the whole affair and tried to end the lesson right then. Catra had thrown a fit, which Adora had felt compelled to match, and the two had ended up working together to get her shooting at the general target before Adora suggested they take it outta town to spare her heart and soul. Though Glimmer suspected it was more to prevent an accidental shooting than anything else.

So out they'd gone, searching for a safe location still nearby enough to not make it a hassle. For a while they'd used a little stretch of mesa a bit too close, then they'd gone into the juniper and spruce a bit too far, and finally Glimmer had seen the old abandoned house. It was a good two and a half miles from town, a hefty enough walking distance but not too bad by horse. After shooting there for a few days Glimmer had started dreaming of doing something different at that little house.

Her and Catra waking up in that quaint little house together.

Catra making coffee and complaining that it was awful.

The two of them on the porch. In the garden. Tending the horses. Anywhere.

Just the two of them.

And dreaming lead to planning.

Despite what people seemed to think, Glimmer had been working for BMR since she was fourteen. At first she'd done it disguised as a boy, best she could. Then one day her mother had come through the station during a walkabout, and Glimmer had only been spared the indignity of being dragged by her ear because her mother didn't want to get the town talking. But after that she'd started assisting her mother without the disguise and far from the trains. Numbers and ledgers and logistics, and all sorts of hooey that Glimmer had no interest in. But for every task she did she was paid, and Glimmer was no fool with money.

So she'd looked into that little house and when she was lacking, Glimmer had gone to her mother for a loan. Proving viability had been one thing, Angella Moon could see exactly when the money would be repaid and understood the sound logistics of Glimmer's plan. The loan was approved and used successfully to put her bid in.

Getting her mother to let her leave their house so soon after a brush with death had been the tricky part. Especially when it got to the part where they started yelling and fighting.

"And just what will you do when people start learning that Glimmer Moon is living isolated and alone?" Angella had shouted.

Tears in her eyes Glimmer had howled back, "Well it's a good thing I know how to shoot a gun now isn't it? I can make 'em feel right at home!"

"Glimmer!"

Just thinking about Glimmer living far away apparently made Angella's skin crawl. Ironically it was her mother's complaining to Catra that had apparently started to wear down Angella's indomitable will. Stuck day in and day out together, and with both on opposite sides of the argument, they apparently had talked it

through. And by 'talk it through', Glimmer was sure Catra had meant bickered incessantly. She'd seen just one short example, and had nearly died of laughter.

"Surely you understand why that would make a mother uncomfortable?" Angella's voice was perfectly pleasant, as if discussing the weather.

"Couldn't say ma'am, ain't never had one to know." Catra had sounded normal herself, but as Glimmer snuck around the corner she'd seen the woman tense and more nervous looking than a foal on ice. "But I do know the more you try t' crack down the more yer gonna find you've pushed her away."

Angella finished some notations with a fine rubber stamp before continuing, "A balance is what's important here, I am not looking to live my daughter's life."

"Says you, begging your pardon ma'am. I think Glimmer should have a say in her life." Catra flipped the page in her book a little more forcefully than needed.

Glimmer had nearly tottled away desperate to not shriek right there and give up the game. She never tire of someone taking another's poor arguments out at the knees, and seeing her mother's shocked frown was a thing of beauty.

Of course it had given her some ideas of her own.

As she traveled out with Adora and Bow, and sometimes Catra despite her complaints, to fix the house up she'd thought of arguments. Trying to play on the foundations Catra was laying out and had been gratified to see it through. Not that her mother approved, but that she understood and was willing to capitulate meant a lot.

Of course that good will had only lasted until the arguments started shifting to *when* Glimmer would be allowed to move.

"You will wait until the spring Glimmer, what would you do in that old shack if you get cut off from town? It won't be fully renovated and fixed for at least three years by your estimation and the winter is no time for contracted work." Her mother had proclaimed over dinner one night.

Eventually that argument failed, mostly because Glimmer had packed her bags in secret and ran away with the somewhat reluctant help of her two best friends. Angella had only sighed when Glimmer arrived for work, but she was certain she'd seen her mother smile. Work had only been awkward as she sat between an insufferably smug Catra and her overly formal mother to prevent a brawl the next day, but it had been worth it!

Now, fixed up nicely, her house had become a home. Nothing quite going to plan but everything falling well enough into place. Well, almost into place until tonight.

Glimmer grunted as she pushed the settee further over, she needed a bigger circuit to pace damn it all!

Catra had started coming by after the move on the daily, picking her up and dropping her off with regularity for both work and shooting practice. No amount of Adora pouting about how she'd done nearly the same and not gotten a single thank you changed Glimmer's infatuation with what it could mean. It had gotten to the point that Glimmer kept a few things around just for her. A change of clothes, spare toiletries, her favorite tobacco, tin of coffee; small things over all for a woman who often ended up spending the night if it got too late. Something that Glimmer often tried to make happen, and something that Catra seemed happy to oblige her with.

And some of those dreams had come right on through beautifully. Glimmer had watched with a soft smile in the mornings as Catra had carefully set up her shaving kit, grumbling the whole way about how it was too damn expensive to get professionally. She'd managed to watch a few times through her fingers as Catra

carefully but quickly took care of the hair she didn't want to keep around.

"I don't know, I think you'd look right handsome with a beard." Glimmer mused, yelping when Catra flicked her to get her attention.

*"And hide this beautiful face?" Catra asked even as a glob of soap began a slow but steady descent down her throat from the half still covered in it. "It would be a **sin** Miss, and I ain't that kind of gal!"*

Morning coffee had turned out better than she'd imagined, and Glimmer really couldn't complain about that much when instead of adorable grumbling she was treated to Catra working in the kitchen. Giving Tao his cool down brushing and making sure the horses couldn't reach the last few apples from the lone crab apple tree twisting up by the barn, to feeding the stove with kindling Catra had helped with. It was a dream come true.

So today, she hadn't been worried one bit when Catra had needed to talk with Ms. Turron about something or another so they'd parted ways for the afternoon. After all, they both knew Catra would ride to her house for supper if nothing else. Her possessions still locked in the company trunk more as a vague nod to polite society and proper conduct than anything else. So Glimmer did her chores and got to cooking.

Well supper had sat for a good hour before Glimmer hadn't been able to sit still any longer. Winter had made the whole town cold, but out here it could get downright freezing. I was something she was typically grateful for as it meant far fewer insects to bother as she worked. Now, waiting for Catra is just felt brutal. She'd gone to sit on the porch, bundled up in her winter coat and scarf until she couldn't feel her finger tips. The stove cranked out a most delightful heat while Glimmer had huffed about Catra's inability to be on time if she weren't being paid, and in a little fit of pique she'd heated up water to take a bath. If she was doomed to wait she was going to do it in comfort, not like Catra didn't have a key!

When she'd woken up from napping in the now cool tub Glimmer realized how late it was. A quick look around was enough to show that Catra still hadn't made it despite how dark it was.

Hence all the pacing, and rearranging to better fit said pacing.

It was late and cold enough to make searching for her a dangerous proposition. With no true trail having been fully cut and maintained, Catra's path wouldn't be easy to guess at. It wouldn't due for her to arrive only for Glimmer to be the one lost and turned around. That was a quick way to get yourself killed from exposure, and it would be with the horrible facts of having died within a few miles of home **and** proving her mother right.

I could use a rope? Leave a trail to follow back!

It wasn't a good idea but it was at least a plan. Glimmer pulled her winter clothes back on before going outside and grabbing her rope. All ten feet of it before realizing just how dumb of a plan it was. "Okay, okay, get your pack, lantern, and a knife. Mark the trees."

She'd just finished getting her hiking pack finished and secured on her back when something slammed into her front door. Glimmer jumped, staring for a moment before rushing to open it. A body collapsed in towards her, and Glimmer caught Catra before she could hit the ground even if it still sent them both sprawling to the ground. She pulled her inside and shut the door, scrambling to keep the heat inside where her friend needed it most. Catra herself just groaned on the floor, eyes closed tight as she tried and failed to roll over.

"The hell did you do?" Glimmer gasped. There was some awful looking bruising under her right eye but otherwise she looked alright. Her first assumption was that Catra was drunk, but no. No, she hated that. "Catra?"

"What?" Catra croaked, eyes cracking open before slamming shut again with a hiss. "Huh?"

Glimmer looked around as if that would answer anything and spoke slower. “What happened to you?”

“Fuckin’ hell,” Catra moaned as Glimmer pulled her upright. She swayed dangerously and almost collapsed, eyes unfocused and face blank as tilted forward to clutch her head with her left hand.

Glimmer waited until she was certain Catra would stay upright before pulling her pack off, shrugging out of her coat and mitts as well. “Catra?”

“Mmmm...where’s Tao?” She asked through clenched teeth, but after blinking a few times seemed to almost focus on Glimmer’s face. “How’d I get here?”

If she had been anxious before, Glimmer was sure she was discovering new ways to feel it. “I’m trying to figure that out.”

Catra’s right arm was pulled up towards her chest protectively, but Glimmer couldn’t see an obvious injury or blood there. “Oh...yeah, Tao threw me.”

Glimmer froze before rushing back over and checking for broken bones. “Jesus! Ah, okay! What hurts? What’s wrong?”

Catra chuckled, then hissed as she reached to cradle her bruised cheek. “Head. Arm. leg…. Uhm, wait...Tao threw me?”

“You mentioned,” Glimmer gently ran her fingers along Catra’s right arm, noting that it only seemed to be her forearm as Catra had reflexively tried to pull it away as soon as Glimmer touched it. Her assessment on the right leg lead her to believe it was more Catra’s ankle than anything. *Lord in heaven do not let it be broken!*

“Oh, that’s good.” Catra nodded only to stop and breathe far deeper than she had been. After a moment she added, “Threw up on th’ way here.”

Probably hit her damn head!

"I bet. Let's get you on the couch, floor ain't no place for you." Glimmer moved to her left side and pulled them both up. She winced in sympathy as Catra whimpered, trailing off into a whine as they stumbled along. Between her limp and listing to one side, it was a miracle that Glimmer kept them upright. Once on the couch proper, Glimmer pulled her left boot off and then the right. Poking around she didn't feel anything off, but Catra still cursed and moaned. "Alright, hang on, I need to get some supplies real quick."

She had gone just a few steps before opening the front door one more time, but there was no sign of Tao. Glimmer huffed, sparing one last look before closing it tight. She wasn't about to worry about him when Catra was injured on the settee.

Glimmer knew a little first aid thanks to Bow's insistence that she learn. *"What if I break my leg Glimmer, it'll be up to you. Safety first!"* But she also knew that first thing in the morning she'd need to ride into town and get the doctor out here. A quick arm splint, cold wet cloth over her eyes, and elevated foot was about the best Glimmer could do, and she would rather be safe than sorry. She also knew she'd need to apologize and thank Bow again for the lessons. Sure, her mother had required it before allowing the two of them to hike or ride outside of town alone, but Bow had insisted on making her actually learn.

She'd thought Catra had fallen asleep by the time she finished, and nearly yelped when the woman slurred, "How'syer day?"

Glimmer did her best to not snap about how it had been wonderful until she'd been forced to find her bottle of laudanum. Instead she focused on counting out the drops before adding some whiskey to the glass she held. When she'd been younger her menstrual cramps had been horrifically intense, and the doctor had happily prescribed laudanum for it. Glimmer hadn't cared much at the time, but was now rather grateful they'd gone to an actual pharmacist and not the tobacconist or barber. They had not turned the bottle over until her mother understood the addictive natures of the drug, something neither had even heard

of. Bow had absorbed the information like a sponge and made sure Glimmer hadn't taken more than needed.

She'd watched poor old Cobalt slowly but surely get swept away by the opioid a few years later, and that had been enough to scare her for life. Still, Glimmer kept the bottle and when she'd run out a year back she had gotten another much smaller one.

"Never you mind that, can you drink something for me?" Glimmer was very grateful the settee had such a steep side now, the idea of trying to sit Catra up again was harrowing. "Some medicine for your headache. It's- I put it in whiskey."

Please say yes, please say yes, how am I supposed to trick you into drinking?

"Suuuure," Catra said, waiting more patiently than Glimmer had ever seen before realizing Catra wasn't going to be able to reach for something when she couldn't see. Glimmer lifted the glass and carefully poured. As soon as she'd finished the small half shot, Catra had burped. "I don't feel good."

"Catra D'riluth, go to sleep." Rest was one of the best prescriptions, but in this case it was more that it was about the only choice.

But apparently Catra was feeling chatty.

"Naw," Catra whined, "dun wanna. You, do you know how hard it was tuh- to limp my sorry self here?"

"No and I do not wish to know." At least not right now. "You hit your head; s'all I need to know."

"I did? Oh."

"...so you said."

"I hit my head pretty hard?" Catra asked, before twitching. "Feels ripe to burst."

“Just so.” Glimmer took another rag from her pile, and dunked it in the water she’d brought to switch it with the one across Catra’s closed eyes.

The worst part of this house had been knowing that she’d have to keep living from a well while her mother’s house had just gotten fit for indoor plumbing. The new flushing toilet, warm inside the house, had made her mad with envy. A tap that could be turned easily for water a dream. She was just glad she had a bucket full inside so it wouldn’t freeze.

Catra smiled slightly, her voice was soft and sweet and she echoed, “Just so.”

“Well it’s a good thing you made it here then ain’t it?” Glimmer asked, poking at Catra’s shoulder gently. “This way you got some medicine and can get some sleep.”

“Why’d I do that when yer here?”

Glimmer waited for her to laugh or smirk or do something else to tease her right back. But when all she got was a small pleased smile, she suddenly realized that Catra was being deadly serious. “You musta hit it pretty hard. Look at you being all sweet as honey.”

“I’s true,” Catra minutely tilted her head, as if to glare at Glimmer from behind the cloth over her eyes.

“A’right, it’s true, I ain’t fightin’ ya now just lay still!” Glimmer said.

Catra groped blindly with her left hand, awkwardly searching to her right. Glimmer rolled her eyes but grabbed her hand. Catra sighed heavily. “Oh good, you’re here!”

“Yup,” Glimmer scooted to sit more comfortably on the floor without letting go of Catra’s hand. “Wouldn’t leave you for the world.”

Catra nearly gave a full blown smile but she winced as her cheek twinged. “Miss, you gonna spoil me.”

Glimmer changed out the rags, trying to keep a cold one on her eyes and forehead to help with the fire’s light and headache. “Maybe I want to spoil you, after your stupid heroics coming out here injured.”

Catra’s grin became a frown. “You always worry too much Glim. You can only do what you can do darlin’.”

And if her heart didn’t skip a damn beat right then, Glimmer would’ve been shocked. *Don’t make this awkward, she is injured.* “You-I-no I do not!”

“You cried over a, uh, that little...”

Glimmer winced, knowing exactly what she was talking about regardless of how jumbled she was.

And first of all, that deer had been anything but little!

Catra had broken, after Glimmer practiced daily with her pistol and then a loaned revolver, and agreed to let her try a rifle. They’d ridden out far enough to not cause a problem, and while Catra had been kneeling demonstrating the proper way to hold it, the deer had stepped out into the field. Glimmer had pointed it out in awe, but Catra had whispered back, *“You ever go hunting?”*

It didn’t take long to make an agreement and Catra had taken the shot just as Glimmer’s shifting startled the poor thing. What should have been a clean shot ended up getting right messy.

Secondly, Glimmer would like to argue that any sane city person would’ve cried too at the pitiful sounds it had made. Catra had quickly finished it off with her hunting knife and a series of apologies to her. She’d still pulled herself together enough to help drag the creature back to the horses, and had made herself go and help when Bow arrived to butcher it.

Of course she'd worried over the poor deer, but that was besides the point!

"That was different!" Glimmer huffed, flushing with a combination of shame and embarrassment over her childish behavior that day.

"Hmm?" Catra's thumb swiped lazily back and forth over her hand, and Glimmer realized she probably didn't understand or remember what she'd just said. "What's yer name?"

God almighty, it would have been funny if it hadn't been a bit frightening. "Glimmer."

"Glimmer!" Catra sounded pleased at least. "Why can't I see you?"

"Your head was achin' so I put a cloth on ya." Glimmer waited a moment before adding, "It's made you all sweet like."

"Mmm always sweet." Catra mumbled. "Least with you."

"Oh good Lord," Glimmer whispered to herself as her heart gave another robust kick behind her ribs.

Catra, though, had apparently misheard her. Because the next thing she mumbled was, "Love ya too."

Glimmer stared at her for a solid minute at least. A mixture of amusement and exasperation tugging at her heart painfully as she processed what had just happened. When she finally broke out of it, the first thing she did was change the cloth again (to keep it cool and damp), only to find herself staring into Catra's eyes. They were soft with a depth of affection Glimmer had not been sure she'd ever get to have turned fully on her or not.

Despite her efforts to make the first move, it turned out it was much easier said than done. Glimmer had tried to be more open with Catra, both when speaking and listening, and sometimes when she got the courage with her physical affections. She hadn't been sure if she was making headway or just making Catra clam up tighter. The two of them had still been locked in a dance. Well,

at least she had an answer for whether her attempts had made any headway.

“Do you know how long I have been trying to get those words outta you?” Glimmer chuckled softly, feeling tears build up before she covered Catra’s eyes again.

“Yeah?”

“I have fallen in love with a fool,” she teased, squeezing Catra’s hand as she wiped at her own eyes.

Catra’s voice was all awe when she asked, “You love me?”

This was not the jewelry or flowers she’d envisioned, not during their walks in the wild where the beauty of the land could leave you breathless. This was something far better than she’d imagined, even with Catra laid up.

“I do.” She almost leaned in, before berating herself for taking advantage.

Catra huffed, petulant. “Well why ain’t you ever kissed me?”

“...D’riluth, do not make me hit you.” Still, Glimmer shuffled onto her knees and leaned down just enough to kiss her.

Catra’s lips scratched a little from being chapped, but it was still so soft and warm and perfect. It lasted maybe a few seconds before Glimmer pulled back unsure. Had that been right? Had it been decent and wanted? Silly thoughts but ones that had her checking just in case.

Catra hadn’t been holding herself stiff by any means, but somehow she melted further into the cushions below her with a happy little sound and a small dopey grin. And that was just cute enough that Glimmer leaned down one more time for another kiss.

*Why did I wait five whole **years** to do this?* Was about the only thing she could think. If Catra was a fool, then Glimmer was sure she must be stupid. This was the best thing she'd ever done in her life! *Why in the world was I so darn scared?*

This time when they broke apart Catra whispered, "Imma die happy, even when yer mom kills me."

"She would not!" Glimmer giggled resting her forehead gently on the uninjured part of Catra's arm. "Probably."

Catra half chuckled and half hissed, letting go to try and hold her head again. Shoot!

"Alright, that's enough of all that for now. Get some sleep. Please." Glimmer got up slowly, letting the stiffness in her knees fade a little before gently stroking Catra's curls. "I'll be here when you wake up."

"M'okay."

When the doctor came the next day he prescribed rest. When he left, Catra prescribed kisses. Glimmer was happy to oblige them both.

Chapter End Notes

FINALLY!

Also, Catra has hirsutism b/c I want her to have big fluffy gray sideburns in place of her little fur tufts and also be wonderfully fuzzy still.

Chapter 7: Sink or Swim

Chapter Summary

Catra thinks about how far the two of them have come before asking Glimmer the most important question of her life.

Chapter Notes

Happy Valentine's Day everybody!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After three years of being with Glimmer, Catra could admit to herself how very bizarre her life would look to a younger version of herself. How disgusted she would have been, or how afraid she would have felt. She'd spent her whole life surviving, from that cursed cabin to the Horde to the one fateful night she'd decided she was ready to give up. Life was difficult, that was a damn fact, and life never wanted to do what Catra wanted it to. Of course when she'd gone out that night, riding until she couldn't see any hints of civilization before sending her stolen horse off into the inky black, all Catra could think about was how nice it would feel when she couldn't feel anything anymore.

It had started in typical fashion after she left the Horde, since life was not fucking her over, Catra had gotten nervous and then fucked it up herself. She hadn't been able to get a job and keep it. Her propensity to get into physical fights over every conceived slight was not an admirable trait out in the rest of the world. After her last screw up with the pompous rich ranch owner degrading her in front of the rest of the crew, she'd stolen all the damn liquor in the bastard's fancy ass house and took his favorite horse to rub a little salt in the wound.

She lined the bottles up and drank until she wanted to get sick. Turned out it didn't take near as long as she'd assumed. Swaying back and forth on the ground as she finished her first bottle she already felt bleary and loopy. Catra could remember laughing at

that, Hordak could drink a whole bottle himself and not even seem that drunk a'tall and here she couldn't manage the same. It was funny because she was better than him at basically everything.

It got a bit hazy at that point.

She remembers struggling to carry the other bottles as her coordination got worse, but that was a problem she could solve by drinking until she could abandon a few more empties. There's the vague outline of her falling into something, probably hadn't been deep at all but the memory was of a valley opening under her feet. She can remember throwing up at some point, the painful fire that ran back up her throat, and the unbearable burn as some of it came up and out her nose instead. Oh she had cried at that, but a quick blow of her nose helped and so did that fancy bottle of tequila the bastard had been so proud of showing off. She had specifically saved it till she was sure it wouldn't taste like much in another spiteful move.

The next thing she remembers is squatting over a bucket in her cell, shitting like it was going out of style and wondering what the hell had happened.

The sheriff was a rather cold and stuck up woman, so disconnected that she almost seemed ethereal as she talked. Catra felt like someone had been ramming a white hot iron poker into her eyes and wished that it would kill her instead. Probably more still drunk than hungover honestly. She was naked from the waist down, humiliated as she continued to have no control over her bowels, getting lectured by a woman who might as well have been made from stone when she first heard Glimmer's name.

"You are lucky that she found you, and thought to bring you here for medical assistance. Miss Glimmer Moon reported that she found you over an hour's ride away from town." The sheriff's head tilted in an unnatural manner before she continued, "Please ensure that you properly thank her."

Catra, drunk as hell, had slurred, “I’ll killin’ fuck er ifn I WANT.”

The woman had tilted her head again, almost as if she was an actor starting a scene over. “I will have to insist that you do not, or I will be forced to press the full weight of the law. Please ensure you thank Miss Moon.”

Catra had ended up spending the next two days in the town jail, alone with Sheriff Hope as she both sobered up and healed up, and with no word on how long a stay was left for her to suffer. She’d just about given up and decided that if there was a god, they were not above a little pre-hell punishment, when she was finally released. With nowhere to go, the Sheriff had put her up at the inn for a night and warned her to remember the dangers of alcohol and wandering the desert by herself before finally leaving. Catra had decided it wasn’t worth it to explain that had been the damned point, too tired to care anymore. A warm bath, clean clothes, and her first meal that actually stayed down later and Catra had decided that maybe it wasn’t pre-hell punishment so much as the much more routine regular horse shit. The morning after her first sleep on something softer than rotting wood, Catra had felt positive enough to go to the large fenced in area she’d seen the day before and was grateful to discover it was in fact an auction house.

She’d lost all her jobs attempting to be a ranch or farm hand, but damn if she didn’t have some flashy skills to help her trick the next idiot into putting up with her a few months. As she’d twirled the lasso around, jumping through it and trying to look as relaxed as possible Catra had forced memory after memory of Shadow Weaver’s rough tutelage out of her mind. Rope tricks when done by a young child were astounding and an easy way to make a little money while distracting the town from a robbery after all.

One of the men had challenged her to do some riding and Catra would love to say she remembered what he’d said, but she really couldn’t. Because part way through proving her damn skills she’d seen her. Sheriff Hope had happily supplied Catra with a description of Miss Moon, with the repeated order to thank her.

Catra had been so fed up with it, that she vowed to do no such thing!

But seeing Glimmer Moon for the first time was like the best sucker punch she'd ever taken.

Light Hope had failed to truly explain just how amazingly beautiful she was. Glimmer had been watching in a pretty pink and purple dress, she had climbed half way up the wooden fencing and smiled brightly as she'd passed. It took Catra's brain a second to register over its own incoherent screaming, but when she did she backed that horse right on up.

For the first time in her life, Catra had absolutely no qualms with thanking someone for a helping hand. Ironically, over the one time she really, really hadn't wanted one. Soon as Miss Moon had tried to deflect her thanks, Catra had doubled down.

Oh she had fully intended on getting out of this town, just far enough for long enough to steal another horse before going another state over. Start fresh with a new job maybe. If not, there was supposed to be a large gorge of some kind there, and Catra had been fully intent on making her next plan stick. Or, more like making whatever would be left of her body stick.

Glimmer had other ideas.

She'd grabbed Catra's hand and her eyes had twinkled with excitement as they talked about anything she could seem to think of. Unable and unwilling to give up whatever little time she'd have with her, Catra obliged. She'd felt strangely numb after partying ways and ended up sitting in the shade of the general store to wait it out. That's when Glimmer had found her to explain that her mother would pay handsomely if Catra would give Glimmer riding lessons as a private tutor. Catra did the unthinkable.

She gave in for the second time ever in her life.

She laid in bed at Bow's house that night, his father's many spare bedrooms easily finding a spot for her, and wondered what the

hell had happened. So she was a pretty girl, so what? Catra had seen plenty of pretty girls in her life! So what was it about Miss Moon that had her being polite and acting like an upstanding citizen instead of a mongrel? What about Glimmer had turned Catra so quickly from her long drop sudden stop to giving private lessons? As the days and weeks and months and years passed, Catra just stopped wondering about why she caved for Glimmer every single time. Hell, she can't even really remember when she stopped making plans to just end it for good. Sometime in that first year. Everyday Catra had managed to trick and con herself into sticking it out for just one more day until it damn well stuck.

Life was strange that way.

It was stranger still, difficult in ways she'd never imagined to just *not* want to cause trouble. To not ignore problems until they exploded or to instigate a fight when the tension got too thick to breathe. Catra had learned that the best way to get enough space to catch some air was to hiss and spit fire. That the best thing she could do was lash out first and be in control of it, rather than wait until she was a victim. Wanting to not do any of that was completely different from actually not doing it.

She was grateful, eternally so, that the Moons had never lost faith in her and that they also took no shit.

Arguing back? Acceptable as long as she remained civil with her tongue. Snapping back a little too harsh when upset? Understandable and not defendable apparently. No matter how often that awful little thing in her mind said things would get easier if she just threw a punch or went for the kill, she'd fought herself tooth and nail to be different. Catra had managed to keep that jagged part of herself pointed away from the Moons, cutting and lashing out at other company workers or herself until that damn day at the canyon.

Catra did her level best to not flinch at the memory.

She overreacted, she overreached, and then in a fit of self pity and fear she'd gone and tried to throw her life away. Not that she'd really realized it in the moment, she'd been a little too busy worrying herself crazy about Glimmer's safety and Angella's reaction to think about it like that. Still, she'd lived, they talked, and Catra had managed to let them in just a little more.

And like a damned fool, Catra thought she'd managed to let go of some of her bullshit to let them in. Ha.

Hordak's screaming and Weaver's fists were never gone, maybe they weren't even hers to put down.

"Ours is not a simple life, we are not content to sit back on our heels and be crushed underfoot!" Hordak's speeches were far and few between, the mere threat of his ire typically enough to keep all of them in line from big to small. Not that she'd known that then. That was the first time she'd heard him speak, his voice going between shrill and growling as he pounded a fist against his chest. "No. We rise up! We rise up to take what should rightfully be ours. We rise up to create a more perfect world- an orderly world. We rise up on wings, not of feathers but of toughened leather."

Religious idiocy, Weaver had called it and Catra agreed, but it was damnably effective. And in the cases it wasn't, well, Catra had gotten acquainted with that too. That's where she'd learned it was usually better if she fought back than just accepted whatever punishment was doled out. Fighting back made you stronger, made you a force to be reckoned with, and Catra had fought back so viciously that eventually not a damned soul could touch her besides Hordak himself. Her position had been hard won over spilt blood and gunpowder. She thought that ignoring that instinct and listening to others meant it was over and done.

The bank had proven her wrong. More wrong than maybe she'd ever been.

Catra had been willing to play along, she'd been on the other side of these a few times and knew first hand that calm and willing victims was easier on everyone. She didn't even care that he was a Crimson Waste member, she'd given up on that life and wasn't gonna start a fight over it. But soon as that giant idiot with the shotgun had gotten far too big for his britches something in her had just...snapped. He was threatening one of **her** people. That had already been enough for her to want to ruin his stupid bullshit. But threatening Glimmer who looked a half second away from crying? Well now she was going to get to be a hero and enjoy herself too.

She'd really thought that, she was stopping a robbery and not a single innocent lost their soul. Catra had lost it a little, her carefully maintained control too much to contain once the fight started proper, but she hadn't gone rabid. She even spared as many of the robber's lives as possible, excepting the big idiot who was never going to make it out alive after what he'd done. She'd still been coming off the excitement of it, leading Glimmer home and proud as hell when they had their fight.

It felt like the end of the world. It felt like drowning.

She'd done it again, fucked it all up beyond recognition and revealed the truth to Glimmer. Catra had always known she was a monster, hoping that if she hid her fangs and ripped out her claws it would be enough to get her by. Enough to keep her close to the two moons lighting her path. Knowing it was over, Catra decided to move forward by taking some control back. She waited until Glimmer retired before telling Angella the whole damn truth.

"...I wasn't in control. At the bank. When that bastard...I, I just." Catra had forced herself to keep talking even as she lost feeling in her fingers and toes. "Glimmer said I- and I just think I should- sorry. Let me start over. Thank you for the opportunities Mrs. Moon, it's...made more of a difference than I can really explain."

Angella had looked at her carefully, critically before pointing to the kitchen table. "Make yourself comfortable won't you?"

The nerves had flared into anger and Catra had to close her one good eye to calm the fuck down before answering, "I don't think that's a good idea ma'am."

"I'm sorry," Angella smiled almost peacefully at her as she poured two shots of whiskey, "I don't know why I phrased that as a request. It's not. You will join me at the table."

Despite wanting to leave quick as she could, Catra knew she'd never forgive betraying them both. So she sat, and got lucky for the first time in her life. Oh sure, she still got a little talking to, but it was nothing like anything she'd ever experienced in her life. No screaming, no humiliation, no knives or fists or fire. It was...gentle. Even with the alcohol.

"Miss D'riltuh, I have never asked you about your past and I don't intend to. It's yours to share or not. But do you take me for a fool? No one would end up passed out in the desert like that on accident."

Catra's whole body had gone cold, shaking at that. She didn't want to even think about it let alone explain herself.

Angella sipped at her second shot before continuing, "You know I read every report on you as well? Do you know what I saw?"

Already shaking terribly, Catra found that she was choking around a sob to answer, "I know miss. I-I'm-"

"Do you?" Angella's voice was so much softer as she moved to sit next to her, tugging softly until Catra was leaning on her. "I saw a young woman, struggling harder than hell to be better. I told you to try- and Catra, you did more than that. This thing? It is a part of you, but have not once let it over rule you."

She'd covered her mouth, desperate to keep her crying and carrying on quiet. Glimmer was trying to sleep! When it barely helped she held her breath, pinching her aching nose shut to try and help stop the noise by stopping the source. Only, there were hands pulling hers away.

"Breathe, steady on. Steady."

She'd meant to leave, not just the house but the town, run until she could try again, try and forget the first good thing in her life. But when Angella had asked her to stay, not just the night (although yes, that as well), but to stay put and see it through? How could she say no? Catra can say she holds the memory close to her heart, the way Angella had held her as she'd nearly shaken apart.

"This is not all or nothing." Angella had said, assuring her gingerly as if she'd break at so much as a feather's touch.

She wasn't wrong *was the thing. Catra had still bitterly mumbled, "Win or lose."*

Beatrix Weaver was years dead and still fucking up her life was taking up every little crack in her foundations, slithering into every shadow available.

"Not always."

So she'd stayed, and when Glimmer had pulled her into her bed with sparkling eyes and asked after her? Catra had burst wide open, desperate to share and prove that she wasn't just blood thirsty only for Glimmer to stop her to ask for shooting lessons.

After that she'd been done for. Just like that robber, her fate had all but been sealed. All those things she'd given in over? Every time she'd held back? It had felt massive. They had felt almost like burdens until she got used to them. Turned out those had all been small potatoes. The only reason Catra hadn't outright moved into Glimmer's house was because she hadn't been invited to, although Glimmer had certainly found ways to show she wanted Catra around.

But the big ones had started when Catra had been too ill to pitch a fit and was trapped in Glimmer's house. She was actually almost happy to let Glimmer dote on her. Administering painkillers and helping her limp around the house. Catra could still remember

vividly the time she'd caught a cold, and Weaver had sneered down at her about how it was her own fault for getting sick so it was her responsibility to take care of it. She'd been seven at the time and took it to heart that her whining was pathetic and a nuisance. That anyone would agree that everyone needed to care for themselves. Glimmer wasn't like that at all, in fact Glimmer had almost killed her every time Catra tried to help.

So she gave up on that big one.

And she told herself that just because she let someone help her and care about her, just because she'd admitted how she felt didn't mean she should go all in. Life would fuck it up if she didn't. So she made a pact with herself, to give in just this once and then wait.

Ha! Just that once!

"I went and collected your affects, since you're needing to stay here and all." Glimmer announced as soon as she'd gotten back from work.

Catra's ankle had healed quickly, allowing her to stumble to her feet a little too fast for her still aching head. She nearly tipped over and scrambled to lean on the wall for support. "What?! Why?"

"Well it just don't make sense to leave it all on the other side a town."

She'd nearly fought then. That she appreciated the care being shown to her, a care she'd never had, but not at the expense of her own autonomy. Not at the expense of giving up her choices! But Glimmer had looked pleased as punch, nothing mocking in her sparkling eyes and wide smile. Like she was genuinely happy Catra was trapped. It had been enough to pin her tongue to think it through. By that evening, with her personal wool blanket wrapped around her, Catra found she didn't mind. Not one bit. The company house was a shack at best with limited space and

you were always at risk of having something stolen. Why not enjoy the space away from people, the quiet, the much better cooked food with none of the offensive odors that always lingered around the stove. Why not enjoy all this extra time with her girl Glimmer? So she sat on the settee and held one corner of the blanket open in invitation hoping her message was heard. Glimmer had smiled and settled in close with her in front of the fire, and Catra could hardly remember why she'd wanted to scream that morning.

And her giving in there, meant that Glimmer began to experiment and push. Not with small things either. The next big thing had been agreeing to do some cooking if she could while recovering. She'd refused initially, sure, if you were cooking in the Horde it meant you had no other uses after all. With a little prodding and a little fightin' Catra had been forced to try and reconcile this idea with the fact that Glimmer cooked and clearly wasn't some animal to beat and abandon. A little more prodding to admit how useless she was feeling from the injury, couldn't even go outside or look at a flame for too long before everything hurt all over again.

Glimmer had hummed thoughtfully before speaking, "Well it sounds to me like you need something to do 'round here. Ain't much you can, and that is not your fault, but it's true. Maybe doing at least some cooking would help, keep your hands busy and at the end of the day you can enjoy what you made. We gotta eat, so somebody's got to cook don't they?"

"You just want me to be a little housewife." Catra had grumbled, accepting Glimmer's kiss to her cheek as well earned compensation.

Glimmer had hummed thoughtfully, pressing kiss after kiss until she'd started to giggle. "Maybe so."

"Miss you are evil."

She'd been right though. Even if Catra had been too drunk on her approval to fight proper like, Glimmer had been right. Cooking

took the whole damned day between its natural rhythms and Catra's need to take breaks when the light got to be too much. So she cooked, and even as she got better began to realize that she didn't mind it so much. Especially not now that Glimmer and her would trade off as she got better.

The whole thing almost went tits up when she had finally gotten well enough to go back to work. Angella, first thing mind you, had mentioned off hand that Catra's spot at the company housing had filled nicely. Unsure what to make of **that** Catra had logged it away and started working on the numbers. As the day went on the stories she came up with got worse and worse. Outlandish in the worst ways. Maybe this was Angella's way of getting rid of her. Maybe Glimmer was sick of her. Maybe Glimmer went behind her back to demand it. Maybe, maybe, maybe until she was ready to scream. Instead Catra feigned exhaustion to make sure she wouldn't clock Mrs. Moon for meddling, riding her new horse Captain back home. She'd fretted the whole afternoon and well into the evening over it until she was convinced she'd somehow made a misstep or mistake.

Catra was half sprawled across Glimmer's legs in bed that night when she finally got the courage to ask, "Did I upset your mother?"

"What?" Glimmer asked, distracted by her penny novel before the question fully processed. She blinked rapidly and set it down to answer. "No. Why?"

"Well she done kicked me out of the company house." Catra whined and felt like a fool for even complaining.

Glimmer had looked thoughtful before shrugging, "Ain't like you been living there, poor greenhorn probably needed it more than your memory did."

"Where the hell am I supposed to sleep now?"

Glimmer had looked at her like you might a particularly stupid animal before waving a hand around, and sarcastically quipping, "Good heaven's where shall you go?"

It had been a very interesting night to realize that living with Glimmer wasn't temporary. That it was permanent. That Glimmer wanted her there and Angella approved enough to give away her bed.

After that Catra had just started letting go more and more. Compromising and agreeing even when she didn't like it, only to discover she often didn't mind and when she did all it took was one quick and honest opinion for them to pull back and make more concessions. It was strange. It felt...strange. Catra didn't feel different but a quick think over her actions made it more than clear that she was. That idea had eaten away until she finally asked during a walkabout, turning to Mrs. Moon to get an honest opinion.

"Am I...different since I hit my head?"

Angella had stared at her in confusion, head tilting. "Not that I've noticed. Why?"

"Just a thought."

Yeah just a thought that she had somehow gotten softer than rabbit's fur and mushier than mud. Like some love sick fool. Catra had spent her whole damn life desperate to stay in charge of any situation. Even her earliest memory of the cabin, hazy as it was, was of herself tearing up books and clothes and swinging a hatchet to get bits of wood to burn when they'd been snowed in. She could remember hearing people outside one day, grunting as they worked to clear the door. So what did she do at the tender young age of five? She'd pulled her daddy's pistol out of it's holster and half aimed at the door, too malnourished to really hold it steady. She knows, now, that when Weaver had her grunts break into the cabin, that they'd planned on terrorizing and probably murdering whoever was inside.

Well the joke was on Weaver, all they'd found was two corpses and a child. She'd never forget the way Shadow Weaver had stared her down over the barrel of the gun and smiled.

"Well, well, well, a survivor through and through. Just like us."

She'd taken to Shadow Weaver like a duck to water, but only with half the sense. That first memory meant very little as she grew up; with her parents being nebulous blobs of colors instead of people she had little to compare to. Her whole childhood she'd been right scared they'd send her back. If she thought about any of it too long, she was likely to get lost in her own damn head listening to the insane bravado of a scared little man and his crazy right hand woman.

But, there was some truths in that life. Fear would hold you back. Do what you must to survive. Take what you want before someone stronger takes it first.

Catra smirked as she hauled on the oars. Her old life may have had some truths, and she couldn't wait to make a few folks roll in their graves today. Using their poison as a cure was just petty enough to make her preen a little.

"Do not make me regret coming out here," Glimmer hissed, hands tightly clutching at her seat.

"Like you weren't the one to beg me to come out on this damned lake!"

Glimmer gave a breathless chuckle before half snapping, "That was before I knew you were a hell beast when rowin'!"

"Ours are the wings that shall set this world free! We are not the beasts but the tamers!"

"Excuse you Miss, I have **always** been a hell beast, an' it ain't my fault you didn't notice till now." Still, Catra slowed down and let the boat glide further without her forcing them along. It was a lot

more peaceful on the water than she'd expected, although every time it rocked too much she still longed for the shore.

Ever since she'd moved into Glimmer's house, Catra had been doing her level best to not just try, but be better now. Be kinder. Be softer. Be open to Glimmer's complaints and compliments. Be the woman that Glimmer saw somewhere inside. The Moon's had asked her to try and now Catra felt ready to lean into this whole new leaf thing. So when Glimmer said, *"You are just like my father, 'sept without the love of water,"* before launching into a beloved childhood memory. Catra had perked up right quick at that. Mr. Moon had been completely off the table for discussion for as long as she'd known the Moon's. From what little she'd gathered the poor bastard had died in a terrible accident, that he was as gentle as he'd been smart, and that both Glimmer and Angella had loved him dearly.

Sitting there listening to Glimmer's story like it was the last one she'd ever hear, Catra started to put a plan together. Scheming had always been a specialty of hers, and putting it to use had been simple enough. She wanted her whole life to be like this, forever and always. She wanted to keep up with the Moon's, even if it meant running and looking at the night sky for the rest of her life. So she decided to take what little she knew of Mr. Moon and worked from that. She'd never met him, but she hoped that if he was looking down he'd be glad to see what she was doing.

The first step had been getting them to the right location. Despite the shiver that had run up her spine at the thought, Catra knew it needed to be near water. So she asked and read up and generally made a nuisance of herself to find out where they could possibly go.

Salineas Butte was not the lake from Glimmer's story, apparently that one had dried up years back before they'd moved a few states away to escape her father's ghost. Catra still did her very best to get them out to Salineas anyways, the soaring cliffs and the tall butte the lake was named for were supposed to be breathtaking. Her plan had involved getting them time off, get

them there, and then happily watch Glimmer as she had a swim. As soon as she'd figured out where they were going, apparently having a friend who lived out this way in an unfair twist of fate, Glimmer had gushed about all the things *they* would do. Regardless of what Catra wanted apparently.

Trying to wiggle her way out of doing anything on the water without revealing things Glimmer didn't need to know about had been impossible from the start. So instead she'd tried to keep as much control on this situation as possible, going so far as to demand she be allowed to row the boat around the lake which at least would get them somewhere picturesque. Catra rubbed gently at her sore and stinging hands with a nearly childish grin.

Glimmer grumbled, throwing her hands in the air, "Well it is no concern of mine what you are when we're on land D'riluth. But I, for one, prefer to not drown!"

Weaver wouldn't let her up, wouldn't let her upwouldn't let herupwouldn't letherupwouldn'tletherupwouldn'tletherUP- and Catra couldn't breathe.

"Hey," Glimmer's hand on hers were as soft and gentle as her tone was firm, "you get back here this instant."

It turned out that settling down came with some interesting side benefits, such as they were. Catra had **never** felt as unstable as she had since she'd met Glimmer. It was a good unstable, if that was even possible. Scary, but good. Not so many rages as it was suddenly learning how much of her life Catra loathed. How many memories meant nothing good compared to what she now knew was good. She'd never gotten lost in the weeds like this before, but then again Catra knew she hadn't exactly ever had the chance to get lost. If she hadn't been running she sure as hell needed to be gunning. Here and now, she didn't have to worry about it so much. Not when there was someone there to help pull her back to reality.

“You know, we can go back if you want. I was just givin’ you a hard time, but I didn’t mean to actually give you a hard time.” Glimmer’s eyes were wide and face open as she spoke. It wasn’t that there wasn’t fear there too, there always was, but just like Catra had been learning, so too had Glimmer. Learning when to stop, when to push, when to ask, how to ask. Both of them slowly but surely whittling through the layers together. Catra learning to not lash out but speak up, and Glimmer learning how to help her stumble away from the echoes.

Catra smiled as she turned her hands up to lace their fingers together. “Now, now, lying is a terrible thing Miss Moon.”

“Ugh!” Glimmer playfully kicked at her knees but gave up quickly enough as the boat rocked. “Here I am being right as rain and sweeter than honey, and how am I repaid?”

Catra idly toyed with Glimmer’s bracelet. It was the same one she’d been wearing when they met apparently, beautiful pinks and purples inlaid around a single white opal. Glimmer had been more than delighted to tell Catra all about that first meeting and how she’d been unable to stop complimenting her on anything she could think of including the “brace-a-klet” (something that Glimmer apparently found hilarious to say whenever she wore one now much to Catra’s chagrin). It was flashy and shiny, and typically Glimmer didn’t wear it; it was a family heirloom from her grandmother on down after all. Apparently her father had seen the way Angella looked at it, and with permission had proposed to her with it. All that considered, Catra hoped that it bode well for her plans today.

“Right as run off and sweet and tar more like it.”

“Oh! OH!” Glimmer shouted, looking around as if there was an audience to their shenanigans. Her desire to make other people both uncomfortable and laugh taking over as she put on her fakest shrill voice. “I am **hurt**!”

Catra couldn't help her lazy grin. Goodness gracious, she loved this woman something fierce. "Good. 'Cause I meant it too!"

"Oh well I suppose I'll just SWIM back to shore then, pardon me." And with that Glimmer made a show of starting to stand up.

Partially in jest and partially in terror, Catra tried to stop her. "Damn it woman do not capsize us!"

"I can do what I want D'riluth!"

So much for her romantic plans, Catra groused silently as they continued to struggle. Maybe proposing to Glimmer on a lake to invoke that connection to Mr. Moon hadn't been the smartest thing to do. She'd just wanted to show she was listening and cared, and was ready to finally dive into the past with her. Glimmer had been more open about her own childhood, and had never pushed Catra to share more than she could. But hearing those words *"You're like my father"* meant Catra was kind and loving and lovable. It made her ready as hell.

"Glimmer Moon, sit your ass down so I can be proper!"

Glimmer gave one last terrific fake pull to leave the boat, which Catra over corrected for, her hand raking down Glimmers arm, fingers accidentally hooking under it, and just like that Glimmer's bracelet fell overboard.

That definitely didn't bode well for her plans. Damn life and it's insistence on ruining **everything**!

Catra began pulling off her boots even as Glimmer turned to stare into the water with a shout. It took a few seconds at most to get them off and ditch her hat. "Don't worry, I got it!"

"Catra don't you dare-"

Thing of it was, Catra didn't like water. Hadn't liked it since Weaver discovered it was a particularly efficient punishment. She'd still been forced to wade into lakes and ponds and rivers to

learn how to swim. *"No student of mine will die because she couldn't swim."* And here was the other thing, she was good at it. Made sure she was very proficient and able to swim faster and hold her breath longer than anyone else to make a point. Something that screamed, " *Weaver got away with it, you won't"* . Octavia had tried one time to kill her, and had chosen the hot spring they'd set up camp around to do it. So Catra had held her breath until she thought she was gonna die, going perfectly still until Octavia let go. The stunt had cost Octavia an eye and Catra had been very pleased to show that just because something had scared her as a child didn't mean it did as an adult.

Whether or not that fact was actually true.

Diving head first into the lake, Catra let her momentum carry her down, blinking her eyes rapidly to find the bracelet in the mostly clear water. Then she swam harder than she ever had. Kicking and pulling at the water, cutting through it fast as she could with the pink coral glinting up at her so tantalizingly close and frustratingly far. She would not let Glimmer lose this last connection to her father if it damn well killed her.

Imma have to apologize when I get back, she hates this sort of thing. Catra let the thought come and go, lungs burning as she finally got her hand wrapped around that one piece of jewelry. Air rushed out of her mouth in a blinding sheet of bubbles as she couldn' keep it in anymore. Her ears hurt from the pressure and her eyes stung from the water. But she did it!

Thinking little of her pains, Catra turned and began to swim towards the surface. But was only half way there when she almost choked from how little oxygen was left in her lungs. Not a good sign. She kicked harder, fighting her body's insistence that she just exhale and take a deep breath. *Oh no.* She was almost there when her motions got so uncoordinated and sluggish that Catra was more concerned she'd drop the damn bracelet before surfacing one way or another. It took a split second to stop swimming up and secure it in her belt, before she was hands free

to fight her way up to freedom. Got close enough to see Glimmer's blurred outline through the surface of the water.

Then she woke up in the boat, with Glimmer rowing them full tilt back to shore.

"What?" She asked, blearily trying to make sense of what had just happened.

Glimmer panted, "You. Stupid. Fool of. A woman! I. Am gonna. KILL you! For almost! Killing me! Fuck! You!"

Catra blinked up at her and coughed wretchedly before wheezing, "I'm fine!"

"Oh ho ho! You ain't gonna be when I'm done!"

She nodded, after all that seemed fair. Glimmer had told her to stop it with the heroics over nothing, but Catra would argue this hadn't been nothing. So instead of arguing, Catra patted at her belt and found it was still tucked away safe and sound. Well that was good then.

"Naw, you wouldn't hurt yer wife." Catra said, pulling the bracelet free with her limited fine motor functions.

"LIKE HELL I WOULDN'T!" Glimmer kept rowing for a moment before suddenly stopping and staring at Catra wide eyed. "...wait."

Catra coughed, spitting some phlegm into the water before clearing her throat. Damn her head hurt. She finally held the bracelet up. "This didn't work the way I'd planned. Will you still marry me?"

"You!" Glimmer's mouth snapped shut as she stared at the offering before looking back up with watering eyes. "How the hell d'you do that? Take me from steaming mad to a mess?"

Catra smirked. "I'm very talented Miss. Will you marry me?"

Glimmer hastily wiped away her tears, a grin breaking across her face. "Of course I will you- you no good- you!"

"I think you're supposed to kiss me at this point. 'Cording to yer novels."

Glimmer laughed and grabbed Catra's face to roughly pull her into a kiss. Then another, then another, and Catra had to finally stop what she'd started when the boat gave a rather harsh wobble. She was more than interested in the rather physical reward Glimmer seemed interested in giving her, just not here.

"Let's get back on land before doing that shall we?" Catra asked smug as you please, but when there was a long pause followed by Glimmer's eyes going huge as she looked around, Catra took a guess. "The oars floated off didn't they?"

"Maybe?" Glimmer blushed as she looked around in the water. "They ain't far!"

As much as the idea of going back into the water made her want to curl up into a ball, Catra started to push herself upright. "Well I'm already soaked so-"

The boat nearly toppled over and Catra shrieked as it did, clutching tightly to the seat under her and staring open mouthed as Glimmer swam for the oars. She got one and seemed to struggle before going under and Catra's heart stopped.

"GLIMMER!?"

She was nearly overboard herself when Glimmer popped back up to the surface without her ruffled skirt weighing her down. She took a large gulp of air before going under again, and this time Catra stayed put and watched until Glimmer broke the surface again. She managed to grab both oars before swimming back, and Catra hauled her back to safety. Unfortunately she hauled a little too hard and Glimmer awkwardly knocked the oars on the sides of the boat, and before she knew it Catra was on her back on the bottom of the boat, oars boxing her in and with Glimmer

sitting on her hips. Glimmer sitting on her hips wearing only her drawers and her blouse. Her white drawers and white blouse. Just. Plastered down over her body and highlighting every curve perfectly.

Her voice was rather strangled when she managed to speak, "You trying to kill me?"

Glimmer huffed, missing the mark by a mile. "Now you see how that feels D'riluth! Ain't so nice when you watch someone you love do something stupid is it?"

Oh it hadn't been, but they were both fine and the matter was practically forgotten as a consequence. She'd always been better at letting the what if's go between the two of them. No sense in getting worked up over something that hadn't even happened. Not now, not in her new life. So instead of fighting, Catra blinked away the water dripping onto her face from Glimmer's hair and snorted. "Naw, it ain't. But I wasn't talking about that."

Glimmer stared at her in confusion, face still flushed from the exertion and anger, hair plastered down on her cheeks and neck, beautiful eyes sparkling away nearly purple looking in the light.

"...seriously?" Catra laughed, reaching up to wrap her arms around her waist. "You come flailing outta that lake with them oars like some mythical goddess out of the ocean while half damn naked, and you seriously don't get it?"

Glimmer blushed deeper, going shades as she looked at what she was left still wearing before stuttering, "I was- it was heavy! I-I needed to!"

"Lucky me," Catra prompted and was promptly smacked.

Still, Glimmer was laughing so it was worth it.

"You are awful! I can't believe you, we have a brush with the devil himself and you're off sinning already! We ain't even married yet!"

Catra's smile turned softer. "You're the one who said yes."

"I said no such thing, I said 'of course'!" Glimmer huffed but made no move to leave as Catra tugged her down. This kiss was special, searing it's way into her very soul. As they parted she decided that maybe Glimmer had the right idea with this whole sinning business. She was completely ready to just get back to where they'd left off, only for Glimmer herself to accidentally drop some metaphorical ice cold water over them.

"I can't believe my mother agreed to this!"

Catra had spent a whole week building up the nerve to ask Angella if she could marry her daughter. Practiced what she'd say in private, and got desperate enough to ask Adora and Bow for help. Bow had cried, of course, and pelted her with a bunch of hooey that Catra would rather die than say. Adora had been shocked, one hand going to her chest as she'd asked, *"Wait, you two are in love!?"* It had actually helped boost her confidence that they'd managed to keep their relationship so quiet and private as they'd started a life together.

And it had absolutely no impact on Catra managing to loosen her damned tongue enough to choke the question out.

Finally, the day before they'd left for Salineas, Catra had gone to Mrs. Moon's house ready to ask and instead found Angella in a heated argument with Lonnie and her boys. She'd watched for ten minutes as Rogelio patted Kyle's back and Angella and Lonnie screamed themselves hoarse before realizing she wasn't going to get her chance. Even if the three idiots left, Catra was not about to risk asking an enraged Angella Moon a damn thing.

"Well, here's the thing," Catra started only for Glimmer to cover her mouth.

"...you didn't ask her, did you? Nod or shake your head."

Catra snorted and shook her head right before licking Glimmer's palm.

“AUGH! Ew! You are disgusting!!” Glimmer flapped her hand a few times before wiping it off on her stomach.

Catra was a bit too pleased at pointing out, “And you’re marrying me.”

“Not till you ask my mother I’m not!”

Catra dug her thumbs into Glimmer’s hips, pushing up slightly to make her gasp. “What if she says no? You just gonna leave all a this?”

Glimmer growled, “Oh a bunch of hair brained schemes and disregard for personal safety wrapped up into a beautiful package? Like hell I’ll leave ya. But she won’t say no!”

“I did try to!” Catra groused when her attempts at distracting Glimmer only seemed to half work. She slid her fingers under her blouse, leaving them just barely touching Glimmer’s lower back before she gently scratched. “She was always already upset when I went to ask.”

“Catra!” Glimmer half gasped and half hissed, back arching even as she landed a few very half hearted slaps on Catra’s chest and face. “We are in the open!”

“So?”

Glimmer leaned back, looking towards the sky as she threw her hands out dramatically. “If you don’t get yourself killed, I’ll do it myself!”

“There you go,” Catra cheered, shimmying a little to at least sit up properly, “positive attitude and all that!”

It was honestly a miracle that Glimmer didn’t outright strangle her on the boat. It was a miracle they managed to row back to shore when all was said and done. And it was a miracle when they found Glimmers skirts washed up on shore a mile down the way as they walked back to civilization.

Catra hoped that she'd get just one more miracle. She was going to ask Angella, and she hoped it was both soon, and that the answer was yes. Back at the inn, sharing a warm bath as best they could, Catra knew that she didn't just want Glimmer. She needed her. She needed to wake up every morning side by side with her. Needed to hear Glimmer laugh the way she needed air to breathe. Needed to push and be pushed, and hold and be held. Needed it so much that her heart felt fit to burst behind her ribs. Watching Glimmer dress for bed in clean dry clothes, Catra found herself tearing up.

"Hey Glimmer?" Catra asked later, quiet in the dark just in case Glimmer had actually fallen asleep. But hearing a soft toneless hum she continued on, "Darling, I love you."

Glimmer had chuckled sleepily, kissing her collarbone as she mumbled back, "Love you too, go to sleep."

So she buried her nose in Glimmer's hair and grinned. Waiting until her breathing evened out before kissing her forehead and closing her eyes.

She was gonna rise up alright, finally rise up right. Rise up not on fists and fury, but on hope and love. By god she was gonna raise on up high enough to unscrew the stars so her moon's could shine brightest in the sky. Catra D'riluth was done trying, and she was ready to move on. Not to another gang or another job or another existence. But hand in hand with an angel. Together.

Chapter End Notes

Basically the bracelet!
https://static1.squarespace.com/static/5612d5bce4b0e75bc4a5c96a/57f3e248725e2522eb23a574/5b3beb9c758d46e22ba4bca0/1580495034434/?format=1500w

Chapter 8: Mother Dearest

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer FINALLY tell Angella that they're dating and engaged!

They're just a whole year later than planned, and really. Is anyone surprised?

Chapter Notes

I love me some dorks in love!

Recap: After years of pining and finally having admitted their feelings, Glimmer and Catra move in together and start enjoying domestic life. Catra decides to propose to Glimmer in a grand romantic gesture, and fails to get Angella's blessing before taking her on a trip to Salineas Butte, which derails when Glimmer loses her family heirloom bracelet in the lake. After Catra goes jewelry diving, Glimmer also takes a dunk to rescue their wayward oars. Even with all the hiccups, she still says yes!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It shouldn’t come as a surprise when Glimmer sat down at work one day, and realized how much time has passed. Just sand rushing between her fingers. Twelve years since her father died. Ten years since she’d met Catra. Five since she’d moved into her house. And, this is the one she shouldn’t have been surprised to realize, nearly a whole year since Catra proposed.

Time moved real funny like she supposed.

Not that they’d done a damn thing about it. Happily living together, marriage was more of a bonus than something they needed to be together. It’s funny in a way. Back when they’d first met, if this had happened Glimmer would have pushed harder to

go to Bow's father and get the minister to set them right. Perhaps it was Catra's influence, as she was overly fond of claiming, that kept Glimmer home but damn if it weren't more that she'd found her faith outside the church than within its walls. Still. A whole year...

"Well shit," Glimmer half whispered and half hummed.

"Sorry, what?" Her mother asked, nose still buried in her ledgers and eyes a little blurry from too many hours of focus.

I am not a clever woman. Glimmer chuckled weakly, "It's nothing. ...actually! Do you mind if Catra and I come over for supper tomorrow? We hain't been in a while."

Angella finally looked up with a glint in her eyes as she said, "I suppose you have not, have you? You are both more than welcome to. Is there anything you'd like me to make?"

"You're gonna be cooking?" Glimmer asked, eyebrows shooting to her hairline. She didn't know if she'd ever actually seen her mother near a stove beyond making some tea.

"Well…" Angella had the grace to look embarrassed, "no. I suppose I mean Miss Baker and Mister Pop. You know they miss you and would love to spoil you rotten once more."

"Once more?" Glimmer put a hand to her chest and put on her most ridiculous pout, "I ain't ever been spoiled once!"

Angella chuckled, a fond smile in place as she returned to her books. "I can see all those lessons on elocution have truly paid their dividends."

Glimmer flushed bright red, and then somehow blushed even worse as she caught herself about to respond with a single heated, ' *'t'ain't like that!*'. So instead she fell back on a perfectly good and serviceable yelp of, "Mother!"

Angella laughed, one hand going up to cover her mouth as she leaned back in her chair. Laughing deeper and harder than the moment warranted by a *long shot* . The nearly translucent pink wrap, which had miraculously managed to stay perched on her shoulders the whole day, drifted languidly to the floor. She had almost gotten herself under control, but another look at Glimmer's face and she started laughing all over again. Which in turn made Glimmer splutter worse.

Which is about when Catra returned, and looked so uncomfortably confused that they both started laughing at her instead.

"Wellp," Catra made a show of grabbing her hat and tipping it, "think that's a good sign t'take off then."

Things really had changed hadn't they?

Just a year ago Glimmer would have been mortified by this situation, hell, Catra wouldn't have taken their laughter in good humor. It would have been a disaster! Instead here they were with Catra grinning ear to ear and putting on a show of getting her things, including looking at her shiny new pocket watch with exaggerated disdain.

It was comfortable. It was soft and pleasant and round on all the edges. It made Glimmer's heart feel too large for her chest as she managed to get herself put together again.

"Hain't-" Glimmer coughed, trying to not fall back into a fit of giggles as her mother snorted loudly, "I mean to say that you shant make it very far without me, seeing as I have the only key to the house!"

Angella smacked her hand lightly on her desk top, sniggering as she fumbled blindly under her desk. And half cheering with the dirty wrap in hand as she stood, as if she'd accomplished some grand task. Then again, miracle she *see* anything with all them tears of joy.

Catra looked between the two of them and shrugged, "Like it's hard to pick a lock. Ain't even hidden 't all."

"Catra D'riluth, are you saying you're a no good scoundrel who would pick a lock?" Glimmer gasped theatrically.

"Mrs. Moon," Catra started with a dry look, "It's been an honor to work with you, truly but-"

"I'm afraid I can not accept your resignation at this time," Angella managed to say, completely smooth and calm like, even if her cheeks were flushed as she was wiping tears from her eyes. "How in the world else would I get good entertainment in this town?"

"Mrs. Moon!"

Glimmer physically pushed Catra out the door as her mother lost it all over again. Better to get back towards the stable and Captain to go home, then stay and start another round of that. Poor old Star Wind had started to struggle a bit on their longer trips, and Glimmer was hoping to give the mare a break now and then. Captain was still a bold and brash young thing, and prideful to boot. But at least he weren't upset by the journey with two people on him.

As they rode home, slow and leisurely with the long lasting summer light helping them the whole way, Glimmer let her mind wander.

After Catra's proposal at the lake, the two had fallen ill. Sicker'n dogs ill! Mermista and Sea Hawk had graciously let them stay until they were well enough for a carriage ride home. And then Bow, Adora, and Angella had all fretted over them endlessly as they continued to cough and wheeze for a few months. The whole engagement itself took a backseat to Glimmer's struggle to draw a single full breath and Catra's awful fever. That damned thing had come and gone, almost every time Catra would make it nearly to a full recovery it snuck back and undid a lot of good work. Mermista had sent them a letter apologizing, apparently there was

something wrong with the lake as several other swimmers had taken ill as well. It had been appreciated if a little silly, it wasn't as if Mermista controlled the water itself!

It took three whole months for them to make it back to rights, and at Glimmer's insistence, they'd begun trying to thank their helpers and assist them in anything that needed doing. From occasionally helping on Razz's land, to assisting Bow with his butcher work, to hosting Salineas's most famous couple. It took time and effort to give a proper thank you after all, and they were grateful! Of course Catra had complained the whole time, but Glimmer knew it had been more for show than anything else.

By the time their whole thank you tour was over, the engagement was old news to them at least.

And there it had remained, and hopefully tomorrow it would be righted. Glimmer watched as Catra worked on Captain at their barn, her motions sure and focused. Face placid as she brushed away. Well, no time like the present was there?

"We're having supper with my mother tomorrow." Glimmer less explained and more ordered.

Catra was still distracted trying to get Captain's brush down finished. "...okay, why?"

Glimmer sighed dramatically and waved her hand with the bracelet on it. "Oh dear, why ever would we do such a thing? When we were supposed to, say, right after our trip."

It still takes another solid minute before Catra stopped brushing, and then her head popped right up. Flushed red as a poppy to shout, "Oh fuck me."

"Not yet. Nor here. No interest in hay being anywhere near my naked flesh thank you." Glimmer is rather proud of how Catra somehow looked redder. It's not that often she gets to be on this side of things and it is wonderful. No wonder Catra delighted in

teasing her, maybe she should return the favor more often. Actually, no maybes, Glimmer smirked, she was *definitely* going to do more of this.

Catra weakly asked, "How has so much time passed?"

"We ain't exactly a quick moving couple. This...honestly? I'm disappointed, but it makes sense. I don't think we can do anything together without making it a big to do."

"We can so!"

Glimmer stared at her, incredulous as she shouted, "It took five years for you to kiss me!"

"So? It took you five years to kiss **me** and you knew I loved you already!"

"And it took you two more to propose when you had already moved in with me."

"Miss this ain't fair."

"Life ain't fair D'riluth, and we're having supper with my mother tomorrow, and that's final."

Despite the harshness of her words, Glimmer almost held her breath as she waited. Catra had certainly gotten more comfortable with her mother, but if she was truly upset about it, then Glimmer would do anything to ease her mind. Instead Catra just seemed...a little nervous. Nothing bad though.

So Glimmer made sure to hug her from behind as she put the brush away. Planting a small kiss behind her ear. "Thank you."

"Oh no," Catra said lacing their fingers together over her stomach, "Thank *you*, you may continue."

Glimmer cackled at her imperious tone, but did anyways. Only stopping to smack at Catra when she offered to lay down a few

blankets in the barn for them before they retreated to the house.

The next day held all the tension she'd hoped it wouldn't. Even as she'd teased Catra for mulling over what to wear to work (the woman had one good shirt and pair of pants, which she already wore to work, what did she think she'd find in the rest of the stained and hole covered bunch?), Glimmer had made sure to keep her own dress conservative. As if her mother would take one look at them and magically know what they'd been up to the previous night, because clearly she'd known for each time. It was dumb and stupid, but they both allegedly felt better for having fretted. Breakfast was a quick affair and after some consideration Glimmer decided to bring Star Wind with them.

As much as she wanted to cling to Catra's back, the idea of a leisurely romantic ride through the woods sounded just as good.

They took off earlier than usual, the sun just barely peeking over the mountains to wash the sky in pink and periwinkle. The colors popping in and out amongst the needles and leaves above them, shadows deepening the colors around them. The air was clean and fresh, the smell of soil and sap soothing after all the years they'd put in out here. Still cool enough to enjoy every moment.

When she glance over she caught Catra staring at her dreamily, and got to watch her blush terribly as she whipped around to pretend she hadn't been a lovesick fool.

"Oh, see something you like miss?" Glimmer gently looped the reins around her saddle horn. Star Wind weren't going nowhere she weren't meant to go, allowing Glimmer to fully face her fiance in her side saddle.

Catra's blush only worsened as she coughed, "MMMmmm, lots of them cute lil chipmunks 'sall."

There really were a lot of them this year weren't there? The little stripped and spotted creatures darting erratically on the tree trunks and across the ground. Their poofy little tails almost

looking like they was floating with how they moved. They were *darling* little things in her opinion, but she wasn't going to let an opportunity roll by.

"Now just who do you think you're calling a chipmunk?"

"What!? No! You-ugh!"

Oh she was really off her game wasn't she?

"Me?" Glimmer asked, faking wide eyes and trying to look hurt. "You're calling *me* a chipmunk? That's it, wedding's cancelled."

"Hey!" Catra laughed, nudging Captain over so their legs nearly brushed. "Don't say that, how can I make it up to you?"

Glimmer smirked, leaned forward, waited until Catra was leaning over to give her a kiss before she walloped her arm good with a cackle.

"Ow! Glimmer, what the fuck? Damn! Here I am trying to be nice and you hit me?"

Glimmer punched her again, "That's two for whining."

Catra growled her annoyance to the tree tops before picking up Captain's pace with her shoulder's hiked up to her ears.

"Aw, don't be a sore loser darlin'!" Glimmer happily jeered, knowing full well that Catra wouldn't actually race ahead. "Think of it this way, I'm no longer mad at you fer calling me a chipmunk!"

Catra's whole head rolled with what she could only assume was her eyes, but she still waited for Glimmer to catch up before smiling at her evilly. "That's alright my lil ground squirrel I'll find other things t' call ya."

"No, wait, don't do this." Glimmer begged far too late as she realized her grave mistake.

“My little honey badger.”

“Catra!”

“My nickering foal.”

“No, that’s awful!”

“My vicious bitely mountain lion.”

Glimmer shuddered, “Oh do not even joke about them!”

“My yowling coyote!” Catra cackled dodging Glimmer ineffective swipes. “M-my plump goldfinch!”

“D’riluth I am going to **hurt you**!”

Catra tried a few more times to talk, but was too busy laughing and gripping at her ribs to say much beyond the occasional wheezed, “I can’t breathe!”

“Then do us a favor and don’t,” Glimmer huffed, blushing and frazzled, and painfully aware that she did look like a poofed up bird of some kind at this point. She still took the time to fully enjoy watching Catra laugh and smile. She could listen to that laugh forever, never truly able to stay mad when the love of her life was so quick to find humor in any situation. Catra's face went in and out of shadow as they rode, her cheeks slowly turned into hibiscus blooms. Oh gosh, she was really falling in love again wasn’t she? Glimmer smiled softly, tears gathering in her eyes. “Hey. I love you.”

Catra’s bashful grin was its own reward, but the way she whispered, “I love you.” would never stop turning her legs to jelly and heart into the sun.

They spent the rest of the ride holding hands, giggling like they were children in on a good joke. It felt like she was in a dream and Glimmer could not have been more grateful that she’d never wake up.

With their horses left in her mother's fenced yard, they strolled arm in arm to the station. When Catra tried to pull away before the last turn, Glimmer only clung tighter. Pressing a reassuring kiss to her collar to seal the deal. Angella smiled when they came through the door, Catra holding it open for Glimmer before shutting it to the hustle and noise outside.

It felt like the blink of an eye. One moment they were standing together preparing for the day ahead, and the next they were sitting down at Angella's table for supper.

And no matter how relaxed and confident Glimmer had been the night before, she could now say that Catra's day long anxiety had fully rubbed off on her. The two of them sat rigid and wooden, a respectable distance between them as Angella sat patiently across from them. Her mother's gaze was narrowed in calculation, no doubt trying to guess what had the two of them acting so strange. The only real relief coming from Miss Baker and Mister Pop teasing her mercilessly for not stopping by to have a meal or say hello, which Glimmer happily accepted in place of her growing nerves.

And the generous serving of summer vegetable soup, heavy on the corn and light on the carrots, certainly helped her disposition.

"So," Angella started, "how have things been?"

There was an awkward pause. What hadn't they told her about besides the whole 'we've accidentally been dating in secret and got engaged and forgot to tell you sorry' business?

"Good," Catra dipped a chunk of buttered bread to soak up the broth still in her bowl. "Saw some chipmunks on the way in this morning, real cute like."

Glimmer kicked her under the table with a glare, but Catra's grin only got wider. Oh she was not getting away with that. "And some beautiful flowers are blooming out there too."

Catra's boot side made a soft thunking sound as she tried to kick at Glimmer and hit the chair leg instead. Now that was some sweet, sweet validation.

"It does sound lovely," Angella sighed wistfully. "There is a lot of beauty out here, but I do miss the flower gardens back home. Did I ever tell you about how Micha was shocked at just how many types my father grew?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes, she sure had. About a million times! But Catra looked interested and shook her head. Mister Pop whisked away their empty bowls, leaving small plates of smoked tongue with arugula and horseradish behind. So Glimmer happily concentrated on that instead.

"Oh my Micha, he'd seen green of course, he'd guarded sheep flocks before. But he was still surprised when we landed at how much green there was in general in England. He had just barely gotten over that when we made it home and the carriage passed through the family garden. He looked at me like a child outside a sweet shop," Angella chuckled, chin resting on the back of her hands. "Poor man nearly vibrated out of his skin between the excitement and the nerves!"

Glimmer squinted at her plate. Wait just a cotton picking minute, wasn't this the same story about-

"Oh? Why was he nervous?" Catra asked, playing right into her mother's hands.

Angella smiled at both of them before replying, "Well he'd never met my parents before, and the poor man felt very strongly about asking them permission to marry me."

Catra choked on her bite of food, smacking her fist against her chest a few times while Glimmer stared in horror. Oh no. What if? No! No!? How could she possible know!? No! There was no way she could have found out! This was, Glimmer thought, heart beating wildly in her chest, this was just a strange coincidence!

Mister Pop appeared from thin air to take their plates away, returning to leave the entree of patty cases and grilled fish without a word.

Angella simply smiled blandly as she sipped at her wine, allowing them both a chance to calm down. "They said yes, of course, I'd been writing with them almost constantly telling them all about the Mister Moon who was sweeping me handily off my feet. Mother was just happy to see us so happy. Of course, I hadn't known then that he planned on proposing to me there. The sly dog convinced me to walk the gardens with him, I was just giddy to watch him so enamored with my father's work I didn't think twice about it."

Catra gulped down her wine desperately, almost choking again in her haste.

"He had this whole speech about how beautiful everything was, and how he was not surprised that I was twice as gorgeous as where I came from," Angella laughed, eyes soft and distant. "And then he pulled out his grandmother's bracelet and asked me to marry him right there. It was perfect!"

Glimmer sighed contentedly, alright she made a fuss about hearing it but each time was just as sweet as the last.

"Of course then it did start raining, which put a little pause on things as we rushed inside."

"It's, uh," Catra started with all the grace of a drunken bull, "it's funny that's how it happened, actually. Because, uh, we- well, we, uhm…"

Catra looked at her for help but it was, first of all, too much fun to watch her flounder and second of all Glimmer thought she might be having a heart attack herself.

"It's just, very similar to something we've been, uhm, damn! I mean dang!? Why is it so hot in here?"

Angella looked slowly between them, and Catra was looking ready to die by any means she could quickly get her hands on.

"What we're trying to say," Glimmer half shouted, coughed, cleared her throat, and started again at a more appropriate volume, "is that we've been, well, together. As a couple. For, uh, several years actually."

Catra looked at once relieved to not be the one trying to explain, and also horrified at her bluntness. Like she'd been doing any better!

Angella blinked rapidly, looking between them again before taking a deep breath and Glimmer panicked. "ANYWAYS we'realsoengagednowandCatraproposedlastyearandwearesosorrywedidn'ttellyou!"

Catra turned slowly to look at her with one eye twitching. Glimmer could almost hear her voice in her head. *What in tarnation d'you think you're doing!?* She tried to smile but more grimaced back at her.

Angella coughed, knocking gently on the table top to get their attention again. "I, first of all, I appreciate that you told me this. But...I do apologize, but did you honestly think I didn't know that you two have been courting one another?"

"Kill me now," Catra hissed under her breath, deflating in her seat.

"I'm more offended that you thought I wouldn't notice after you two moved in together. Also," Angella paused to take another bite of her meal, swallowing before continuing, "I work with you both every day of the week. I sit next to you and between you. Your flirting hasn't exactly been-"

"Mom!" Glimmer begged her to stop.

"-subtle. It's not exactly a strong suit for either of you really."

Catra's hollow gaze turned to her meal before she began to mechanically shovel it into her face. Glimmer glared at her because how dare she use food as an excuse to leave this whole thing up to her.

"Besides," Angella continued after taking a sip of her wine, "you really thought Adora or Bow could keep a secret from me? Catra, I know you wanted to talk to me before your trip, and I do apologize. It seemed like everything that could go wrong did and prevented us from having that discussion."

Glimmer could not believe that both of her very dear friends were now **dead to her**. Tragically, tragically **murdered**. "They never told me that!"

Angella lifted a brow. "Did you ever ask them?"

"No! Why would I think to ask, oh by the way did you happen to break Catra's *trust* by telling my mother before she could!?"

Angella sighed, "Glimma…"

Catra suddenly smacked a hand over her face, before slowly speaking, "Are you telling me that each time I got nervous and they told me not to worry, it's because they already told you and knew the answer?"

"Well, that does sound rather bad when you say it like that," Angella conceded, before continuing, "Anyways I have some ideas for the wedding if you'd like the input of an old biddy. Also, please tell me you haven't told anyone else? That I'm technically the first person. I would be so very hurt as your mother if you had told someone else, not that I have anyone in mind in particular."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, not falling for her act one bit. "No mother, I did not tell aunt Casta yet."

"Excellent!" Her mother's eyes lit up with excitement. "I do...enjoy

your aunt's...lively company, but she can be a bit...well, you know your aunt."

And in that moment, Glimmer suddenly realized with building dread that she was going to have to tell her aunt Castaspella about this. That she was going to have to kindly but firmly decline her aunt's offers to plan every last detail. Repeatedly. Oh. *Oh no*.

"What's, uh, what's wrong with her?" Catra asked nervously.

"Nothing!" Angella practically yelped, fingers tapping at the table before caving instantly, "It's just that when Micah and I married, Castaspella took over the whole thing and planned out her perfect wedding and I *appreciate* the effort she put in!"

Her and Glimmer spoke at the same time, Angella with a manic edge and Glimmer with terror. "She just made it for herself first."

"Yes, exactly." Angella looked almost relieved that Glimmer remembered. Then tried to backtrack. "Not that I think she'll do that to you two! Only that she's a bit...persistent."

"Glimmer," Catra looked at her, alarm bells ringing in both their heads, "would you do me the honor of eloping tonight and we can tell her afterwards?"

"It's not *that* bad." Angella chuckled as if she had not been complaining about this exact issue for over twenty five years. "Also I forbid it. Which I can do! As Glimmer's mother!"

"Maybe, maybe if we plan it all out before we tell her," Glimmer began hopefully, before groaning and slumping in her chair, "UGH! No, then she'd just undo all our work and that would be worse. Well! At least we have some time to come up with a plan!"

Catra glared at her, "Because we can't do nothing without a hullabaloo?"

"Yes! And also at this rate we'll actually get married with canes to hold us up."

Catra threw her hands in the air, “We don’t move *that* slowly!”

“Ten years!?” Glimmer said incredulously.

“We didn’t even-”

“Five years for you to just admit-”

“Like you’re any better!”

Angella watched as the two of them bickered, only sighing and pulling the bell to let Mr. Pop know they’d need another bottle of wine and hopefully she could warn Miss Baker to delay dessert if possible. If there was anything she’d learned about her daughter and her someday to be daughter-in-law, it was that their fighting could make even a simple task convoluted. He’d barely entered with the next bottle before looking at them, leaving, and returning to place two bottles of wine on the table. They shared a quick smile as he left for the kitchen.

Luckily the whole thing was not noticed by the betrothed, that would have been its own disaster.

So Angella refilled her glass and sat back to wait. After all, she had not been holding onto her suggestions for almost a year just to be accidentally railroaded!

“Oh don’t you dare D’riluth!”

“OOOooooohhh, you gonna stop me, chip-OW!” Catra jumped in her seat as Glimmer's kick managed to land in the already tender spot she'd kicked earlier.

“Serves you right!” Glimmer crowed viciously.

“Are you two quite finished?” Angella asked, somehow equally amused and bemused by the fight. “I do have a few suggestions of my own if I may. Now, first of all, have you chosen when you want to marry?”

Catra paled and looked like she was gonna be sick, “Why does that matter?”

“Well...it will affect who will be able to come out for the whole affair. Although I’m sure some will send congratulations or gifts no matter what.”

“L-like, wait, come out, as in, come out here?” Catra looked at them both confused.

“Yes?” Glimmer shared a look with her mom. “You know, as guests?”

Catra covered her face and groaned into her hands, “Why is it, every time I think I’ve finally understood this place, y’all make things more complicated?”

“Wait, what? Catra, what did you think a marriage ceremony would be like?”

She threw her hands in the air, “I don't know! We didn’t do stuff like this back in the Hor- look, it was kind of a messed up- that’s not the point! Ugh! Ain’t nobody got married in my old family okay? It was religious phooey or another.”

Glimmer was gobsmacked. It was always pulling teeth to learn much about Catra’s family, and just knowing this she was starting to understand why. No one was allowed to marry the person they loved? “Well that hain’t fair!”

Catra looked at her, face shadowed for just a moment before she smiled weakly. “Not much was with them. I uh, learned about it from some dime novels one of the guys hauled around with him.” She blushed terribly, shrugging her shoulders at her plate as Angella pushed a tumbler of wine over to her. With the most adorably embarrassed voice Glimmer had ever heard, Catra mumbled, “Sounded nice.”

Well that certainly put Catra’s over the top proposal into better perspective considering her only reference had been those trashy

novels!

Heart feeling fit to burst, Glimmer took pity on her amazing, stupid, brilliant, beautiful, sweet, and sappy finance. “Awww, you really like me, huh?”

It got the surprised laugh she wanted, so that was a win.

“Well then,” Angella lifted her glass with a smile, “congratulations to the happy couple, and here’s to doing things in your own way. And time.”

“Mother!”

Miss Baker and Mister Pop suddenly burst from around the corner with a loaded tray. Blancmange with raisins, apricots and almonds, and assorted candied peels. A pot of coffee carried carefully as they quickly switched out the half eaten entrees for the lavish dessert course. Both of them pausing to give Glimmer a half hug in her chair; Miss Baker giggled as she pinched her cheek.

“Oh my god,” Catra moaned, “how were you better prepared for this than we were? Don’t answer that.”

Angella smirked from the rim of her glass. “You say that as if there isn’t port and cake after this.”

“Oh god!”

Glimmer laughed, lifted her wine and unhelpfully added, “I’ll toast to that.”

Catra’s insistence that she hated them both was tempered by her grin and blush, and all was forgiven by the meal’s end. “Someone’s gonna have to roll me out of here.”

Glimmer chuckled, “Oh I can think of a few ways to do that.”

“You see, this, right here?” Angella said with a lifted brow, “Not subtle.”

Which was more than enough to get them both fleeing out the door giggling in mortification.

“Have a good night, I’ll see you tomorrow, we can plan more then! Be safe! I love you!”

Catra was laughing too hard to open the stall doors, and Glimmer was laughing too hard to get up on Star Wind the first few attempts as Angella waited patiently to wave goodbye to them.

All in all, it had gone rather well.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you all enjoyed, seeing as it's going to be sad and angry glitra hours for...a while. :'D

(also let me know if the spacing is wonkalicious, it seemed extra kerfuckity when I put it in and I think I caught everything, but we all know that the best time to catch every mistake you've made in a fic is after you've posted!)

Chapter 9: Them's The Breaks

Chapter Summary

> Catra finally tries to open up about her past. It doesn't go well. At all, at all.

Chapter Notes

> A gentle reminder that this fic is half angst/whump and to double check those tags. Catra is...not well y'all. Welcome to the start of the pain train portion of this fic. You're, uh, welcome?
>
> CW: panic attack, self harm, self loathing, vomiting (mention), violence, semi-graphic depictions of violence, child abuse, suicidal ideation, intrusive thoughts
>
> Thank you to dragonesdepapel for beta reading this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was almost ironic that barely a few days after their dinner with Angella, Catra had found herself once again tied up in knots over her now year old engagement.

She'd been chopping up a bit of pork to make a stew, fully enjoying the quiet and repetition of the task. Letting her mind wander wherever it wanted to, and following with no complaint. Her and Glimmer had talked more about what to expect with a wedding, something Catra was becoming more comfortable with, and they'd started to put a list of guests together. At the time, when Glimmer had asked, " *Is there anyone you want to invite?* " she shook her head. Adora and Bow were gonna be there already, and ain't no one else needed to be there for Catra. Glimmer hadn't pushed for more, and all was well.

But now, knife in hand as she worked, Catra suddenly did think of someone. *Would be nice to have Scorpia there.*

Suddenly the raw meat looked like fingers and Catra found herself shaking as she did a double take to find the cubed pork and bones sitting there benignly. Her stomach ached and chest felt hollow as she breathed slowly in and out to calm down. Wasn't like she could actually invite her old friend. And not like anyone from the Horde could find her even if she *could* invite Scorpia. So why was she nervous? Not a soul from her old life knew where she was, for better or for worse. Catra had managed to focus and work for another few minutes before the shaking came back worse.

Glimmer doesn't know.

The knife had slipped right out of her hand. Glimmer didn't know. About her. About the Horde. Glimmer didn't know because Catra had been lying.

What will you say when they find you? That damn witch asked from beyond the grave. A smile twisting on her face, somehow more cruel than it ever had been in life. *What will they do when they finally catch up to you? Nothing good I fear.*

It had been a long time since she'd thought about that last bit. A constant worry those first few years in town, it had faded slowly as time passed without so much as a peep from them. Her nervousness that someone would figure it out was almost as bad. As if anyone could look at her and know she'd once had wings. As if the Horde would waste it's efforts to find one worthless, pathetic runaway. If they were gonna look for her, they'd have found her by now. *But Hordak never forgives a grudge.* She shivered even in the summer heat, even by the stove.

She'd left for a damn good reason, even if she hadn't ever intended to. And she'd never told Glimmer, and that left Glimmer vulnerable...because of her.

"Shit," Catra stumbled back a half step and sank into a crouch on the floor. Hands fisted in her hair despite the blood and gristle on them. *Why? Why do you need to tell her anything? She doesn't*

know, it's fine! Hordak might kill you on sight, but you know they ain't expanding this way. She doesn't need to know! That wasn't fair though. That wasn't fair to her or her mother. To tie them to a marked woman. Her life might be expendable, but their's certainly weren't. *Glimmer would kill me for that, she'd say mine is worth something.* Catra chuckled roughly, almost wheezing as she choked all those tangled thoughts off. "Shit. Later. Think on it *later* "

She had managed to get herself under control, stand up, and get back on task. She'd even managed to smile and tease and generally harass Glimmer for the rest of the evening.

She had not, however, managed to get a wink of sleep, instead she stared at the star painted sky out their open window. Every worst case scenario running through her mind, until she'd slipped out of bed to throw up outside. Catra wasn't sure how she'd managed the next day, only that the second night she'd fallen asleep to nightmares of what Hordak would do to Glimmer if he caught them.

It had been Prime, back when he'd been alive, who'd set the rules against the weakness of love and kindness, but when Hordak took over he didn't let up one bit. He nearly doubled down in some bid to please the ghost of his brother. She could still remember when she was twelve, the night he made an example of two boys just a few years older than her for the grave crime of loving one another.

It took hours before their screaming went silent.

Catra had stumbled that night on weak legs, set her bag between two of the boys she'd seen kissing that very same day and didn't sleep. They snuck away in the night, having watched two of their own choke on their own blood. They had ignored what was true and right. So she'd gone and spit fire the next morning. Viciously attacked them, daring them to be stupid enough to get caught. A lot of her motivations back then had been a might too tied up in

other people's desires, but that one had been some twisted desire to help. Fat lotta good that had done.

Hordak had noticed her shortly after. God knows why he'd finally noticed her then, but at the time it had felt like a sign that her hard work was going to be rewarded. And she'd happily clawed her way up the ranks for the next several years, having been given just the barest of opportunities. Using her power to tighten the screws and left shocked when the two she'd tried to protect never returned from a low risk robbery. At the time she'd assumed they'd abandoned her like cowards, never once believing the rumors that they'd fled to protect themselves. " *I think they cared for one another."* Catra almost killed the poor bastard who dared to sneer about her crew like that.

It was only now, with years to soften her and the love of her life waking her up each morning that Catra suddenly understood it. She hoped those two boys were in love. She hoped they got far away and were never caught. She hoped they were happy and free.

Catra tried to convince herself that their assumed success boded well for her own. She just needed to work through this and keep her mouth shut. So she said nothing, awake all day and all night.

Until that collapsed in on her as well.

The fourth night of nightmares in a row found Glimmer trying to pry the problem out of her to no avail. They'd fought all day, simmering with resentment as they worked and dead silent at home. The fifth night Glimmer stayed up with her the whole night through, not asking anything just being there. Angella saw the bags under their eyes and the exhaustion in their souls and sent them home for three days rest.

" *And don't come back until you are able to focus, you hear?* " It was done because Angella cared about them, loved them. It made Catra want to scream.

Catra knew she was hurtling head first towards a cliff. One of her own accidental making. Like she'd set to dig a post hole and finished with a canyon. Not telling them was killing her faster than any noose could. The guilt of understanding what hiding it meant, the shame of knowing she'd waited too long to explain.

She **had** to tell them. It was the right thing to do.

It burned.

She waited on that first day, still trying to find the right time, knowing it needed to be during this imposed break. Sooner the better. Catra repeated that to herself as she trashed awake so violently that she nearly punched Glimmer. God help her, she needed to pry her stubborn mouth open! The sooner, the better. Breakfast came and went with little fanfare, and by then Catra knew she'd waited too long. Still not too late...but almost. So instead she made another pot of coffee, splashed some whiskey into their mugs and gone to sit on the porch steps. She had the best of intentions but even the few minutes alone left her dead eyed and lost to the world. Not even snapping at Glimmer's hovering just...not having the energy for it knowing what she needed to do.

Glimmer still sat next to her on the steps, bitterly nursing her own mug, each sip she took sounded like a scream. Like she knew and was disappointed that she wouldn't admit to it. *We know all, **see** all.* Catra was wearing her patience thin, too thin. Patience of a saint! Still a human. Why was this so hard? She'd gotten better right? She was better than this, right? *No helping those who do not wish to be helped.*

"You know," Glimmer started, her tone unnaturally even and worse for it, "you do better when ya tell me what's wrong. And then I can help. In fact, we both do better when we're talking."

Her hands shook violently, hot coffee sloshed over the edges and burned. *Wasteful.* But she didn't put it down. The sooner, the better. Her voice was somehow a croak and a whisper, "I know."

Glimmer gave her a dry glare and blew some hair out of her face in frustration, but when Catra didn't continue- couldn't continue, she turned away with a scoff. *Well? Speak up.* Which somehow hurt worse. Was there an upper limit to pain before you just died of it? She couldn't keep fucking this up. She promised she wouldn't go hurting Glimmer on purpose no more, but here she was hurting Glimmer Moon in the hopes it would save Catra herself from pain. *Pathetic little beast.* Before she could open her mouth Glimmer was facing her again, the hardness gone and replaced with something softer and open.

"Sorry, sorry. I'm not, I swear I'm not mad atcha. I'm just…" Glimmer took a slow sip before continuing, "I'm just scared for you is all. I wish you'd talk to me. I hate seeing you hurt."

Catra couldn't contain a single manic bark of laughter. Scared for her? Scared **for** her? She didn't know, she couldn't know! She had to know, had to understand. And Catra was scared, god almighty she was scared. *Cowardice seems to suit you so well.* No! *You think you can be something more? Ha! I'll believe it when I see it.* She would, she would, she would. This was the biggest one. The biggest leap of faith. This was practically what all her little concessions had been for! Training for. Finally sharing the truth the way she'd promised five years back. The truth that Glimmer had never pushed her on, no matter how curious she obviously was.

This wasn't about Catra. It was about Glimmer and Angella and keeping her family safe. "I...I know. I just need tuh...to find the words? It ain't gonna be good. Ain't pretty."

She took a moment to try and collect herself, closed her eyes. What if Glimmer hated her? What if this ruined it? *These things aren't meant for a mongrel like you.* Hell, killing that lug at the bank had almost ruined it, what would she say when-when-when- Catra took a slow deep breath with her eyes still closed. That was a mistake. The burning in her hands, the soreness in her limbs, the smell of alcohol and sweat. It was so nostalgically familiar. Disgustingly too familiar and-

Catra might have been thirteen years old, but she wasn't an idiot, she knew that the Horde wasn't exactly a happy perfect family the way Hordak tried to portray them to outsiders. They were a gang. A good one too. She'd technically helped with bank robberies and one time even played the role of a kidnapping victim on a train. They weren't good people, they were the bad guys. Every last one of them; rotten to the core.

But that night was the first time Catra had gone with Hordak for any job. "A simple debt collection," he'd said, no more explanation than that. Nothing to worry about.

She was so ***fucking*** *stupid.*

The man didn't have their money, and his wife and kid didn't either. Catra thought that Hordak would have her help beat them up a bit, maybe trash their house or steal some of their possessions back. A simple debt collection. *Ha!*

"These ropes," Hordak growled, glaring at her, "should be tighter."

"Yes sir," Catra nodded, quickly going to fix her mistake. The kid was crying but she'd gagged him easily enough. His mama watched as Catra tightened the bindings. Her eyes shifting through too many unknown emotions for Catra to hold her gaze. Kid was younger'n 10 for sure, built like a soft breeze would hurl him right over. Even with his bindings tied loose enough to not cut off circulation he weren't going nowhere. She still tied him tighter.

"Please," the man pleaded, not to Hordak but directly to her. The hair on her neck stood on end and she shoved the twisted knot in her stomach down. "Please, I'll have the money next week I swear to you! I swear it!"

She ignored him the best she could.

Hordak double checked her work and nodded with approval, before putting a hand on her shoulder and pulling her to the middle of the room. Dead center between all three members of that little family. "Alright now Catra, take this."

She could hear alarm bells in her head. One of the first rules everyone learned was to not use anyone's real name on the job. Someone could remember it, use it to find them, use it to kill them. Real names meant more killing, meant more attention. She glanced nervously at the woman and man, even as she took the revolver from Hordak's hand-

Catra blinked hard, stared into her mug and watched the ripples on its surface with a detached interest. Huh. Damn. That was fucking vivid. She was not in a great place, was she? Two gentle, warm hands tugged until she let go, putting the coffee aside.

"Hey, seriously, what's wrong?" Glimmer asked with big, sad eyes and no clue who she was sitting with. "You can tell me, I swear it."

"Yeah," Catra swallowed hard, her throat too tight and dry to choke much more past. She was going to have to do it. She had to do this. She couldn't let this come back to haunt her, she wouldn't let it ruin everything she'd earned. It was terrifying, but if she meant it, if she meant that she'd do better, she needed to get to getting. "I need to...before this moves forward any further, you need to know the truth about me. The whole truth."

Glimmer's smile vanished, tone serious when she spoke and rubbed Catra's arm. "Okay, but nothing you say is gonna change anything."

"Don't say that!" She hadn't meant to shout, but Catra could feel her emotions boiling over. She jumped to her feet, practically ripping her arm away from Glimmer. Away from comfort as she stalked inside, only half aware of Glimmer cautiously following her. "That's the sort of shit that just brings it all down! I can't-oh hell!"

She was being ridiculous, right? There's a small part of her that whispered while she paced. *You are spiraling out of control. You're safe, Glimmer loves you, and you love her. You will work this out but you can't do that if you don't calm down and talk.*

Catra hated it. Because it was right. Because she couldn't seem to do anything about it. Because Glimmer looked scared and she can't tell if it's for her still, or because of her erratic behavior. *The sooner, the better.*

Put up or shut up D'riluth.

"That family I found? I lied. They found me. I had parents and they died, and my new *family* ," She spit that word like the curse her whole childhood felt like, "Weren't no family a'tall. They were a gang. A very violent gang Glimmer, that's who raised me. When, when I said, when-when I said I'd done dangerous things...ha! I've done worse."

Glimmer's voice was brittle when she tried to interrupt, "Catra-"

But she knew what Glimmer would say. She'd try to argue that Catra had been too young to know, or that she was misunderstood, or that her past mistakes didn't define her as if most of her life hadn't even happened. Little wisps of smoke scattering through bright green leaves. She didn't understand, she didn't know so she couldn't- "NO! You don't understand! I'm not a good person!"

"Like hell you ain't!"

"YOU THINK THAT ROBBER WAS THE FIRST!?" Catra panted for breath, like she'd been running for hours instead of barely talking for three minutes. Shaking and shaking as she stared Glimmer down, knowing that look of shock would be seared in her mind forever. "'Cause he wasn't! I've been on the other side of that bullshit, and I- fuck that's not even covering the shake downs and scams and more! I don't even know how many people I've wronged Glimmer. I don't even…"

She was gasping for air, feeling light headed, feeling out of control like she hadn't been in a long time. *What if the monster comes back? I wonder what it'd do to her?* She had to keep that part of her leashed, she had to. She had to.

When Glimmer spoke, it was with such conviction that Catra had to stop and look at her. "You aren't with them anymore, and they ain't you."

She wanted to agree, to plead her case, but instead hysterical laughter poured out. She laughed hard enough that she almost fell over, forced to drop into a squat or collapse on the floorboards. Catra cradled her head in her hands as she 'calmed' enough to speak. "You don't get it. No one ever really leaves. You can get out, sure, if'n you're stupid and lucky enough. But you don't ever just...stop being what they made you into."

"Hog's wash-"

"Have you ever heard of Heaven's Horde?" Catra waited to make sure Glimmer wouldn't try and spin this into some heroic tale, almost enjoying the look of hatred that crossed her face. Her 'family' was infamous, known for their sadistic violence. *You liked it when you were on top.* Glimmer had to really and truly know who she was, who she'd always be. "Not surprised. They got driven outta lot of places. I had to run past a few state *lines* to get away, but you don't grow up with them and just not…"

"You were part of the Horde." Glimmer's voice was ragged. The conviction gone and replaced with all the fragility and sharpness of glass.

It's funny, the way certain things, innocuous things, could take her whole existence and throw it on it's damned head.

It was like coming out of a daze. Like surfacing from underwater. Catra can feel it in the air, the way her whole world is suddenly tilting dangerously on its side. A train flying too fast around the tracks and ready to derail. She'd known better than to do it like this. Why did she do it like this? Why couldn't she just keep her damn mouth shut and be happy? Why does she have to ruin every *good thing in her life* ? "G-Glimmer?"

"The Horde," she whispered, eyes going colder than ice and harder than steel, "killed my father."

Catra's ears rang, her chest hurt, and the **world** was ending. She had fallen down into an endless pit. There were no stars left in the damn sky. *This can't be happening. Please, please this can't be* ***happening to me*** . *I'm doing the right thing! Please!* There was no recovering for that! There was no taking back Micah Moon's death!

"Glim-"

"Stop! Just...stop." Glimmer turned away and stared out the window. They both stayed where they were, silent as the grave before Glimmer jerked towards the front door.

Catra's throat constricted, trying to choke her out right there. "Where, where are you-?"

Glimmer stepped over the threshold, one hand gripping the door when she turned to look at Catra on the floor. The glance took a split second, and it felt like getting shot. The rage in her normally sweet eyes burning hot like tar before Glimmer looked away.

"I'm going for a walk. I can't...I can't look at you right now. I *will* come back later, I just…" And with that she left, shutting the door nice and quiet and gentle.

Somehow it's worse. It was so much worse.

Catra doesn't know how long she stayed there on the floor, at some point she rocked backwards and sat down. Just stared at the door unblinking, not even crying as her body went fuzzy and numb. *So that was that. That's how it all ends.* Had the front door always looked so strange? Too brown to be brown, too perfectly cut to be real? *You need to lie down.* That sounded like a good idea, not that she could listen even if she'd wanted to. Catra stayed on the floor, sitting upright as she felt the whole earth rotated jarringly beneath her palms. The streaks of light coming through the windows changing position every time she blinked. It

took a long time to swim through the molasses her mind had become, and when she did it came with clarity.

"Glimmer hates me." She hadn't even meant to say it, but there it was. Just facts in the open. *You don't know that.* But she **did** , and anyone with a lick of sense would too. *She told you to stop assuming.* It wasn't assumed if it was true. *"I can't* ***look at you*** *right now!"* Her voice rang almost crystal clear in her mind through the silence of their house. She'd left. She couldn't stand her, so she left. "G-Glimmer huh-hates me?"

In a strange way she almost felt calm, nearly in control. Like watching someone else pitifully crying on the floor. Wait. Was she crying? She lifted a hand to her face to feel. Ah. For another eternal moment she stayed there not thinking or feeling or existing. Oh, she finally thought to herself, oh these weren't normal shakes were they?

Catra gasped as she slammed back into her body. Unable to breathe through the sobbing and the panic, crying miserably onto the dusty floorboards. Her back hurt and her head hurt, and she felt like throwing up. Her ass was dead asleep and hips complaining from all the weight she'd started leaning on them. She deserved it. Small prices to pay for breaking Glimmer's heart all over again.

"Next time will be the last. You can't go breaking my heart again."

If she'd just kept her stupid mouth **shut** - Catra howled, stumbling to her feet, she stumbled and found herself punching at the wall until she remembered she wasn't supposed to do that. Break things when she was mad, it wasn't right. So she pulled at her hair and scratched at her neck as she lost her mind. She was so fucking STUPID. Always so stupid and pathetic, knowing that it was gonna hurt and poking at it like she needed to be reminded how awful she was and how horrible it would all go. A whimpering animal! What was the fucking point if her life was nothing but mistake after mistake? She'd gotten to the highest high and made the mistake of wanting things that *humans* have, that real people

deserved and things like her should never covet! She thought she'd beat the monster inside when there was no other magical being existing inside her chest. Just her. Just her and she'd finally been ready to show the worst parts of herself and-and-and she didn't even get to! She didn't even explain a god damned thing because even the barest glimpse brought Glimmer to her senses. Fuck. FUCK!

She stumbled, unaware of where she was beyond trying to keep her violence contained where it wouldn't hurt anyone or anything important. Catra didn't stop until her fingers wouldn't flex and dig in anymore. Didn't stop until she'd run through it fully, the emotions running hot and thick. Even then she stayed still afraid to move. If she moved she would lose the few fragile bits of herself she had left.

But she needed to go.

She needed to leave. Now.

She'd ruined everything because that's what happens. Adding Catra never added value, it only made things worse. Spread the rot. No. No, not her. Life. The universe. Ha! Mostly her wasn't it? She stuttered a half laugh, wheezing as she tried to understand what she was looking at in her hands and where she even was in the house. She'd, she'd moved hadn't she?

She couldn't quite remember.

It didn't matter.

Why would it matter what she did when everything always went wrong in the end? Why did...why…Glimmer hated her and couldn't stand to even be near her. Couldn't look at her. Why did it always…?

Catra's eyes closed shut so hard she could hear thunder rumbling between her ears. She managed to hiss between clenched teeth. Not anything she'd meant to say. A pathetic little plea to nothingness. "Please come back."

It didn’t help. She gasped for air. She wanted to die. She wanted to die! There was no coming back from this, it had been inevitable and she couldn’t, she couldn’t do this again! She couldn’t! The giving up on everything, giving up everything she had. Starting over. She couldn’t, she wouldn’t! No point to it. No point when the same problem always came back. She could take care of the problem though, she’d always been someone’s problem after all. But she couldn’t take care of it here, she couldn’t do it here. No...that would, that would piss Glimmer off worse having to clean up the leftover bits. She couldn’t inconvenience her like that. Not again. Not after everything she’d already put her through. *Who could she have been if you’d finished the job right the first time?*

She tried to breathe, to reason with herself, to find something to hold onto.

But nearly a week without rest and the cold hard truth certainly set her head on straight. *She couldn’t see the surface, couldn’t see the light, just cold cold cold dark dark dark and she couldn’t breathe.* Catra gasped, fingers twisting deeper into the solid/soft/rough *thing* in her hands. What the hell was she holding? Some cloth? A creamy off white thing with shiny spots on it. *Their skin was ashy white at the edges of the burn, a ring of shiny little blisters just past that.* Catra coughed and gagged, and knew she was overreacting. That had been years ago, she should be over it by now. *You always do this, can you not control yourself?* Like a little child. *Disgusting.* She just needed to stop. Simple as that. *Are you proud, Catra? Are you proud of this behavior?* Stop and think and leave, and then, and then, and then, and then, and then-

She didn’t want to. *It would have been a mercy onto us all if I’d left you to die in that damn cabin!* She had to.

“Please come back.”

It didn’t help.

Chapter End Notes

That boy needs therapy...

As always, come scream with me on my tumblr, I try to post WiPs from my active stories and I'm always open for questions and prompts.

Chapter 10: Sometimes It Breaks Right

Chapter Summary

> There weren't words to describe what her daddy's death had done to her.

Chapter Notes

> While from Glimmer's PoV, we still have some content/trigger warnings for folks!
>
> CW: self harm (after effects), anxiety attack, referenced violence, dissociation
>
> Shout out to dragonesdepapel for beta reading and leaving the best comment I've gotten on this fic while doing so. :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There weren't words to describe what her daddy's death had done to her.

Any attempts she'd made over the years to explain it had come out in howls and screams. Angry tears and aching jaw while justice was blind to their plight. No convictions or arrests, just a vague report and half assed wanted poster looking like every generic villain, only redeeming quality was it's proclamation that the bastard was in Horde colors. Where Angella had folded like a bad hand of cards after Micah's death, Glimmer had become a pack of dynamite with the detonator left in the hands of a maniac. All attempts she'd made to set things right were foiled and stopped before she'd so much as gotten out the door to find them herself, and eventually her mother decided to move their railroad's headquarters elsewhere. A thin veil to try and cover her running away. Moving far enough away that they'd left Horde territory; which hadn't helped a damn thing. Running **never** helped.

And she would never forgive her mother for that.

When she'd met Catra his death had still been young, it had, in fact, been the cause of the argument that had sent Glimmer riding off in a furious huff. Her mother's insistence that Glimmer let go of her desire for vengeance, to accept a safe and comfortable life that she'd never asked for. It had been a two year old argument by then, one that still cut but no longer left them unable to talk for days or weeks. Still enough to leave her furious and hurt and needing space. That was why she'd ridden out. Her anger cooled to coals by the time she'd found Catra.

And rescued her. And used her as an excuse to not think about her poor daddy *burning alive* while his killer walked away laughing.

It was awful knowing she'd rescued a member of that cursed gang of demons, flying their bloody red wings on pitch black flags.

She felt like she was gonna puke.

She should have told me, she should have told us! That was the thought, round and round and round. *She should have told* ***me*** .

If she'd've told me, I wouldn't have given her a chance in hell!! She would have happily left Catra to rot, would have gleefully taken her out to try and burn that fire of hurt out of her own heart. Instead, she'd taken her home.

Glimmer shouted wordlessly into the trees, grateful beyond words to live out in the forest where she could become deranged in peace. That's how it felt. Like she was spiraling out of control in the safety of solitude. Muscles aching from her desire to punch and tear and shred. Skin burning hot and heart pounding like a war drum. *She said it herself, she was still Horde like!*

There was no conscious thought between noticing the branch on the ground and picking it up to slam into the tree it fell from over and over until it splintered under the abuse.

Her hands shook as she gasped for air. *I need to calm down.* WHY THE HELL SHOULD SHE!?

Her father was dead, and Catra- Catra had been one of them! She could have helped kill him! She could have supported his killer, fed them, comforted them, laughed with them, loved them. Glimmer was **allowed** to be angry!

Over a decade of silently shoving her pain down for lack of an outlet and all that suffering had finally found a place to roost, exploding violently from her in bursts and waves like molten metal blistering in water.

It was as terrifying as it was freeing, a formless rage. Some small composed part of herself whispered desperately, " *This won't help nothing. You need to calm down.* " She didn't want to calm down, not now, not ever! But she didn't want to be alone. *I wish Catra was here* .

Glimmer hurled the bits of shattered wood still in her hands, blindly throwing it with a broken scream.

That was part of the problem, wasn't it? She was furious with Catra. She was scared and wanted her fiance to hold her and help her and love her. It wasn't fair. It just wasn't fair! To be so hurt and so in love that for the first time it felt like chains dragging her down.

I wish Catra was here. I hope she's okay.

"THIS ISN'T ABOUT HER!" Glimmer howled to the sky, furious that she even cared. Panting and huffing, desperately trying to get any air in her lungs at all. She leaned into the nearest tree, pressing her sweaty forehead into the bark, trying to focus on the small burst of pain as it dug into her instead of her aching heart. Tears fell slowly to the dirt below. "This isn't about her!"

Damn it all to hell she was allowed to be as furious as she wanted! Catra had-Catra…

Catra had been found by them, hadn't she? That's what she'd said. They found her as a child. Why had she been alone as a child? What did gangs do to children who they decided to invest

their efforts into them? *IT DOESN'T MATTER!* But her mind was now racing in a whole new direction. How old had she been? What would it have been like to be raised by a group as violent and cruel and **evil** as Heaven's Horde? *It doesn't matter.* Glimmer had her mother and father till she was fifteen. Parents who loved her and cared for her, and did their best to protect her from any suffering they could. The Horde sure as shit wouldn't a done that for Catra. *What did they do to her?*

Glimmer growled, softly smacking her hand on the tree trunk. It didn't matter. It shouldn't matter. It had nothing to do with her now broken family, and the role Catra had played no matter how small. But the longer she stood there, breathing and thinking, the more she cooled.

Glimmer whispered to herself, "This isn't about her."

Right?

She pushed heavily off her support, taking a moment to look up at the sky. Time had passed, more than she'd thought, but she didn't want to go back. Not yet. Soon. *I just need a little more time* . Instead she turned and began to slowly walk further away. Vowing to herself that she wouldn't focus on it, wouldn't let it consume her.

A course, desperate as she was to think of anything else, she couldn't.

Her hands shook as she swirled languidly between anger and hurt and sorrow. Never staying on any emotion long enough to do much about it. Instead she did what she often did, retreated into her head. Hashing out and planning what she'd do or say, imagining whole scenarios into existence. Some more realistic, some completely fantastical; winding herself up just to calm herself down.

She'd go back, and Catra would probably get in her face about running off; woman had a temper. She could picture it, the

accusations back and forth, finding every way she could to win a fictional argument. Demanding that Catra leave. Throwing her out. The two of them screaming in one anothers faces.

Some scenarios they'd manage to talk calm like, but Catra would press and twist her words and try to argue why Glimmer wasn't allowed to be upset. Even though she'd lied for a decade, Glimmer "couldn't" be mad at her. HA! In those, she'd stand tall and proud as she packed her things and left. Riding away as Catra begged her to stay. Would serve her right!

In a few she tried to plan out what would happen if verbal jabs became physical blows. She weren't as strong as Catra, but she was *damn* quick. If Glimmer snuck in the back she could grab her pistol just in case, more for insurance than anything. If they were in a fist fight, Catra was going to win. Only one time did she try to picture shooting Catra and it hurt so bad, she changed it. No, she wouldn't have to lift her gun in self defence or try to clean up the blood or have to explain to everyone else what had happened. She'd prevent it! She would be the eye at the center of a storm. Regal and graceful, using all the tools at her disposal to threaten or defuse more than hurt.

Each time, she tried to imagine what Catra would do. Catra apologizing. Catra Snarling. Catra begging. ...Glimmer hated them all.

So she started again, starting from the top. No, they wouldn't fight at all! Glimmer would make sure they talked like civilized people! Or at least reach a silent agreement on what they would do. Or, or, or-

Or maybe she'd go back and Catra would have already left, and she'd never see her again.

The thought left her cold. *She wouldn't, she wouldn't do that* . But what if she did? What if Glimmer would get home to find all of Catra's things gone. Captain missing from the stable. Maybe a note left behind. She pictured it angry and full of fury before

letting the image drop from her mind. Catra wouldn't leave her a cruel note, not her stupid, lovely Catra. One last geode she'd been hiding would hold it down. Or it would be folded and left on the bed with care. What would it say?

"I'm sorry."

That was all she could picture.

Standing alone in her bedroom reading two simple words over and over as she tried not to cry.

She didn't want that. Glimmer swallowed a half sob, shaking her arms out and letting a slow hiss of air out between her teeth. God, she didn't want that! She wanted this to go away! She wanted to go back to not knowing, she wished that she'd never been told!

No.

That wasn't true.

Why did this sting like a betrayal? Catra would've been, what? A teenager when she ran away. The thought left her a little dizzy. She wished Catra would've told her sooner, would've said something in those first few years. But when? At what point would this admission have hit some magical sweet spot between early enough to have not been a secret and late enough that Glimmer wouldn't have tried to outright kill her?

There was no perfect chance.

There was never going to be a 'good time' to reveal something like this. Never.

Glimmer finally stopped walking as her thoughts chugged to a clean stop, steam venting before laboriously starting up again. There would never have been a good time, but Catra had come clean before they got married. Like she wanted to give Glimmer the choice to leave or throw her away. She wiped fiercely at her

eyes as the last few tears escaped. Idiot. That was just like her wasn't it? Never thinking through what someone else might be feeling.

Like she'd ever tell Catra to leave.

She froze up as the next thought cold clocked her. *Does Catra know that?*

Of course! Her heart thumped painfully. She had to know that. She had to!

Catra who thought her life was so cheap that she'd thrown herself into every possible dangerous situation in the hope of pleasing Glimmer. The same Catra who had thrown herself into the maw of a mountain lion. Who she had once seen grab a rattlesnake from behind when it had started hissing at her and then spent the next ten minutes sweating in terror unsure how to let it go safely and without injuring it. The same woman who, after the robbery, had just assumed the whole town would hate her after she'd got all that hot air out of her head. Thought that Glimmer would hate her.

Skittish Catra, who's mind was her own worst enemy.

And Glimmer had left her home alone.

She turned back towards the house, walking slow but steady as she tempered her desire to be back with common sense. She had told Catra she'd be back and they'd talk. Yes, and that was good. Catra had almost as amazing an ability to turn every little issue into a big one as Adora, so being forthright was key. And Glimmer had told her she'd come back home. *No, you said you were going out because you couldn't stand her and that you'd go back later.* Her pace picked up as her heart began to painfully kick. Without the shock and pain of her father's death feeling fresh in her soul to linger over her, it sounded a lot worse. *What if she already left? What if you can't find her again? Would have been kinder to shoot her.*

Just like that, what little false serenity she'd mustered was gone. Replaced as always by her fear of the people she loved leaving her behind. She couldn't lose Catra too, not after this, not like this, not like him. She couldn't, she couldn't!

Glimmer ran. Bones rattling with every thud in her desperate bid to get home. Good lord in heaven, how far had she walked? How long had it been?

Because this wasn't just about Catra or just about Glimmer, this was about **them** .

She'd never run so damn fast in her life.

Glimmer nearly bashed the door down as she tried to stop her momentum, her shoulder ached from how hard she'd hit. She didn't care, couldn't care right now. It opened under her rough treatment all the same, and that was all that mattered. She left it wide open as she stared at the main room where they'd parted in shock. The daguerreotype of her and her mother was on the ground, a damp patch and shards of ceramic were all that was left of her forgotten coffee.

And blood on the clean new wall paper, red smeared over the yellow. Not a lot. Still.

"Catra!? Catra, where are you?" Glimmer shouted, hearing nothing and rushing up the stairs. Only glancing in the study before pushing on to the bedroom. *Thank you, thank you!* Catra was there, standing by the closet with her work shirt in hand. Holding it so tight and taut Glimmer was surprised it hadn't ripped wide open. There was a lone bag at her feet, nearly empty but surrounded by other random clothes. Like she'd knocked them off the hangers and hadn't known what to do with them. "Catra?"

No response was bad. It was always bad and Glimmer hated that she'd been the cause. *I am allowed to be hurt! I'm allowed to be upset! Why do I always have to give in first even when I shouldn't have to? It's not fair, it's not fair!* She swallowed the thoughts and

pointed words at the tip of her tongue, stumbling forward until she was in arm's reach.

It wasn't fair, but she loved Catra more than she wanted to be free of responsibility. Loved her more than she hated the Horde. Loved her more than some unachievable notion of fair.

"Okay, hey, whoo!" Glimmer huffed, still trying to catch her breath from running before trying again. "Catra, I need you. I need you to come back alright?"

She inched her way around, careful to not startle the other woman, and gasped. Catra's face and neck were covered in scratches, some faint red lines and many welling with blood. Her eyes were red and puffy and staring a thousand miles away. Whatever reservations she'd had were lost, discarded as useless, as Glimmer reached out to take Catra's bruised and scabbing hands in her own. Not prying at her fist, but resting as she called again. "You don't need to stay there, you're at home. With me, Glimmer. We're in our bedroom right now. Sun's coming in that way you like to nap in. You're holding your good shirt right now. Can you feel that? The shirt and the sun? I'd hold your hand if you'd let go. Can you hear me? Please. Please come home."

It wasn't sudden. Catra had started to blink as she'd talked, eyes darting back and forth as her breathing hitched. Her mouth moved soundlessly. Her shoulders tensed and raised, and she pulled harder at the shirt. A hiss of air almost made a word. The longer Glimmer talked the more reaction she got, so she kept talking. Anything she could think of, sweet meaningless nothings, until Catra finally started to shake and cry.

"There you are," she held a little tighter, moved a little closer. "There you are. Come on back now. I miss you."

When Catra's eyes finally focused on her the world stopped.

"Gl-Glimmer?" Catra wheezed, a harsh whine quick on it's heels.

She was still angry. She was furious, but not at Catra.

Catra had been a member of the Horde, but not for a decade at least. Catra was kind and sweet and a little bit silly. There was a temper, but she'd learned to balance it with patience and poise. Glimmer loved her. Always had, always would. It didn't matter who she'd been before, she'd been a kid, god have mercy on her soul! She'd been a ***child*** .

Glimmer was angry, and Catra wasn't her father's killer, and it was damnably unfair of her to act otherwise.

It was easy to smile, to mean it, to let all that relief through in a heartbeat. Bow always said love was a choice, and he was right that it was hard work, but this felt as natural as breathing. "I'm here, I'm right here darling. I told you I'd be back, and here I am. Here with you."

Catra stared at her, face twisting terribly as she tried to stop her tears. Gingerly, Glimmer reached out and brushed them off her cheeks. Cupping her face delicately in case the scratches hurt.

"Please don't go," Glimmer whispered, hoping it would be enough to get her back, "stay."

Catra nodded, twisting the shirt a little further. Glimmer winced as she heard the poor thing's seams finally give up the ghost but didn't look. Her diligence was rewarded when Catra finally managed a single watery, "Okay."

"Okay. We're alright dear, we're a'right. Let's take a sit, just right here on the bed alright?"

"Okay," it was even quieter this time, but Catra managed to shuffle to the bed and sat with little prompting. "You're-you're here."

"Yeah," Glimmer sighed, sitting so she could hold Catra close. Throwing one leg over her lap and pulling her in under her chin. "I'm here."

The birds outside were pitching a fit as the wind rustled the leaves. The sun was almost too warm on her skin.

“You came back?” Catra whispered into her neck, confused and awed and hurting.

“Always, I’ll always come back you know?”

“Y-you sh-shouldn’t.”

“I can damn well do what I want Miss D’riluth, and my love ain’t some well that’s gonna run dry.”

Catra didn’t answer, just nuzzled closer a few tears landing cold before soaking into her collar.

“God as my witness, we will be at the altar and you are still gonna be surprised when I show up ain’t ya?” Hell’s bells. Didn’t even get a laugh at that one.

Glimmer sighed but fell silent, just let the both of them breathe and calm. Only shifting enough to ease the aches and pains in her muscles and joints, holding onto Catra tight as she could manage as she planted kisses into her hair. Concentrated on the heat between their bodies. On the sound of Catra’s breathing evening out slowly into something closer to normal.

“Do you remember what happened?” She finally asked when Catra dropped her shirt and tentatively, nervously rested her hands on Glimmer’s leg.

Catra nodded miserably as her breathing picked up a bit again. “I-I, uh, I, uh, t-told you. And-and-and, uh, and-and, I? FUCK!”

“It’s alright, s’alright. I ain’t going nowhere.”

Catra hunched more, pressed into her further before starting again. “I t-t-told you about, about ***them*** . ‘N y-you left.” Her voice cracked, but she pushed on. “And, and, I-I, uh, I, sh-shit, I punched something?”

“The wall, I think. Is your hand alright?” Glimmer didn’t let go of her hug to check, didn’t want to risk her spiraling right back down.

Catra half nodded, half shrugged; hiccuped a cough. “S-sorry. I’ll clean it-clean it up. I pr-promise, I promise- I promise!”

She soothed as best she could. Forget the damned wall, it would keep! “Don’t worry ‘bout that. What else? You remember anything else?”

“No.” She whispered, shaking but slowly getting herself back under control.

God, Glimmer was exhausted and she bet Catra was too. Miracle they hadn’t just passed out sitting in the sun with everything they’d been through. But the day weren’t done yet, and she still needed and wanted to help.

So she prompted. “Do you remember scratching yourself?”

“Sss-scratching? No. Did I?” Catra leaned back first, so Glimmer let go. Dropping one hand to rest on her wrist as she rubbed circles into her back.

“Looks like it. All over your face, some on your throat. Does it hurt?”

Catra looked awful. Her eyes focused but watery, somehow both flushed and pale, with the sweat rolling down from her temple matting down her sideburns nearly flush to her skin. Her brow furrowed, then she slowly shook her head. “Is it...bad?”

A few of the deeper ones had blood smeared and drying, most of them were angry raised red slashes. Glimmer wondered how many had already faded before she’d gotten home. “Well...it, uh, it ain’t good?”

“Oh.”

As they sat in silence once more Glimmer found herself circling back to a question she hadn't even realized she'd been asking herself. Did she still love and want to be with Catra D'riluth knowing even just a tiny part of what she'd done before they'd met?

It, well, it didn't feel silly. It didn't feel dumb. But it also felt ridiculous now that she'd gotten so much of her anger out.

Glancing out the window Glimmer almost startled as she realized that they'd been sitting here for hours, the sun sunk low in the sky. The whole day gone in a blur and haze of desperation and pain. It brought with it the awareness that she was *very* uncomfortable and specifically the numbness in her left leg, still thrown over Catra's lap. Her everything hurt and Catra's everything probably did too. It was a thought from damn nowhere, but Glimmer wished they had a bath big enough that they could share it. Just soak in some hot water and sleep.

And that, ironically, answered her question well enough.

Because she still loved Catra. Because she still wanted to be with Catra. Because even though Catra **had** done awful things, even though Glimmer didn't know them all yet, she had changed. She had changed so much from when they'd met. Back when finding out she'd gotten into another fist fight had been a regular occurrence and normal to now was a world of difference. No more concerned Adora finding her to talk about any 'violent occurrences' or Bow asking if they were okay. Her mother hadn't warned her away from Catra in years, hell, she'd just condoned and been excited to hear they were engaged. She'd changed and grown.

Whoever she'd been before, Catra had moved not just on but forward.

"Hey," Glimmer pulled Catra over gently, kissing the sharp corner of her jaw, "I love you Catra D'riltuh."

Catra pursed her lips and shook her head, red eyes squinting as a few more tears gathered in them.

"Yes I do! I love you so much. I love you more than naps and cake and starlight."

Catra snorted, lips quivering but turning up, at last, into the most timid of smiles. Finally making her way out of the storm, finally fully listening. "A-awful specific."

"Says you." Glimmer chuckled then cleared her throat theatrically. "Not these, O none of these more than the flames of me, consuming, burning for his love whom I love, O-"

"Are-are you quoting *poetry* at me??" Catra barked out one incredulous laugh. Which was exactly where she wanted her.

"Hush! See if I try and be romantic with you again!"

"No!" Catra turned as best she could, so they were sitting face to face. Grabbed her hands almost shyly and mumbled, "...I, I like it."

"Well then, let me start from the top. Ah-HEM! ...Not heat flames up and consumes, not sea-waves hurry in and out, not the air delicious and dry, the air of ripe summer, bears lightly along white down-balls of myriads of seeds, wafted, sailing gracefully, to drop where they may; not these, O none of these more than the flames of me, consuming, burning for his love whom I love, O none more than I hurrying in and out; does the tide hurry, seeking something, and never give up? O I the same, O nor down-balls nor perfumes, nor the high rain-emitting clouds, are borne through the open air, any more than my soul is borne through the open air, wafted in all directions O love, for friendship, for you."

Well at least the pale flush had become a full out blush, a watery smile that easily shot her through the heart. " 's nice. Did you write that?"

Glimmer laughed nearly hysterically, after the day they'd had she felt rather justified, but tried to get herself under control regardless, "Sorry! No! Goodness, I wish! Just liked it enough to learn it. Mister Walt Whitman wrote that one."

"...I don't think I've met him."

Oh goodness gracious she was gonna die! It could not be healthy to suppress this much laughter after crying so damn much.

"If you had I'd be surprised, big name poet living out on the east coast I believe." She smiled, lifting Catra's hands to kiss her finger tips. "When I read it the first time, I thought of you. And me. Just...us, I suppose."

Catra mumbled, sounding almost ready to pass out, "Do you still have it? I'm guessing one of your books?"

"I do. Tell you what, let's get some of this cleaned up, and wash up ourselves, and I'll read you some more."

They went slowly, both tired and sore as they put away clothes and cleaned up the mess downstairs. When Glimmer realized they were both almost swaying, she shoved Catra to the settee and lay down on top of her. Regretfully giving up on her dreams of washing up the tears and sweat and dust, it sounded like a herculean task.

"Too far t'go up, uuuhhhhp the stairs," she'd yawned and settled in. So much for reading them both to sleep.

They'd talk.

They would.

Not now, not tonight when they were both too raw. Soon. Glimmer listened to Catra's heart as she slipped into sleep, kissed her collar bone before settling into the side of her neck to breathe in deeply. They'd talk soon about Catra's past, as much as she would be willing to share. Probably her largest regret for the day

was that she’d ended up ruining Catra’s genuine attempt to be open. God, there was so much they had left to do and talk about and sort. Her head throbbed painfull and Glimmer sighed heavily, trying to let the familiarity of Catra’s scent soothe her.

And they’d need to talk about her father. Catra deserved to know why Glimmer had fled.

Not tonight.

But soon.

Chapter End Notes

Them's the breaks. Sometimes it breaks right, usually it don't.

Come scream with me over on my tumblr!

Chapter 11: Usually It Doesn't

Chapter Summary

Catra finally tells Glimmer as much about her time in the Horde as she can stand, and Glimmer finally tells her what happened to her father.

As you can imagine, this doesn't go well.

Chapter Notes

strolls in almost a half year late with a cup of coffee Sup?

Anyhow, please ~~suffer~~ enjoy almost 10,000 words of Catra having a year+ long mental breakdown, our girl is in S4 with all the cognitive dissonance and self-sabotage and sunk cost fallacy now.

As per usual on Catra heavy chapters, be aware there is a lot of unhealthy behavior, and includes backsliding in this chapter. It will be emotionally pretty draining (look there's a reason this took so long to write okay), so if you're not in the place for that I'd suggest waiting on reading this one.

Specific CW for: underaged drinking, alluded violence, murder off screen, and self loathing. If I missed something major please let me know and I will add it in!

Last Time on Angsty Cowpoke
After a decade of dancing around one another, Glimmer Moon and Catra D'riluth have finally proposed and are planning to marry with Angella's blessing. But Catra realizes she still hasn't told Glimmer the truth about her past and decides to do so before they tie the knot. Glimmer, caught off guard on learning about Catra's past with Heaven's Horde, freaks out and leaves to calm down. Catra takes that as Glimmer leaving her and has a breakdown. When Glimmer returns they both spend sometime together and try to decompress.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the end, they had needed those extra two days off just to sleep and recover from their first disastrous one.

Catra felt more beat up than she'd ever been, even after actually getting beat to hell and back. It was pathetic in it's own way, but she tried to find something good in it. She didn't really succeed as she slept, waking from nightmares with too fast breathing and too much cold sweat and grateful that Glimmer was such a heavy sleeper. She'd wanted to help clean up properly but half the time she was awake was spent just desperately trying to pull herself together long enough to finish telling her the truth. Hard to do when Catra was less shattered and more ground to a fine powder, half blubbering all the damn time.

Not that Glimmer pushed, and not that she hadn't mentioned it. It was...tenuous at best, but at least Glimmer was able to move forward.

And that was almost worse, here she was a fully functional adult while Catra laid in bed without a single ailment. Too tired and too scared to move.

Glimmer went back on the fourth day and made her excuses, allowing Catra to stay home for a while longer. Bow stopped by with some vittles and Adora even stopped by during the day, which had been as awkward as it was nice.

She and Adora had gotten along rather well when she first arrived in town, equally competitive and giving as good as they got in any fight or argument. And they had a lot of them! Back then, back when Catra was still waiting for the axe to drop so she could try and kill herself in peace, Adora had been something of a rock. Catra had been infatuated with Glimmer, something Adora had also fumbled through admitting, but neither felt they had a chance with the Brightmoon Heiress. And where Glimmer felt unattainable, Adora didn't; even if that had ultimately not gone anywhere. She was a ranch hand, an orphan, and working proudly towards becoming a Sheriff, something that many towns just gave

to the biggest bully instead of the most steadfast of their citizens. It had felt...safe to be around her despite her leaning towards the law. Felt like Adora would take her side if the Horde arrived, and that Adora would take her down if Catra was flying off the handle.

Not that there wasn't some truth to all them rumors about them, but it hadn't been nothing serious.

And then, almost as quickly and easily as they'd become friends the damn bank happened. She still spent plenty of time cursing herself over that one damn afternoon. Ruined far too much. Glimmer might've been ignorant to why Adora was suddenly around every corner, but Catra wasn't. Adora had made sure to corner her and ensure she understood exactly what could happen if Catra fucked up like that again. Moving out of town didn't seem to help matters much either. It had been slow going to stop feeling Adora's suspicious glare following her around to being civil around one another again. But Catra wasn't sure she could call them friends just yet.

"Catra? You home?" Adora had called, waking her up from a nap on the settee. "Please tell me yer still kicking D'riluth, your woman will kill me otherwise."

The door creaked open as she struggled to do more than feel an awful pit of dread.

"You ain't heard of knocking?" she'd mumbled, unable to do more than glare and even that was half hearted.

"Sure have," Adora rolled her eyes as she hauled the small crate to the kitchen. Smirking, which was a sure sign of a bad joke to come, "NoGK HEEn, am I saying that right? Anyways, you look like shit."

It was the most open and friendly interaction they'd had in years, and it only upended her further. At least this was a good type. Catra snorted at Adora's attempt at a joke. "Careful miss, my soon to be wife wouldn't like you flirtin' with me much."

“I ain’t scared of her none.” There was a beat of silence before Adora cracked up, waving a hand desperately, “Wait, no no no! Don’t tell her I said that!

It was nice, this was nice. She’d missed this. “Butcha said you aren’t scared!”

“Ma’am, I am scared of scorpions in my boots, spiders in the outhouse, and the Moons because I am sensible.”

“...there aren’t any real scorpions out here, just them vinegaroons.”

Adora put the sack of beans down to shake her hands out while sticking out her tongue. “They are worse!”

Scorpia had gotten her name because of her love of all creatures, and that had included creepy crawlies and things that could kill ya. She’d been in charge of handling anything the others didn’t want to and had even kept a little scorpion as a pet. Not that she’d succeeded, the poor thing was in a jar without air holes, but she’d gone from an unnamed ‘ *that scorpion kid’* to *Scorpia* at some point. She’d loved vinegaroons the most even when they pinched the hell out of her. Catra hadn’t liked them much, but she was missing her oldest friend something fierce.

“I dunno, they’re kinda cute.” Catra smiled softly, the first smile in days as she forced herself upright.

“We already know you’re sick D’riluth, ain’t gotta prove it.”

Catra ended up finding the energy to eventually make some stew, but by the time Glimmer got home looking excited and proud she was back to square one.And by the time they went to sleep they’d fallen back into a tense silence. She hated it. She hated this.

And it was all her own damn fault.

A week passed and then another before she could do much besides sit around the house like the most expensive piece of shit

you'd ever seen. She still felt heavy and tired and slow but by god she was at least upright and functioning. Her cuts had healed by then, her hand almost normal as well, and so no one knew. Glimmer hadn't said a word, just that Catra had fallen ill. She'd been terrified to go into work until she found that out.

"It wouldn't…" Glimmer sighed heavily, an unreadable look crossing her face before continuing, "It wouldn't a been right. It's not my story to tell and, well, I blew up before you could even tell it."

It took another few days after that before Catra tried again, only for Glimmer to stop her again and ask for a little more time. It had been both a relief and maddening to have found the nerve and been stopped. But stop she did, both agreeing to wait and hold off.

But they were still *them* , and knowing that Catra was able to hold on. Slowly but surely they began to right themselves. A few months passed and they were almost back to normal if not for that subtle tension. And just as suddenly as the first time, they were finally both ready. This time with bellies full and nothing but water in 'em, sitting together. Cuddled together in a two person rat pile.

Catra started from what she knew. The cabin where it all started, being found, not knowing who the Horde was. Just being grateful that it was warm and there was food, and she'd been promised protection. Ha.

"What do you mean?" Glimmer had asked, shifting to lean more comfortably against Catra's chest.

So Catra had just rolled up her sleeves. Wasn't like the scars were news to Glimmer, she'd spent years with her sleeves rolled up around her thanks to all the ink stains. "That woman who found me? My...well, I'd say mother but I think she was the devil himself. She did this. I was- I think I was eight at the time? I don't really remember. Lot of it, t-the pain and such, it just, it,

uh...just...blurred together if that makes sense? Moments that I can't forget if I tried and the rest a bit hazy. And, well, got them touched up every so often too. Doesn't really help the memory much."

Glimmer had squeezed at forearms, thumbs swiping over just the edges of those parallel lines. "Who the hell does that to a child? Ain't a single good reason for it!"

"I wouldn't know," Catra shrugged as she dug into that hazy period before she'd been given responsibility and was therefore little more than property, she'd spent a lot of that time just living in a muted terror. Not even knowing how long she'd been there with years blurring into little more than Weaver's hissed vitriol and cold dismissals. "Never said why. Just told me to sit still while she did it. I was a baby about it-"

"You were a child!"

Her heart had swelled at that. "Yeah, but by Horde standards I was a young recruit and a crybaby. Weren't no such thing as children in there."

There'd been a long pause as Glimmer kissed all four lines, they'd once been raised and discolored. Aching and inflexible thanks to repeated exposure and her inability to not mess with them as they healed. Over the years they'd faded some, became less obvious. Still felt nice to have someone outraged on her behalf even two decades too late.

"Please tell me she died a horrible death." Glimmer nearly hissed, her tone so at odds with her gentle actions that Catra had to take a second to understand it.

That twisted knot of guilt and shame and joy and anger never had gone away. She'd always assumed she'd be so happy that Weaver was dead that she'd dance on the crone's grave. The love she hated herself for giving her mentor, as messed up as it felt to Catra, had never truly faded. Just ached different these days,

coming in waves of fury and guilt. But at least this time she could just feel grateful the witch was gone. "Now **that** I can promise."

"Good, I assume she's the reason for your back?"

The first time Glimmer had seen the mess of scars there had been nearly catastrophic. Catra had purposefully been avoiding letting her see, too scared with having to explain them to want to share. But while she'd been changing shirts Glimmer had walked into the bedroom and that had been the end of hiding that. She'd cried, she'd cried and been furious, but when Catra fumbled through saying she didn't want to talk, Glimmer had quieted. Still touched them all the time. It was sweet. Tender.

"Mmmm, no, or at least not most of them actually. That was Hordak himself. Got to a point where I'd got his attention for better or worse."

They'd had to take a break after that, Glimmer too caught between fury at just hearing their leader's name and feeling awful on Catra's behalf to stand anymore. Which was fine with her. She hadn't been ready to dive into *him* either. They'd sat curled tight until their hearts had slowed to normal, and then they got up and made dinner.

They broke the bulk of it up like that. A bit here and a bit there. Tried to time it so it wouldn't affect them at work, but sometimes the best time was when they first woke up with the sun still hidden and the quiet of the night still there. Soft and sleepy and warm, it helped smooth the edges of it all.

Regardless of when, Catra made it a point to speak up. To actually tell her things, things that mattered.

She talked about her only friend back there, how she hoped Scorpia got away in the years since. The way Hordak had started to favor her just long enough for Catra to buy into it. She spared the details where she could, spoke slowly when Glimmer

demanded. Shutting her trap completely sometimes with just a look. But still, they talked.

"How'd you escape?" Glimmer asked one evening as they did the dishes, nothing but a gentle curiosity to her.

Catra had to apologize for laughing, but it was funny. She'd never once thought of it as *escaping* . She'd never wanted to leave, only growing grateful as time had passed that she was out. It had been one of the things she'd been most frightened to admit to, that she hadn't wanted to go, that she'd been basically forced out.

The explanation was halting after that. "I didn't want to leave, see? Was helping finish off an insurance scam, some innocent folk got caught in the crossfire and I drew too much heat to go back. 'Specially considering that I was falling out of Hordak's favor at the time, it would've been a death sentence. So I left."

That evening had ended with them stiff as boards in bed, Glimmer too upset to speak and Catra too afraid to push. They slept and woke and didn't speak till they were on the road to work. Her leaving was never brought up again and it felt like she'd failed some sort of test. Planted some seed of resentment.

But they *still* talked more. Until Catra told all the pertinent things at least.

She'd tried. She really had to be open about all of it, but it weren't something she could do. Not yet. So some details left out, some people spoken of vaguely, some deeds alluded to but not confirmed. How the hell else was she supposed to do this? *Want to hear about the time I publicly murdered someone for doing what I told them to do? Weren't no thing, everyone cheered!* God! Some things Glimmer would **never** understand, could never condone, could never forgive. So she stuck to pertinent information. It came out all the same until the damn thing dried up leaving only those greasy black shadows to haunt her.

She'd snickered weakly afterwards as she tapped at the calendar, hoping she'd pick up on the fact that a simple few hour explanation had somehow dragged out over a half year. "See I need to concede the point to you Glim. Looks like we *cain't* do nothing without a long hullabaloo."

Even with Catra's story mostly out, pathetic considering all she left out in fear, the tension between them was sometimes so thick she wished Glimmer would just tell her to leave and be done with it. Each day felt like balancing on a tightrope, wanting to just move on and forget about it completely but aware that acting too much like things were fine could shoot her in the ass. The back and forth emotionally was almost enough to make her do something foolish.

So she confided in Bow, not her past, but that she'd told Glimmer and was worried it had been the wrong choice. He'd looked surprised but had smiled at her warmly all the same before hugging her.

"I'm glad. I'm proud of you."

God she would never live down the fact that she'd broken down crying on BEAUREGAURD ARCHER'S shoulder. Much as she wanted to be kinder and softer and better, it felt mortifying. Apparently the feeling was mutual based on the way Bow had held her and then they both parted awkward as can be. His gentle acceptance and fierce pride was a balm strong enough to soothe her, his listening ear always available for her to just vent about the whole situation. With a place to finally dump and air her concerns it became easier to breathe, and easier to be steady so Glimmer could work through her own shit without being smothered at every turn.

More time passed and the tension thinned a bit, and even if she was lying Catra was grateful that Glimmer didn't push her anymore on her past. Hell, she knew she was lying about being alright with it, but she still needed to hear those words. So when

the tension finally drained Glimmer had admitted, "I think...I think I need to tell you about my father. But I can't yet, but...soon."

Well, Catra had certainly felt every last strand of hair on her body lift in a shiver. They didn't talk about Micah Moon, and for Glimmer to want to tell her *after* hearing about the Horde, well, Catra wasn't an idiot.

The next few weeks were like walking on eggshells, whatever progress she'd made vanishing. It was as if everyone could tell Catra was on the edge of a nervous breakdown and had held a town hall on treating her like glass. For all she appreciated the efforts it left her feeling worse.

Frustrated and stupid and small.

"Vulnerability is exactly what it sounds like," Weaver had almost sneered at her, "it leaves you powerless to another. Beholden to them. Perhaps that's why you thought this was acceptable behavior, hmm? You always did work best when reminded of your place."

Which was such unbelievable bullshit! Catra still half listened and now wished she never had. Life would be easier if she'd just stop getting hurt about people wanting to help. She did her damned best to bite her tongue.

When Glimmer finally said she was ready to talk, it had felt like she was going to the noose. They lay down together, in comfortable clothes and holding hands, side to side on the bed. She let Glimmer play with her hand. Start and stop without saying a word. Only pulled their hands to kiss Glimmer's knuckles when she sounded like she was about to cry. Catra couldn't look, just in case it set her off into another panic because this wasn't about her, so she *couldn't look* . Glimmer had listened very damn patiently and kindly let Catra stay living in her house throughout the whole thing, hell, she'd done her level best to protect her. The least Catra could do was shut the fuck up and let her say her piece.

It was so much harder than she thought it would be.

After a good thirty minutes, Glimmer took a slow breath in, eyes fluttering shut before she was actually able to start. "It was in the spring of '68 out in Erlandia, that's just out past Plumeria a few week's ride east. We lived nearby, close enough to have some small holdings in town..."

No. It can't be. Don't be stupid! Catra could feel the way her breath hitched and forced it to even out. This wasn't about her. This **wasn't about her** and her fucking mistakes. She fought the white noise rushing through her body like lightning. She had already had one stupid hysteria this year over god damned nothing, and she was not about to do it again just because Erlandia happens to be-

"There was some bandit who was up to no good, who knows why. Maybe...maybe one of them insurance type scam you talked about? They burned down a barn there see-"

No. No! That was, that was the year she'd- please, not like this! *No, no, no, no nononononono!*

She lost part of the story, forcing herself to calm back down. Maybe it wasn't! Maybe it wasn't the same a'tall and it would be fine. It **had** to be fine, it had to be. But she knew. She already knew the truth even as it spilled from Glimmer's lips. "-you know? Sorry...anyways, they trapped my dad in there and, uh, h-he…. Witnesses said he was locked in and- and screamed, he was- we wanted to take a mourning photo but my d-dad was, was- we couldn't, not like that. I hated looking at him- I hate that I couldn't even see him again! He was a good man, he was s-ssssuch a good man. I...god, you know they say that being burned alive is one of the most painful ways to die, and I just-I just, when I think about my daddy trapped in-in there I jusssst!?"

Catra moved on instinct alone, rolling to wrap Glimmer up in a hug and rocking her back and forth. For all that her voice was steady as she whispered condolences and sweet nothings, she

was barely there. She was floating outside her body and the whole damn world felt bigger and bigger and bigger, leaving her small. Leaving her as small as nothing.

Letting the truth sink into her skin.

She killed Micah Moon.

She hadn't meant to, but she did. She **killed** him. The Moon's might forgive her general past but this was unforgivable. *I didn't mean to, I didn't want to!* **She** was the reason Angella Moon would get lost in misty eyed memories. *It's not my fault!* The reason Glimmer sometimes **cried at night**. *I warned him, I told him!* The reason these two amazing people still mourned the man they'd both loved so dearly. *He went in anyways, it was his own damn fault!* She was the reason they had his portrait placed over the mantle. *It's not, i-it's not-* She was the reason they had suffered, and would always suffer this.

Her.

I can't tell her, I can't ever tell her, she almost left me over the Horde and if she knew about-andandand I can't live without her !

Catra tugged Glimmer closer, tears welling up as she rocked them both. Struggling between her desire to do better and be better, and the knowledge that if anyone ever knew the truth Catra would cease to exist. Even if her body kept shambling along, she would be gone. She weren't nothing without them anymore and she would lose them the moment they knew.

She would honestly rather die than lose Glimmer. She couldn't tell her. Not now. Not ever! ...Not ever?

Shadow Weaver smiled at her, all teeth and fire. *I did tell you that you would regret it child. I was right. I'm* ***always right*** .

No.

But she was, wasn't she? Maybe Scorpia had been right, maybe Weaver had been an honest to god witch who'd cursed her. It was like every time she was about to reach the summit she'd fall off a damn cliff and have to start again on re-broken legs.

"Your impulsiveness and selfishness will be your undoing child," Weaver had sighed at her, even as she roughly cleaned the gash on Catra's forehead. "Someday you'll thank me for stopping you, before you could haunt yourself."

Weaver had been right. She'd been right.

It was strange how knowing that turned some kind of switch in her brain.

Suddenly she was back in place, panic acknowledged down below the surface where it couldn't make a fuss, allowing her a sort of calm detachment from the moment. Her racing thoughts somehow both faster and frozen as she held Glimmer, and tucked her in after she'd cried herself to sleep. It was like checking off items on an impersonal list. She'd gone downstairs quite and easy like, cleaned up a bit around the house from the day. Ate and washed up. Checked the horses. Cleaned a bit more. It was funny that she couldn't quite remember it but she knew she'd done it. She smothered a bout of laughter and muffled her crying afterwards. Like she had a right to be upset. Her breathing stuttered along with a few tears.

Ican'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan'tIcan't!

But the tears were wiped away and her breathing forced out as she found more and more to do. The longer she stayed up doing meaningless shit, the calmer she became. Not centered though. Not...quite right. That kind of eerie calm she used to get right after she'd killed someone. Sharp. Focused as she weighed the pros and cons of speaking up. Of telling the full truth. Explaining the murder and torture and worse, admitting to killing Micah. Sometimes she wished she didn't exist, admitting to her sins and

being hung would be the quickest way to fulfill that old desire. In its own twisted way, it was a win win.

The best way. Right? Justice served and she could just stop being in so much pain all the fucking time. That sounded nice even if the route there made her nearly hurl her meager dinner. Maybe it was for the best. Give them a chance at closure, a chance at revenge against his killer. It was the ***right thing*** to do.

But she knew she wouldn't be telling them. The thought alone had her break a glass while washing, caused her to tear off the nearly rotting planks on the side of the barn with her bare hands, had her chopping the wood hard enough to get the axe stuck in the stump. No. No, she wouldn't be telling them.

But it sure was a nice dream.

So what was she going to actually do? ...between her fear of dying and her fear of being thrown in one of those god awful prisons she just...couldn't. It was a kick to the teeth. All that talk about being a better person and it turned out she wasn't, she should've known. Nothing she touched was ever good, and she'd always been a fucking coward.

And just like that it all fell into place, the decision was obvious.

Alright then.

So she couldn't do the right thing. Fine.

This was fine. She could work with this. She could feel her mind spinning, catching and releasing ideas before they'd fully formed but this time there was no panic to them. Only a grim sort of, not quite satisfaction, but not something else either. This was fine. She would *salvage* this.

Catra quietly put the last glass away, and ran her hands through her hair. The feeling so strangely soothing that she did it again, pressing her curls tight to her scalp and heaving a big sigh. It was just gonna have to be fine.

Alright.

She couldn’t tell them, wouldn’t tell them. Didn’t want to let go of this.

After thinking it was all over and realizing it wasn’t, after riding the highs and lows of terror and relief, after finally having given herself just the barest hint of permission to be happy again...she couldn’t let go. Not now. Not yet. Not ever. Besides, *besides* ! What was one more? One more lie on the rest of what she’d kept inside? Glimmer thought she knew everything, thought she had the whole story anyways. Why burden her with more? Why make her suffer more when it had already hurt her so? It was really for her benefit, not Catra’s.

It was the one thing Catra knew for certain. She didn’t want to hurt Glimmer. Hell, she didn’t want to hurt Angella neither! All she had to do was keep one more lie and they could **all** be happy. The Moon’s wouldn’t have to suffer another trauma. They wouldn’t have to leave this town to escape Catra’s ghost haunting every corner of their lives. They would be happy and safe and free from the knowledge and pain. And she’d be happy too. Not forced to run, not strung up, not thrown away like she so rightfully deserved. She could be happy with them. They could all have a brighter future- a better life!

All she needed to do was keep one last secret. One more.

Simple.

*They **deserve** to know.* So what? So what. Didn’t matter. Wasn’t it better to give them this gift? The gift of contentment? This was the right thing to do, truly the right thing for them all.

So she slipped into bed and slept, and got up wrong. She could feel it in the air, in her soul, in the very fiber of her being. She really wasn’t going to tell them, and that meant that she was just as awful as she’d always been.

A nothing.

Worthless.

Stain.

Ruining people's lives to cling to her own comfort. That was fine, accepting it would just make it easier to move forward. *You can do it. Nice and clean like. No one has to know.* Just like before. Close to the vest. It would all be fine, she'd make sure it was.

So for the first time in a long time, Catra listened to that little voice in the back of her head. The one that had always helped her survive. The one she'd worked so hard to silence, although now she couldn't quite remember why. She didn't give into the new voice she'd worked so hard to create, she stood strong no matter how exhausted it left her. No matter how thinly spread.

She would protect and provide the only way she could.

She just had to stay strong...for all of their sakes.

The first step is simple enough. Make things easier on all of them in the short run. It's not the worst thing, not by a long shot, but Catra kind of hates how easy it is to convince Glimmer to wait on the wedding.

"I mean, not like anyone's expectin' us to do nothing different." Catra shrugged, feeling worryingly numb where she should have been nervous.

Glimmer had nodded along, "Might as well use that to our distinct advantage. Give us a chance to adjust."

Neither of them smiled or laughed the way they used to over these jokes. Both ragged and worn thin from the near year gone past. So many secrets shared and yet there was no relief. *Not all of them* . And all the hurt that flowed between them. Inside them. Ate them up and spat them out.

Now they needed to adjust to just existing with one another again.

But it was fine. This was fine. Had to be.

So she dedicated herself that summer to showering Glimmer in attention for all the wrong reasons. To prove to herself that she loved her. To make sure Glimmer loved her. To make up for lying. To make up for Micah. Anything she could think of she does, which, as per usual, does not exactly work out as intended.

At least she thinks Glimmer found it charming at first. Maybe she was just putting up with it though. Probably the second one more than the first, but that was alright. Had to be. She just needed to hustle a bit more.

Glimmer had very carefully gotten that black widow out of Catra's hair after she'd squeezed into a little crevice to grab what she'd thought was going to be a geode but wasn't. She'd been exhausted when Catra arrived late with the fresh hare hanging over her back. Glimmer had nearly murdered Catra for going into the old silver mine, especially when she admitted she wasn't sure what she'd find in there.

"I know what you'd find. BLASTING CAPS," Glimmer had growled at her, checking all over for injuries despite the fact that Catra still had both her legs and hands intact, thank you very much.

"Miss that ain't fair, I *also* found several used tins of Prince Albert." Her, frankly hilarious, joke earned a swat that was bordering on a slap and a cold shoulder for the rest of the day.

The next morning they talked a bit, somehow both too bluntly while still dancing around the topic.

"D'riluth, I love you, please stop trying to kill yourself to prove it." Glimmer had held her hand so tenderly, eyes begging with worry and shining with frustration. It made Catra sick to know it was directed at her. "I promise I'll still love you even if you see some purdy thing and don't bring it home for me."

Ha!

Still, acts did need to be maintained. “If you insist, but I don’t think your mother will approve.”

Glimmer’s nose scrunched in confusion. “Of what?”

“Well me not taking you home a’ course. Purdiest thing I’ve ever seen.” Catra had smiled and prayed that this was a good thing to say. She didn’t know anymore, never was sure what she’d do or say and how Glimmer would react. For all that she was doing her damned best to help them both, it was almost like Glimmer was doing the opposite some days. Just never letting things go and always speaking up, her reactions a mystery now that Catra was relying on them so heavily. So she twisted each and every word and action to keep her affections. It was funny as the weeks passed how quickly she forgot how to be herself.

Probably a good sign that I ain’t being myself.

Or maybe you’re just going home.

She’d gotten a kiss for her sass and it burned like fire. But everything did these days.

“You alright?” Glimmer had asked that fall, thumb swiping over Catra’s knuckles. “Do ya need to stay home?”

That sounded like heaven. Staying home. Not doing nothing at all. Not having to see Angella and Glimmer together. Not having to see Micah’s picture. She’d barely been able to focus the last few weeks, somehow getting worse every month. Forgetting what she was doing half way through, mixing up simple things too. Catra thought she’d been doing a decent job of hiding it, but considering Glimmer had found her frowning at the matches in her hand next to the still unlit stove maybe she hadn’t been. She couldn’t even just fuck up in *private* , had to drag others into it and she knew going in meant making more and worse mistakes.

But staying home meant doing something kind for herself. Taking a break and avoiding the issue. And she didn’t deserve that more than anything else.

“Naw, naw, I’m fine.” When Glimmer only frowned harder, Catra kissed her temple. “I promise, everything’s fine. Perfect in fact. I’m just a bit groggy s’all.”

She already knew though, just from Glimmer’s face that the splinters were starting to show. Just more lies to cover the other ones. More and more and more and more.

And eventually she could see them too. Not in herself, no, Catra was aware of the spit and wire holding herself together. But the cracks in Glimmer’s facade, the truth shining through despite her best efforts. Whatever love she used to hold to Catra, it looked like it was fading fast as she snapped and avoided.

Hell, Catra had taken to staggering her leaving from Glimmer’s, which hadn’t been too hard as Glimmer could actually get to work on time and took to getting there even a hair early to make everything ready. Or at least that’s what she *said* , could be she just wanted to get away from her. Either way, it was awful because it was more work for her, but it wasn’t like Catra asked her to do it. Wasn’t like she would’ve survived without the help either. Wasn’t that she liked it neither. But going in late made her stay late, too behind in work to leave at a reasonable and safe hour, so she stayed to do more of it. By the time she’d finish it would be dark out and she was always desperate for a reason to not go home these days.

It had become routine to avoid their house, routine to avoid Glimmer as much as she could. If the numbness wasn’t there to keep her in check the fear and fury would ruin everything. Better to get yelled at for something she did on purpose than get that bitter concern for things she hadn’t meant to. In some ways it was actually soothing to be back in such a familiar routine.

That particular night she puttered around the office until she decided to go get a drink at the inn. It was quiet like she’d expected, mid week weren’t when folks came out to dance after all. The few patrons were all folks just passing through Etheria,

which was perfect. No one would know a damn difference, or well, most of them wouldn't know her at least.

"My, my, my, if it isn't my favorite kitten." Double Trouble's smile could cut glass, and Catra instantly regretted her decision.

Double Trouble had taken over the establishment just a year prior and word on the street was they traded more in information and illegal fair than drinks. Hell, Catra was pretty sure they were collecting a bunch a' soiled doves if nothing else. Not that she could prove a damn thing nor did she want to. Them folks could make or break a town, and despite Catra's own presence ruining it just by living here, she did want the town to stay viable for the Moons.

"You know I can just go home instead of spending my money."

Double Trouble pouted, already grabbing a glass to pour her a bit of the five cent cask. "Me- *ow* darling, no need to be threatening. I was just trying to make friendly conversation!"

Catra grunted as she gave up her nickel and somehow managed to convince herself that this would go smoothly. Like an idiot.

"Trouble in paradise?" Double Trouble asked, leaning heavily against the bar. Not even budging at Catra's glare. "Aw, don't be like that. Bartending is more about the personal relationships than the drinks after all. Unless you actually enjoy that swill, but you strike me as enjoying the finer things in life."

She almost snorted some of her beer through her nose. Wasn't that what got her into this mess in the first place, wanting and enjoying nice things? "And how do you figure that?"

Under the lanterns Double Trouble almost transformed just with a tilt of their head and a shift in how they held themself to appear a little shorter and pudgier, her heart kicked painfully as she knew exactly who they looked like. "Well you do seem to enjoy your fiancé after all. One of the finest things if I do say so myself."

"Excuse me!?" Catra hoped they'd say something stupid, she would love to punch their fucking face in. Maybe it's what she needed, a good old fashioned brawl! God that sounded good.

"Are you two ***not*** engaged? I could've sworn I'd heard you were. My mistake darling, you two just used to be so close is all." The world shrunk down, freezing up as they smiled at her. "I simply noticed that I've seen you around alone quite a bit more often these days. Never a good sign you know."

They weren't wrong. Catra swallowed roughly, willing the buzzing anger down and forcing the guilty panic alongside it. "Do yourself a favor, shut your mouth a-fore I shut it for you."

They pouted, but still moved enough to look like them again. "Well if you insist I suppose I can keep my relationship advice to myself, this time. Next time I'll charge you for the pleasure."

But they left all the same to check in on their other patrons, allowing Catra a half moment alone staring into her glass pensively. So. People had noticed that huh? Damn. Her need to protect Glimmer by staying away was going hand in hand with her desire to run away, but always ran up against public perception. Wouldn't matter much for her, but it did matter for the women practically running this town. She didn't finish her drink before leaving early.

Her ride home was freezing and Glimmer's concerned doting after her shitty behavior didn't help.

Not that *that* kindness lasted either. A fire reduced to coal, and rapidly cooling to ash. Despite it being her fault, she felt the sting of it all the same. She'd never lost love before and that made it worse, even if it's sometimes what she feared she truly wanted.

Catra had always been sensitive to rejection. Not that she'd ever admit to it, but she'd always known as soon as someone was upset with her. She'd had to know in the Horde and she'd learned that pushing meant she didn't get pushed. But she'd been putting

that armor down for over a decade now, and it sat too heavy and awkward on her shoulders.

But at least her pushing had the desired effect.

Glimmer, once leaving only a scant half hour before was leaving earlier and earlier. Sometimes they didn't share a single meal together for a whole day! Seeing one another more in passing than anything else. The play fights they used to have chilled into deadly sharp barbs. Their mutual discomfort only grew as people tried to ask what was wrong. Each time Catra failed to keep up the only promise that fucking mattered, Glimmer drew further away and she knew. She knew that if the truth didn't come out, it was possible she'd lose Glimmer anyways.

And that was infuriating. Couldn't she see that things weren't going well? Did Glimmer even care about her really? She just needed to stop acting like everything was alright when clearly it wasn't! She just needed to stop looking for things to get mad at Catra over! She needed to fucking back off, and she needed to actually be there when her help was *wanted* .

It was around her fourth episode of the damn month that she realized anyone with fucking eyes could tell something was wrong with her. But Glimmer didn't seem to know that, only behaving more and more erratically as time went on. Because if she wasn't getting cold and quiet and trying to avoid Catra, she was smothering her under unwarranted affection. Or she was hissing fire when Catra *tried her damned best* to give her the **fucking stars** . Everyone clearly knew but the supposed love of her life.

Glimmer already hated her, she just didn't know it yet.

But truly, the worst part was that she would take it. She'd take anything Glimmer would give her and not just because that was how pathetically weak and dependent she'd grown, but because it meant she didn't have to think too hard about Micah Moon. Because thinking of him was like choking down poison, it eroded away her will bit by bit to do the right thing. It tugged and pulled

so the bleeding never stopped. Made her feel weak and helpless. Made her want to spill forth the truth.

She had that same conversation with herself daily, and each time she knew what the right choice was.

So why did she keep trying to ruin it? *I'm trying to help. You're a fool.*

Because if Glimmer wasn't upset with her, Catra would prod to learn more about him. With the floodgates finally open, she was already learning more about the man she'd killed. And the more she learned the more she loathed herself. The further she wanted to dig until she melted away to blackened bones.

Where she'd spent most of her life stealing and hurting and killing, Micah had helped open orphanages and donated more than just his time and voice. He had been a benevolent quasi-ruler, his family name carrying weight and respect because he never abused it. While she had been threatening subordinates into falling into fucking line and backstabbing them later anyways, he had been teaching kids in need. While she had been making statements with gunpowder, he'd been making them with his patience and kindness.

That was the trade she'd made. A beast under the devil's command for an angel, in order to kill one woman.

She'd sometimes laugh too hard about that in the morning alone, razor blade shaking in her hand as she thought about how little relief and joy the trade had given her in return. She'd wanted to kill one genuinely evil person and all it cost was an innocent life. Funny how that had been alright with her until she learned more about him.

Glimmer had read to her quite a bit over the last few years, and all she could think about was some of them ancient stories. Prophecies coming true no matter what was done, curses being laid out, and people who had thought themselves heroes forced to

meet their true destiny regardless. Not that she had been anywhere as good as some of them. Clearly. But damn if it didn't seem familiar.

Because the price of her need for distraction was Glimmer's patience and love and kindness.

Glimmer spoke less and less about anything of consequence, the few times she did she'd fall into a cold silence when Catra couldn't pull it together to support her. She was having more bad days than good ones, driving in the wedges when she had the strength and resenting them when she didn't.

She was doing this for *them* so she couldn't just...push them away completely even if it would be easier. Catra was doing this as a favor to them! Would it kill her to just give Catra some damn time? But apparently she'd used up her time, been draining the well constantly for years now, convinced it wouldn't dry up. She'd burned up her love and affection carelessly. All she could do in the face of it was keep doubling down and hope someone else would fold before she did because there was no way to a happy ending anymore.

Shouldn't be hard, they was barely a couple anymore anyways.

Glimmer was splayed out on her side of the bed, claiming she was too warm to simply cuddle before bed but the steel in her eyes made it very clear that were true. It wasn't fair! It wasn't fair, she was doing her damned best and she was still in trouble! Her mind raced along well worn paths.

But see, it wasn't really your fault. The idiot killed himself! ***Weaver*** *killed him! She couldn't just be cold, she just had to be cruel and she pushed you over the edge. If Hordak had just kept Weaver on a fucking shorter leash none of this would've happened! If Scorpia had just managed to do her fucking job none of this would have started anyways, you could've been second in command and Weaver already ousted from power. It was out of your control. No one can blame you for this! No one!*

Catra was sweating bullets even in the cold of spring, the typical howling winds keeping her awake until she managed to slip away. Trying to tip toe as she stumbled to the kitchen, hoping to slip and break her damn neck on the stairs and be done with it; without any luck.

So instead she turned to her newest growing vice. Catra, quietly as she could despite the noise of the gale, pulled a bottle of whiskey out and quickly downed a shot. Then poured a second, then a third. There was a spare bottle hidden in Captain's stall, she'd just refill it in the morning. Her hands shook as she drank and Catra jumped as something banged outside, her frayed nerves telling her it was a gunshot even when she knew it wasn't. P-probably a tree branch had broken. How the hell was Glimmer still asleep? How could she sleep through so much noise and destruction?

"Better than next to me," she chuckled, one hand rubbing roughly at her eyes.

She's gonna find out. Wish she'd get on with it.

Her breath hitched and heart hurt, eyes going blurry as those damned tears formed. She was not going to have a damn breakdown in her own damn kitchen at god knows what hour it was! She wasn't, she wasn't! Catra took a deep breath, smoothing her hair back and down away from her face. Glimmer knew, Glimmer already knew that Catra had killed, hell she'd done it in front of her! She wasn't forcing her to do nothing by proposing and sure as shit wasn't forcing nothing now! *GLIMMER* was the one who said yes knowing the truth!

*She doesn't know the **truth** about you. You couldn't have just left could you? Always have to make it personal. Killing poor Micah Moon just to get Weaver.*

"I didn't!" She hissed, shaking her head as if it would stop her own thoughts. "I didn't, I didn't! It wasn't like that, it wasn't!"

Her mind began spinning a mile a minute, too many thoughts piling up like trains at a poorly run station. A burning wreck and mess. Her eyes burned as she tried to focus on her shot glass, but her mind latched onto the first unfortunate memory it could as another gunshot went off. Catra flinched and dropped down below the counter to try and breathe but instead she gasped for air and- and-

The man screamed as he cried. His wife and child hollering right alongside him. The sound pounding into her skull from all sides.

Hordak placed himself where she could easily see him as he demonstrated. "I want you shooting mass, not cards. So stand square, that way you can turn the target to the left or right without moving your feet. Keep your face flat, and bring the gun up to your eye not the other way around."

Catra stared at the man, and cursed him in her heart. None of this woulda happened if the damn fool had just had their money as promised! This was all his fault! She blinked away the sting of tears and shoved the part of her that was balking down.

This was life. This was the Horde. Get over it.

It still took every ounce of willpower to keep herself calm and listening to Hordak instead of the weak sniveling voice in her head. She wanted to assure the man that it was just for show, that it was ***meant*** *to scare him to death.*

She also didn't want to lie.

So she did what Hordak told her, repeating the simple motion on his command and correction too.

"Acceptable. You've seen some of us shoot haven't you? Some of us shoot like idiots trying to get control of the gun." Hordak demonstrated the stance she was much more familiar with. One foot slightly back, pushing with one arm and pulling with the other on his revolver. "Works like a charm until you screw it up. If you

can't shoot proper, then I'll have someone else show you the push pull."

This was a test then, a test to see if Catra was worth his time and effort. She couldn't fail it.

She made sure the revolver was pointed at the floor as she asked, "How d'ya stop it from hitting you?" That had always been her biggest fear with guns was it slamming back and taking out her eye.

Hordak sneered, "It don't kick that hard, just feels like it does. Now lift and keep it up."

Catra noted that that did not answer her question at all, but turned her face forward again. The man had dissolved into begging, his crying turning it into a jumbled mess.

"Good way to hold it if you want to hurt yourself," Hordak adjusted her grip until her hands were clear of the cylinder and squeezed until her grip tightened up. "Don't want to lose a finger or an eye do you?"

"No sir."

"Look down the sights. Make sure they're lined up and even. Once they are, focus on the front sight, that middle one. It should be dead center."

The man was praying now, looking straight up as he hollered scripture. Her arms were starting to tremble.

"Take a breath before you shoot. Then when you're ready, you pull straight back on that trigger with the pad of your finger. Don't jerk it, solid and steady pressure. You understand?"

"Yes sir." Catra lowered the gun back to the floor, and she could hear the woman heave a relieved sob behind her.

“Good. Now do what I told you.” Hordak motioned to the man before stepping back. “Center mass.”

It was like she detached from her body, floating a few inches back and up. She didn’t mind. It made her less nervous. Catra took her stance, lifted the revolver, and was surprised at how hard the trigger was to pull. She shook it off, let go, and tried again. Aiming for smooth and steady, not jerking it-

She almost dropped it when it fired. The force from the bullet kicking it up and her inexperience allowing it to twist slightly. She’d aimed for his chest best she could. She’d hit the wall behind him to the left.

The woman was screaming, the kid was still crying, and the man had pissed himself.

And Hordak chuckled, but it didn’t sound joyful, “To be expected. Again.”

It took a few more tries to hit him. Her ears were ringing; the gun was so damn loud.

Catra didn’t really remember much after that, just a flash of looking at the blood pooling under the man’s feet. She didn’t know a human could hold so much blood.

But she did remember Hordak chuckling as he slid her a glass filled with something.

“Drink.”

It took some effort for her to try and follow his order, but she tried a little too slow. She spit it right back out, coughing as she spilled most of the rest on her neck. The alcohol burned as it went up her nose. Hordak only laughed as her eyes watered and she cursed up a storm.

Still, he took her mostly empty glass back and refilled it, sliding it back to her across the table.

"Not the best tasting is it? But you'll appreciate the effects after today. Think of it as a reward." His hand covered the top before she could even lift it. "Spit it out again, and I'll start to get angry ya hear?"

Catra nodded, and this time she didn't spit it out and didn't spill. Turned out it burned the whole way down and she gagged on the fire. "Holy shit, are you trying to kill me?!"

She'll never forget the way he grinned, like they were sharing a joke. Maybe they were. "Not yet."

He poured a third and Catra was uncomfortably aware of how many people were watching them. Oh, *she vaguely remembered thinking,* we're at camp. *As usual, she looked around and found Shadow Weaver stood by the fire, eyes firmly fixed on the two of them in Hordak's tent. Now that felt like a real reward, the old bitch's impotent fury was enough to keep Catra going. She finished the drink, and was rather relieved to find it didn't burn as much, but chalked it up to her mouth having been seared to hell already.*

Catra doesn't know how many she downed that night, she was swaying dangerously in her seat by the time Hordak finally stopped. Her stomach felt awful and her arms were heavy and also felt oddly fat. She swallowed a few times, thoughts foggy as she muttered, "Thfuck's this?"

"The benefits." Hordak stood, pulling her to her feet. It wasn't that the world was spinning, it was like she didn't have control of her body, nearly collapsing right at his feet. "You did better than most for a first kill and drink. Good job. Now, off to bed. Long day ahead tomorrow."

She barely made it to her sleeping roll.

Catra blinked, the trees moaned, and the house shuddered as it rocked in the wind. Somehow she was standing again, another glass poured in front of her. How many was that now? Damn, he'd

be pissed if she took too much. Wait, no. Her bottle wasn't it? Right. Right, spare in the barn, but this was hers too. The wind died down and she took the last shot. The only good thing about getting lost in it now besides being too rattled to break down, was the clarity that came with it.

She'd killed plenty of people, she'd even learned to not feel so awful when she did. But she hadn't murdered Micah , because it was an accident, so she hadn't killed him. She hadn't done it at all. It was a freak accident. She carded her hands through her hair again, slowly breathing in and out.

"It's fine. You're fine. Just keep it under control." God, what she would give to have it be true.

She hastily shoved the whiskey back into the cupboard, rinsed her glass in the sink. Took her time and waited until the shaking became more of a swaying. Then staggered back upstairs to their bedroom. She curled up tight and watched Glimmer's chest rise and fall with each breath until she fell asleep.

It was never meant to last, was it?

"C'mon, get up!" Glimmer's voice and shaking finally roused her from the depth of a dreamless sleep. Somehow, someway, she actually sounded chipper this morning. "Sleeping like the dead!"

Catra groaned, her head hurt and mouth tasted awful. She noted dully that she didn't even have a proper full blown hangover to use as an illness to stay in bed.

Glimmer poked the side of her nose, but her tone was still light. "You alright?"

"Didn't sleep much," she muttered, slowly sitting up to be safe.

"The wind keep ya up?"

"...yeah, helluva night."

"...a'ight, well I got some breakfast made up for you. Are you sure yer alright dear?" The fact that Glimmer could still look at her with any love and concern, well, it made her sick.

But she smiled anyways, pulling Glimmer in for a kiss. It was like burning herself on a red hot iron. She held it anyways because otherwise Glimmer would *know* . She cupped her face between her hands, and tilted their foreheads together. "I'm fine. Everything's...everything's well. I'm just tired."

"You sure? You seemed like you were ready to scream for a moment there." Glimmer chuckled, swinging their hands lightly between them even as her voice got strained and her smile went tight. "We can talk about it, if you want."

Just get it over with. Tell her. I can't. Throw me out! Just tell her damn you! I need her, I need her, I need her.

Somehow she found a smile, "Naw, just the wind. I'll see you shortly alright?"

Glimmer's own smile almost puttered out as she failed some sort of test, "Well alright, see you soon."

Catra stayed sitting in bed for a while longer after Glimmer left. First time in a long time she hadn't been told 'I love you' before they parted.

Her grip was slipping. It had been a year since she'd learned about Micah and every day she lost a little more the tighter she held on. For all her anger it was the guilt that was really eating her alive.

What'll you do when she finally forces you out?

That was no longer a terrifying possibility but an assured fact. Catra wasn't sure why she'd lied to herself, after all, she never could have nice things without breaking them eventually. She needed a new plan.

She was nearly two hours late to work, and got home long after Glimmer had gone to sleep.

The next morning Glimmer was gone and Catra scraped up a meager meal since Glimmer hadn’t left anything for her. And that just cemented it.

It was really just a matter of how long Catra could hold on before she cracked. No whispered assurances could calm her, no logic could soothe her. It was already over. Had been over before it had even started.

Of course she failed, what the hell else had she expected.

“End of the line,” she’d chuckled mirthlessly to herself after Glimmer stormed out, too angry to stay after their latest fight.

She’d just hang on till she either got the damn courage to say the truth, or Glimmer found her resolve to throw her out. Just a little longer. Just enough to figure it out.

Because that had worked out so fucking well the last time.

Chapter End Notes

So who's ready for Glimmer to find out the truth next time? Show of hands? Oh good, me neither!

As I told Angela, don't worry too much! Catra's S4 ass kicking is much less fatal in this AU and Glimmer didn't burn the house down! :D

Chapter 12: The Big Bad

Chapter Summary

> Sometimes Glimmer wished Catra hadn't told her anything at all, but sometimes she wished Catra would just tell her the whole truth. What is she hiding?

Chapter Notes

> Shout out to the ever lovely Dragonesdepapel for beta reading!
>
> CW: body horror (nightmare description of burn injuries), domestic violence, there's a lot of verbal fighting and some physical fighting in this one, anxiety/panic attack, dissociation, not enforcing boundaries and the consequences of that, and a lot of mishandling and miscommunication around emotions
>
> Look, Catra isn't doing well, but if you thought Glimmer was at least doing alright I have got some bad news...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sometimes Glimmer wished that Catra had never told her anything at all.

Between the two of them alternating back and forth from anxious to angry, and the guilt that inevitably creeps up on her for being angry, it had been a hellish year and some change. Probably one of their worst, if not *the* worst.

In large part she knew it was because she'd gotten comfortable. They'd created a life together and everything had seemed damn near perfect! But now it's almost like starting over, but worse for the knowledge of what it was like to be so close. Loving one another from a distance and second guessing every move all the while feeling like there was no safety net to catch them. She was

on egg shells everyday, praying that Catra would be in a good mood, and weathering each day that she wasn't. Not that Glimmer doesn't also have bad days that Catra helped her through, but her bad days ain't nothing like *hers* .

Glimmer idly toyed with her bracelet, frowning as the thought floated back up to the surface. *Do I even know her?*

Ah yes, and there's that guilt again. Fantastic.

Because it wasn't just their instability as a couple causing issues, oh no, Catra seemed to be wildly swinging from almost smothering her with love to scared to touch her to quietly furious without cause. And the thing was it was *all* Catra. Glimmer had known for years now that for all she loved that woman, that she didn't seem completely right in the head. She didn't care, never had! So what? Ain't like other folks were living a perfect life. So what if sometimes they'd spend a few days working Catra back up from nonfunctional to at least talking again? So what if sometimes she got lost in her own mind? It didn't matter. And she believed that, for all it made her stomach and heart twist with an awful selfish desire that it weren't so.

And good lord, was it draining. It was constant.

It hadn't been too bad before, maybe a day here or a moment there, but there was always enough time for Glimmer to also recover after Catra had. Quietly and usually on her own, managing to grin and bear it until she'd had the time she needed to calm and cool. For all she loved and cared and gave, it still took a toll on her too. And faced with the choice between helping the love of her life and leaving her high and dry, she'd suck it up and find a smile and be there damn it all! And giving her all when she'd already felt ragged, that was hard work that she didn't want upended by Catra getting guilty over it. And so she'd keep quiet, take care of it, and be grateful when her own stress had passed.

It weren't like that no more.

No more a day here or there, Catra seemed to shift suddenly for weeks on end, or worse, she'd flip rapidly through it all in the span of an hour. Always near a crisis, and thus, Glimmer was always on high alert too. Glimmer had changed **everything** she did, hell, even some of how she thought just to take care of her! Choosing meals based on what she thought might get a smile and dividing chores based on what she knew Catra preferred. Not even going out on a whim with her friends to just spend time together, she okayed everything with Catra so as to not worry her, even as it was driving her up a wall. Anytime the bitterness rose up, she forcibly reminded herself that she was not the one struggling.

I am struggling, this is unfair! Glimmer winced as her bracelet caught a little bit of her arm hair and tugged painfully.

Grateful to be brought back to the present as she waited for Catra to come down to breakfast. She'd gotten the day off well in advance, and so had Adora and Bow. So it was going to be a good day if it killed her. They was gonna head out on the trails and just ride for a while, and it sounded like heaven. She just wanted to make sure Catra ate some damn food before she left and remembered that Glimmer would be gone the whole day. Catra without food in her was somehow twice as bad, and a Catra who'd forgotten where Glimmer would be was often in turns angry at being "left out" and scared of "driving her away". She nervously looked at the stairs as she waited, dread building up in her stomach and chest. It was never a good sign when Catra took this damn long these days. *Please, just one good day.*

Glimmer finally lost her appetite as a wave of bitterness boiled up inside her. Catra was a fully grown adult, but sometimes it felt like she was watching over a troubled child! It wasn't a fair thought. Not a kind one either. And she hated herself a little more for feeling it.

But that was just her life now, wasn't it? The building anger, then bitterness, then guilt, then anger, then bitterness, then guilt. An awful cycle that at least *she* was trying to break them free of even

if she had to drag Catra along with her. *Funny how she didn't have no troubles before, and now she cain't even get out of bed!*

Glimmer took a slow breath in and out, willing herself to get out of that looping track.

"Sorry," Catra basically whispered, barely managing to drag herself into her chair and still scaring the hell out of her. Woman was still damn silent even when she dragged her feet! "I can, uh, I can get the dishes after."

Glimmer smiled, a mixture of love and frustration weighing her down. Catra would absolutely not get the dishes done on her own like this. Moving like molasses and forgetful as she was gonna be. "Nah, don't worry your pretty little head darlin', we can do them together before I go."

Catra sighed, nodding as she stared down her plate like it was an invading army. "Yeah. Okay."

Would a thank you kill you? Glimmer shoved the thought away, once more frustrated with her own anger bubbling around her heart. She knew Catra weren't well and it was childish and unfair to expect her to act like she wasn't. *Be grateful.* So she reached across the table to hold Catra's hand and felt her heart shatter as Catra hastily wiped a few tears away. It was funny how easily the words came, how genuine they were despite how she forced them out. "Hey...I love you."

Catra gave her a watery smile, but it didn't make it any less warm or kind. "You're amazing, you know that? I'm so damn lucky. Love you."

Glimmer smiled back, squeezed her hand again, and then finally forced herself to eat. Here she was being a damn monster, and Catra wanted to thank her for it. *You said you* ***wanted*** *a thank you, was it worth it?* She gently shook her head before that could become something awful on it's own. They were having a nice morning, it was going to be a good day!

It didn’t take long for them to finish eating, and by the time they were nearly done cleaning up things felt almost normal. Catra was smiling and teasing, her eyes slowly brightening back up as her energy seemed to return. Glimmer had just dried and put the last glass away when she remembered the other thing she was supposed to do this morning.

“Catra, I nearly forgot! Mother said she sent out a few cards to folks, letting them know we’re planning to marry.” It had felt a little silly to her, they didn’t even have a date! But it made her mother happy and she hoped it would make Catra smile too. The engagement had become a sore subject after they’d both agreed to wait. But maybe...maybe they just needed a push to get things going?

She felt the barest hint of humor at the thought. They must’ve had the longest engagement ever by this point! Maybe they could enter some sort of world record? Could be a funny story to tell.

“What?” Catra asked.

“Yeah,” Glimmer finished patting her hands dry, “she wanted to at least have it in folks peripherals-”

“I didn’t agree to that.”

Glimmer blinked rapidly as she looked up, startled by the venom in Catra’s voice. “Pardon?”

Catra was grinding her teeth, hands balled up into fists as she tried to control what looked like a terrible rage. Instantly what little good mood she had plummeted to her stomach, she wasn’t sure if she was tired or afraid or angry, but Catra was clearly furious. “What gives her the damn right to do that without talking to us, huh!? That was presumptuous!”

Oh here we go! Glimmer managed to control her volume, but couldn’t help the bit of frost coating her words. “Excuse you, she was doing us a favor!”

"Well I certainly didn't ask her to!" Catra threw her hands in the air as she stomped about. "She shouldn't a done it!"

"...are we really having a damn fight because my mother did something **nice** for you? Well, I am *sorry* she didn't think about how you'd blow this out of proportion!" Glimmer hastily began grabbing her things. God damn it all, shoulda kept her mouth shut!

But wasn't that the way of it these days? Do something nice for Catra and inevitably it would burn you. She'd long since given up on Catra just being mature enough to *tell* her what was wrong. Nowadays it was more a guessing game of if she refused to tell her because she didn't love Glimmer anymore, or if she was just trying to be a stubborn ass about being independent. She just wanted to grab her and shake her a bit, maybe a few good slaps until Catra's tongue would loosen!

They'd always worked best when they **talked** , but now it was like opening her mouth was pulling the trigger on a half loaded gun. Never knew if she was gonna take a damn bullet.

Catra was still talking. Glimmer's breathing went a little ragged as she realized she had no idea how long she'd been caught up in the tidal wave of emotions. Just knowing that made her feel like bawling. She could feel the pressure inside her building up, to screaming or tears or something. She needed to get out of there. She needed to leave right this damn second! Glimmer needed this ride more than anything in her damn life at this point.

"And now you say it's supposed to be nice!?" Catra laughed, a bit manic and a bit bitter. "Way she's been acting, you'd think she's the one getting married."

Glimmer slammed her hand down on the table, mostly to get Catra's attention but she couldn't deny it helped to get some of her anger out somewhere. "Do not take that tone about my mother."

“What fucking tone?” Catra growled, face twisting with indignation. “Oh, what? I’m not allowed to get upset anymore? I didn’t even say nothing rude!”

“ **That tone.** You always do this!”

“No I don’t!”

The two stared at one another and Glimmer sighed heavily. So much for the better morning they’d been building. The only thing she could do now was cut her losses to try and survive the next onslaught, whenever that was. “Fine. You don’t. Happy?”

“Why are you like this?” Catra nearly hissed.

Oh! Oh ho! So that’s how this was gonna be!

It took a supreme effort of willpower to not scream. For the moment she didn’t even care that both of them were posturing like a damned fist fight was about to break out. Glimmer just concentrated on breathing for a moment before shouldering her way out the door.

“Where are you going?” Catra shouted, even as she followed her round back to the barn.

“I’m meeting with Bow and Adora, and I ain’t gonna be late because you’re upset and want to take it out on me!” Glimmer had never been so grateful to know how to saddle up her own damn horse. She focused on that instead.

“What the hell are you even talking about? I ain’t mad atcha!” Catra snarled, which really didn’t help her case.

Glimmer managed to tighten the last few buckles and then hooked her pack up on the side. “Well that’s just peachy then. I’m still meeting up with them.”

“Can you fucking just- damn it!” By the time Glimmer was up in her saddle, Catra was pinching the bridge of her nose and looked

defeated. “Glim, can we please just...talk about this?”

“Sure. When I get back,” she wasn’t going to let this bump ruin her whole day, and these days there was no way for them to even talk without it being a damn fight. Bow and Adora didn’t deserve to deal with her fuming mad over something that weren’t their fault..

Catra looked up at her, and it was like seeing multiples. She looked furious and terrified and exhausted and so deeply sad. But if Glimmer stayed to help her, she knew she’d never go for the ride and she needed a moment to completely relax or else she was going to say something they’d both regret. She needed to be firm.

“...okay.” Catra moved out of the doorway, mumbling as she rode past. “Have a good time.”

She didn’t even answer as she left.

Glimmer huffed as she finished explaining the latest fight, feeling tired and lighter for it.

Bow whistled low as his brow furrowed. “Glimmer...that sounds, well, pretty bad.”

“No, no, it’s not that bad really. I’m just- it’s- I’m just a bit tired so it feels worse than it is.” She assured him as best she could. Glimmer knew that after she’d just spent a good hour ranting about Catra that it sounded far worse than it really was. But good lord above, if she didn’t complain to someone about her she was going to explode. “It ain’t all doom and gloom, she just isn’t well right now.”

“That ain’t no excuse,” Adora muttered darkly, Swift Wind jerking to the side as she squeezed her legs a little too hard.

“I am not making her excuses, land’s sake! I’m just saying we’re both worn thin, which is why I’m glad to be out here with you two.” Apparently she should just shut up! Just shut up and stop talking and stop trying! Damn it all! Couldn’t do nothing right, couldn’t say nothing right, just fuck up after fuck up these days wasn’t it!

There was a sort of grim amusement as she thought of all the times this past year she’d tried to explain her feelings to Catra only to get a muted anger and a, “ *Well congratulations. That’s what it’s like to be me, that’s what it’s like in my head all the damn time!* ” Couldn’t even escape it out here without her.

“I, please don’t take this the wrong way,” Bow said, which was a sure sign he was going to say something she would hate, “but if you two are really getting into it like this, this frequently...is it worth it to get married? Youcanalwaysmarrylaterifyouchangeyourminds! Not saying you two shouldn’t! Just, maybe it should be called off till then?”

Oh, she’d be right all right. Glimmer hated that.

“No. It’s my wedding too Bow, and I am damn tired of waiting. I think that once we get it over and done with all this stress will go away and we can just go back to the way things were.” Glimmer nodded firmly even as she ducked under the branch of a dead tree. “She just ain’t sleeping well anymore, anyone would be grouchy if they didn’t get sleep.”

“Nightmares again?” Bow asked, offering an olive branch of sorts after knowingly pushing her.

Glimmer snorted, “Wish I knew, she keeps sneaking out of bed at night and doesn’t seem to realize that I know about it.”

“You didn’t tell her?” Adora’s voice was still a little tight but she was obviously trying to get it together.

"No, you know Catra. She needs to feel independent and in control of something. Not like she goes outside and cries or nothing." Glimmer purposefully didn't mention how often she'd go outside to retch, the sound easily floating through the window in the warmer months. Or the slowly growing pile of bottles Glimmer knew were half the problem. Catra never went into work drunk, and never seemed inebriated at home. If it weren't for the retching and the morning headaches, she probably wouldn't even connect the two. "She hain't said nothing about it, so I need to trust that if she wanted help she'd ask. Simple as that."

"None of this sounds simple," Adora sighed.

"It really isn't that bad!" There was still a slight bite to her words and Glimmer wasn't sure who she was trying to convince.

"Oh yeah? So why are you two riding in separate these days huh? Or better question," Adora turned a bit to look at her, "why in the hell is she in the saloon every night?"

She had no idea. Glimmer knew for a fact that Catra wasn't getting drunk over there, and she never stayed too late. But truthfully, she didn't care. She was *grateful* because it was a few hours a day where Glimmer knew she'd have a bit of peace at the house so she never asked. Hell, Catra probably appreciated that Glimmer left early most days so she could have some time alone at home too. "What are you really asking me?"

Adora huffed. "Just seems to me like she don't respect you well enough."

"Well, you're wrong." Glimmer said, grinding the words out as her frustration started growing again. "Now I've had my damn time to just complain a bit. What have you two been up to?"

Bow had barely opened his mouth when Adora spoke over him. "You know what? No! Glimmer, we ain't seen ya in a long while and every time we've tried to get together you always decline

because of her! And after hearing all this? I don't know. It's like she's controlling you and I just- I just think it don't sound right."

"Well good thing you ain't marrying her then!" Glimmer growled. "And I don't appreciate the way you are talking about my woman!"

Despite her aggressive lean, Adora's voice was rough with pleading. "You don't need to appreciate it, what you need to do is damn well listen to me!"

"OKAY, STOP!" Bow shouted, spurring Archer in between them and pulling up hard enough to stay there. "I know this is a big deal, and we *should* talk more about it. But that was not what we planned today, and it's clearly not what Glimmer is looking for right now."

Adora flushed red, sputtering a bit before trying again. "But-"

"No. No buts! Love takes a lot of work, and it isn't always gonna be pretty." Bow said, and Adora's mouth clicked shut, which was *very* satisfying. "And you."

Glimmer nearly startled as Bow turned to look at her. She hadn't done nothing wrong!

"Glimmer, we're both just worried for you. We love you and we love Catra too. We want you both happy alright? But it don't sound like you are right now, so we're trying to help." He reached a hand out, taking hers to hold. "I know you're tired but you don't need to fight us."

They didn't get it though. Glimmer scowled at the trail but let herself fall silent, just trying to enjoy the sway of the ride and the warmth of Bow's hand. After a few tense minutes she finally said, "I don't want to fight you, or Catra. Just...please remember that you're talking about the woman I love."

Despite being on the other side of Bow, Adora's voice carried well enough anyways. Tired and strained, but trying. "Okay, I'll try. I

just get mad when people hurt my friends, intentional or not."

Bow tugged at her hand so Glimmer adjusted until they were riding a bit to the side, which allowed Adora to ride up on her other side with her hand out with a hopeful smile. Glimmer chuckled but took it all the same, grateful for her old steady horse and her two best friends.

"I know, and I do appreciate that you care about me." Glimmer squeezed Adora's much larger hand and snickered as the two locked eyes and started a grip strength competition. She was gonna lose. Adora had literally caught a bull by the horns once and not been thrown instantly, woman had a grip like steel. But she also wasn't gonna back down!

"...aaaaand you two have made up. Excellent." Bow mostly deadpanned before grinning mischievously over Glimmer's head and started to squeeze the hell out of her hand.

"That's cheating!" She gasped, now focusing on both sides with a wild grin.

"Aw," Adora simpered, "all's fair in love and war miss."

"Gray, I am gonna **hurt** you!"

"But only jokingly for fun!" Bow added unnecessarily.

Adora and Glimmer both turned to look at him, competition temporarily halted, before humming thoughtfully. Glimmer shook her head and clarified, "Nah, just the regular kind!"

"Yeah Bow, this is war not faro!"

"Of course not," Bow said very reasonably while literally doubling over to really put the pressure on Glimmer's hand, "if it was Glimmer would cheat!"

She gasped more from the pain of having two freakishly strong friends, but played it off as she pretended to be offended, "Excuse

you mister! I was a child!”

“Who-” Bow grunted with effort, “cheated!”

“One time!” Glimmer hissed, desperately trying to hang on for just a few more seconds before giving up and letting her hands go slack. “And like you two ain’t ganging up on me right now. It’s not right is what it is!”

“Yeah, but it worked,” Adora said, with the dumbest looking smug smirk in place and a hand over her heart she at least gave them a little room.

“Yeah Glimmer, it worked!” Bow laughed, pumping his fist up and down before shouting, “Best friend squad!”

“Thank you for scaring away the bears Bow,” Adora said as seriously as she could.

“You’re welcome! Safety first!”

Glimmer giggled as Adora lost it, Bow barely managed to keep from his own belly laughter to try and double down on his bullshit. Eventually all three of them calmed down, and Glimmer happily soaked up the comfortable silence. Her mirth slowly evening out until she finally, for the first time in a long time, felt happy.

And with that, came perspective. Darn them both, but they were right!

Glimmer didn’t feel bad as she thought about the situation, not like she’d been doing at least. Even as a pit formed in her stomach she could admit that she did need to talk to Catra, instead of coming up with excuses for why avoiding her was the better solution. Bow was right, maybe they just needed to postpone the whole affair. Hell, maybe they *should* even call it off for now. Focus on getting themselves righted first and then they could give marriage another crack later. No way it wasn’t adding additional pressure on them both. Glimmer could say she knew her growing anger at feeling like the finish line was moving didn’t

help things. And thinking about just how nervous and anxious Catra had been about proposing "proper like", the idea of a big wedding wasn't helping anything at all.

As much as she hated to even think it, Adora was also right. Catra hadn't been treating her right, and Glimmer could only sigh because it wasn't like she'd been open and honest with her either. It's not that she'd given up on Catra, she knew for a fact that when this passed Catra was gonna climb back up out of her pit and do anything she damn well wanted to. But right now Glimmer was having to go into something of a survival mode just to make it day to day, so it made everything, even Catra's victories towards some kind of recovery, turn to ash. Yet every time Catra asked, soft and unsure, "How can you still love me?" Glimmer pretended that everything was right as rain. Her lies were born of a desire to spare Catra, but they weren't helping none. Both of them had been lying and going around each other, and no matter the reason it weren't right. Goodness gracious, what were they? Twenty year olds dancing around their mutual attraction again? Catra had already agreed to talk with her when she got home, so Glimmer would have a very easy opening to start this conversation.

She just...couldn't wait until this was behind them. She wanted to go back to how it was before she'd known about the Horde, but that wasn't possible, was it? They both needed to figure out how to move on together or risk falling apart. Glimmer couldn't take that, she couldn't. She'd fought tooth and nail to keep Catra with her, and the idea that after all this they'd just...fall apart? No. This had to all be worth something at the end of it!

When she looked up, Glimmer startled as Bow and Adora both pretended they hadn't been looking at her anxiously.

The sweet fools!

"Okay, not to make this all about me again, but to make this all about me again," Glimmer started with a weak laugh, "Thank you for listening, and...you're right. Me and Catra are gonna talk

tonight anyways, I just...I don't know how to even broach the topic honestly."

Bow smiled softly while Adora grinned nervously. "Well, that's what friends are for! Let's help you figure it out!"

The rest of the ride was much lighter and far more pleasant as they came up with a game plan for Glimmer. She'd have to take on a lot of responsibility, emotionally and otherwise, if this was going to work. So figuring out what she wanted to say, the questions she needed answers to, the things Catra needed to understand about Glimmer's threadbare abilities, and more, was important. With Adora mentally listing and organizing for them, her and Bow were able to rapid fire through various ideas and even planned just in case she or Catra needed another place to stay for a while. Knowing how bad their fights could get these days, it was important to have even if she hated it.

But with that out of the way, Glimmer was sick of talking about her own situation. They were out here together to be friends, and she'd had more than her allotted time!

So they talked about Bow's older brother's insistence that he only needed to move to another city just one more time, a pretty standard refrain for Pole who just couldn't be happy settled down but wouldn't take a job that allowed him to travel. George was still insisting that his eyes sight was just fine, thank you very much, although he'd started defaulting to having Lance or Bow read him the paper.

Bow had rolled his eyes, "Because that screams perfect vision!"

"But you still read it to him?" Adora had asked in confusion.

Bow teared up a tiny bit, looking so much like Lance when he saw a baby bunny that Glimmer did a double take. "He's my father, course I do!"

Bow's work had, of course, been solid and steady. He didn't really love being a butcher but he didn't want to be a minister either.

Adora and Glimmer had made exasperated eye contact with one another, because Bow was actually considering seminary school and was basically doing an apprenticeship under Lance to take over already. They were sure he'd do it eventually, but only once he was actually ready to. And if not, they were happily prepared to get the best damn sausages money could buy!

They'd eventually moved on to talk about Razz in relation to Adora's new position. Sheriff Hope had finally retired and Adora was officially the law in Etheria, and while it was everything she'd wanted it came with its own pitfalls. Razz was alone a lot more now, and while she seemed to still be kicking just fine, she'd always been battier than a belfry. And old age cared little for if you thought you had the ability to jump off of a two story building chasing your newest invisible companion. Adora lamented that she couldn't even really check on her often without a deputy to pick up the slack. In fact, today had only managed to happen at all as Hope had agreed to keep watch while she went out.

"Said it had been unusually long for us to not spend time together," Adora smiled and shrugged, a sure sign that Hope had worded it just a little more awkwardly, but with all the genuine love she had, "but it's probably the last one till I get someone else in."

"Well, we'll just have to spend time where you are then." Bow said with the same firmness she'd seen people warn others off their property.

"Can't wait to spend so much time in jail, truly the place where we belong." Glimmer snickered, returning the kick Adora sent her way.

"Miss I can lock you right up!"

"On what charges? I am an *angel* Sheriff Gray, and I have never done anything wrong in my life ever! Tell her, Bow."

He smiled sagely, dipping his head before turning to Adora. "Glimmer Moon is a right menace miss, and some time behind bars would do her good."

"BOW!"

It was perfect and wonderful, and exactly the oasis she'd needed before facing reality again. But, of course, it couldn't last. The pit of nerves that never seemed to leave these days instead it creeped back in more and more, until Glimmer had felt tense with fear for what would happen when she got home. Eventually they picked up on her growing nervousness, and waved her off. Each wishing her luck as they parted early. She couldn't help but smile as she started to ride home on her own, poor Star Wind was plodding along anywho and it was more than time to give the girl a good rest.

And then it was time to get her damn life in order.

Just ten minutes into her ride home and Glimmer already felt herself getting worked up as if she'd practically just left the house again this morning. Without Bow's smiles and Adora's confidence, she was slowly losing her own. The rest of it was practically torture as she imagined all the ways this could go wrong, and, in a twisted bid to keep her emotions in check, at least tried to figure out what the hell she was gonna actually gonna say. An outline was nice and all, but a solid start would be helpful.

"Catra, I think it might be worth it to call off the wedding to...oh goodness that'll send her into a right panic."

"Catra, I feel like we don't talk like we used to and- goodness that is awful."

"Why don't you trust me? C'mon Glimmer, get it together!"

"Catra, I need your help. See I haven't been feeling well lately and I am worried- ugh. See, I have been worried recently about- I have been-"

"I love you and I want us to both be well. I've been talking with Bow and Adora- oh she will pitch a fit if I tell her that."

"Darling, is there anything you want to tell me? Lord preserve! She ain't a child!"

"Catra, you are *scaring* me."

"Some days I want to just scream at you! Ugh!"

"Sometimes you make me so mad I could die, and it ain't right that-"

"I'm tired of you **lying** to me!"

"I'm afraid that everything I'll do will- no. It's like no matter what I do, I can't win. Goodness no!"

"Catra...I've been thinking some, and I feel like we ain't been honest- is that too forward? Lord she'll run."

Funny how the script they came up with had been so simple when it was theoretical. Glimmer stared forlornly at the house through the trees, it just didn't seem right that it was this hard to talk with her. Catra was delicate right now, and that did deserve some thought, but Glimmer needed to be able to talk freely. And the fact of the matter was that she couldn't without a simple talk turning into a full blown fight. Adora was right, it wasn't right how Catra was treating her, it wasn't *right* that she had to be afraid of Catra hating her over something as simple as expressing her own damned experiences!

She pulled Star Wind to a dead crawl and closed her eyes to take a few deep breaths. She needed to go into this with at least a hopeful attitude if not a positive one. They'd make it through this, god they had to make it through this! It **had** to be worth it, all the suffering and skulking and lying and tears- it had to be worth something more than Glimmer losing someone else she loved.

And oh, what a terrible thought to have when she already felt like she was teetering on a ledge with no clear view of the ground. This would *not* be like it was with her father. Glimmer Moon was done losing people she loved and if she had to push the hurt down further then by god she would- she'd stop it. They'd stay together, and Catra wouldn't leave her, and it was all going to work out!

Glimmer could feel that she was about to start spinning her wheels again when she registered what she was seeing out front. It was like she'd been dunked in ice water. Every single emotion she'd been fighting for a damn year somehow both vanishing and compressing. Captain stood out front with his saddle on and loaded down.

Very loaded down.

Too loaded down.

Her heart thumped painfully and her mind went into autopilot. There had to be an explanation. There had to be, she just, she just needed to stay calm and not jump to conclusions! She'd barely gotten off Star Wind and tied her to the porch when Catra came out the front door with a pack stuffed to bursting.

The two stared at one another, Catra with a sort of resigned panic and Glimmer with her own mix of confusion and fear. After a moment Catra snorted and loaded the pack on, taking up every last bit of space and probably near every ounce Captain's back could take.

"What are you doing!?" Glimmer gasped, half fighting her instinct to just tackle the other woman right into the dirt and half in pain as she looked again at Captain. Too much. It was too much stuff to be a trip, an unannounced trip, an unannounced trip she was leaving on while she thought Glimmer was away. After the morning they'd had... It was a gut punch. All thoughts of a calm and rational talk flew straight out her head. Her fury mixed with pure terror. "Are you running away?"

Catra barked out an awful laugh, like a sick dog, nothing like her Catra. But she didn't turn to face her. "I'm setting things right."

Her hands were shaking. This wasn't happening. This couldn't happen! *If you'd just been kinder, if you'd been more understanding, if you'd been better this wouldn't be happening!* Glimmer was surprised how steady her voice was considering how it felt like she had a whole murder of crows tucked inside her ribs. "By running away? No, Catra that don't make one lick of sense! If you're nervous about the wedding we can-"

"It ain't that." Catra spoke so softly she could barely hear her. "Listen-"

No! No, this was some- some hair brained thing Catra came up with again! There was the smallest lick of anger at that. Like the whole summer she'd been horrified that Catra was actually trying to kill herself when she was actually trying to make Glimmer happy. She couldn't stand to listen to whatever poppycock was about to come out of her mouth, so Glimmer rushed forward instead. "No you listen to **me** , I don't know what this is about but we can fix this! We've stuck through thick and thin, we can solve whatever this is!"

"No. We really can't, I wish we could, but we can't." Catra sounded agitated, but finally turned around. Her voice was like stone grinding against itself and it was awful to realize she looked more like herself than she had in over a year.. "Glimmer, I *have* to go. I can't stay here with what I've done. I need you to understand, I've lie-"

No, no, no, no, no! It was like every worst nightmare she'd ever had rolled up into an awfully cheerful sunny afternoon. Catra was trying to leave. She was going to *leave her* . Glimmer couldn't even remember what she was supposed to say during the talk, this was no talk, this was talking someone back from the damned edge. "I know what you done, and I don't care! That ain't you anymore and-"

“Let me talk.”

Glimmer heard her, of course she heard her, but she couldn’t stop. The frustration and joy of the day morphing into panic as she tried to convince her to stay. Anything to make her stay with her, Glimmer could live without her! “-it’s silly to think that I would-”

“Listen to me!” Catra sounded furious. Furious in a way she hadn’t heard in years.

All it did was spur her on further. Every drop of emotion in her babbling forth from her mouth as she inched forwards. Glimmer wasn’t even fully sure what she was saying. Just that Catra was getting mad again, and in a way she preferred that if it meant they’d *talk* . B-because she- she couldn’t go, she couldn’t just leave after everything after all of this!

She didn’t let Catra speak, each time she tried, Glimmer blustered on further in her desperation. It no longer mattered how awful things had been. It no longer mattered that she was tired as hell. She willingly give up everything to keep this from falling to pieces. Her **heart** couldn't take it. So she pushed on, the way she always had. Reaffirming her love was always good, it was always good, it fixed things, it could fix this! Glimmer could save them and Catra would see and she’d understand and they’d talk and it would be fine! “-just, what, go and give up on you now? Like hell-”

But the funny thing of it was, Glimmer had never been in control of Catra. Never wanted to be in control of her. And this?

Well this wasn’t only about her.

Catra was turning shades, eyes watered up and breathing labored as she tried and tried to speak. Each time she was shut down, the shaking got worse, the twisting fury grew deeper instead of lighter. Until she damn near burst at the seams. “SHUT UP! SHUT UP YOU STUPID BITCH AND LISTEN TO ME!”

Catra had never yelled at her like that. She could have a mouth on her, and she’d shouted on occasion, but nothing like this.

Glimmer froze and stared. It was like seeing a demon come to life, the woman there was the one from the bank. Raging and wild and terrifying, red leather wings unfurled wide. Nothing she'd done had mattered. None of it helped. She was losing everything under the gentle beams of the sun.

" **Listen** to me!" Catra begged. "You don't understand, you **don't understand!** It was me. Glimmer, it was **me!** You understand? You're father- he- in Erlandia, I- it was supposed to be an insurance scam. That's why I burned it down, an insurance scam!! I swear! I checked before and made sure there weren't no one in there- I checked it twice, but that man? He just, God, he thought he heard screaming and ran into the barn. I told him not to Glimmer, I swear I told him not to go in 'cause I knew it was gonna fall any damn moment ***and he still went in*** ."

Catra gasped for air, staring her down with wild, wide eyes. Terrified. Waiting. And Glimmer...Glimmer was…

She didn't know.

There was no way to explain the mash of emotions, the intensity of the fire inside her as she processed the words. But they didn't make sense. It couldn't be true. She knew it was a scam that went wrong, that's what forced Catra out. But it...it couldn't be that. No. They, they said he'd been trapped inside. Catra wouldn't do that. Not her sweet, anxious Catra. Even back then when she'd been more monster than person, she was still herself. So it couldn't be true. She wanted to scream but her voice remained calm. "No, no that can't be."

"You can't just wish this away." Catra sobbed, roughly brushing tears off her cheeks. "You can't!"

No. No she couldn't, but this couldn't be right. Couldn't be. If it was then that meant this was the secret Catra had been hiding. The one she'd pushed Glimmer away over. The reason they'd been fighting for a damned year. She couldn't have known for a whole damned year and not said anything right? Sh-she couldn't kill

someone like that. Catra had told her about her past, why would she leave something like this... *unless she wanted to trick me, unless she wanted to hurt me.* But that didn't make sense, C-catra wouldn't do that. This was too big. No.

She was made of heat and dust and fire, an explosion turned into physical matter.

And this couldn't be real. This couldn't be true. Because if it was, if it was-

"No, it couldn't have been you, I refuse- you didn't even know him!" Glimmer's voice cracked the same time as her heart did.

Because *what if it was true.* The anger she'd felt that Catra could have just *known* her father's killer had almost ended them. This couldn't be right, god please! But it wasn't like anyone was there to save her either.

"He had two stripes of gray in his beard, framing his chin. Black hair tied in a bun on his head. About my height, broad shouldered." Catra said it slowly as she could, her voice was breathless as she trembled, "I didn't know who the hell he was, but I did get a look at him. He don't look nothing like that photo."

The daguerreotype on her mother's mantle was the only image of her father on the whole planet. He was sitting down wearing his best clothes, his face cleanly shaven to look good for the picture, his hair pulled back in a tight ponytail behind him making it look like he had short oiled hair. The limited focus made everything but his face a touch blurry. He wasn't smiling thanks to the exposure time, 40 seconds was a long time to hold a damn smile. He'd been young, very young. Glimmer wasn't even a spark in his eye when it was taken.

Catra was right, all her memories of him were not of the man in that photo. But the man she described, that sounded just like her father. A description detailed enough that they must have been standing close in the darkness, at least so that the flames had lit

him up, and Catra hadn't stopped him. Just told him not to go in. Catra hadn't stopped him from trying to rescue a phantom when she knew there was no one in there. What if- why wouldn't- even the angry young woman she'd first met, even *she* would've tried to stop an innocent person from rushing to their death.

Catra had been there. She had...and she could have **stopped him** and she didn't.

She's known. She held me while I was crying my eyes out because she KNEW SHE'D KILLED HIM. And she didn't tell me.

"...do you get it now? You-I, it isn't right. When you told me how he died, I was stretched thin, and I didn't want to, I wanted to not...well, but I couldn't keep this from you. I couldn't. I *tried* to, but I couldn't." Catra laughed ruefully, and it felt like knives stabbing into her heart. "That's why."

It was every red flag she'd ever seen popping into existence in a heartbeat. Every worry Adora had expressed and she'd denied. It was everything going so terribly wrong that it didn't even register. Not really. Not fully.

Not yet.

"You…" Every excuse she'd ever made on Catra's behalf, every chance, every kind word. Every ounce of love in her bones colliding with the pain of her father's death, like it was fresh all over again. All the suffering she'd gone through to try and comfort Catra. All the concessions they'd made to try and ease her worries, when this whole fucking time- "I don't…" Mixing. Awful. "...you killed him."

Tears fell freely down Catra's freckled cheeks, and Glimmer both wanted to soothe her and kill her for it. How dare she cry when she- her father was- he'd- and she KILLED HER FATHER.

"Yeah... I did. I d-didn't mean-"

"Shut up." Glimmer said it firmly but softly. She couldn't hear it, whatever excuse she'd been about to make. Whatever ***new lie*** she was about to spew forth to save herself. There was never a good reason to kill someone. Never. And Catra killed him. And then hid it, lies again, always more lies. She'd known, she'd known and she'd…? "You killed him."

Catra nodded miserably, as if she had any right to feel awful about a murder she'd committed over a decade before. It felt like she'd skipped a step, from deadly calm to almost murderous rage as the love of her life finally, *finally* told the truth. But only said anything at all because she'd meant to run away and avoid it forever.

How long, Glimmer could barely think as rage began to eat her up, how long would she have looked for Catra? Worried about her? Prayed for her to come home when this was the reason why.

And Catra's now quiet acceptance, as if she'd been willing to accept responsibility the whole time?

It was the last straw before her vision tunneled.

Glimmer lunged at her, fists flying as she screamed. It was unreal, like watching herself instead of being herself. Catra didn't do anything to protect herself either, just kept standing up and moving closer if a hit pushed her too far away. **It made her furious.** How could she be so calm? How could she act like a martyr when she was the CRIMINAL and not the victim? How could she have **done** this? The robber had been one thing, he'd been threatening to shoot Glimmer with deadly intent. She didn't like it, but it was self defense! Her father was not. He died in horrifying pain while trying to save someone's life!

Because of Catra. Because Catra let him go in. And now she'd hidden the truth, knowing who- and that was the gifts and the mood swings and Glimmer had been trying so FUCKING HARD- and Catra had tried to leave without a word.

And she'd killed her father!

Glimmer had never taken his death well, had been furious at her mother for being resigned, had tried to get justice seen to. It had been hard to do when she was fifteen years old. Impossible in fact, hell, she hadn't even been able to get the full story of what happened having to instead eavesdrop on her mother and aunt. Her fury and pain had overflowed, causing her to lash out at everyone with a kind intent towards her. It had never cooled since then. Never. She'd only gotten better at pushing it down, pretending it didn't hurt, managing the white hot rage when she thought about it for too long or something brought it up. Each time someone had warned her off Catra for her temper it had been hard to explain that she'd understood, because admitting to it would mean acknowledging it.

The nightmares had been intense, they came less frequently but never lightened. Her father, stepping out of a blaze with a smile. Half his face melted away in red and white and black to the bone. Fat boiling and his skin curled and crisped. " *What's wrong baby girl? Aren't you happy to see your old man?* " It didn't sound like him, more like a mockery of him. Deeper and crueler as he tried to pull her into the flames with him. *"Don't be like that darling, come into the light with me!"* They left her gasping and screaming at night; throwing up so often that she had a bucket by the bed. Sleep deprived and unwilling to mourn when his killer was free, Glimmer had started to plan her own trip to Erlandia. She'd been willing to do **anything** to see her father's death amount to more than just a tragedy.

Angella had read between the lines and had them move within a few short weeks, claiming it was for Glimmer's own good rather than admitting to running away like a coward. And Glimmer had spent years seething at night, trying to picture her father's killer. What she would say. What she would do. To pay them back for the pain they'd caused. To make them pay dearly for making her kind, sweet father burn. She'd pictured sneering men and women alike, cackling evil incarnate with no remorse for their actions. It had haunted her ever since to not know.

It was worse, far worse to find out they were a face so loved and so soft and so sorry.

It felt like forever but Glimmer knew it must have only been a few minutes at the most. Her heart racing and arms aching as she sobbed. Choking on her own words. “How dare you! You killed him! How could you? How could you!?”

“Glim, I’m...I'm so sorry. For everything.”

She had just enough energy to give one last punch, the way Catra’s head jerked to the side not nearly satisfying enough. There was a pause and Glimmer listened to her own ragged breathing, before finding the words. “Get out.”

“Oka-”

She shoved her hard as she could, watching Catra sprawl on the ground with a pained hiss.

“Get out! Get OUT! GET OUT!” Glimmer screamed, pulled at her hair, tried to get back inside her own skin. She needed space to just *breathe* . “I **HATE** YOU! I LOVED YOU!”

Catra opened her mouth, and closed it with a nod. Her face was already swelling and bruised up, a little blood dripping from her nose as she winced. Glimmer didn’t care. She couldn’t care. She did care.

And Glimmer watched her as she got up on Captain and got him moving.

She didn’t want Catra to go. She did! She wanted to kill that damned liar herself! She wanted to be held in that way only Catra knew how. She wanted to howl until the world shook. She wanted to beg her to come back. But she didn’t, she stayed silent and watched as Catra rode off without looking back.

She’d been tricked into giving a murderer everything she’d had. She’d give it all up again to make this right.

She waited until Catra was long gone. Till she couldn't see or hear her anymore and then Glimmer turned and numbly marched inside, but the contradictions didn't stop. Crowding in her mind until she slapped herself. The sun had dipped low while she stood there, hours had passed in that one eternal minute. Prioritize. What did she need? God she was lightheaded and her head throbbed. "Water." Decent enough place to start as any.

She'd made it into the kitchen and opened the cupboard only to see Catra's favorite glass up front. Newly washed just that morning while they'd laughed over some foolish joke.

Glimmer hurled it across the house, and the next, and the next. She found Catra everywhere. Clothes and linens and food and more. What she couldn't smash she threw in the back, all into one big pile. The feathers and rocks, and all the little gifts went in. Gifts, ha! More like **bribes** to try and **buy her love** . All of it! Anything with a *trace* went in. For all she stumbled, her hands were steady when she struck the match to light it up. She went to Star Wind's side to calm the old mare and she watched the blaze.

She didn't feel any better for it. The rage was so white hot that it left her calm while it ate her alive. Her mind was a whirlwind of too many thoughts to track. Until she realized just what she'd done.

Glimmer had let Catra just...leave. No consequences, just leave. She'd always said she'd get justice, and what did she do instead? So desperate for a chance to think, for the space to just think for a fucking second that she'd let Catra leave.

She'd go somewhere else and make a new life for herself. Just like she did here. She'd go somewhere new and settle in, maybe even fall in love with someone else. Live a good life.

It was **unacceptable** .

Catra didn't deserve to find a new life and a new home and a new happiness after she'd spilled blood and lied to them all for years,

she didn’t deserve a damn thing! She vaguely remembered turning towards Star Wind, watching her arms move but feeling them still at her sides with fists clenched. Too many arms and she couldn’t remember to breathe, and then she was nearly into town.

Adora’s face was shocked when Glimmer arrived late in the night, not even getting a word out before she’d shouldered her way into the jail.

“You said you’re struggling to find a deputy?” Glimmer asked, her mind buzzing in too many directions, but she knew for sure what she wanted. What she needed. What she should have done instead. Already knowing the answer from that afternoon she plowed forward. “I’ll do it. I want to be your deputy.”

Adora looked at her carefully, critically observing her red eyes and pale face. “Are you okay?”

“No. I want to be your deputy, what do I need to do? Is there paperwork or…?” She wasn’t gonna take no for an answer.

“Hang on, why are you really here? Where’s Catra?”

Glimmer bristled. She would not be associated with that-that monster! “Gone and good riddance! Will you take me on or not? I can always find another town.”

There was a long pause as Adora tried to parse through that, the shock on her face melting into a deep concern to an ice cold anger before nodding.She spoke a little too slowly, everything was too quick or too damned slow, “I can take you on.”

Glimmer nodded, eyes watering before she got a hold of herself. Adora wouldn’t ask, wouldn’t push unless Glimmer offered. She was the safest person to be with right then, the best person to be with right then. Not even her mother- oh god, her mother didn’t know yet. She was going to have to rip that old wound open again! She couldn’t do this alone. It hurt, but she couldn’t-no. No she **wouldn’t** . Her mother couldn’t know this, wrong as she’d

handled Micah’s death, she would be ruined if she learned about Ca-

There was a pause as Adora’s furrowed brow smoothed, eyes twisting in deep guilt. But when she spoke it was pure anger. “Where is she?”

Glimmer didn’t know what Adora must have assumed. Didn’t want to know. Just needed to right her mistake. “I don’t know. She’s gone.”

When Adora wrapped her up in a hug it was the best and worst thing that could have happened. It was strong and warm and protective. Her heartbeat sounded clear to Glimmer. But her arms were too hard and she was too tall, and as she whispered something into Glimmer’s hair there were no loving kisses. It was all wrong.

It was all so very wrong.

Chapter End Notes

Hey, congrats! We've made it through the big bad reveal, and are officially only 3 years off from chapter one! :D

Or D: depending on your point of view I suppose!

Also, happy half way point of the fic everyone.

Up Next: Catra has finally gotten something of a handle on her thinking and behavior, shame about the suicidal ideation.

(I am so, so sorry y'all it's still pain train hours for a while)

Chapter 13: Every Little Thing Is Reminding Me of You, Guess I'll Set Fire to My Whole Room

Chapter Summary

> Catra snorted, closing her fist around the watch and resting the cool metal on her forehead. Now she'd figured out how to survive the feelings and thoughts in her mind, learned how to listen to the good ones instead. No fire, but no fight either.
>
> Like the world's most pathetic ghost, too stupid to quit but too sad to move on.

Chapter Notes

> It's sad cat hours and that means a lot of self loathing, dysfunctional coping mechanisms, and suicidal ideation. We also finally see Erlandia from Catra's perspective, so that's fun.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I'm sorry D'riluth. You seem like a good woman, I just can't keep making excuses for basic mistakes. You understand?"

Catra stared at him, chest hollow, and nodded. She'd known it was coming, there was no way to avoid it. After all, she'd been forced the last couple years to live this moment over and over again, but she had been foolishly hopeful about this one. A numbers job, and she was damn proficient with accounting these days. It should've been a good position in a good town with a good boss. And it was. Had been. It was just...she caught herself looking over his shoulder at the calendar and had to refocus on his face.

Mister… God damn it all, what the hell was his name again? He'd told her. Plenty a times too, she'd managed to keep this job for a

almost a half year after all. She never could remember it though.

Oh well. Didn't matter much now. "No, no I understand sir. Thank you. For the opportunity."

He had a round face, large mustache, and kind black eyes. What in the world was his name? *George* . Catra managed to shake off the shiver trying to go up her back. No. Not George, they looked a little bit alike, sure, but he was not George Archer. She swallowed hard to keep from crying, no need to get a stranger wrapped up in all of that.

Even if his face was crinkled in sadness, his smile was genuine. It was too much. Scorpia's smile and George's face and Angella's thoughtfulness. How the hell had she lasted so long here? Recipe for a damn disaster. His voice was soft as could be even if there was a wet chuckle to it. "Hey now, I thought we was past the formalities."

"Sorry, just gonna have to remind me another time sir." Catra's smile was brittle in return, not that he noticed. It was almost funny actually. She'd finally managed to figure her damn self out and was worse off than ever, she just finally knew what masks to wear and words to say. "And, hey, don't worry about me. I always find my way."

He nodded, swallowing hard and clearly hopeful when he asked, "You gonna stay here, or nearby at least?"

Oh yeah, she'd never told him where she was staying. Not that *that* mattered anymore either. She'd finally broken down her little camp site this morning, took a bath at the inn the evening before knowing it would be the last one here.

Turned out, after so many years of living peacefully in the woods Catra couldn't really stand city life anymore. Not even in a sleepy town like this one, uh, the...it was called, hm. Ah well, least she knew which state she was in, and really that was what mattered right now anyhow. No map required, that was a nice plus.

"Naw, don't do well nowhere long term. Maybe I'll see you around." She accepted the small stack of bills, a severance pay she had no right to take for how much trouble she'd caused. But one she needed to take regardless. Not like she knew where she was gonna end up after this. Maybe nowhere. That sounded nice.

A large warm hand pulled her gaze back off the calendar, goodness gracious how long had she…? "A'right. Stay safe Catra."

She tried to smile, couldn't be sure it worked but oh well. Couldn't be helped with the time of year and all. He still didn't notice, and she stiffly walked away back to Captain who was fully loaded down after her shopping trip yesterday. He was a full mature adult these days, mellowed out from his youth but not the most loving of creatures. Or, well, he had been relatively sweet before. Maybe he missed it all too, maybe he was angry at her for it. Well, angry as a horse could get over something like that. Catra gave him a pat all the same and he nudged his nose up into her hand before dropping his head back down.

"Sorry buddy," Catra sighed before getting herself up into the saddle.

She carefully patted at her vest pocket where she'd stashed the bills, and on verifying that she hadn't dropped them at some point, something that happened depressingly often these days, she just needed to pick another direction. Couldn't hurt to go a little south west this time. Circle around and see what other fuck ups she could make. Maybe ruin a few more lives in some bid to keep moving forward.

Forward. Ha.

Glimmer would be so disappointed if she could see me moping. Catra shook her head slightly as she left whatever this little town was called. What was his name? Where the hell was she? She could have sworn on her life that her memory was too damn sharp most days, but she certainly couldn't do that no more. *No,*

she'd shoot you dead like you deserve. "Have ta find my damn head first."

Didn't matter she supposed, riding almost aimlessly along. Sitting in the quiet storm of her mind was quickly proving to be a might more than she was able to handle.

She counted trees and flowers, and when that was too much reverted to something easier than counting. *Tree, rock, scrub, dirt, rock, clouds, sky, sun.* Catra had gotten rather proficient at keeping her mind both blank and occupied. A decent enough combination when wandering like this. *Road, dirt, flower, road-split?* She pulled Captain to a stop and considered it. The main "road" was tiny and under used, not at all like the one she'd left on. So she must have taken a branch somewhere already. Why not another? A few soft clicks was enough to get them following the smaller path, more of a forgotten and unmaintained trail than anything else. Might as well.

Might as well.

Took her a while to notice Captain's ears were twisted back, and a quick glance confirmed his agitation with the erratic swishing of his tail. She looked up again and realized how long they'd been going, poor boy was probably tired and she hadn't meant to go this long without giving him a rest. She pulled them to the small patches of grass and got off him for a while, wasting time till they could ride safely again.

She was already aching a bit from the ride but too spent to do much besides sit next to her pack. God, she was tired too. She was exhausted. *Glimmer smiled, gently poking at Catra's cheek to tease her. "Funny how you might need to* ***rest*** *on occasion."*

Catra shivered, it felt like a thousand spiders going up her spine.

No. No sleeping. Sleeping was wasteful, took up too much time, never lasted long enough, never took her deep enough, always spat her back out, always meant nightmare after nightmare after-

"Poor little thing," Shadow Weaver sneered, "Frightened of fictions you made up." She whined, hunched down into herself and checked her watch with shaking hands. Been enough time, probably not long enough to be fully restful but enough to get by. So, she got them moving again and stared hard at Captain's head. Not that it quieted her voice at all. *"Well, good to know you treat your horses as well as you treat your people," Weaver sighed. "When you break this one, you'll have to put it down yourself, you ungrateful brat."* She was **not** doing this today.

She was **not doing this**!

"T-tree, pine tree. Juniper," Catra gritted her teeth together and forced herself not to just break down in tears over literally nothing. Nightmares were silly to be upset over and she had always done her best to treat her horses right. *Can't say that about people though can you?* "Juniper bushes. Lots of 'em. Butte. Uhm, m-mountains." Damn she probably went too far west first she'd have to correct and go more south at some point. She still kept on the trail as it turned closer towards the cliffside. "Boulders, rocks, uh, uhm, uh…"

"Well wouldn't it be nice if you could get your shit together, huh kid?" Grizzlor snickered as she tried to stand up again, happily kicking her back into the mud. "C'mon then, ain't got all day. Get up."

Why had she even fucking tried with the *stupid* fucking- no, no, no. Her damn head was already trying to kill her, no need to help it. *Could be nice.* Ha! Okay...okay. So that weren't working, okay. Try something else. Happy thoughts? Something better at least, something newer that could- could- maybe something w-with-

"Happy 'someday we'll get right in the eyes of our families and god but still aren't this year'!" Glimmer crowed, drunk off their shared bottle and leaving little fluttering kisses all over Catra's neck.

Funny, with how little she was able to track these days that she'd been able to remember this particular date without fail. Fourteen years since Glimmer rescued her out on that mesa. An anniversary Glimmer had insisted they celebrate, something to look forward to every year. She did always like a good party, even a quiet celebration could become lively with Glimmer Moon involved. That was the kind of person she was, looking for the good in things.

Hopefully she could celebrate Catra leaving instead. Hopefully she didn't remember what day it was today. It had been just under two years since Catra left, but she didn't want to think of Glimmer forced to think about her today. Two years. Jesus fucking Christ.

She was just so damn **tired**.

The day blurred a bit until Captain nickered softly, and suddenly she was finished setting up their temporary little camp for the night. A quick glance confirmed that she'd tied him close to the smallest trickle of water she'd ever seen but it was water and he weren't loaded with anything. Captain's ears and haunches twitched from the last few flies of the day as she watched him settle in. She didn't have the energy to help chase them off of him, and even if she didn't wouldn't make a difference right now. Summer was almost over, they'd leave him be soon enough. He was all she had left really, well, him and the watch. Everything she'd taken with her had become too painful to keep and her inability to stay employed meant it was simple (not easy, lord no, it hadn't been easy) to sell them piece by piece. The nice clothes, the books, and more.

But Captain was his own horse (Ha! Adora was finally rubbing off on her). And the pocket watch was just a watch, but it was sentimental she supposed.

"Catra," Angella called, "come over here."

She could tell something was up, Mrs. Moon hadn't sounded that detached and cool in a while. So she went quickly. "Yes ma'am?"

"Do you know what today is?" She asked, fingers resting expectantly on one of her desk drawers.

"Uhm, Thursday the twentieth I think."

Angella chuckled, smiling soft to one side as she opened the drawer. "You aren't wrong, but I meant more generally. Do you know how long you've been working for me, I suppose is the better question."

Her brain ground to a halt at that. How long had it been?

"Ten years," Angella said, finally taking pity on her, "to the day. Thank you for that. You've managed to take Bright Moon Rail from good to exceptional. Our efficiency has only gone up since you started working with me directly, and our accidents have gone down. Congratulations."

She pulled a small silver pocket watch from the drawer, holding it out to her with a grin. "Here's to another ten I hope."

The watch felt like a lead weight in her vest pocket. She couldn't get rid of it though, no matter how much money it would've fetched her. It was the only proof she had that she'd done right for once in her life. That at one time she had been an asset and done the right thing. When her thoughts went too blank she often found herself reading the simple inscription, just the date she'd started at BMR over and over. She carefully oiled it, winding it up diligently everyday. Taking better care of it than herself sometimes.

Tonight was no different in that regard. And when finished she flipped it over and started reading. The date brought her little comfort though.

And worse...It was a full moon out.

Her throat closed up and nose stung. " *If I'd known just how weak you are, I'd have left you at that cursed cabin."* She really needed to stop being such a worthless waste of air. *Who are you*

kidding, you'll never be anything better. She took a slow deep breath, only to choke on half a sob as she let it out. " *I am so tired of you trying to manipulate me with theatrics!"* No need for that. She was a'right, and she was going to be alright. Just had to make it through the night. One foot in front of the other. " *Do us all a favor next time, get it done right or don't come back."* All she could really do was her best, she couldn't control what she couldn't control.

Glimmer pouted as Catra whispered, "Darlin' you can only do what you can do."

This was already shaping up to be a terrible night, which she'd at least expected, but the full moon was just there to make it all that much worse. God, she'd kill for a fucking drink, too bad she couldn't afford none these days. No drinking, nothing to help it mellow and pass. *Maybe something else could help.* Yeah. Maybe she could just...stay here. Long term like. Catra looked around, squinting in the dark, trying to remember what this spot looked like in the light. Couple trees, some scrub brush, she'd liked how red the rocks were. Large red cliffs just jutting out of the earth like someone splashed blood all over them. It was a nice big marker. Easy to see and find. Fitting. She turned her gaze back to her watch. She could just stay here and make life easier for everyone, couldn't she?

"You get right back here, you belong here with me," Glimmer said so softly, thumbs rubbing circles on her knuckles and she softly pulled Catra back to reality. "Justy stay here, where you belong."

But she didn't belong nowhere. She never had. She'd been living on borrowed time from a dead man, and she'd never had the right to be where she was. Just one more thing she'd stolen. One more thing she'd broken. *"Catra, please don't go...stay."*

"Okay," she huffed to the memory, wiping at her eyes. "Okay. After breakfast we'll see. Make a decision then."

One foot in front of the other.

She knew she needed to find a reason for it, some sort of goal. But good god that sounded hellish and foolish.

She'd considered going back, back to Erlandia and turning herself in. The bounty was probably still good and active after all, so showing up and surrendering would see it through. Truly set things right. But the fear that they wouldn't take her to the gallows had been enough to make her leave well enough alone. The thought of being trapped in a small cage for the rest of her life was worse than anything else. She remembered the stories from Grizzlor about what prison was like. The tortures he'd faced, the things he'd seen...no, no she wasn't about to risk that. So after leaving that sunny afternoon, Catra had taken a hard look at the fork in the road, knowing that right would mean getting justice served and left would mean nothing at all.

She went left.

How *very typical* of her.

First just a county over, then another, then a state border, then another, even passed quietly into Horde territory. Almost went looking for them but instead she'd ridden straight through. She'd gone too far east though, circled back when she realized how different everything looked that far away. Then she went too far north. Never been so cold in her whole damn life as that first winter in the north, so Catra had turned and gone just far enough south to feel her fingers again. Puttering around until now. South west it was, not too far though, no sense getting anywhere close to the Moons again. She was pretty sure too far thataway would land her right back in Etheria. Hell, she didn't even want to be where BMR's rails ended, just to be safe. What if Angella showed up and had to see her? She could only picture how hurt and angry Mrs. Moon would be to be forced to see her husband's killer again. She couldn't do that. Didn't want to hurt her like that.

But Catra really didn't want to see the look on her face neither. *Coward.*

It was like before the Moons. Worse because at least then she'd had a fire in her. Now? Catra snorted, closing her fist around the watch and resting the cool metal on her forehead. Now she'd figured out how to survive the feelings and thoughts in her mind, learned how to listen to the good ones instead. No fire, but no fight either.

Like the world's most pathetic ghost, too stupid to quit but too sad to move on.

"Wonder that anyone puts up with you, God knows I don't know how I've done it all these years." Catra scowled at her feet, that old hag would never shut up would she? Hadn't even been able to stop flapping her lips when...when…

Well, that had been the absolute **worst** thing she could've picked.

Weaver stopped struggling, green eyes cutting through her like a razor blade. "You'll regret this. This will be the end of you, child. Start that blaze and I will strike you down."

Catra dumped the last of the oil directly on her face for that. Hands shaking with fear and excitement and loathing, but she knew her face would look delighted. She'd perfected that a long time ago. She pulled the rags out of her belt, stuffing Weaver's mouth to silence her. "You know? I don't think I will." An armful of burlap sacks, soaked through with grease went on top. Not enough to suffocate though, that would do. Catra had been under bags before, hers soaked with water. Not enough to actually die, just enough to feel like you were. She'd thought about drowning the witch in the river, but ever since Shadow Weaver's near brush with a fiery end, the woman had a fear of flame.

That would make this much, much worse. And she deserved it! Didn't she? Of course. Of course.

Besides, she'd spent far too long setting this all up to chicken out now.

Catra moved the palette of empty barrels over the pit she'd dug and carefully set her long fuse and severely underpowered dynamite down nearby, not close enough to end it too quickly for the witch though. The whole barn was rigged to burn hot and fast and completely. Weaver had no chance between the flame and the smoke. Hell, the smoke would probably get her before the heat did. Or maybe the lack of air? Fire needed plenty of that.

Catra shook her head and rolled out her fuse until she herself was safe from the blast. Her hands barely worked, shaking so badly like that, but the fuse lit on the fourth try.

She watched the blaze with mixed emotions, more good than bad. She should have left, but she needed to watch. To make sure. Could barely see it through the tears, barely heard it through the ringing. She had to make ***sure*** *.*

"There's somebody in there!" A man cried, dropping his bag and rushing forward, the blaze lighting him up. Pausing only as one of Shadow Weaver's wails of pain cut through the night. Catra stared at him dumbfounded for a moment before he started forward again. Oh hell!

Shit, this was not what she needed right now. "Don't do it! That's gonna come down right quick!"

"No, you don't understand I-" He looked at her for one moment, his face cast in perfect light, "I think...I think I know her, and I can save her!"

Catra's blood had run cold. There was no way in hell he knew. No one had seen them even come into town! But as she pulled her jaw up off the floor, Catra realized there were several people staring at her. A few of them were also *running towards her. No, fuck no! This was supposed to be easy!*

So she ran.

And wasn't that an awful thought? What if he **had** known who was in there? Micah Moon had no dealings with the Horde, so

maybe he'd never known and just thought he did? Who could even hear over the roar of the fire? Or maybe that had just been her own rushing blood, she'd heard a scream after all. Catra wasn't sure if that would make it better or worse to be honest. Had she killed a man, brave and mistaken and foolish? Or had she killed someone who had actually *cared* about Weaver, with some hidden past? Her breath caught in her throat as she forced the dizzying wave of panic down. Didn't matter anyways. Not like either of them was alive to explain it to her.

Not like there was anyone left who could confirm or deny it without killing Catra right afterwards.

Ha. *Start that blaze, and I will strike you down.* Now that was funny. *You'll regret this.* Yeah, she did. Even when she'd been minutes from death, Shadow Weaver always needed to have the last word didn't she?

"Guess it really was a curse," Catra laughed mirthlessly, for one beautiful moment caught in a good memory.

"A witch?! What, is she gonna, like, curse ya? Hex ya? Oh this is ***bad*** *Wildcat!" Scorpia nervously tapped her shiny new hooks together, wide eyed as she looked around. Like Weaver would be right here.*

"What? Why would you- you know what? I don't care, not the point. The point is, what do you do with a witch?" Catra waited until Scorpia shrugged her shoulders. "It's traditional, ya see, to burn them alive."

There was another pause, but this time Scorpia's nervousness finally disappeared. Melted into an absolutely vicious smile most folk would never guess she was capable of. "Brilliant and beautiful."

What even happened to Scorpia? Catra frowned, tucked the watch away as she lay back and looked up into the night sky. She hadn't had the chance to find out. After Erlandia, Catra had laid low for a

few days, not wanting to bring anyone back to base. Hordak had been pissed enough with her horse shit that she knew one more screw up wouldn't end well for her. He'd told her himself, after all.

This time it was just reminiscing, which was really lovely in it's own right.

The poor bastard had tried to scream, but only gurgling came out. His broken ribs poked through his skin. His body was held in the air by the rope around his wrists. Like most everyone else, Catra had watched in silence as he was prepped for this. Like almost no one else, she was still watching his last dying gasps instead of celebrating. It was bound to get her attention she didn't want, but she couldn't seem to stop. And sure enough two large hands almost slammed down on her shoulders.

Hordak's grip was like an iron vice, and twice as cold. She could feel the tackiness of the blood still on his fingers against her neck.

"Beautiful work as always sir." Catra kept her voice as neutral as she could. It hadn't been within her control when that train robbery got bungled, but she had been in charge so the blame fell on her anyways.

"Is it?" He whispered, far too close to her ear for comfort. "I'm glad you think so. These are the red wings we fight for after all."

"Praise the Horde." Catra responded, automatic. No energy to them.

His grip got tighter. "Praise indeed, there is no place in our more perfect world for failures. Don't you agree?"

She swallowed thickly, trying not to scowl when she started shaking. He could feel it, the bastard did this specifically to lord it over her. "Yes sir."

He chuckled, almost affectionately as he gently shook her back and forth. Like he was a fond father with a beloved daughter. "Ensure that you do not need them as well."

"Yes sir, I will."

No. She had refused to let herself end up on the wrong side of Hordak's justice, not when half the camp would be cheering him on. So she'd waited, came up with a few stories she could tell about Shadow Weaver, and finally made it to a train station to make her way home. She was sitting on the bench, hat pulled low, when she saw the Marshall waltz in and start plastering up new wanted posters. At the time she thought nothing more about it than maybe taking one on to add more to her stash. Then she'd realized whose face was on it.

Her own poorly rendered features looked back out at her, the description too far away to see. But there at the bottom, a $750 Reward. She knew if the posters were out this far, that Hordak would have seen them for sure. So she waited till he left and actually ran away like she'd swore to herself she wouldn't.

Always running from something.

She blinked slowly and turned her head from the sky to the cliff wall again. Blood red. It would be fitting though wouldn't it? Cut Captain loose. She could even build herself a little shelter to protect her body afterwards. Trail was almost non-existent out here anyways. It would be easy. She could even make it painless.

Catra looked back up into the sky, staring at the woman on the moon and counting the pearls on her necklace over and over. Glimmer never liked pearls much, least not in a necklace like that. She smiled softly. Glimmer was more of a pearl earring girl, it was classy looking on her. Timeless. She counted them one more time before letting her tense body relax. No point in being dramatic about life like this, at the very least Glimmer would be pissed as hell if Catra was found in some shrine like she mattered. It was kind of a funny visual. Glimmer scowling and stomping, waving a hand at her heat dried corpse spitting one last, 'Damn you D'riluth!'

She snickered, one hand rubbing over her eyes. God she didn't want to sleep. But she hadn't in a few days, and it was better to do here in the wild where no one would startle when she woke up screaming than in the saddle. She'd only needed to fall the one time with Tao to decide she never wanted to do that again.

Maybe you could snap your neck, right angle and all. From sleep to Sleep.

"That's too much effort and hope on chance," Catra grumbled. Even her own mind hated her enough to be obnoxious. "Next month. I'll do it next month. Promise."

She wouldn't.

It was still nice to pretend there was something good coming. That the light at the end of the tunnel was an escape and not a damn train engine.

In the end, she didn't sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> Don't forget to check out the amazing fan art for this fic! Nessie-The-Longneck-Monster sent me a fantastic piece recently and I've got it linked at the bottom :D

Chapter 14: Trust My Lonely

Chapter Summary

> Deputy Moon has certainly been working hard. To do both her jobs, to help the town, and most importantly to catch a no good killer.
>
> Shame that no one else seems to appreciate the efforts!

Chapter Notes

> As always a shout out to Dragonesdepapel for beta reading and dealing with me gripping about this chapter for, like, months.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It wasn't an instant process to get deputized. Not only was there the paperwork Adora signed and submitted, there was also her current job which needed adjusting, and , the most time consuming part, dealing with her mother.

Glimmer almost found it funny, she'd been vague about Catra's departure to spare her mother's feelings, and then she'd become insufferable and ignored *Glimmer's* feelings. It felt like being sent over a decade into the past, their relationship had begun to fizz and snap as they circled one another over and over once again. She hated it! One more thing Catra had to go and ruin for her, and if her mother would just listen for once they wouldn't even be in this predicament. One moment they would be tense and ignoring the past, the next fighting over what happened, and the next her mother begging her to let it go.

So what if she wouldn't let the fire burn out, she was perfectly fine! She didn't need nor want to "let it go"!

"You are clearly not alright, considering the post you are trying to take after she left, and I think I deserve to know what happened!"

Angella had half shouted, no longer caring that they were arguing outside the jail house. She'd never once allowed their arguments to spill into the public eye before and it was even more frustrating for it. Another tick on the invisible list she was keeping.

"Well this will certainly help make things right won't it? Let's just hash everything out in the open! And you know what you need to know. I don't want to go through it all a second time!" Half truths and half lies that burned fully under her skin.

That was truly the most difficult part of this whole- whole-

"It's okay to grieve someone who's still alive," Bow held her tight as they lay together on the floor of his father's home.

She'd always had a second home with the Archer's, practically growing up beside Bow and the rest of his siblings when her mother's hours ran too long. They'd spent so many days like this, that it was at once soothing beyond reason and heartbreaking to need it again. She curled up tighter against his chest, pressing her forehead into his neck like it would do anything.

"I'm not ***grieving*** *her. I will* never *grieve for that- for that-" You'd think eventually a person could run out of tears. Glimmer was a crier, sure. When she was sad or angry or even happy, tears were just part and parcel, but god she was sick of crying and you'd think you'd just run out eventually.*

Bow held her tighter as he placed soft kisses into her hair. "Okay. You don't have to, but it's okay if you do. It's not about forgiving someone, it's about letting yourself heal."

But healing meant letting it go.

She refused.

The memory dislodged and feelings that came with it easily discarded. The worst part of this whole DEBACLE was the way she found herself shifting between sad, furious, upset, inconsolable, and numb. So moments like that, where she half lied to the

people she cared about *hurt,* because that was part of why she'd been so mad with **her** . It was different, she reminded herself, this was different. Catra had lied to protect herself, and Glimmer was doing it to protect others. It was different damn it!

"Glimmer, listen to me!" Her mother demanded, but Glimmer was done giving up everything for everyone else.

She had almost literally plugged her ears before storming off, and her mother only somewhat relaxed when she threatened to just quit BMR all together. They couldn't afford to lose another part of that machine, so even though it was low of her, it worked like a charm. So it didn't matter if their chatting fell silent and interactions cooled. Work wasn't about making friends and feeling happy, she was there to make a living independently and to help her mother. And these were her damned terms.

She hadn't set boundaries with Catra, hadn't laid down the law so to speak, and look what came of it.

Glimmer had expected that to be the last of it, but the questions never stopped and the rumors spread more and more. As she followed alongside Adora, apparently Glimmer was the only damn lawman who was going to get training before being allowed on, she grit her teeth and was forced to listen. Tall tales about which of them had been cheating on the other, finances because clearly the rail was failing- all sorts of poppycock, but the one that bothered her the most was whispering that she'd actually killed Catra and buried her in the woods.

If only she'd been so damned lucky!

Of course as the time passed by her initial desire to use her gun alone cooled, and instead her desire to bring Catra to Erlandia grew. Not that anyone seemed to notice how she had handled her emotions or the changes taking place in her heart. Which was also upsetting considering how they all seemed to think she was one bad day away from a complete breakdown. In the last year she'd had more people look at her like a poor starving child than as a

woman doing just fine. Like, after so many years wasted together, that Glimmer could only have her measure taken if it was against Catra in some way.

"You just seemed so happy," Perfuma had sighed during the fall cotillion, and Glimmer worked hard to not crush the woman's hand as they danced. "I'm just sorry it ended so poorly, but maybe she'll come back some day!"

Frosta had stuck insufferably close to her the whole night of her eighteenth birthday with rapid fire questions. "Did you throw her out? Can you show me how to shoot a gun? D'ya think she was kidnapped? Is that why you got deputized? To rescue her? Can I come with you!?"

Hell, even Bow had gotten in on that action. Where at first he'd been a comfort helping her out where no one else could, his care was like a sweet wine left alone too long until it turned to vinegar. His hugs became smothering, his love acidic, and his advice like kumpur covered in glass.

"I wouldn't worry about her," Bow said, sagely as he nodded his head. The two were on their first ride together in years and Glimmer had foolishly been looking forward to it. "She'll be fine and you'll find someone else. Love is built!"

And worse, as the second year passed sedately by, he'd certainly changed his damn tone! If dealing with her mother was frustrating, have Bow turn on her was worse.

*"You're shutting us out Glimmer, you're shutting **me** out! I'm just...Glimmer I'm worried about you. You're just- I don't know, you've changed and not for the better. Please, I'm your friend. Let me help you." Even though his eyes had watered, Bow stood tall and strong with shoulders squared. Like he already knew the answer, like he expected she was going to be a loose canon when she had a damn plan.*

*Trust them, ha! They needed to **trust** her first!*

But worst of all she knew what he was really asking. He just wanted her to say what happened with that no good, awful woman! Glimmer had told him she didn't want to talk about it and now he was trying to back door the topic by pretending to be oh so concerned about her. Well, it was ridiculous! Glimmer hadn't changed, not one lick! Her often put on pleasant veneer was just stripped a bit and if folks couldn't accept that, then fine. Fine!

Almost another year past that argument, and the two of them practically weren't talking either. Bow slowly became more distant no matter what she did. Yet another mark against Catra, stealing her best friend from under her and not even here to reap the rewards of her labor.

Adora, once annoying for her hovering and disapproval of their relationship, became a bastion in the storm. Sometimes she looked at Glimmer with big sad eyes, but she'd never once asked or talked about it. The occasional, "You okay?" more than enough to tide them over. Even if she wanted to know more, help more, do more she understood it weren't her place and that made her friendship pure gold.

Certainly made it a lot easier for Glimmer to throw herself into her duties when it was the one place she could be free from it all.

Which, currently, was how she found herself picking up trash on the main road. Broken glass, cigarette butts, and more had built up over the spring and it turned out being a Deputy wasn't very glamorous. If not for her job with the rail, Glimmer wouldn't even make enough to survive. Adora herself was salaried, apparently a rare thing, but even she helped old Madam Razz out on her ranch on and off throughout the year to supplement it.

Adora had laughed when Glimmer asked why it wasn't better pay, she'd been hurt at the time only 'cause she'd thought she'd have more time to dedicate to the hunt. " *The long arm of the law is about righteousness and justice, if it were about money, who knows what deviants would sign on? Can't have that. Bunch of thugs with the law on their side, no ma'am I don't think so.* "

Glimmer, unsure how to broach the way many towns **preferred** to have outlaws running them due to the law being nothing but a pack of bullies, had awkwardly nodded and decided it was best to never be brought up again. Arguing with Adora was like willing the sun to set in the east and that girl wasn't ready to hear something like that. But, answer received, Glimmer knuckled down at *both* of her jobs to make the damn time.

She spent most evenings at the empty office alone for as long as the anger would allow, crunched numbers at home at night until she was practically passed out at the table, swept streets in the day in between glugs of overly bitter tea, and made a shocking number of arrests for drunken behavior at the inn. That last one at least was actually entertaining, not for the drunkards, no. But for another field of mines waiting for her to step funny.

Double Trouble, the big wig themself, had a shrewd business sense after helping to keep this town growing once the Moon Boom (and *that* was such a ridiculous name) was finished. They was always able to find a new way to make a buck and more than happy to spend it as well. The way they encouraged it only strengthened their town's economy, and their personality certainly kept them revolving in everyone's good graces. She specifically enjoyed their quick wit, that could be actually fun until it came to slice back at her. For instance, when asked what these highly intoxicated folks had been doing naked and alone with their employees, they'd answered without hesitation, "Oh they're seamstresses dear. Same day work, but clients often don't think to bring another set of clothes! How embarrassing for them! But a little libation and they relax enough for us to get the work done. Oh well. Hm, but perhaps you'd like to try it out some day? I'm sure I could get a vest fitted to you in no time darling."

Glimmer was suitably impressed and made sure to stay on their good side after that, after all she didn't know anyone else who could so successfully flirt with you by threatening you.

Regardless, no matter what the reason was, Glimmer was always hard at work. Her trial period on the job came and went in the

blink of an eye, and on finally getting Deputized she'd even posed for a tintype. Standing still as could be, white knuckling her rifle as she posed. She'd been sweating under her kerchief and despite how small the badge really was, it weighed her down that whole day. Which had been infuriating in its own right! She'd worked hard to get where she was, and it should've been a big accomplishment. Something to celebrate and be happy about!

Not much worth celebrating these days though, and getting the badge didn't exactly open up leads.

And Catra was still at large and living free somewhere. Sometimes, alone in the office she'd catch herself wondering what Catra had actually *done* all those late nights she'd pulled. Which, inevitably, made her wonder what she was doing now. Probably locked her lips up tighter than she'd done here, but surely settling somewhere happily enough. It ached to think of, so she let the burn take over as she did her damndest.

Double Trouble had been delighted when she'd approached them for help, their little network stretched far and wide after all. And even though they didn't advertise all their services, well, she'd put two and two together easily enough. Their smile had been sharper than glass as they shifted on their feet, and Glimmer did an admirable job of not screaming when she realized they were holding themself the way Catra always had. Hell, put a hat on 'em and at a small distance the two coulda been confused for one another.

"Of course, I can help you look...for a price of course. Times *are* hard after all."

Glimmer had shifted further back, unnerved as they almost sounded like her too. "You gonna start up a damn theatre or give me a price?"

Double Trouble had simpered, dropping the act, "You're no fun you know? Fine, let's talk money darling."

And sure, the network *had* found things. Catra's old work clothes, with her initials still stitched in 'em had been found outside a small village half buried in the dirt. There was a town she'd been hired to work at before getting fired for negligence on the job (which didn't seem much like her a'tall so Glimmer was rather suspect of that one). Another town had someone who remembered seeing her for a few months before she'd suddenly left. According to Double Trouble, over the last three years Catra had practically been a wandering nomad without any sort of rhyme or reason to her path.

Made enough sense, she'd met her while she'd been wandering after- So, she was probably just trying to lay low before trying again!

"Like I can take another day of just- just sitting on my damn ass!" Catra half growled through the last of her tears. Frustrated after being bed ridden for too long. Glimmer had cradled her head close to her chest to drop kisses anywhere she could reach, letting her fiancé ride out the frustration.

Glimmer gritted her teeth as she swept a bit harder than necessary. Had to be. She **had** to be laying low. Didn't make sense otherwise. Right? Right! Probably planned out a whole winding route and timed how long she stayed in each place. Catra did like her plans and her schemes after all. Probably tracked it all in her damn head. If only she could figure out what Catra was trying to do, Glimmer could crack the case wide open; but no patterns had emerged.

About the only good news they'd been able to give her was that Catra wasn't going more than a month's ride away by horse, or a few days by train from each place she'd been last. Double Trouble's "friends" even tracked her back to Horde territory before looping back in. Glimmer had held that particular report in shaking hands. Swallowing back bile at the thought of her going back (*what would they do to her?*) and holding back fire knowing she'd just become an outlaw again (*what would she do* for *them?)* . Then she'd been spotted leaving again within a few days, so

quickly that she got both bits of information at the same time. It just...didn't make sense.

It was infuriating and chaotic to say the least.

Last word she'd gotten was that Catra had circled round again and was creeping closer to Etheria again. Good, make it easier for her to catch up.

Glimmer viciously swept up a few bits of broken glass with a glower, happily kicking a crushed tin in behind them, very much unaware of the world around her. "Do us all a damn favor and get closer D'riluth."

"There you are!"

Glimmer jumped as her mother called to her, equally frustrated and scared each time they were together, but boy howdy did she find the strangest ways and places to pop into existence! Especially considering she'd only decided to do this grunt work since her mom was *supposed* to be a town over doing a walkabout. Hell, she'd probably said that just to lure Glimmer out!

Because, out of every single well meaning idiot who tried to soothe her soul, her mother was the most persistent of the bunch. She'd given time the first few weeks before forcing her way through.

"Glimma, what happened? Adora was just by and said-"

Oh she did her best to not growl about that, she'd known Adora would probably approach Angella after all. "Not much to say."

"Not much to- Glimmer! Your fiancé just went missing and-"

Oh that burned like a bitch. "Ain't my damn fiancé, not no more. She's gone and good riddance!"

Angella stared at her like she was a stranger, slowly sinking into her chair before asking again, this time her voice choked thick

with emotion, "Glimmer...what happened between you two?"

And the temptation was there. To tell her the truth. Admit what she'd learned. Maybe it would even help widen her net of resources, she'd already asked Lonnie to keep an eye and ear out but if she was heading the company maybe...but no. No. She couldn't, she really couldn't tell her. Not yet, it would break her heart and worse, she'd be so disappointed at Glimmer's colossal fuck up. She'd be so very disappointed that her daughter had loved her husband's killer.

But she'd already lied her way here, and speaking up meant also showing her hand before it was ready. Once Catra was arrested or dead, everything would be different. She'd tell everyone then, they'd understand it.

"...nothing you need worry about. Just- it's over, okay? It's over for good."

Glimmer straightened up with as much of a grin as she could manage, tilting her hat just so. Didn't hurt to put on a bit of a show these days. "Thought you were over at Mystacor?"

Angella grimaced, hands neatly folding across her stomach as she nodded. "Yes, I was. But I went over as early as I could, first train there and back."

Glimmer didn't roll her eyes through a supreme effort of will. Probably planned this to corner her in public seeing as she refused to go over for supper any more. When each meal became an interrogation or a pain in the ass from formality she'd given up the ghost. Another casualty to the whole situation she supposed.

"Your aunt is, as always...well, herself." Angella cleared her throat awkwardly.

She did her best not to wince. Here she was assuming the worst when she damn well knew better. Castaspella was a lovely person, who cared about them both deeply. They were all she had left after all. Her excitement over the wedding planning had shifted

into frustration and worry thick enough to make the normally energetic woman a lightning bolt in a bottle. Anxiously fretting about this and that, and anything in between without leaving anyone the space to shut her down or shut her up. And that alone made it impossible for Glimmer to make what used to be an annual trip out.

"What do you mean?" Castapella had gasped, one hand clutched dramatically over her chest. "I just finished that girl's sweater!"

"Yes, well-" Angella had tried to shift the conversation along.

Glimmer wasn't having it.

"Burn it." They both turned to stare at her and Glimmer roughly pushed back from the table.

"Pardon?" This time there was no theatrics, which meant that Castaspella ***finally*** *understood that this wasn't some cute little game.*

"I said, burn it. She didn't deserve it. Or, I don't know, unravel it. Whichever you prefer. More tea?"

That had been a right mess of an afternoon as Aunt Casta had pushed harder and harder until Glimmer had stormed off. Neither followed knowing the passenger trains were done for the day, and somehow neither of them thought that she'd simply hop on the next freight going through, tickets be damned. When Casta's letters became too pushy she'd stopped reading them too.

What the hell was she supposed to say? " *Oh sorry, the woman you both loved like a daughter? Well, turns out she is a bloodthirsty Hordesman. Oh, and she killed dad, so there's that. Don't worry she said it wasn't on purpose! "*

Right.

"She said she hadn't heard back from you in over a year. You are still getting her letters, are you not? She was very worried about

you."

Ah. Well, between the options of 'you are upsetting your aunt' and 'what happened with Catra', she'd take talking about her family, thank you very much.

"I am. If she'd like to write me something that *ain't* about everything that happened three years past, I'd be happy to respond."

"Glimmer Moon, don't you lie to me young lady. She wasn't even writing about Catra, she was asking about the lunar eclipse." Angella's tone was clipped and she stood up straighter, because she didn't already loom nearly two feet taller than her apparently!

Glimmer violently swept up the town's trash into her sack to buy a little time, trying to focus on the sound the glass made as it hit the rusting can she'd found (*"You think I'd come back empty handed? My princess only gets the best used tins of Albert I cain find!"*). Good way to bleed off a little frustration and good lord did she need to burn that off. "Must've slipped my mind, got a lot going on these days and I can see it from here if'n I want to."

Angella glanced about before grabbing Glimmer's arm and physically hauling her between a few buildings. Glimmer was so shocked by it that she didn't even resist. The last time that had happened was when Angella had forced them both out here, dragging her onto the train like an unruly dog.

"Alright, I've had it up to here missy." Her mother frowned as she glared down at her. "I lied. Castaspella did nothing of the sort, and now I know you've been lying to me. Why are you shutting me out?"

"Are you serious!?" Glimmer huffed and made sure to take a step back to get a little space. "You really want to do this here where anyone can hear it?"

"No, I don't, but I think you want it even less. How unfortunate that you won't even talk to me anymore if I don't catch you

outside! If you would be so kind as to come home with me we could-"

"If it ain't an emergency, no can do. I have a job to protect this town and-"

"Oh yes! Saving us all from the ravages of a dirty street!"

"It is part of my job and I am NOT going to ignore it just 'cause it ain't glamorous!"

"I don't think the main road has ever looked this clean, and I think I **deserve** an explanation-"

Glimmer's blood was boiling. "And here we go! Always goes back to *her* doesn't it?"

"...No! It's not! **Why** do you keep bringing it back to Catra?! Blast it all, I want to know why you've been lying to *your own mother* while playing keep away and more! Is there something about whatever happened, god knows I don't know that story, that you want to tell me? Because I am all ears if it would help you talk to me again!"

She was always bringing it back to Catra? Ha! Glimmer wasn't doing nothing of the sort! Angella kept bringing it back up and around! Bow kept bringing it back! Everyone kept pivoting back to one afternoon and she was sick of it! Sick and fucking tired of it. And this? This was a very old argument and all it did was convince her further that it was a good thing her mother knew nothing. If her mother was going to fixate on Catra like this and beat the dead horse, then Glimmer certainly didn't need to share anything. "I ain't gotta tell you nothing!"

Angella clenched her jaw before she shouted, "About this or her? You know what? Fine. You don't trust me anymore, for reasons you won't explain but then you go and drag all that back up every time- and I think you are forgetting that we got hurt too. You aren't the only one who cared about her! She *hurt* you, I understand that much, but I think I-"

“WELL IT ISN’T ABOUT YOU!” Glimmer white knuckled her broom.

It was a terrifying flash of wanting to swing it like a weapon, or snap it over her knee. And Glimmer hated it, because she’d never felt like this before. One more thing she could trace directly to Catra and her childish outbursts! *That ain’t right, you know that ain’t what happened.* Absolutely was, had to be from that. Regardless of origin, she tried to slowly take a few deep breaths to calm down. Physically assaulting her own damned mother was not something she wanted.

There was a beat of silence before Angella stepped forward to squeeze her shoulder. Her tone was much softer, which was somehow worse. “I am trying to understand. I try and *try* to reach you, to trust you to tell-”

Glimmer barked out a sarcastic laugh before ripping her mother’s hand off of her. “Oh, you want to talk about trust? Now? After all the years you’ve spent hiding the truth about dad- after all the years you spent refusing to let me take on responsibility? Seems like you only want ‘trust’ when you want it!”

“I…” Angella’s face crumpled as she took a step back.

She scoffed, “I told you I didn’t want to talk about any of this because I trusted you to care about me, but it seems like you care about *her* more! You NEVER talk to me for anything else anymore!”

“I have **tried** to, Glimmer I have tried, but this is eating you alive...it’s changing you darling. I am your mother, I am *supposed* to protect you and I don’t know how to.”

She shoved off the splintering wall with a snarl, “You’ve never protected me! Not when I needed it, and now I don’t even want it. I’m a full grown woman, you need to damn well treat me like one.”

Her mother took another half step backwards into the shadows.

"Just…" Glimmer looked at her, really looked at her. Angella looked a mess with dark bags under her eyes, her clothes rumbled and wrinkled. She'd never looked so small before and it almost was enough to tip her over. But she couldn't. She couldn't, not until she could assure her that that murderer was behind bars. If her own mother wouldn't trust her, then Glimmer would just have to put space there. It would be fine, once she could actually tell her what happened it would work out. She just needed to put that final wedge there for insurance. "Just leave me alone until you figure out which of us you actually care about."

It didn't feel like a victory as she shouldered past her mother back into the street. Didn't feel good when she told Adora she needed to pack it in early. Felt even worse when she got those big sad eyes again.

Her anger felt almost burnt out after all the day's turmoil, and that was damn dangerous these days. It was the fuel keeping her awake through the grueling days and sharp in the lulling quiet of the night. It was the light at the end of the tunnel, promising relief if she could make it. So, Glimmer gathered her things and mounted up, doing her best to remember why she was doing this. She was going to protect people, truly protect them and not just- just run away because she was hurt! The right thing was rarely the easy thing, and hard work required plenty of elbow grease. Giving into them now would just make everything worse, ruin it all. And how awful, how awful that they all said she didn't trust them when she did! Showed it in every way she damn well could, and nobody seemed keen to return the favor. She was so tired. She was just so tired.

Glimmer was so focused on reinforcing the anger, that she almost missed Double Trouble waving her down.

"Well thank you kindly for sparing me the time of day Deputy," they smiled, thin and sarcastic. Letting it turn into a very pleased smirk as they twirled a strand of blonde hair around their finger. Not quite themself, not quite like-

Catra smirked, far too pleased with herself.

"What did you do?" Glimmer asked, squinting at her suspiciously.

Catra slinked forward, looking every bit like a satisfied cat who caught the canary, and nuzzled the side of her head. "You'll find out."

She was worn too thin by the damn day to care much a'tall. "What do you want?"

"My, my, my," Double Trouble lightly swooned and pouted, one hand going over their heart as if she'd shot them, "Is that anyway to treat an upstanding citizen. Perhaps an upstanding citizen who got word of a certain someone's location?"

Glimmer's heart raced as she quickly hitched her horse and all but scrambled inside after them, all the exhaustion and doubts gone in a blink.

Within a few hours she'd stopped at the jail again only for Adora to be nowhere in sight. With a growl, she hastily scrawled out a note and grabbed the emergency travel bag Adora always kept on hand in case they had to chase someone right quick.

And Glimmer well...she certainly needed to chase someone before the bastard slipped through her fingers.

Chapter End Notes

> I can't lie, I love Glimmer being super convinced that Catra is some genius mastermind for being so unpredictable when really it's just the depression and the memory problems that causes lol.
>
> Also, next chapter takes place essentially same day as chapter one, how cool is that? :D

Chapter 15: Stop in the Name of <strike>Love</strike> the Law!

Chapter Summary

> Funny thing about living and her new nemesis, the linear progression of time, it turned out you continued to change as time went on, long as you wanted to that is. And Catra had certainly come some ways, or, well, at least she thought she had. She hoped she had.

Chapter Notes

> I have no idea if HTML works in chapter titles. Guess we'll find out together, but either way I'm hilarious if I do say so myself!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The rumble of the tracks felt extra loud as Catra absentmindedly picked at the small patch of hair she'd missed during her rushed shave two days before and waited for the train to pass her. She was thirty six years old, and somehow was once again riding brakeman although this time she was more experienced which was, she supposed, a good thing. But, on the down side this time she was with the much less scrupulous Krytis Rail lines. It was kind of funny how much pride she took in technically a competitor's company, but every time she watched someone ignore safety protocol or saw how old and poorly maintained something was, all Catra could think about was how it *never* woulda passed muster with BMR. It had been a bit funny to go from not caring to almost scandalized over irregular line and untrained, drunken idiocy (especially considering what she'd become over the last few years), but still!

Not that the pride part really mattered since she really, really couldn't go back. So Krytis Rail it was, which meant that the company was too cheap to upgrade and update their gear, and to

top it all off the boy riding front was too damned weak to throw the heavy switches along the line. Not that he had any grace about it, or cared, or even tried. Little dick lick had simply flagged her up front before nearly kicking her off the engine in a panic. Which was unnecessary, the engineers had been smart enough to slow the train so she had about thirty seconds to throw the switch before they derailed.

Weren't *that* time sensitive really! They probably ran a greater risk of derailment from the uneven line and people who kept putting coins on the track to flatten for a weird souvenir.

And, honestly, she couldn't even complain too much about this kid or the other assholes on this trip. Catra had ridden a few jobs with some real pieces of work giving her less than ten seconds to run ahead and flip the track. Apparently uncaring if they killed everyone on the train, damaged their only ride to civilization, or what happened to the goods they were hauling. It was strange how recently it wouldn't have bothered her, or it would've made her hopeful to be on the train when it went to hell. Nowadays she was far more likely to chew someone out for being a dumb motherfucker before banishing herself to the caboose.

Yeah. Times were strange, *that* was for damn sure.

While the last year had certainly been an improvement over the two before, she was still mostly just going through the motions of being alive. Krytis, luckily, cared a helluva lot less about the mistakes and "mistakes" she made, and that meant she'd finally found a steady job even if the pay was shit. Just enough pay to float and not much else, certainly not enough to get out, she was actually probably going more in debt with the company store than anything else. Didn't matter though, she couldn't exactly focus long enough to do book jobs these days which made her feel like an idiot. She'd skated by on her limited understanding of letters and numbers, but become down right educated back in Etheria. Education and dedication meant very little when numbers switched places on the page as you forgot everything you'd ever learned.

Brakeman wasn't the biggest head job, but it was still an essential one always looking for folks. So what it really gave her was something steady and consistent, and it forced her into a new routine of sorts.

Catra would never describe herself as some stuck up rule follower who counted the minutes down in her schedule. She'd been a proud bean counter, not a minute man. But it turned out that a regular schedule was pretty important to her well being. Like, strangely necessary to her feeling like a real live human and not a fucked up monster. Waking up, doing whatever work she could, lunch, work, dinner, work, bed. Not luxurious, oh no, it was nothing compared to the downright lazy seeming morning she used to spend with Glimmer. Sure they had to wake up at some outrageous hours to make a breakfast and ride into town, but it meant she'd had hours of time spent just *being* . Just existing and breathing in the day. Glimmer used to moan that her mother was a slave driver, but now that Catra spent easily 16 or 18 hour days doing little more than working, well, Mrs. Moon sure seemed much better in comparison. Even as a brakeman with BMR she'd only worked 12 hour days most of the time. She smiled softly at that, god she'd hated that limit and been pretty vocal about how stupid she thought their safety rules were. Ha!

Of course, riding the trains overnight was a different matter with shifts that could stretch for days. And this did happen to be a week long shift she'd volunteered for. No time off, no time to really relax. Wake, work, eat, sleep. Five days left...this was gonna eat her alive.

That was fine.

Not like she had other places to be, or anyone to care about her outside of work anyways. *C'mon D'riluth, ain'tcha tired of being a sad sack all the damned time?* She was, she really was exhausted by being tired and sad and exhausted. Not that it helped her all that much to change it up, but lord all mighty, she desperately missed the days when she'd been a respectable level of grouchy

in the morning and charming by the evening. She just...she missed being herself. *How the hell does that even make sense?*

There was a particularly loud squeal that got her focused back into reality right quick. Good timing too, that was her ride about to pass on by while her mind wandered aimlessly!

Catra jogged and deftly caught the caboose's ladder, hauling herself up the side and scrambling up top to signal she'd made it. Like what's his damn name would care, but still, principle of the matter. (*"Why Miss D'riluth, did I just catch you* enforcing *a rule? Who are you and what have you done with the woman I love? Answer me villain!"*) And in line with her strange new position of being lawful, she did a quick walk up top to make sure things looked right. She stopped short of the open air cars where a guard smiled and waved up at her. Woman had actually been personable considering her profession. Yeah, real nice lady. Probably wouldn't last long in that line of work, but still a good change of pace. She gave a quick wave and all clear before turning around again.

With her duties fully seen to, Catra happily went back to the end of the train to take up her watch. After all, she might not technically be a hired gun, but she preferred not to be robbed and kept an eye out for bandits and gangs as she sat down. Her head ached and eyes burned as she squinted into the darkness, and Catra had to concede that she needed to sleep at the next refueling station. It had been, what? Uh, hmm, well it woulda been back at Fairview right, when they'd had to do an emergency stop? That would be two days passed back at the start. Shit, she probably should see about dropping the extra days at the next station to get her head on right, but the idea of getting off the train and being sedentary somewhere while waiting for the next Katie to roll by made her skin crawl almost as bad as the nightmares waiting for her to curl up on the seat below.

For all that her life had calmed down, she was starting to feel...antsy again.

Funny thing about living and her new nemesis, the linear progression of time, it turned out you continued to change as time went on, long as you wanted to that is. And Catra had certainly come some ways, or, well, at least she thought she had. She hoped she had. She was no longer an outright hazard to work around at the bare minimum, but she also felt more in control of herself again. Over the last few months of boring, endless rides it meant that Catra had actually spent some time wondering about what she actually wanted out of life. Kinda like she was right now.

Almost fantasizing about a future felt...odd.

"Shit!" Catra cursed as she realized she'd been pulling hair out of the underside of her chin again. Damn it all to hell, but she did hate it! Would she rather be properly clean shaven? Yes. Did she have a kit to use on this long haul ride? No. Would she be okay with one stupid looking bare patch growing in because she stress pulled it out? Hell no! It would probably look like the patch she pulled out of her leg and the even smaller ones on her arms. Mangy lookin'. T'wern't no way to look civilized! She shook her hands out trying to convince them to stop all the damn plucking.

"Catra, sweetheart, you know that I love you," Angella started with one of those bland smiles that promised she was dying of laughter inside, "But if you keep literally pulling your hair out, you're going to be left looking like a fresh plucked chicken."

She flushed with shame. "Uh, suppose we don't want that?"

Mrs. Moon chuckled softly, reaching one hand to gently smooth down what was left of the hair at her temple. Her touch was cool and gentle, and god damn it all to hell she was not going to cry over this!

"No, most uncivilized I'd suspect."

Catra slowly stroked her hands through her hair, trying to, what? Pet herself? Well, it helped was what counted. Between the stress

and that new habit she was gonna go bald, and that certainly wouldn't be a look to keep. Catra snorted, grinning at the blur of train tracks below as she imagined the way Glimmer would howl with laughter at her shiny head. Maybe Bow would shave in some weird bid for solidarity, which Adora would probably throw up from laughing too hard before joining them. They'd look like a buncha dumb cue balls. Lord she missed them. The thought was warming and silly, like pulling a comfortable old blanket around her shoulders. God damn, what she'd give to make that happen. Catra popped her neck and tried to actually settle into her watch with one last delayed chuckle at the mental image of the three of them embarrassing Glimmer to death around town.

Much fun as it was to imagine, weren't like it could ever happen. The soft feelings slowly turned jagged as she scanned the horizon, and Catra swallowed hard to stop herself from tearing up. Well, that went about as well as usual. You'd think she'd learn by now not to dwell in some fantasy "what if" daydream. *Moon, trees, track, mountain, bush, trees, stars.* Yeah, best to move on.

Better to try and think more about what she was gonna do with the rest of her life. That *was* the eternal question at this point anyways, she could just try and actually come up with a damned answer and maybe move on with her life. Catra was moving forward now but her destination was as foggy as ever. She'd barely spent a few minutes trying to think of something, anything, she could actually aim for before the ache in her knees made her shift. Then it was her back. Then her damned hips. Catra finally stood up and almost gave up on the whole mental exercise.

Scattered fucking mess, tell you what. (*Angella had that hilarious little half frown she wore when trying to lie so blatantly, "No, no, no, more like, erm, ah! More like a refocusing of resources, see?" No, Catra thought, she did not see why planning long term goals for her personal life or whatever the hell 'career' this was supposed to be was so important. Resources could actually be shifted, but life? Hell, life just happened to you.)* The past did have some sort of clue there didn't it? Maybe it was that simple and Catra was just making things difficult like she always did. First

following rules and now long term goal planning, younger her would've probably jumped off a damn bridge if she'd known the future. "Damn, focus girl, c'mon now."

Alright, so...so she was in a dead end job right now. So what? Brakeman wasn't even so bad these days, a nice enclosed caboose for her to ride in most of the time and no actual brakes to apply! Just signaling and coupling or uncoupling the wagons. So easy a monkey could do it. Almost literally. There was a story she'd seen run in the paper about a monkey trained as a switchman recently. Not much difference between her and him, except the little bastard was paid both better and in rum. That was just unfair. Wait, what had she- right, career goals.

Catra snickered, maybe she should just go inside if she was gonna get this damn distracted. She still felt at least a little justified about the side path her brain took, everyone else at the company house had been equally as enthralled by the story. Still dangerous to be up here and not very aware. But, she certainly didn't feel like retreating to the stuffy enclosed area, and the cold night air felt too nice to call it a day. A little longer and they'd be outta Snakemen's territory and then she could go take a nap till the station, it might help her make the rest of the trip. And it weren't like there was anything more she needed to do until they stopped anyhow.

Hell, couldn't even play poker with the guns. Most of them seemed to despise her for no good reason, which was frustrating considering the plethora of good reasons they coulda used! No real distractions and being this forgetful, Catra didn't feel any need to move anywhere else. Be nice if she could just restart today by actually getting some sleep earlier, night time was just better for thinking.

"You know," Bow started as he helped her clean up the vase she'd hurled at him in a fury, "this doesn't have to mean anything. You got mad, fine, do better if you can the next time you get that mad, but right now you can try harder too. You can get back on the wagon any time you want Miss D'riluth."

She hadn't understood what the hell that meant at the time, but she certainly appreciated the Archer's mostly sound advice more than ever these days. Okay. Start over then, she wanted to think about her life a bit before getting sleep like she shoulda done, and then she was going to finish this ride because she needed to push herself a bit. Okay.

The past was a box full of rattlers that she needed to open somewhere safe and when she had a damn big stick to fight back with. Okay, so that meant that she couldn't tackle that particular lodestone. Right now then? Not so great honestly, not so bad neither, but could be improved upon she was sure. The future? Totally obscured to her, and frankly at this point she was less actually trying to figure that out and more about pretending she would. Catra chewed on her lip as she watched the passing scenery. That felt like a bit of a copout. She muttered to herself, pitching her voice up to how she imagined she must sound when whining like a child, "Oh, I can't magically see the future so I guess fuck it, I'll just suffer". It was like something she'd a done before. Maybe she wasn't doing better?

Catra huffed at herself. Better was such a bullshit subjective word, and yet she also clung to it. She'd promised to be better and she damn well was trying. So she would better be better, damn it all to hell!

"Ow!" Catra hissed, rubbing at her chin where she'd already started plucking hair out again unconsciously. Next stop she was getting a shave come hell or high water, she'd kick that boy's ass at five finger fillet to use his kit if she had to. Scraggly and uneven little thing looked like shit anyways.

This really what you wanna be chewing the cud over? Only a few more miles, pull it together.

Good thing she did too. As she looked out, once again trying to do her damned job, Catra saw something moving in the dark. A small patch of black on black, too big for a cougar and bears weren't around here.

She squinted at it, waiting until a patch of clouds moved aside to reveal a lone rider kicking up dirt as they chased the train. Catra could feel her hackles go up and looked around quickly for more. But there were...none? Now that didn't make sense, they were obviously tailing the train and gaining on them. No idiot would try and rob a freight train alone. Not much gain for one person. A crew, maybe, you could get supplies. But one person?

She slowly squatted, careful to stay mobile but as low as possible in case she hadn't been seen and started to creep closer to the front. Easier to shout for help and maybe even get heard, but she also couldn't just leave the back undefended. The rider jumped from their horse onto the caboose instead of riding along side somewhere safer and Catra snarled hand resting on her gun. That was basically her home this wannabe just invaded! She was gonna enjoy kicking their ass right back off!

To her surprise, they climbed on top of the cars instead of going in, and that left the two of them facing one another in the moonlight.

Catra's heart stopped.

She could feel the train swaying under her boots, the wind and the smoke, the chill of the night air. All just as real as they'd been. But they couldn't be. Because there, at the other end of the car glaring her down, was Glimmer Moon. She looked different sure, but it was her, it was her, it was her! Glimmer's hair was slicked back under a cattleman style hat, her duster flapped all around her, she wore a gun belt with a hefty looking revolver, and there on her chest was a badge of some kind.

"Catra D'riluth!" Glimmer shouted, and god if that didn't feel like heaven to hear her name outta that mouth again. "You are under arrest!"

Glimmer had already started running towards her when she started shouting, and Catra frankly didn't care. It felt like the stars were aligning. **This** was why she was still on god's green earth,

this had to be why! All this time trying to figure out what she was supposed to be doing, when she'd really just been doing what she'd always *been* doing, always would be doing! Waiting for Glimmer Moon. So she raised her hands in the air, saw Glimmer's eyes go round as dinner plates, and realized that she couldn't stop running in time. *Oh shit.* It was a sloppy half tackle that sent them both careening to the train top, the back of her head smacked into the unforgiving metal before Catra noticed that her momentum hadn't stopped. No, in fact they were both tumbling to the edge of the car. She twisted desperately trying to grab something and watched Glimmer barely manage to get her grip on top of the train car, while Catra's own fingers brushed the side, just missing the lip of the roof.

The world was a blur of colors as she tumbled, managing to partially roll with the fall out of sheer dumb luck before smacking side first into a tree.

"AHNHH FUCK!" Catra writhed on the ground, breathless with tears pricking at her eyes as the pain in her ribs flew through her whole body. "Oh shit motherfucker, god damn, argh!!"

After a few minutes of cursing and moaning, Catra finally managed to wiggle herself upright against the tree and wiped away some snot and tears that'd come with the whole debacle. Nothing felt broken (how the hell was nothing broken?) but it still **hurt like hell** . She looked up to where the train was in the distance and chuckled. She watched as Glimmer made a much more controlled jump and roll from the train and began running back towards where Catra had fallen.

For a moment every instinct told her to run, to get away, that staying meant dying, and she knew that it was all true. She was under arrest, apparently, by a woman who had an axe to grind. Hell, she hadn't even cared to try and talk anything out before practically hurling Catra off a moving train! The smart thing to do was steal her horse and get the hell away from here. She could do it, have plenty of time to ride away while Glimmer was too far to stop her.

She stayed put, only moving to toss her pistol and knife a few feet away from herself.

Glimmer was sweating and huffing by the time she made it over, shooting her an incredulous look as if it was an affront that Catra stayed put. Catra herself just sat there and stared again, couldn't help but look. It was like getting a drink of water after her three very long years without a drink. She struggled with herself to not just smile like an idiot, because clearly Glimmer was not happy to see her at all.

She came looking for me! The thought probably shouldn't have sounded so excited.

When she still didn't speak, Catra finally managed to unstick her tongue and miraculously, half slurring, spoke a real word, "M'ello!"

Glimmer actually growled at that, stalked forward, and right after Catra lifted her hands up to be cuffed, wrists together and all, did she realize that just like up top Glimmer had no intention of stopping.

She watched the punch come towards her face in slow motion, and closed her eyes.

When she woke up, she was tied on the rump of a horse, head banging against its flank as it cantered along. She pressed in a little closer with her head and knees to stop herself from getting knocked around too much, before Catra realized that the sun was up. Well. Fuck.

"How long was I out?" She moaned.

"You alive back there?" Glimmer called, not even turning to look.

There was a flare of pure outrage at the whole situation before she snapped back, "Naw, I'm still out like a sack a bricks! What the hell Glim? I wasn't resisting!"

"Nah, I just wanted to hit you. Real cathartic ya know."

"...yeah okay, that's fair," Catra chuckled. After another few minutes of valiantly not hurling stomach acid, she asked, "So, you a, what, Marshall now or-?"

"Deputy actually. Under Adora."

Ah, that made sense honestly. What could she say? Catra wanted to the distraction from the aches and pains, but more than that she just wanted to hear Glimmer talk about anything at all. "Oh? That's real nice, she probably appreciates the help ya know. You like the work?" *Real smooth idiot.*

"D'riluth, shut up or I will make you shut up."

Considering the way Glimmer's fist shook, the way she shifted just a hair in the saddle, Catra was sure she would. So she decided to wisely keep her trap closed, and then resigned herself to watching the earth pass below. As the nerves slowly kicked back in the longer they rode, Catra decided that the best thing she could do was keep herself as calm as possible. Life might be something that happens to you, but she weren't about to give up what little control she had to blind fear!

So she took as good of a breath as she could, and worked to get her mind blank again. To just...go with the flow the way she'd learned to.

Dirt, rock, rock, stump, dirt, flower, dirt, dirt, flower, grass-

Chapter End Notes

If you haven't in a while, I'd recommend taking another read through Chapter 1 to get back up on the time line :)

We did it folks, we made it back to the present/future!

Chapter 16: Heart of the Matter

Chapter Summary

> "You could pay that bounty off on her behalf, send word out to her. And there. You didn't forgive and you didn't take her back, but you kinda apologize for the whole throwing her off a moving train business."
>
> "You ain't ever gonna let that go are you?" Glimmer groused.
>
> "You threw her off a moving train as a Deputy!"

Chapter Notes

> What is happening? I'm not complaining, I just want the secret sauce recipe I'm using to post weekly like this.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer didn't sleep that night.

Staring into the coals of the fire she'd made as she tried to come to terms with everything that had happened in the last three days. She'd found out where Catra was. Finally found out specifically where she was working down to the train she'd volunteered to long haul. Glimmer had felt *almost* as angry to see Catra working for one of her mother's biggest rivals as she was just to see her again, but she supposed that was neither here nor there. Finding Catra working BMR might've sent her into an early grave anyhow. So she made her way out, spoke to a few folks, and made for the train in record time.

The irony of jumping onto the moving train where Catra was working as a brakeman was not lost on her. Last time she'd been dolled up for one of Frosta's little dances, running in heels, and not a lick of sense in her. This time she was prepared.

Or she thought she was.

Seeing Catra on top of the train car made the world stop. She looked far older than she should have; too thin and waxy, and even in the moonlight she could tell there were bags under her eyes. Her heart had clenched up something painful as she stared, and Glimmer shoved down those old feelings as ruthlessly as she could when they tried to rear their heads. She was **not** happy to see Catra, she was **not** glad she was okay, she was **not** going to cry in relief damn it all! Because she couldn't be feeling those things, not about her daddy's killer, never again. So she shouted her intent to arrest as she knew she should, and charged without really thinking it through. A second too late she got close enough to see the small but genuine smile on Catra's face and the fond glint in her eyes, and realized that Miss D'riluth was not going to run for probably the first time ever in her life. Of course that woman had to choose the worst possible time for a change of heart, always being difficult till she weren't!

Oh, Glimmer had tried to stop, but those metal tops felt slick under her boots and instead of stopping she crashed right into her. There was a sickeningly loud crack, which she'd at first feared was her arm or wrist from how hard she fell. It didn't help that she'd, on pure reflex, tried to not land with all her weight directly on top of her. But she hadn't had much chance to check before she'd bounced along with the car and tumbled off her target anyways, scrambling desperately she'd gotten a grip somewhere just before she could fall any further.

Catra hadn't been so lucky. Glimmer had actually screamed when she fell off, a mix of fear and anger knowing full well they was at least 15 feet up from the ground and the wheels on the wagons sure wouldn't stop just because Catra's head bounced under them. It was a frenzied haze as she quickly looked for a safe way down closer to the ground, to find a spot she could safely jump from, and she ran like hell as soon as she touched the dirt. Because if she weren't hurt, that woman would probably be long gone before Glimmer got there.

Only Catra was sitting up against a tree, one hand holding her side as she wheezed slightly.

Only Catra lit up on seeing her, like she was genuinely glad to see her.

Only Catra had half slurred her hello like the first time they'd met, and all Glimmer could hear after that was ringing in her ears.

If felt damn good to punch her, twice as good to realize that Catra had actually been offering herself up when it happened. It felt distinctly less good to watch her head ricotche off the tree behind her as she slumped over. And a lot less good to tie her up, then go find her damn horse, and then get her on said horse while still unconscious. But worst of all she wasn't waking up. Glimmer had gotten nervous as the hours went by, checking to make sure Catra wasn't dead. People don't stay out from a hit that long unless there was something awful wrong. But a loud snore proved that Catra had probably woken up and fallen into an exhausted sleep at some point.

Glimmer could admit that was upsetting, seeing as she couldn't do the same and good lord was she tired as hell.

But sitting there after letting Catra fade into the inky blackness of the night...it was surreal. Not in the way finding out the truth had been. No. This time Glimmer was in full control, but just… cut adrift. She'd let her anger guide her for three long years, listened to it, fed it, kept it close to keep herself motivated. Talking to Catra again, hearing her voice and her laugh, and actually listening to her...it felt like the worst kind of sucker punch.

She'd built Catra up as some conniving schemer, a villain who had taken advantage of all of them. That somehow, someway she'd known from the start and was a grifter or sorts trying to con a few years off those she'd hurt. Glimmer had imagined that on catching her Catra would try to sweet talk her way out of her fate. In her most embarrassing moments, she even pictured Catra trying to seduce her to let her guard down for an escape. Instead, Catra had been a shell of herself sitting there scared as hell and twice as patient all because she knew Glimmer wanted her dead. She

was just going to go along with it, she was willing to just give up and die. As long as that's what Glimmer wanted.

Because she never meant to hurt Micah Moon, and because that love she felt for Glimmer had apparently never faded.

It had been almost pathetic to watch Catra our of the corner of her eye when she'd made camp. Like an old dog that had clearly been beat by its owner, but couldn't help but wag its tail hopefully. What the hell was she supposed to do with that? With the knowledge that Catra hadn't meant it. That Catra loved her still. That Catra was completely willing to do whatever she wanted as she wanted it. How was *this* the same person who had once fought her tooth and nail over who got to hold an umbrella during a downpour? What happened to the girl who refused to talk to her for a week just because she didn't get her way? Catra was brash and bratty and always pleased as punch to be difficult, but this version of her… no. That was too much power for anyone to have. Too much power for Glimmer to feel safe. So she cut her free, and Catra had still stayed put just in case. Offering herself up like a damn sacrifice even as something awful twisted in her voice.

It had been a heat of the moment decision, hot on the tail of realizing that Catra was still fully expecting Glimmer to stab her to death, to steal one last kiss.

Why the hell had she done that?

What was ***wrong*** with her!?

The night gave no answers as she stared up at the moon and caught herself hoping that Catra would limp her way to safety.

The ride home treated her even less kindly, her mind spinning in endless circles as she tried to reconcile what she'd convinced herself of compared to what she now knew was the truth. It wasn't just what she'd done to Catra either, oh no, that wouldn't been better. Instead her thoughts opened up a whole other set of problems she'd created, namely every single person she'd been

pushing away and holding at arm's length. Glimmer had said she'd tell them the truth once Catra was locked up. She'd said it was alright to lie to them in the name of protecting them, but now she'd taken her own faulty logic out back and shot it dead. She knew better than that. She knew better but she didn't *do* better. The guilt had crept back in and made a roost in her chest, happily getting comfortable as her heart kicked and she had trouble catching her breath.

Wasn't this exactly what Catra had done, after all? Lied to try and protect them?

But unlike her former fiancé, who had at the bare minimum tried to keep her relationships up (even if she hadn't managed it well), Glimmer had pushed them away one by one. Trying to, good lord what? Trying to force them to see what she saw? Trying to set up the chess board so that when she returned triumphant they would understand and forgive her? Foolish. WIthout the strings wrapped around her throat, it was obvious how foolish she'd been. And she had to concede that it wasn't going to be easy to apologize, but now that her hurt had been lanced the idea that they might not forgive her right away was both more unbearable but also more acceptable. After all, she only had herself to blame.How long had Glimmer fallen back on doing things so people would like her, so people wouldn't be mad with her, instead of because she cared about them? A long time. Too long.

And equally as frustrating as that revelation was, was the slow realization of just how hurt she'd really been by having someone she loved lie to her. Gingerly noticing that without an immediate jump to fury, she was left tender and aching and raw. Crying on and off as she sat at camp each night and looking for any justification the next morning. Even her dreams had become plagued with guilt and sadness and hurt. No longer crackling fires or violent attacks, but simple quite things. Sitting up night after night hoping to catch Catra coming home. Really listening to her that afternoon when everything went wrong. Dreams where they simply sat together sobbing. She woke in fits and starts only to

jump to the next unsettling dream. Not nightmares, but not pleasant either as she slowly began to circle towards a realization.

Unwanted as much as it was inevitable, and so she took her time. Where Glimmer had driven her poor horse near to breaking on the way out, the much more sedate ride home felt longer than it was as she was left alone with only her own thoughts.

She was pathetically grateful to get home under the cover of darkness.

Glimmer stared longingly at the path towards her home before slapping her cheeks to wake up and make her way towards the jail. She had a lot of explaining to do and of everyone who deserved to know, Adora was probably the only one still awake. And, also, was kind of her boss who she'd just ignored and gone around in a bid for vengeance. Glimmer winced as she hitched up Bright Wing and stalled to feed him some oat cakes. Arbitrary task done, she turned towards the front door and groaned to herself. Her creation, her responsibility though.

So, with a deep breath to fortify her constitution and sooth her frayed nerves, Glimmer walked forward without hesitation to open the door. She knew full well she'd gone off without permission and half cocked, and Adora had probably had to face the very pointed questions her mother had been bound to ask. This weren't going to be pretty for many, many reasons and she wasn't going to lie about it to herself about it, but she also couldn't afford to give herself a way out.

Sure as sugar, she barely made it a few steps in when Adora whirled on her.

"What in tarnation did you think you were doing!?" Adora spat, red in the face and angry enough that Glimmer melted in shame on the spot. "You got responsibilities and duties, and you take off without any notice-"

“I left a note!” Glimmer protested weakly, mentally slapping herself. Well, old habits die hard she supposed, and no amount of wanting to be better would make it magically happen overnight.

“That said and I quote, ‘following a lead be back in a week’! Yeah, real descriptive!” Adora growled, throwing her hands up and paced as she continued her half yelled tirade. “You can’t just go off like this Glimmer, you ain’t some nobody Deputy scraping by and even if you was you’d need to ask ME for permission first. You were reckless and selfish!”

“You don’t understand-”

“Enlighten me!”

For one endless moment she almost made up a lie. But she grabbed her shame with both hands and refused to let go. Glimmer was surprised by how loudly she screamed. “IT WAS CATRA!”

Adora looked exactly the way she had when Glimmer showed up in the middle of the night three years ago, barely explaining that Catra had gone and she didn’t care.

“It was…it was Catra, alright? She, lord have mercy, she used to run with the Horde Adora.” Glimmer hugged herself at the way Adora’s gaze narrowed in concentration, the sheriff’s fury instantly quenched only to now be replaced with her undivided and very serious attention. Oh that never felt good. Disappointed Adora was much harder to take than angry Adora. “And, I, like a fool, I forgave her that, but then I find out… Adora she killed my dad. She killed him in that damn fire and I couldn’t just- I was- it- So I threw her out, but I couldn’t just- and UGH! C’mon Moon, get it together!? I wanted to be a Deputy to arrest her, serve out justice for murdering him, and then I finally, FINALLY got a lead.”

She practically gulped down the air, she’d been talking faster and louder with each word and good god she needed to breathe and not pass out damn it! Glimmer risked a glance up at Adora to

gauge her reaction so far, after all, the woman was quick to anger and quick to calm and there was no telling where she was at. That was a mistake. There was far too much sympathy and far too much concern in that gaze for Glimmer to keep it.

"So I went. I found her. Served her warrant for arrest. She… Adora she weren't herself. Like she was broken, and when we talked, she really *was* . I didn't- I couldn't bring her in. I couldn't do it. She was so... she's a different person now, and I… I just couldn't take her to a hangman like that." The image of Catra tied to a tree, trying to smirk and only looking seconds from crying was never going to leave her alone. Because she did that. She *did* that to *her* .

Adora wrapped her up in a hug, rocking them both slightly before pulling Glimmer over to her desk. "I wish you'd told me Glimmer. I wish you'd trusted me."

That stung, and she flinched as Adora gently shoved her into her chair. "I know, Adora I know and I'm- I'm sorry."

If she thought the sympathy hurt, the half second of naked surprise was worse. Had she really been so awful that a simple apology warranted shock?

Adora smiled at her, even if it was a little stiff. "Thank you, but I didn't mean as your friend. I'm the Sheriff. You think I don't get the bounties from other lawmen? Sure it's old, and it was Hope who got it, but I want you to look at this carefully."

Adora unfolded a yellowed bit of paper, and slid it across the desk's rough and stained top to her.

It was strange. Glimmer instantly recognized who it was, but it took a moment to place *what* it was. A very young (good god had they really been that young when it happened?) poorly remembered Catra glared out of the picture. There was a scraggly five o'clock shadow, which had probably been more peach fuzz than anything else at the time but at a distance had done the

trick, and her hair was short. A single piece of it hung limp in front of her face, but it was still short and slicked back which caused most folk to assume she'd been a man much older and bigger than she was ever gonna be. Only her own mother had seemed skeptical of it, making Glimmer suspect as well.

It was Catra on her wanted poster, as set by the mayor of Erlandia. Reward of $750 dead or alive for arson and two charges of manslaughter.

Funny thing was she'd seen it before, from a distance where it had been hard to see the drawing and the writing covered by arms and shadows. Manslaughter. It had always been set as manslaughter, a mistake, not murder. It made a world of difference to her seeing it now, but she wondered if she'd simply pushed the information out of her own head at the time. So hurt and scared and damaged by her loss, would she have cared at all or just construed it as something worse to make it make sense. Her daddy was dead and if it was an accident then it meant no one had really meant to do it, which had been so unacceptable the last three years that it changed her. Glimmer pulled the paper closer to her and blinked away a few tears as she thought about the aftermath.

Her mother had gone to Erlandia by herself, even though they didn't live that far out, leaving Glimmer in her aunt's care. She had hated her for that for a long, long time. Her mother treated her like a child when she was nearly a woman full grown. It hadn't mattered though because it hadn't taken long at all. When she'd returned, Glimmer snuck as best she could to listen to the two talk and caught a peek at the wanted poster. It had been far away and dark, and when Glimmer asked if there was a poster up, if anyone knew who it was, Angella had rebuffed her without a real answer. It had only infuriated her worse to not be trusted, so Glimmer decided she'd find out on her own! But no amount of snooping had ever found it again, although her Aunt Casta had eventually caved on some details, and she hadn't been able to leave her mother's sight before they'd moved far enough away that she couldn't have gotten a copy if she'd wanted to.

She carefully traced the image there, she wished her mother had told her more, been more honest with her. But it was nearly two decades passed, and Glimmer could understand why you wouldn't want to give a hot head any ammunition. "...I don't understand why you're showing me this. I know what this is and I know it ain't got an expiration on it."

Adora sighed, leaned back in her chair and rubbed at her mouth before answering. "Glimmer...Light Hope was the one who got this, two years before Catra arrived in town. Hope didn't connect the two at first, but when I was working to get deputized? She told me that she had an active warrant for Catra's arrest, and that she did not want to serve it, *and* didn't want me to either. I didn't...I couldn't understand *why* , what could she have done? But she wouldn't tell me either, only saying that it was nothing with malicious intent. Why wouldn't Light 'Dot the I's and Cross the T's' Hope not serve justice to the letter of the law like usual? And then-"

"The bank." Glimmer less sat and more collapsed into the other chair, eyes drifting back down to the poster. "This is why you got so distant with her, ain't it? The robbery?"

Adora nodded, "And then the robbery happened and I couldn't prove nothing, she'd saved lives that day by killing, it was just so ruthless that I...kinda assumed a lot after that."

"Why didn't you tell us?" She whispered, head aching worse than ever as new complications and spider webs cropped up into what she'd thought was a past set in stone.

" 'Cause when I told Hope that I needed to know, wanted to serve that warrant...she told me no. Light Hope said she'd been keeping an eye on her, and that she felt Catra was not the same person anymore. Temperamental, yes, but she didn't want to ruin the life of someone who was actually turning over a new leaf." Adora looked exhausted, and for the first time Glimmer realized how much pressure she'd been under. Between two jobs, caring for the

aging Madam Razz, and carrying a secret so large about one of their friends.

She wanted to be furious that Adora had known, she wanted to hate her for not saying anything. But all she had left was a sort of exhausted acceptance after all her own lying and hiding. They sat in silence for a moment before Glimmer jerked upright, an old question of her suddenly connecting with an answer. "Wait, is that why you jumped the fence with Swift Wind? You thought she'd killed me or my mother?"

Adora blushed just as bad as she had that day, stammering, "M-maybe? Okay, yes! But she hadn't, and you seemed calmer learning, and then you was looking so happy and she was calming down, and then you two moved in together!" Adora threw her hands in the air and groaned as she let them fall heavily to her sides. "By the time I took over and actually saw the damn poster, she was nervously asking me fer advice on how to propose proper like to you. ...Hope had been right, Catra wasn't who she was even just a few short years earlier. And the combination of arson and manslaughter? She set it on purpose, but the deaths were an accident. The only reason she was even charged with anything was 'cause the damn owner of that barn was some rich big wig."

There was a long pause and before Glimmer could figure out what to say, Adora blustered ahead, "And I know, I'm an idiot, okay!? B-but I didn't know when Mr. Moon passed and it said TWO counts of manslaughter, 'n I just kinda- you know? Soon as you told me what she'd done I put two and two together and...I just, kind of, forgot until now? About the poster."

What in the world? It took Glimmer an embarrassingly long few moments to understand what she'd just been told. She had to compartmentalize some of that information, too much to handle in one go. Adora knew her father died in a blaze, set by a ne'er-do-well in Erlandia. And she'd seen a wanted poster for a known criminal for arson and manslaughter... *in Erlandia* .

Glimmer weakly chuckled, “Adora, how are you so damn smart till you ain’t?”

“Oh shush.” She crossed her arms, before leaning on the desk. “The point here is that...I just, I wish you’d told me what you were going to do so I could have given you the background I did know. I probably woulda helped you find her too.”

Glimmer looked at the poster again, the scowling face of a younger Catra mixing with the dazed but genuine smile she’d gotten just four days prior. The spot where anger had been... it wasn’t empty. But a large chunk had burned away, and a larger pit fell right out from her chest to her stomach. “Thank you, but, I think I… I don’t think I’d’ve cared. It probably woulda just made me madder. And if I’d been *any* dang madder, I don’t know if I’d have let her go.”

In the low light of the lantern, Adora’s face shifted in and out of shadow as she chewed on her lip and tapped on her own arms. “Do you regret it? Letting her go.”

“...” Glimmer grimaced, staring both at Adora and past her. Everything was just such a *mess* . “...no. She didn’t even try to resist. Didn’t fight or plead or nothing. Even after I threw her off the train and I’m pretty sure broke her ribs, she just sat there waiting till I caught up.”

“I’m- wait, I’m sorry did you just say you *threw* her off a train?!” Adora gasped, rocking forward to gape at her.

“I didn’t mean to!” Glimmer growled, scrubbed at her face as if that would stop her blush. “I thought she was gonna run and when she didn’t, I didn’t exactly have time to stop chasing! The point is I had to wait till it was safe to jump off and walk back to her-”

Adora’s eyes went wide with equal amounts of shock and terror. “You threw *Catra* off a *moving train* !?!”

“Damn it, it was AN ACCIDENT!” A half second after she said it, Glimmer realized exactly who she sounded like and let out a choked half laugh, half sob. “W-will you let me finish?”

“Sorry! Okay, sorry! Uh, she wasn’t resisting?” At Glimmer’s unimpressed look Adora mimed turning a key by her mouth and flicked it away.

Thank goodness, one more cut in and she wasn’t sure she’d be able to get through what happened.

“No. She wasn’t. She looked so happy to see me, and tried to talk with me a little, even enough to piss me off...where I maybe punched her a little, BUT-” Glimmer desperately cut across Adora’s stern look, “-she just stayed pliant! And when I confronted her, you know what she told me? That she was scared as hell and going along anyways because she knew I wanted her dead...when I cut her free she thought I was going to kill her myself. She tensed up and closed her eyes, Adora. Just...no fight.”

“Shit,” Adora breathed out softly her eyes watering and brow furrowing with worry, “that ain’t like her.”

The world tilted for a moment, and for the first time in a long time she was realizing someone had genuinely cared about Catra’s well being and for once she was just grateful. All the voices blurred together as they whispered those hated words to her again, *you aren’t the only one hurt by this.* She quickly wiped away a few tears, coughing to stop a sob from rising right out of her chest. They’d all been trying so hard to reach her, to share the burden on the pain they’d all been dealt in some form. Just one week ago if Adora had said that, Glimmer would’ve blown up at her.

One week ago she’d been furiously looking for any possible way to prove that everyone was lying to her, looking...for what? Evidence of something, her head throbbed with pain. Probably best to think on that later when she could.

She just wanted this to be done. Wanted to already be past everything happening, go to sleep and wake up in a few years with everything right as rain. Glimmer was so tempted to just call it a night, but she'd already started and she desperately needed to finish. Just, she just needed a little boost- and one soft voice rang out twice as loud as every ghost from her past " *Almost there darlin', almost done, just a little more now. I promise.* "

"I think- lord have mercy- I think she was... gall damn it. She said she'd made a promise to me, and- and I think she just meant that she loves me. Adora, she still loves me and I was trying to kill her." Glimmer felt exhausted from admitting it out loud like that. She slumped even further in her chair and stared at the poster without really seeing it. "...I almost did a couple times. You're right, she's not well and I almost murdered her out in the wilderness like it woulda made a difference."

It was only when Adora reached across and held her hands that Glimmer realized she was shaking. "I'm- I think I'm...ha. I spent a long time thinking she was a monster. Only thing monstrous out there was me."

Adora squeezed her hands tighter, and Glimmer sniffled a little even as she half manically giggled, "Ain't this the part where you say I'm not?"

"Does that need saying? You're not a monster, just a human. Glimmer," Adora grinned softly at her. "Ain't you the one who helped me realize that having a bad thought is nowhere the same as acting bad?"

They both chuckled as Glimmer squeezed her hands back.

When she'd been forcibly moved to Etheria, Glimmer had very few friends. Sure she'd met a few colorful folks thanks to the dances and balls and celebrations, hell even the funerals! And she'd kept in touch with them all, from Mermista just a short ride away now to Entrapta who had still been living more east than west. But she'd been very lonely and very isolated nonetheless, her day to

day woes and victories shared with her family and without her father even that had stopped. Bow, bless his heart, worked his behind off to weasel his way into her heart. Goodness knows what he saw in her back then! But he'd tried until she cracked, and then they was thick as thieves. Sometimes it was even hard to remember a time when he wasn't there, and sometimes he'd push her to something she hated and it was glaringly obvious.

Adora had been one of those things. He and her had been friends almost their whole lives, and while Glimmer certainly met her early on they hadn't really met properly. And once they did it was honestly all downhill from there. Glimmer had hated her almost on sight. Young Adora was brash and stubborn and sometimes alarmingly ignorant, all wrapped up in a reckless hurt that lashed out thanks to that mountain sized chip on her shoulder. Glimmer couldn't stand her brown nosing and nosey nature, and Adora didn't seem to much like her either. Any time she found the two of them together it had made her so mad she could burst. What did Bow see in this hot headed fool?

Any ambiguity on Adora's feelings towards her were cleared up quite well on a sunny afternoon when the two ran into one another alone and almost instantly began to fight. Not just some petty argument, no no no, a literal fist fight after that damned violent idiot thought she could sit up on her high horse without consequence! Her mother had been furious and Glimmer had been sentenced to spend a few weeks on Razz's ranch assisting them to make up for it.

"Two weeks!?"

Angella had narrowed her eyes, almost white knuckling her desk despite her calm voice. "You're right, that's not enough time. Three weeks then."

*"I!?! UGH!" Glimmer tugged at her hair to stop herself from stomping and throwing a proper fit. "Why do **I** have to go and help them? She started it!"*

"I do not care who started it, I care that you escalated it. Glimmer, you are becoming an angry young woman and I shant stand for it. Do you understand?"

She'd seethed the whole way out and the whole way back each and every day, her and Adora working in near dead silence. Until one day they were simply too bored and too tired to keep up their little feud. Thank goodness, since Glimmer had been dead wrong! Adora, it had turned out, used false confidence as a shield and bravado as a sword. It became clear alarmingly quickly that the other girl was sheltered as hell and a complete fool at times. Somehow breaking in wild horses and manhandling steer, but then tripping over her own two feet as she mispronounced all the words she'd ever read but never heard before. Sure, she was still stubborn and self righteous and far too much of a stickler for the rules, but all that got put under a new light of her anxiety and loneliness. Something Glimmer understood too well.

Most shocking of all though, was that, somehow, Adora had been sure she was a bad apple ready to spoil the bunch.

"Why?" Glimmer had asked in confusion, leaning heavily on her shovel.

Adora had growled, face twisting as she quickly turned to ***kick*** *the only tree in the whole damn pasture. Just a few days ago it would have scared her but by now Glimmer had gotten used to her physical outbursts. "You should know! GOOD PEOPLE aren't violent idiots!"*

She'd been so ashamed in that moment. She hadn't said that to her, but lord almighty if she hadn't implied it for a long, long while. "You aren't-"

"I AM!" Adora had snarled and glared at her, eyes flinty and fists shaking. "I knew you for, what, five minutes and then started punching you! Good people don't do that!"

It was a weak argument considering Glimmer was the one who'd swung the first punch, but that didn't mean the sentiment hadn't run deep.

After that the two didn't just chat, they actually talked. Shared ideas and thoughts, even helped one another out on the boiling hot days where neither could quite hold their tempers in check. Turned out that digging fence post holes and hammering the wood together did wonders for their anger, the physicality of the work helping. When Glimmer popped her top, Adora simply handed her to the post digger. When Adora went from posturing to punchy, Glimmer made sure she was hauling the bucket of nails and hammering away. All the while they talked, sharing hurts that no one else seemed to understand.

By the time her punishment was finished, the two could walk through town laughing and holding hands.

Bow had been **thrilled** by their new friendship and, a bit overzealously all things considered, dubbed them the Best Friend Squad. Complete with little bracelets he'd woven for them while talking made of straw and hay. Glimmer's had been destroyed within a few weeks but Adora had kept hers safe, which never failed to make Bow cry when he remembered either situation. One of them wore it to breaking point out of love and the other kept it perfectly safe for the same reason. All together they had worked hard and grown together, learning better where to draw the line and practice restraint.

Adora had admitted years later that no one had ever told her that acting bad and thinking bad weren't the same. Glimmer had called her an idiot and Adora had put her in a headlock, which was unfair seeing as Glimmer had been stuck in a frilly dress and hadn't been able to twist away in time.

Had she forgotten all about that, or just been so caught up she'd ignored it? That hard won battle for them both fading as she'd lied to herself about how well she was handling things.

Or not handling them, depending on your point of view she supposed.

"Suppose it ain't the same a'tall." Glimmer said softly, giving Adora's hands one more squeeze before finally letting go. "I just hate how close I got to crossing a line. And I let her go again. I don't- I don't regret that, but I also...I don't know. I just *feel* bad." It wasn't all that she had in her, but it was the biggest and most important for now at least.

Adora looked at her, squinted in thought before pushing the poster far enough that it fluttered off the desktop and into her lap. "Well if'n you feel that bad, I can think of one thing to help make up the guilt."

Glimmer looked down at the paper and back up in confusion. "I- I did just say I don't want her dead, right?"

Adora laughed, snorting a little as she scrubbed at her face. "You- you idiot! No! You could pay the fine!"

Pay the fine? The outrageously expensive fine? That fine?

"What?!"

"You could pay that bounty off on her behalf, send word out to her. And there. You didn't forgive and you didn't take her back, but you kinda apologize for the whole throwing her off a moving train business."

"You ain't ever gonna let that go are you?" Glimmer groused.

"You **threw** her off a **moving train** as a Deputy!" Adora paused before slowly saying, "Wait, you said you ran at her?"

"UGH! Yes *sheriff* we were up top, she's working brakeman for Krytis- Krytis! Can you believe that! Direct competition with us and all!!" Glimmer blushed horribly at the look Adora shot her. Right. Not the point.

Adora cradled her head in her hands, “Oh goodness gracious, alright, you’re basically obligated to pay that fine now seein’ as they're the ones with them big ol’ cars. How in the world did she not break her neck!?”

Glimmer at least had the good grace to blush. “I- I don’t know! Here I thought you was talking about when I almost shot her, or when I almost stabbed her, or when I thought about leaving her tied to that tree-”

Adora quickly plugged up her ears, “YUP I DON’T NEED TO HEAR ANYMORE, NO SIREE, NO THANK YOU!”

“I...yeah alright, that’s fair I suppose.”

“You suppose!?”

“I’ll think about it!” Glimmer folded the poster up and jammed it in her pocket only for her mind to finally let her have that last piece of new information. “... you said two counts of manslaughter?”

“Yeah, there was another body in there too, charred up pretty badly is my understanding. Hope never knew who the second one was though. Why?”

It didn’t make sense. Glimmer frowned, toying idly with the folded edges of the old poster. Catra said she’d checked and no one was in there, and that’s why she’d warned her daddy away. They could’ve gone in after Catra set it all up she supposed, but it niggled in the back of her mind. Logically, she knew it didn’t matter. Catra, on purpose or not, she’d killed two people that night in an awful blaze. But oh if it didn’t bother her! *Why should I care if she lied to me again?* She was infinitely grateful to Adora for interrupting her before that thought got carried away.

“Glimmer?”

“She said she’d checked and no one was in there, s’all.” Adora looked at her, head tilting as she tried to parse through it. Glimmer felt another wave of exhaustion roll over her and decided

that enough was enough. Four days of being slowly roasted and by her own mind were clanging into one hell of an emotionally draining talk. She weren't done, but she also couldn't take another minute. She'd think about it all later. "Don't matter much, I suppose and I'm too beat to care."

"Fair enough, but, maybe Mrs. Moon knows more about that bit? If you want to look into it later that is." Adora tapped her fingers on the desk before grinning weakly. "And on that note, I ain't explaining this to her. Talk to your mama Deputy, and that's an order."

She'd completely forgotten about having to talk to her mother. "Aw damn it all t' hell. Is it too late to run away for good?"

Adora popped out of her seat to go lock the door (which, rude, she wasn't actually going to try nothing! ...probably) and then pointed at the cot they kept clean for their own use. "Yes deputy, it is. Now get to getting while the getting's good!"

It took a while for Glimmer to fall asleep. Long enough for her to notice that the place she'd buried her old feelings seemed to oddly line up properly now with where the heat of her hurt had been. Gosh darn it, that was something to unpack with Bow. *Oh fiddlesticks, I gotta talk with Bow!* Glimmer promised herself to talk with him as soon as possible. Her mother needed to come first, but she needed to patch things up with him as well. Hell, she still needed to work on it with Adora even. She had accepted her apology but that weren't the same thing as forgiveness. Not that Adora had to forgive her, but that didn't mean that Glimmer wasn't going to try and work for it anyways. It was the right thing to do

Glimmer groaned and rolled over. She had surely followed what she thought was her heart, and now that she'd actually found it it was going to be one hell of a struggle wasn't it? Maybe she should just give up and get started on it. Weren't like she was going to get much sleep anyhow. She barely rolled onto her back as the memory rolled gently over her.

"Hey there, what's a pretty lady like you doing up at a time like this?" Catra whispered, half asleep as she rolled over in bed to throw her leg on top of Glimmer's and snuggle into her neck. Effectively pinning her down and stopping her from getting up like she'd been planning to.

Oh nothing much, she thought, just feel like the world's ending is all, no big deal. Glimmer instead sighed a more palatable, "More than I'd like, but probably less than I think."

Catra hummed, the sound tickling against her skin. "Sounds awful."

"I don't like it one bit miss," Glimmer mumbled back, wrapping around her just as tightly.

"You can only do what you can do, princess. Now, you don't need no beauty rest, but some of us aren't so lucky."

"Excuse you!? How dare you talk about my beloved like that!"

"Shhhhhhh," Catra curled up tighter and kissed her jaw, "Sleepy time sleep for sleep no think."

Glimmer tried to not burst into gut busting laughter at that, it would surely wake her girl up fully if she did and half asleep Catra was always a hoot and a holler. "I'm sorry miss, can you run that by me again?"

"Mmmm, no."

Well she certainly couldn't argue with that flawless logic could she?

Glimmer yawned, shifting to curl around their sad excuse of a pillow. Well, no need to argue now either. After all, night was for sleeping and she could worry herself sick in the morning. She didn't actually expect that decision to make a difference, but the next moment after she made it Glimmer was blinking awake in the weak sunlight as Adora tried to brew them up some tea.

"Okay then, ups and daisies starshine, got a whole day a suffering ahead!" And if that cheeky voice sounded familiar to her at all, well, that was between her and her own heart thank you very much.

Chapter End Notes

Finally it's some extra backstory and a lot of exposition finally done!

Also, who's ready for the bestest boy to finally make it into the fic????? 🐆 :D

Chapter 17: A Helping Hand From Friends

Chapter Summary

> She just couldn’t picture any future that didn’t involve Glimmer. As the weeks went on, Scorpia’s suggestion sounded better and better. They could all go, all three of them moving closer at the very least. Scorpia seemed pretty hooked on the idea and Entrapta hadn’t seemed to care all that much. There were all those little towns nearby, maybe they could hole up in Alwyn, or someplace like it. A day's ride by train, with plenty of grass for Melog. She just, it was dumb, but Catra felt like she was just waiting for a sign.
>
> She’d heard the saying careful what you wish for, and even understood it. By god did she not listen though.

Chapter Notes

> I need to scream thank yous from the high heaven's to both dragonesdepapel and Venn364 for looking this chapter over, talking it out with me, and dealing with me completely re-writing the whole thing and majors scenes as well. This chapter has been an absolute monster and both of you are the reason it's actually a good one that works! :D
>
> Content Warning for a severe hand injury described in some intense detail. If you need to, skip starting at "The pain had been worse than anything she’d ever experienced in her life" and come back at "They’d rinsed it best they could, applied whatever they could, and then wrapped her up."

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It had been over a year since Glimmer had arrested her, and then let her go. Over a year since Glimmer had last said a word to her. Over a year since she’d kissed her.

It had been one ***hell*** of a year.

It took a few days without food and limited (and highly questionable) water to get to the nearest town and Catra had been near delirious by that point. On arrival, the local lawman had helped her out, the irony of *that* was not lost on her, and even bought her a ticket back to 'home'. A half day's travel after which Catra discovered that her possession had been sold off to pay her store debt as they assumed she'd fallen off the train and died. " *Drunks fall all the time."* They'd said, despite the fact that Catra hadn't been drinking nearly like she used to. She supposed the few times she did must have left one hell of an impression, but the bigger issue was that it was ALL of her possessions. Including her beloved Captain, who had been purchased from the rail within hours. Bullshit if she'd ever heard it, but the buyer was long gone. So, she ended up spending the next two months getting the most important of her things back, trying to find any work she could as Krytis wouldn't take her back on (she was apparently only *now* a liability, which had been outright infuriating), and fighting with both the coroner and the law about her legal status as dead.

Which was ridiculous! A non-stop merry go round from hell of explaining patiently that they didn't have a body because ***she weren't dead yet*** .

Mucking stalls to delivering goods, hell, she'd even done a bit of shoe shining as she saved money up and bought herself some necessary provisions and possessions. About the only good thing between the exhaustion and the headaches, had been getting the chance to actually digest what the hell had happened between her and Glimmer that fateful night.

And whoo boy, had there been a bit to digest on the other side of some actual sleep.

Glimmer had been *looking* for her! And while there was a small thrill of excitement that never went away at that thought, it had finally been tempered by the fact that it had been for the sole purpose of ending her. Oh she'd gone through the gamut on that one. A petty sort of anger and hurt had smouldered over how much Catra was still in love with someone who clearly hadn't once

worried about her since they'd broken apart. A deep seated pang of hollowness over how this all happened because of her and if she'd just been a better person or a kinder person or a smarter person...maybe it wouldn't have and she'd still be home. A quiet wonder over how far Glimmer had gone in a few short years professionally speaking, she'd always known Glimmer could do anything she put a mind to but it kind of made her fall in love all over again. A gnawing worry over how tired she'd been, how unlike herself she'd seemed. Catra had once watched a giant tree by the Horde's base get hit by lightning, that giant oak had burned for days and days from the inside out. It had barely stopped burning before it ate through the whole thing, so its charred hollow remains had been left standing until a storm rolled through and finally broke it apart for good. She hated how much she could equate that tree and the love of her life right now.

As much as she was grateful to have just had the chance to see her again, hear her again...Catra was hurt. Her heart ached at how callously Glimmer had treated her even if she knew it was earned. Her heart ached wondering why Deputy Moon had let her go. What could it mean? *It could, it might, possibly, perhaps*- And even if it did mean that, what did it matter now? The deed was done. Her last chance to make real amends finished, and it left her feeling cold.

God she was so fucking lonely it was pathetic.

But it also weren't gonna get fixed in that hell hole of a town.

So she worked and ducked head and went before the judge yet again to plead her case for being alive. Saving every last coin in all sorts of unpleasant ways to escape it. Sitting at her very makeshift camp outside of town, she tried to not worry about the whole thing too much because there was nothing she could do about it now. For all her wondering what she should be doing with her life, seeing Glimmer again had been the kick up the ass she needed to honestly try to move forward. Easier said than done when her mind felt like it was rotting away, only able to focus on the woman she'd been trying to bury for years.

What'll she do without a goal? Did she have other plans? Was she happy? Is she gonna be alright? I might die if she ain't alright.

She had to believe that Glimmer would find her way, that she *would* have friends and family to fall back on. She'd be okay, she always was. Catra clung to that with both hands as the weeks rolled by. Glimmer was gonna be okay and she was gonna be happy someday real soon, she had to be.

Why can't that be me too? The thought popped in and out of her head, thinking of the future no longer so terrifying but still as foggy as ever. Why couldn't she try to be okay too? Glimmer hadn't forgiven her, no, but letting her go had to *mean* something (had to, it had to!).

Catra had always found a way forward even if it was as precarious as sliding down a forty foot fall in a narrow wash and by god she would do it again! But that meant actually fighting through and thinking about what the hell she wanted. So, Catra forced herself to really sit and think, her mind slowly shifting back into something like it used to be. Make a plan and see it through. She was doing her damned best, and her refusal to try and move on was what had held her back all this time. What would old her have done? *Punched the bastards that sold her damn horse and then leave.*

It was a better plan than she'd had in years.

With her pocket watch and boots back, along with some provisions and a pocket full of change, she went to the station and bought a train ticket. Catra was going to leave this dump behind and go somewhere with decent jobs and decent folk! And if she just so happened to have watched the house manager teeter precariously before falling into a pile of slurry, well, she didn't push him and it certainly served the bastard right. So far, so good!

She really shoulda known better then to expect her plans to ever pan out.

The Wastes was aptly named, and not where her ticket had been to, but it's not like she'd had much of a choice either.

Luckily, when the fucker tried to corner her and steal her watch, she'd been cognizant enough to fight him off and lucky enough to have her rucksack on her at the time. Because shortly thereafter the bruisers, who were apparently in on this little robbery, blamed her for it and hauled her sorry ass to the nearest connection...and threw her off the train for fighting... while it was moving. Catra had gotten luckier this time in that she was tossed onto some very nice soft sand, saving her from any broken bones or real injuries besides a few small bruises. The down side was she'd gotten sand everywhere and had to walk back through the Wastes to the town they'd just passed at full speed.

The Crimson Waste. A well known hotspot for thieves and killers and worse. It was a genuinely wild part of the west with all sorts of gangs ever fighting over a piece of shit in the middle of nowhere. The Horde had been "above" the Crimson Waste with no need to squabble and almost as soon as she'd set foot she could understand why anyone with a lick of sense in 'em would turn their nose up.

God she *hated* this fucking town.

She'd tried to find a damn numbers job, she was tired of her body aching from hard labor and frankly didn't care to get thrown from one more train if she could help it. She'd been practicing best she could keep the math in her head and posing fake questions to herself like it was a damned test. It wasn't like before, but she could at least keep on task with it. But all the paper and book jobs were crooked as hell, and worse, some of them appeared to be gang related. It was almost impossible to sort the few genuine jobs from illegal side gigs, and she had no damn desire to go back down that road. Because even if they hired ya without you knowing, when someone decided to take you out it made your options real slim. Between the never really getting out till you were dead part, and the fact that someone could figure out she was Horde it just wasn't worth her time or life.

So, sufficiently desperate, Catra had gone back to the train station to beg for a job.

And after almost five months combined of nearly starving and camping in the wilderness both before and after the most recent train eviction, Catra had finally gotten a steady, well paying position *and* got permission to sleep in the station when not on duty. She'd been too relieved about finally catching a break to care much about the working conditions. Soon as she could get a horse she was gonna get out of this shit hole town anyhow, and then possibly ride back to Kyrtis Rail to trample the house manager. Hell, maybe even the damn coroner too! Then, by golly, THEN she was finally going to get moving on this damned goal of hers! After all this desert she'd determined that she'd go live in Plumeria. According to Glimmer's friend Perfuma, the place was filled with wildflower meadows and always in need of ranch hands.

Catra was gonna go work there and build a little awful cabin right on a meadow of flowers, and then she'd live there till she found some sort of peace or fucking died. Whichever came first at this point.

Her new plan had been going near perfectly. Starting with buying her horse.

It was a beautiful black appaloosa with the cutest bald face and a white blanket just at the base of its neck. Sure, she'd heard about them and their striped hooves, but she hadn't actually seen one before. Gorgeous is what they was! While Catra had originally avoided the horse just based on its coloration, striking marks like that had made Catra rightfully assume it would be mighty expensive, she kept going back to it for it's damn personality. Not that it was a sweet thing, oh no. Quite the opposite, it musta bit someone at least twice a week and once almost killed a drunk idiot with a kick. That horse was an asshole and a bastard, and she was kind of falling in love with it. And then it started going to *her* . Nickering gently when she was in a good mood and sometimes stomping or nipping when she was in a foul one. It

was, god, it was so nice to feel understood. Sad as it was that her first real connection since leaving Etheria was with a damned horse, but she really couldn't find it in herself to care much as he playfully stole her hat. Her face would damn well hurt by the time she'd leave the stable from all her smiling.

That horse was the one good thing in the whole of the Crimson Waste.

Glimmer would love him . Catra had thought one day while sneaking him an apple she'd swiped from a particularly crotchety old man, and that had sunk her. Now she *had* to get him. When she'd finally arrived with the money, the giant of a woman who was selling them had chuckled. Apparently she'd been watching Catra mooning over the horse for months now. She still *took* the money of course, but had included all the basic essentials she'd need to ride him for free.

"He is an ornery bastard to everyone but you, and you seem about ready to steal him." she'd said, a few strands of white hair fell out of her ponytail as she'd laughed, "Might as well sell him and get it over with kid. I ain't gonna miss Melog one damn bit, so do me a favor? When he gets you good and your all crying about it? **Don't** bring him back."

She was only a little embarrassed about how offended she'd been on behalf of a damn *horse* she had owned for all of thirty seconds. She was a lot more embarrassed by the way each time she looked at him, all she could think about was how cute he was. Glimmer Moon throws you off a train one time and apparently you picked up her sense of aesthetics as part of the deal. All the same, she'd taken the freebies.

The only downside to buying Melog was it had eaten up all her cash. Every single cent and dollar she'd been earning for a good half year dried up quicker than a puddle in the summer. Meaning she couldn't buy proper supplies to ride out. Water skins, preserved goods, first aid, hatchets and knives, and hopefully a firearm for hunting of some kind. None of it was cheap and

certainly none of it was available even at a normal price within the limits of the Crimson Waste. Catra hadn't wanted to wait too long after having enough money to get him out of fear someone else would buy him right up. Which, sure, it was a bit irrational seeing as no one had bought him the whole time she'd been there, but she wasn't going to risk losing him.

Catra carefully cared for him, hitching him close to her little makeshift bed to chase off anyone looking to steal him. But she needn't have worried at all, the one time someone tried that Melog *did* kick the fucker in the head and killed him. She was, perhaps, a little more proud of that than she shoulda been but oh well. Melog was there, every morning and every evening, and always pleased as punch when she spent time with him. The first thing that seemed happy to see her in a long time. Catra would rather die than admit how often she'd gone out there just to feel him nuzzle into her and have a good cry about it. Melog might still bite on occasion and his mischievous streak wasn't cute when it fucked her over, but Catra could say this: He had been absolutely worth it.

So she had to adjust her plan again, so what? Nothing had gone smoothly since its inception and Plumeria weren't going nowhere either. She'd work a little longer here, then go ride out and see if any sheep herds needed someone to watch them. The little ramshackle cabin in her mind shifted to be a little barn they could both live in. Melog could enjoy the grass under his hooves and eat all the damn vegetation he pleased, and if all Catra did with her life was survive to give him the life he deserved, then that was what she was gonna do!

And save and provide she did, hell, it even went well!

Until it had gone horribly wrong.

Really it was her own damn fault for expecting life to give her a break after giving her something so damned nice.

The rail yard was pathetic and always short on workers. Few folks cared to help with freight trains and it wasn't like there was a pedestrian stop for them to turn to their advantage. So Catra worked a lot of odd jobs. She manned the post office most days, helped load and unload wagons as needed, and occasionally chased off people who thought they could just pick up a box of whatever happened to be coming through. Mostly she was there as "security", although security without a firearm seemed a bit funny in her opinion, since the few lines that did stop had their own employees to handle it all.

That particular day at the station though, even the rail line had been short on folks, so Catra offered to assist for a nominal fee to speed up her own departure. The engineer had been relieved and paid her five dollars promptly before ignoring her, especially once she made a few recommendations to make the process smoother and safer next go around. *Idiots* , she'd thought to herself in a resigned huff. Not like she'd spent most of her life working either with, on, or around trains after all so what could she possibly know? So Catra had rolled her eyes and ignored him right back, instead going to babysit a coupla kids who were running top side. And she meant that literally, they couldn't be much older than fifteen or so and despite riding together neither had uncoupled a wagon, and that meant that coupling like they needed to do was just that much worse. Catra had been determined to let them figure it out with minimal input from her but...well…

One of them had her hair up in a ponytail so tight Catra's head hurt to look at it. She crossed her arms to tap her fingers and hummed nervously as she watched Catra's demonstration. She rattled off instructions like a canyon echoing them back and the way she'd looked hopefully towards her for praise on a job well done almost broke her fucking heart. The other was a kind and thoughtful type, well meaning but not always paying attention. Their curly hair didn't need anything to be secured up on their head, and their horrible sense of humor threatened to make Catra smile. The resemblance to her old friends was so damned strong that she actually debated asking them for a hug before getting a hold of herself.

They weren't her friends, they were strangers trying to do a damned job and she was here to help them. And, ultimately, that attachment and responsibility she'd felt to a couple of kids was what did her in.

Catra had been hurt in a lot of stupid ways, but never like this.

They'd nearly been done when the girl was in the wrong place with her timing completely fucked for the task, and Catra had panicked. Because there wasn't *time* for a mistake here, not as the 50 ton loaded wagon was closing in regardless of where they was. And that girl? She was right in the damned way. Catra had rushed, not even thinking as she yanked the girl's hand away, only for the kid's long denim sleeve to catch on something. Catra had a sudden terrible realization, if she couldn't get this girl freed she'd lose an arm. And she couldn't fucking tear a denim jacket. Losing an arm out here was a damned death sentence and for a moment Catra had forgotten who she was trying to save exactly.

So she'd reached in and managed to unhook the snag, and luckily the girl had given a wildly frantic tug getting free of that trap.

And unluckily for Catra, she hadn't been quick enough to do the same.

The pain had been worse than anything she'd ever experienced in her life, and that was saying something considering the whipping and burns and beatings and worse. Pain so intense, that if she'd eaten a thing that day she'd have thrown it up instantly. There was *nothing* to compare the nonstop agony to. It still hurt these days too, but when it first happened...honestly she's not sure how it just didn't kill her outright.

The worst part though, had been just how gruesome her injury had ultimately been. She'd managed to get most of her hand down in time, but the fingers that had gotten caught had looked like exploded sausages. The skin and fat hung limply from her palm and back of her hand. She could've gone her whole life

never seeing her own bones but Catra got front row tickets to bones, tendons, muscles, and more.

She didn't pass out, no that would've been merciful, the whole aftermath was just a blur of never ending suffering, choking on whiskey, and the taste of leather to help her not crack her damn teeth open. Catra was aware that they'd been dragging her somewhere, before some giant had picked her up and ran. One moment they were near the station and the next they were inside. Hands held her down after the whiskey and the belt and things went from a blur to an outright nightmare of awareness. The bone saw had hurt too, she'd have thought with the rest of the pain she'd been feeling then, that it wouldn't have even registered. She'd been *very* wrong. Somehow her whole hand lit up, the white hot feeling shooting up through her arm and shoulder. Some lightning snaked across her jaw and chest. And she still hadn't fully fucking passed out.

They'd rinsed it best they could, applied whatever they could, and then wrapped her up.

Of course life was funny, or at least thought it was funny. Catra had been pain mad for almost two weeks, barely cognizant and rarely lucid as she'd been taken care of. Blubbering on and on about her wife and going home, and how sorry she was apparently. Not that she really remembered that much, although the doc who treated her had kept extensive notes on her ramblings for future use. Whatever the hell that meant.

When she'd finally come to, Catra honestly thought she'd still been in a fever dream. Or dead.

She'd stumbled from her little cot, tucked into a room filled from top to bottom with gears and schematics out into the main room. The lights throbbing in time with her aching head as she recognized the table she'd been laid out on. She didn't even remember what she'd been trying to do as she smacked into a cabinet full of medical supplies. But the next thing she knew, a too familiar shadow had fallen over her. "Hey, you shouldn't be up

yet Wildcat! No, no, no! Come on, back to bed. Unless you need to relieve yourself? Do you need the pot? I can help!”

Scorpia had smiled down at her nervously, arms already gently circled around Catra’s waist as she started to walk them both back to the bed she’d just escaped. Her smile only grew more nervous as Catra stared, and then it broke as she started to gasp for air. She vaguely remembers that she’d started crying before she smacked her hand and passed out.

Entrapta promised it was due more to the amount of drugs in her system then from pain and she clung to that fact to make herself feel better about the whole situation. Especially considering that on waking again she been demanding to see Melog and hadn’t let up until she’d been escorted to her baby boy and back. Which may, or may not, have also resulted in a fainting incident. Catra was never going to live down the embarrassment of knowing she told Scorpia to keep his apples warm so his teeth wouldn’t hurt, even if she was never going to remember saying it.

It was a few more days till she was actually lucid after all.

It turned out that Scorpia had left the Horde not long after Catra had. In fact, she’d seen the wanted posters before anyone else and knew she needed to get out too. Catra felt like scum at that, because of course she had needed to leave once Catra was ousted, but had she ever once considered that? No. No, she’d always been too wrapped up in herself to consider it.

Scorpia had chuckled darkly as she told her story, tracing abstract shapes into the doctor’s table top with her hooks. “ *I mean, they already got my hands you know?* ” Oh Catra knew. She’d spent a long time staring, it wasn’t that she hadn’t seen the hooks before, Catra had helped Scorpia learn to function with the two wood and leather contraptions she’d gotten at first until you’d never guess she hadn’t been born with them. It had been the least she could do after Hordak had ordered her to cut them off herself, and she’d shaken so badly that she’d missed the first cut and went into her hand.

So, yeah, Catra fucking knew about that one.

When she nodded mutely, Scorpia continued a bit more cheerfully, "I didn't know where you were though, you know? I tried going to Erlandia in case they gotcha, but that didn't pan out. And the sheriff didn't exactly believe me when I said I was a bounty hunter looking for leads on you."

They'd both gotten a chuckle out of that. Catra could only picture Scorpia walking into the jail house, looking intimidating as hell and then saying something like, " *Oh hey, excuse me, don't mean to bother, but I'm a very bad person who's a bounty hunter for sure and I'm looking for that no good rotten person who burned the barn. Got any leads on that, friend?* " Scorpia had doubled over with laughter on hearing it, because apparently she wasn't that far off the mark for what actually happened.

"Yeah, after that absolute debacle I had to make an educated guess. So I went, Scorpia, think, where would Catra most likely go? And I figured, you shoulda been running the Horde by that point, since, ya know, you basically were, so you'd go somewhere your talents would be appreciated. And hey! I was right!" Scorpia clicked her hooks together with a smile.

"Well, you were wrong," Entrapta had cut in rather bluntly, "but you both made it here anyways so that's what counts I suppose!"

Entrapta herself was a character and a half, and it was probably best that they'd been introduced while Catra was high off her ass on morphine. Feeling all warm and safe, and half asleep, she had gotten to work through the good doctor's peculiarities with a calm objectiveness that she wouldn't have otherwise.

Entrapta had come to the Crimson Waste rather like Catra herself had, completely by accident. Woman woulda been a quack slinging snake oil if it weren't for how damned good she was at her job, and after showing little interest in the politics of the town and having no sense of self preservation in the face of violent criminals, the whole place had simply agreed that the doc's office

was neutral ground. Not that Entrapta knew this, no. Scorpia had told her to watch her mouth when some small fry boss was in for stitches because she didn't care to have Entrapta defuse another bomb while they were living there too. Catra had decided that she didn't need to know more than that, and spent her time mostly sleeping or listening to their stories. From how they'd met and become friends to their own little adventures, she couldn't do much more than listen really. Entrapta had all sorts of technological designs that seemed the wrong side of batty and Scorpia was a hired hand which never failed to make the large woman laugh. Catra learned an unfortunate number of hand jokes those first few cognizant weeks, and their hilarity slowly lessened along with the morphine doses Entrapta would give her.

So as much as Entrapta unnerved Catra, she cared about Scorpia and that was all that mattered.

In fact, it mattered even more when she realized that Scorpia literally didn't expect Catra to explain a damned thing. That had made her a weepy mess all over again, which scared Scorpia half to death apparently. It was a shock to the system to realize how much she'd actually changed, and God help her, she'd...she'd been a terrible friend. She tried to tell her right there and then, but all it did was leave her a pathetic blubbering mess. She'd left her friend to die and didn't even have the fucking backbone to tell her what had happened to her.

Catra had resolved to tell her everything. The good, the bad, and the ugly.

It took a few days to pry it all out of her chest. The things she hadn't told anyone. The Moons, the life she'd been settling into, getting herself better with her numbers and letters, and more. The proposal and the plans and the way it crashed down around her ears. The arrest took a few days to get through, because Scorpia had been rather hung up on how much Catra wanted to die leading up to it. And she understood why, she did, but god damn she was tired of feeling sorry for herself and this wasn't really about her. Scorpia *deserved* to know, and so she was telling

her. Afterwards, Catra had tried for days to apologize for leaving Scorpia behind, but the words never came right. When she had finally managed to choke out a meager apology, Scorpia had shot over the damn moon.

And weirdly enough so had Entrapta.

"Thank you. For telling her and for apologizing to her."

Catra blinked slowly, her hand was in throbbing pain that night but she'd insisted on staying to help Entrapta clean up after Scorpia broke a jar of some kind and had to lay down from the fumes. "...You're thanking me...for apologizing?"

"Yes! It means a lot to me because it means a lot to her. More than you know." Entrapta had tilted her head quizzically and Catra found herself entranced waiting for her messily piled up buns to fall apart. Honestly, if it wasn't for the whole quack doctor/mad inventor thing, the woman's strange hair would've been her most interesting feature. Not quite chestnut, not quite auburn, almost purplely looking under the right light and always piled in ways that seemed to defy gravity. "...you hurt her really badly, you know?"

She'd flushed with shame, blinking away tears as she carefully picked up a few jars that had fallen when Scorpia knocked the cabinet. "Yeah… I… I tend to do that."

"But! You are working on it, and that's commendable. So. Thank you!" Entrapta had smiled blisteringly bright before noticing a cracked jar Catra was handling and cooed. "Oooo, this should've exploded while you were handling it! Tell me, was there any heat? Bubbling? Anything odd? Don't spare the details!"

Catra had gone to bed grateful to still have one fully intact hand and with a weight lifted off her shoulders.

It hadn't felt like nearly enough for how big of a deal they both made it out to be, but that was just typical of her wasn't it? When she'd finally managed to voice that thought, Scorpia had nearly crushed her to death while Entrapta theorized that Catra's self

loathing and quiet guilt had been blamed as a problem with pain management.

Which, well, wasn't *completely* wrong.

When they'd finally gotten her morphine down to barely enough to make a difference, which she had been frustrated to realize was well before the pain was completely gone, Catra had decided to try and trust them on this one. She had been doing better before the accident, hadn't she? Had a plan, was feeling hopeful, didn't even think about killing herself for almost a whole year and that had to count for something.

Especially considering how all her plans felt like so much dust thanks to the injury. She had a vague idea of the damage after Entrapta had been a little *too* happy to ramble on about the technicalities and even lent her a textbook to understand at least some of what she'd said. The gist of it, as later explained painfully slowly by the doctor was, "Biiiiiiig cruuuUUUuuush destroyed inteeeeegrity of your fIIIIiiiingers. So I had to saw them off to prevent gaaaaaaaAAAAaaaaaaAAAngreeeeeeeene. Wait. You do know what gangrene is, right?"

Which would've felt condescending, but by the time Entrapta had started to mime out a sawing motion Catra decided it was probably for the best to just nod her head and keep her damned mouth shut.

The only thing for it was to keep busy and ignore it, so Catra got back to work helping to clear some of the paperwork that Entrapta had allowed to pile up over the years.

"No one's asked for it though?" Entrapta said and Catra was horrified to realize that she was not only a bean counter, but apparently someone who had opinions on **filing systems** .

The invoices, letters, patient records, and more needed a good sorting before she could really get to it, but it was busy work for

her brain and appreciated all the more for it. And as she worked, the more time she got to spend with Scorpia and Entrapta both.

Sure, it was annoying at times, but Catra had already realized how desperately she missed just...being with people. The hugs and pokes, the jokes and stories, all of it a strange sort of camaraderie from a bunch of loners who, for some reason, had finally found a place to be.

Which was great! Except for the part where Catra sometimes waxed a little poetic about her silly daydreams of going back to Etheria. Plumeria had been a nice dream, and she'd let herself have a little more as she imagined moving back into town. On her own this swung wildly between everyone jumping her for showing her face, and everyone just accepting her presence.

It was Scorpia who sighed dreamily one day, the romantic fool, and said, "That sounds so nice, Catra. You were always better than this anyways, so you should do it!"

"Do what?" She'd mumbled, trying to determine what the hell the letter she was holding even said. Some people's handwriting was just too damned fancy.

"Go home! Get your girl! You know, live that good life."

Catra had not reacted well to such an outrageous suggestion, and even as she'd stormed away she knew she was being an ass. It was exactly what she wanted, but nothing she could have, and having someone else fall in favor of her silly dreams was a new type of heartache. Melog had let her stumble wildly between ranting and thinking aloud before blocking the exit to glare down at her imperiously. And when she'd eventually sat on the hay covered floor to have a quick cry, he'd laid down beside her for pets. The whole thing was outrageous, she didn't even know *why* she was crying!

But the next morning, well, things seemed clearer.

She was tired, she missed her friends, she missed her home, and she missed the woman she loved. Catra wanted to go back. She wanted it more than anything, but she didn't understand Glimmer. Didn't know what *Glimmer* wanted, because the woman seemed ready to tip any which way and yet, she'd made her stance on them very damned clear. Hadn't she? *They why'd she let you go?* She couldn't see the logic, didn't understand it at all. It was like one of those metal puzzles that Entrapta loved so much. The solution was most likely simple, and Catra just couldn't see it yet. And making the wrong choice could just ruin everything all over again, or worse. Her life already felt like it could be a trashy penny novel, she didn't need to seal the deal by trying some over the top romantic declaration of love just to get shot.

But Catra just couldn't keep her damn mouth shut.

"Well, maybe all three of us could go then." Scorpia tapped at the table and Catra pushed a few coins into the pile, which Entrapta met without looking up from her notebook. "You know? I'd love to see it!"

Catra squinted at her cards trying to understand how they'd gotten from talking about the latest shoot out to this, before it all clicked. "Scorpia, I cain't just go back like that."

The giant of a woman burst out in a cold sweat, which was impressive considering they were going through a heat wave. "Sure you can!"

"No, I really can't-"

"Technically you can, but you don't want to." Entrapta supplied as she laid out both her and Scorpia's cards.

Catra twitched as she looked at Entrapta's second royal flush of the night. "Don't semantics me Dr. Cheats At Cards."

Scorpia had gasped, glaring at her, "Catra! How dare you? Entrapta'd nev-"

“Oh, are we not cheating?” Entrapta asked, finally looking up from her notebook. “I assumed we were after you swiped that ace.”

Scorpia’s sad look was the cherry pit on the shit Sunday, especially considering her own cheating hadn’t even worked! Desperate to move them along, she’d quickly choked out, “I’ll think about it, but I’m not promising nothing!”

Like she wasn’t already swirling in endless circles over this. She just couldn’t picture any future that didn’t involve Glimmer. As the weeks went on, Scorpia’s suggestion sounded better and better. They could all go, all three of them moving closer at the very least. Scorpia seemed pretty hooked on the idea and Entrapta hadn’t seemed to care all that much. There were all those little towns nearby, maybe they could hole up in Alwyn, or someplace like it. A day's ride by train, with plenty of grass for Melog. She just, it was dumb, but Catra felt like she was just waiting for a sign.

She’d heard the saying careful what you wish for, and even understood it. By god did she not listen though.

“Catra, this one’s yours!” Entrapta basically shouted, despite them sitting so close together, and then tossed a small envelope towards her.

She didn’t even respond, assuming it was something for the files until she actually looked at it. It was addressed to her. Catra squinted at that in confusion, no one even knew where the hell she was so how did she get a letter? She carefully ripped it open and unfolded the top of the letter to get a sense of what it could be.

Catra D’riluth, as the sworn mayor of Erelandia, this is official notification of your bounty being paid in full, removing your charges from active status and rescinding your bounty.

...what? She read just the opening line a few times. Then read it aloud under her breath to make sure it was right. Unfolding the

rest caused yet another scrap of paper to drop out. One with familiar handwriting.

Hey Catra,

Congratulations and I hope you can start anew. You might want to thank Deputy Glimmer Moon the next time you see her as well as Doctor Vesselak for writing your location.

Sincerely,

Adora Gray

She barely clocked the familiar signature with a small hum when the enormity of what she'd read crashed into her. Her ears rang and eyes stung, nose stuffed up properly. Because this had to be a dream right? A dream, or a trick, or- or- or-

"Are you alright?" Entrapta asked, startling her with a light touch to her freshly healed hand.

Catra had fled, staggering to the stables as every fear and every hope crashed together in a horrible symphony. *I knew that kiss meant something!* Why would she do this? *This is a trick, Adora's in on it and they're just gonna turn me in and-* Why would she do it **now** ? *"Please ensure that you thank miss Moon."* The burning rage she understood, the cold shoulder she understood, but this was- it didn't make sense. *Unless she's forgiving you.* But that couldn't be it, it couldn't. She'd spent so many damned years drifting because what she'd done was unforgivable, she couldn't be- *"You might want to thank Deputy Moon."*

She had barely noticed what she was doing, before she'd made it to Melog. The horse stamped and huffed, nervous just because she was in a tizzy. Catra just sat with him, letting him push his giant head into her arms and nibbling at her hair. His soft nose tickled as she quietly settled back into herself and felt roughly like she'd been trampled. A nap sounded amazing, but her exhaustion was no match for a half ton of pure muscled baby.

Melog chomped down hard around her shirt collar and yanked her nearly upright. Catra *did not* squeak as her heart pounded from the shock. When she glared incredulously at him, Melog only turned to look out towards the desert and look pleadingly at her.

Catra was, rightfully, offended. "Excuse you? Like hell we're going for a ride! I have a big damn decision to make and I-"

But Melog stomped again, cutting her off before he looked out again. This time Catra realized he wasn't looking towards the mesa, but actually up. Towards the moon.

For fuck's sake. "Seriously?!"

He seemed almost excited as she looked at the moon herself. *I'm trying to fight with a horse,* she thought glumly. This had to be her lowest. Glimmer would laugh herself blue if she could see this. Her heart gave a painful whump at the thought, because that could actually happen. Catra could go home and tell her all about this, and she would take all the teasing that would come with it. The weight of Adora's letter in her pocket was only making her wonder again what the point of it all was.

Wait a minute.

Catra roughly shoved Melog's head away, checking for damages from his rooting around for a snack, and was not surprised when he turned to look at the moon *again* .

She couldn't help but bark out a laugh. "You're either scared of that damn rock or very insistent."

This time Melog didn't try to dig into her pocket, just huffed hard enough at it to get a little spittle and snot on it. Like he was trying to tell her what he thought.

"...seriously, can you understand me?" Catra waited a moment, unsure what she was looking for. "Whinny for yes, blink twice for no."

Melog stared at her pocket like the secret to the universe was there before blinking once.

"I'm talking to a horse." Catra groaned into her hands, then chuckled. She was just coming up with excuses now. She'd needed a moment alone, desperately. And now that she'd had it, her mind was pushing towards an obvious conclusion.

Yes, this was, in a way, Glimmer forgiving her, but it was also Glimmer trying to forget her. Her own internal want so heady and clear to her, that she was panicking over a fiction. Adora and Glimmer mean that they want to move on, that everyone needs to just move past this, not that they had actually forgiven her. Afterall, forgiveness is for people who make mistakes, not murderers. This wasn't the cherry of a cigarette starting a fire, it had been her own two hands and the desperate desire to start it. That's all it is. That's all it can ever be.

But then...why…? *"You might want to thank Deputy Moon."* Like she would see Glimmer again. Like they would do more than pretend they didn't know one another. Why say that if they want to move on?

Melog huffed at her and Catra stared into his deep brown eyes before the narrative slipped.

No, that's **not** how Glimmer does things. Glimmer Moon does not forget a slight, she holds a damned grudge until the day she dies. She doesn't half ass anything that she could slam through with her whole heart and soul. And Adora- ha! Adora? Taking the easy

route? Letting someone walk all over her?! It's laughable, she actually snorts a little thinking about it. That ain't them!

"Self sabotage," Entrapta said with all the authority of a professional diagnosis, hell, maybe it even was. "You are afraid of an outcome, so you cause it yourself."

"That's stupid." And Catra had never heard anything stupider in her life.

"Meeehhhh," Entrapta shrugged, "debatable. But you still look for the worst outcomes and then work towards them."

Well god damn it all to hell. She was doing that wasn't she? Assuming the worst and then taking the easiest action she could to prove it. She **wanted** to go back, and the two of them were sending her an invitation for it. Sure, it weren't worded clearly like that, but where words were lacking actions spoke loudly. It was like that year before she left all over again, they'd all done their damndest to be there for her and Catra had just kept pushing them out. And here she was doing it *again* like a moron.

*" **I'm** the dramatic one!?" Glimmer had gasped in only half feigned outrage. "Are you* hearing *yourself right now Catra D'riluth? Woman, do not make me get up and go over there!"*

When Glimmer inevitably did get up it was for a slap so soft it was like a gentle pat and a few kisses.

Catra mindlessly stroked Melog's neck as a plan formed steadily in her mind, whispering her thanks for his patience. It still took a while for her to find the energy to go back to the office, not that she even got to the door before it was flung open hard enough to nearly come off the hinges. And then she'd been scooped up into a crushing hug as Scorpia hauled them both inside where a very sheepish Entrapta was waiting.

"I'm sorry. I thought I could help if I wrote, test the waters so to speak. Was it Glimmer?" Entrapta twisted her fingers together at Catra's confusion. "The letter? I wasn't sure if she'd appreciate

hearing from me since I stopped writing back, but I wrote Bow instead and-”

Catra's head was throbbing. “Wait, wait, wait. You wrote Bow? How do you know Bow?”

“Because...I used to write... Glimmer?”

“WHAT!?”

Entrapta looked at Scorpia for help, but she looked as confused as Catra felt. So the good doctor continued on. “I told you that after you said Glimmer was your wife.”

“When I- wait. Do you mean when I was high on painkillers?” Catra held up a hand to stop the answer. “You know what? Doesn’t matter right now. Were you two serious about...about coming with me? About me going and trying to...”

Scorpia smiled warmly, her voice was soft but filled to the brim with happiness. “Yeah we are.”

Catra carefully slid the letter to them, and waited until Entrapta finished reading it aloud for Scorpia’s benefit in the low lighting. “Well good, ‘cause I think it’s time.”

They stayed up until well past sunrise, plotting and planning how to make it all actually work, building from the framework she provided. Which was how Catra found herself being ganged up on to leave first, seeing as uprooting would take Entrapta a long while yet as she refused to leave anything behind. She could at least, somewhat, understand not wanting to give up anything after selling parts of her own past off, but she also knew if she had to stand around and watch Entrapta wax poetic over some doohickey she named a scant minute prior, Catra would be less than helpful here. Besides, it would be at least a half year before Entrapta would be ready even with Scorpia’s help, and the idea of waiting that long made Catra’s skin crawl.

Scorpia waved her hooks in a way that Catra could only assume was supposed to look like finger guns. "You gotta strike while the iron's hot!" She wasn't *wrong* , although Catra begged her to never do that again. If this was a sign, and she was going to take it as one damn it! She was ready- more than ready! She was done letting opportunities slip through her fingers, and this time it had been Glimmer reaching out to her. Glimmer implying something better than a life wasted in the red sand of the Wastes.

The kiss had meant Glimmer still cared, and the bounty proved it. It meant something alright, it meant something pretty darn good too!

Catra smiled softly as she hit the last switch back, reigning Melog in as she saw her friends still waving goodbye to her from the edge of town, before letting him run as wild and free as he wanted. She leaned in close to his neck, grinning ear to ear as they went.

She was finally going home.

Chapter End Notes

Am I a terrible person? Yes, absolutely :D

By hey, hey, hey, glitra start to really interact again starting next chapter! So, accolades please!

Chapter 18: You Know What They Say About Bad Habits

Chapter Summary

> "Are you telling me you don't want to warm up some?" Catra teased, her smirk so familiar and warming it felt like sunshine.
>
> She threw her hands up dramatically, scoffing, "Ugh! See you never got less annoying!"
>
> Catra just laughed again where a younger her woulda pushed back with a wicked but mean type of humor. Of course, that didn't mean she was going to pass up her chance any more than Glimmer had. "Now don't go hurtin' all three of my feelings before I even get a chance to say thank you properly!"
>
> She couldn't help but cackle, slipping into their banter was easier than putting on her favorite skirt, "Oh land's sake, three whole feelings? Look at you, all grown up ain'tcha!"

Chapter Notes

> As always, a huge thank you and shout out to dragonesdepapel for beta reading and editing this for me!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The last few years had not been the kindest to Glimmer, and yet she could say that it hadn't been cruel neither. With her quest for vengeance cooled, she'd found herself somewhat at odds with life.

There'd been, at least to start, some initial things to keep her occupied after she'd returned. Painful but ultimately mundane things. Such as going to her mother's house the morning after she'd returned. It should've been simple to go visit her own mother, but the years stood between them and turned Glimmer's

stomach into some kind of soured mess before she even set foot inside. Her timid knock and nervous smile were not missed by Mister Pop, who didn't smile back as he took her hat and coat, but did guide her with a hand on her lower back.

Her mother was mid bite of what looked like the fluffiest pancakes, reaching for her coffee absentmindedly, when Glimmer made it to the dining room. And oh, she'd seen her mother mad plenty of times, sure. But "spit out her bite of food directly onto her plate while knocking over her drink" mad? Well, it was just a whole new level for Glimmer to feel ashamed of.

"H-hi mom, I, uh-"

"What in the world did you think you were doing young lady!?"

There had been a brief flash of anger at being talked to like a child, and then it snuffed out. She stood quietly and took the earful as respectfully as she could, because she got it now. It wasn't her mom trying to lord anything over her, or tell her she was lesser. Her mother loved her, and Glimmer had just vanished without a word or thought. Ironically, it seemed her acceptance was what snapped her mother out of it. The shouting dwindled until it faded into a scared whisper.

"...Glimmer...Glimmer, what happened?"

She almost wished that her mom would keep chewing her out. Glimmer's answer started strong and ended mumbled. "I found a lead on, uhm, Catra."

"What?" Angella asked, wide eyed and shocked. Hell, she actually collapsed back into her seat.

Glimmer had winced, but plowed on. "I-I said I left 'cause I got a lead on Catra. ...and I found her."

There was a long pause before her mother looked at her, with her face unreadable. "Glimmer, what **happened** ?"

It had been as mortifying to burst into tears explaining it all as it had been so great a comfort to finally tell her *everything* .

How they'd been falling apart for a long time before Catra left. She felt so *seen* when her mother's face had gone stone cold with fury on learning what Catra had done. The quest Glimmer had given herself, finding Catra again ("With Krytis!?" Angella had gasped.), heck even the failed arrest. It was so warming and plain ol' heartening to watch her soften when Glimmer explained the accident.

Because it was an accident.

But she also sort of hated that. How did everyone else find it so easy to forgive, and Glimmer herself hadn't? Couldn't?

They sat quietly together to let Angella process it all, and Glimmer, who had been such a devoted lover to her anger, was left stinging from her mother's quick acceptance. Or, no, that wasn't quite right was it? It was embarrassment at how long it had taken her to get there. At least a large part of it was, she was sure of it. She breathed in slowly through her nose and exhaled through her mouth, forcing tears back before they could fall. Glimmer had made this all about herself for a long time, and now she wanted to just be here instead. God it was hard when she still felt raw.

"Are...are you okay?" Glimmer reached over and held her hand loosely.

Angella's breath had hitched as she shook her head, and Glimmer understood. There were no words for the mixture of relief, and pain, and anger, and mourning. To know with finality that it was truly over. To have gotten the last piece of the puzzle in place and to still feel no closure...god, Glimmer wanted to be *angry* .

Instead she just sat with it. Felt it slowly drain out in a way she'd never felt before. Glimmer held her mother's delicate hand in her own calloused one and just let herself breathe. She spent the

whole morning with her mother, talking and, eventually, even laughing and crying as they swapped stories about the two most important people they'd lost. The pain coming and going, but more like a sunset than a fire. Ever changing colors in the clouds that cooled each time you looked rather than an errant cigarette catching the forest underbrush a flame. When they finally finished late in the night she'd stumbled to her old bedroom and slept like a damn rock.

It took another night and some odd change of sleep before she'd been ready to talk to Bow. And while it hurt, she was almost glad that *someone* was mad with her. Almost.

He'd almost been more willing to listen at the start of her apology but by the end he was closed off and all the hurt he'd been pushing back reared its ugly head as she desperately tried to finish strong. "The things I did, the things I said? I was wrong. I'm really, really sorry, Bow." She'd been reaching to put her hand over his, but he yanked it away before she could.

"Yeah." He winced before trying again. "I- I get that you're sorry, and I really appreciate the apology. But do you get why it's hard to trust you, when you haven't really trusted us?"

Glimmer bit her tongue as she nodded. He'd spent years trying to help her, years where she'd been nothing but alternatingly sad and clingy, and more frequently cold and distant. She understood the effort he'd put in, the energy devoted to it…the way you could just give away parts of yourself for someone you love until you had nothing left. Maybe even understood it better than most. Sure, Bow hadn't gone as far as Glimmer had when Catra had been struggling that last year, and thank goodness for small mercies! But he'd reached to her, time and again, and his attempts had nearly stopped. It was her own damn fault on this one.

"I just…" Bow finally reached over and squeezed her hand quickly, jerkily like he couldn't decide if he really wanted to appease her or not. "Give me some time."

It was well after the fact that Glimmer would realize it was a real request and something of a test. She gave him time and even space, but didn't shy away when they did interact. Awkwardly smiling and doing her best to be both cheerfully polite and not flippant. The next time they sat and talked was at his dad's house, waiting to see if George had something worse than a concussion. It wasn't warm, but it was less hard all the same. It took a few more talks, re-hashing events and prying every last shard of her feelings into the open before Bow could do much more than smile awkwardly at her.

That was worth it, even if they weren't completely normal again, that alone had been worth the effort.

Strangely enough, the talking had helped *her* far more than she'd expected it to. With her mom, Adora, and Bow all sharing their feelings and hearing her out, it started to click into place. Her frustration swirled for a few months in the bottom of her heart, draining away talk by talk and day by day to leave her chest aching. But at least it was finally empty of coals.

"You know, sometimes I would daydream about my one of my brothers finding her. Catra, that is." Bow chuckled sadly, letting the gentle sway of Archer soothe him during their first ride together in years. They'd talked about everything and nothing on that well worn trail, funny how wild this ride seemed to her at the ripe old age of seventeen. She hadn't been expecting *that* little confession though. "I thought about how I'd go out there and talk to her. Maybe it would be like when she lived with us, you know? All hissing and bark, with some bite to back it up. Other times, she would hear me out and agree to come home. And we'd both come back, and you'd be…"

Glimmer did her best to not squeeze her legs or choke the reins as he whispered, voice choked with tears, "You'd be happy again. I missed you so damn much, and you weren't even gone."

She scooted closer to take his hand, riding side by side along the small arroyo.

“I kinda was though.” Glimmer sighed. “And I missed you too. I missed all y’all so damn much and it weren’t no one’s fault but my own.”

It was a simple fact, but not something she’d have recognized a few short months prior. And it felt *good* to admit to it now, like losing a tooth. A slight pain, a tug and pop, and then relief. So she kept at it, slowly but surely she worked at it until one morning she found herself going into town early with a plan. See, she’d worked it through with everyone else who really mattered to her, everyone but one last soul. That’s what found Glimmer at the bank withdrawing the funds needed to make the payment. Looking at the now dull brass paneling and thinking more fondly than not about Catra making faces at her in it, she withdrew most of her savings without a second thought. God, life had been simple back then. They’d been young and in love, and it wasn’t like they was dead yet. There was time. They still had *time.*

So, cash in hand, Glimmer had gone directly to the jail house.

“Glimmer, you’re here early,” Adora called, unlocking the cell for its occupant to stagger outside. The woman cursed a few times but managed to stumble out the front door without issue. Glimmer recognized her as a drunken regular and paid her no never mind.

“Yeah. I’m, uh, I’m not punching in.” Glimmer waved Adora over to the desk and waited till they were both seated to pull out Catra’s wanted poster and the deceptively small stack of cash. Well, less a stack and more a pinch of cash. Eight whole bills in total. “Can I pay this here?”

Adora looked surprised before she smiled at her warmly, “You certainly can and I’ll handle the notifications. ...Glimmer? I’m proud of you.”

The bounty paid, the quest over, the lying and hiding over...she’d been unsure what to do with herself.

So, she first went back to writing her old friends. Apologizing for her lack of response and offering to help where she could. Scared as she was to open each response as they came, her friends were all just happy to hear from her. Writing to her all about the things happening in their lives, asking after her health and such. Only Frosta had even alluded to Catra with a simple, " *If you are in need of a hired gun, I have recently finished my shooting lessons.* " It was sweet, in it's own way. Even those who didn't still cared after she'd been such a terrible friend. They were all just too darn good for this world. Glimmer wasn't sure why they weren't angry but she also was not about to refuse them for accepting her apology. Instead, she was merely grateful.

Time began to slip by without her noticing for once. The only real changes came from her becoming comfortable in a way she hadn't felt in years, the kind you don't notice till it's gone, and letting herself enjoy all sorts of little things she'd pushed away for so long.

When Bow found some petrified wood, Glimmer took it fondly and displayed it proudly. When she found particularly pretty flowers or feathers, she took them home too. Her tintype from when she'd first been deputized no longer sat on the mantle as a reminder, instead now on the wall like any other to make room for a small landscape Adora had found in Razz's barn of all places. She'd tried to remember some of the more inventive dishes Catra had fumbled into something edible. Brought coffee home for the first time in too long, which had almost brought Adora to tears when she'd made a pot at the jail house.

"You don't understand," Adora almost moaned into her mug, gripping it tightly like someone was gonna knock it out of her hands, "Glimmer, I've been drinking salty and fishy coffee since you stopped. You don't understand- I love you, you don't get it, please tell me you're makin' coffee again forever and ever? I really, *really* hate tea, please say yer makin' coffee again!"

No amount of showing her how to, carefully, add the egg shells in to keep the grounds down or add a pinch (not a palm ful good

golly miss molly!) of salt to improve the flavor seemed to help. Why there were even fish bones to start with she didn't know, but after wasting enough beans she'd realized how out of her depth she was. Glimmer had tried to turn to Bow for help, but that only resulted in Bow showing up to the jailhouse to say howdy and get a cup for himself.

The traitor!

"You don't understand," Bow whimpered as he slowly sniffed and sipped at his coffee to savor it, "You really, really don't understand. Glimmer you are a coffee god, it's so good, and I missed it so much. You don't get it-"

Adora, triumphant and validated, and on her third cup of the day had crowed, "That's what I said!"

But she did get it. Glimmer could still remember the first time Catra had made her coffee and the way it changed her view of the brew. The countless attempts and patience she'd shown while teaching Glimmer how to make a drink so good it was sinful. Now they'd all had years of over-steeped, bitter tea and were well prepared for luxury again.

It weren't ever anything life changing, just… little things. So many little things that brought a comfort to her heart. One at a time she let it back in. In a way, let her back in. No longer associated with a betrayal, but with all the years of joy from before. All tinted golden in the light of her memories.

So of course, something *had* to give.

She'd been out of her house for two whole days thanks to a group of travelers stirring up trouble. Each attempt to go home for some proper sleep foiled to the point that she'd only got a handful of hours on a cell cot. She was exhausted. Just… too tired to do much. So she'd let Bright Wing mosey at his own pace, more asleep than awake in the saddle and hoping she wouldn't take a tumble. She'd never live it down, because sure and sugar they

had never let Catra live it down either. It was times like this that living so far away felt like a horrible decision. And that was with the town having grown enough that her ride through the forest was cut in half. Between the ride and the whole getting snowed in during the winter thing, sometimes her home made her ache for her childhood bed. Glimmer shivered as a frigid breeze shot through her very soul, like just thinking about a snow in had called it down. Yup. She knew it was probably still coming, snows were late this year and if it came down at all she was going to be trapped.

"Probably," Glimmer's jaw cracked painfully as she yawned, "gracious! Probably need to get more food a'fore then."

Bright Wing didn't respond, at least not to her. Instead, he pulled up hard before reaching the clearing around the house and nervously whinnied. Glimmer looked around blearily before realizing there was a horse tied up out front. A beautiful black and white speckled thing, it turned to look at her revealing a full bald face to boot. At any other time, she would've been in love and tried to pet it, but it was a *stranger's* horse at *her damn house* . Honestly, after all the trouble they'd been she wouldn't put it past those assholes to look for a little retribution. And if it weren't them, then it surely was nothing better. So Glimmer quickly slid out of her saddle and drew her gun. Listening intently as she tied Bright Wing sloppily to a tree, Glimmer walked quietly as she could in the dried pine needles and twigs only to half jump at a few loud bangs.

That was out back. Was someone trying to rob her? Or steal a horse? Or-

The banging started again and Glimmer realized it was rhythmical...and it sounded like hammering. What in the hell?

Giving the mysterious horse a wide berth, Glimmer slipped around the side with her gun safely pointed down and away from her feet. And there, at the broken bit of fence Glimmer had been

promising herself she'd fix for months now, was a figure fixing it for her.

"Identify yourself!" She barked, and then the world broke.

Catra turned calmly, apparently having heard her approach, and smiled weakly. Glimmer could only stare. Barely aware of the cold anymore, no longer exhausted, and no longer sure of anything. Her heart fluttered with that old spark she'd never quite managed to smother, and then kicked hard as the adrenaline hit.

"Howdy Glimmer," Catra called, her breath billowing out in large white clouds. "Didn't mean to be presumptuous, but I didn't know when you was getting back. Figured I'd make myself useful while I waited."

For one moment it's like Glimmer's split between the past and the present, and she didn't really remember which one was happening now. Then she snapped back into place and lifted her revolver, even if she had no intention to use it. "What are you doing here?"

Catra looked at the gun and shot Glimmer as unimpressed a look as someone can with nails hanging out of their mouth. "Right now? Fixing this damn fence. You don't want your horse bolting do you? In general though, I was...well, I wanted to say thank you. Maybe talk. If'n...if you're willing that is."

She didn't drop her gun right away, instead tried to think of something to say to end this before it got started. Did she pay that bounty in the end? Yes. Did that mean she forgave Catra? Not really. Did it mean anything else? ...maybe.

Catra finished hammering the nail she'd started, standing and groaning when her joints crackled, with no apparent worry about the weapon trained on her back. She put the hammer and nails down before slowly approaching with her hands up just in case. Good choice. But as she got closer Glimmer gasped, holstering her revolver at long last to grab Catra's hand. Or what was left of her right hand.

“Good lord what did you do?” Glimmer hissed, pulling Catra’s altered glove off to look at it. The thumb and pointer finger were still there. Some of the middle finger too. The rest though...stumps at best. Looking at the palm Glimmer blanched when she realized part of that was missing too. The whole thing was still rough looking, although clearly healed. She’d always loved Catra’s hands, small and thin but powerful and gentle. It cracked something inside to see the injury.

“Found out why most folk don’t work topside,” Catra said, her voice soft and the cheer in it completely forced. “Don’t get yerself tied up over it, it’s been a while.”

“Top si- why the hell were you running up there?” Glimmer knew that she was being demanding, but just couldn't care. She was cold, and tired, and her head was throbbing, and- As she shivered again, she dragged Catra inside the house where it was warmer. After all, Glimmer knew she wouldn’t be shooting Catra, so she might as well not be shooting Catra inside where it was warm. Her own aching hands and feet would thank her later.

“ ‘Bout the only thing I kin do is work the rails. I was stuck out in the Crimson Waste and trying to make some extra cash helping out. That, uh, that didn’t work out so well.”

Inside was only a hair warmer right now and suddenly Glimmer felt unreasonably flushed. *“That didn’t work out so well.” Well no shit, you dumbass!* An old righteous fury she didn’t think she’d ever feel again rearing its head. “Oh you think?! You ain’t some young hotshot no more!”

“Excuse you,” Catra grumbled but couldn’t quite seem to frown, as if she’d just been paid the highest of compliments, “I’m not even 40.”

Catra’s clear fondness alone should not have been enough to fluster her. But fluster it did, so Glimmer stomped her way to start the stove burning hot again from the coals before asking, “And why in the hell were you out in that hell hole of a city?”

Catra laughed and it felt like seeing a rainbow. God what was *wrong* with her? This was just exhaustion, right? Right?

"Y'know, I don't know when this little 'throw Catra off moving trains' club got t'gether but y'all have been doing a mighty fine job."

When she whirled around, she found Catra struggling to unbutton her coat.

"I'm sorry, you were ***what*** ?" Glimmer choked. For a moment sheer terror poured through her body. It had been a miracle that Catra hadn't died when Glimmer tackled her off that train, and the idea that it had happened a *second time* left her feeling weak. *She coulda died and I'd never have known. Never of had a chance to...*

Catra didn't seem to notice her shift in mood, tongue sticking out as she concentrated and managed to get the third button undone. "Uh, I was thrown off a train. Kinda screwed everything up. See, Krytis Rail sold Captain thinking I was dead-"

"THEY SOLD CAPTAIN!?" Glimmer blushed horribly when Catra grinned at her, not even fully looking up from her coat. That image was going to be seared into her mind's eye forever. "Don't you dare take that the wrong way D'riluth."

"Yes ma'am," Catra chuckled, "but yeah, they sold Captain and all my things. Took a bit before I got most a that settled, but he was long gone. Saved up and hopped on a train towards civilization. So getting hurled off a that kinda caused an issue with the whole plan. Ended up trapped in Crimson Waste saving up some money to get Melog."

It took her brain a half second to suggest it was the name of the unknown horse. Dang, she needed to move both them horses into the barn sooner than later. "What kind of a name is Melog?"

Catra actually did frown this time, pausing her efforts to grump, "He's a good boy miss, you leave him alone!"

Glimmer growled, finishing with the stove at last before bruskly going to stand in front of her uninvited guest. It was silly to be so embarrassed over a horse she'd known for all of five minutes, but with her face having been so close to the fire she had a good excuse for the red in her cheeks. At the last second she managed to pull her temper back in, unsure what she was even going to say originally, so instead she quietly asked, "Would you like some help?"

Catra blushed, scowling as she went back to it. "I ain't stupid Glim, I can handle some buttons it just...takes a little longer s'all. So damn hot down there I didn't need to relearn all this shit, and, well, someone sewed the bastards on a little too tight."

Not wanting to push anything, Glimmer had nodded and simply gone back out. By the time she moved both horses to the stable, Catra had finished so Glimmer took her coat and hung it up with hers by the stove to dry. "Why didn't you sign up with BMR again? You coulda taken them from almost any damn station."

"I, uh," Catra scuffed her boot on the floor, looking around awkwardly for something to do before going to grab the kettle, "it didn't seem right. With everything I've done."

Glimmer grabbed her arm before Catra could go outside to redirect her to the sink. "I got indoor plumbing now, was a bitch to have put in, but the town's grown out this way anyhow. So I splurged a bit."

She'd splurged a lot, but no one really needed to know that. If there was one thing she'd learned as a deputy, it was that younger her had no concept of how much she'd flaunted her wealth and status.

Catra eagerly turned the tap on, eyes sparkling as water came out, looking like a kid outside a candy store. Glimmer softly laughed to herself at the image until she noticed Catra's mangled hand again. She hadn't forced Catra to live out in the wastes, but her failed bid for revenge had put her on that path. It felt like she

was the reason for the injury. *She could've died.* Crushed or from infection; medical aid weren't exactly a commodity out there as far as she knew. *She coulda died 'cause of me.* It took a lot for Glimmer to pull herself back to the conversation.

Even if pulling herself back really meant being more awkward than ever, half stuttering and she mumbled, "Anyways, I- well, uhm, thank you. For being considerate about it. But I wish you woulda just signed on with us all the same. We've got them new fangled auto couplers on most of our cars now that that whole Safety Appliance Act is about to kick in and all."

"Okay, hang on, t'be fair here. I kinda lied, I wasn't working topside by that point, I was working the freight station, but the damn kids didn't know what they was doing. Got crushed making sure one of them didn't lose an arm." Catra said as if that wasn't one of the most heroic things Glimmer had heard of in a long time. Instead, she had put the kettle on the stove before going back to the cupboards to pull out a teapot and mugs. "It wouldn't have felt right anyways. I don't want to take advantage of you."

Glimmer looked at the mugs and tin of tea in her hands pointedly, not really meaning it but unwilling to let such a golden opportunity pass her by.

"Are you telling me you don't want to warm up some?" Catra teased, her smirk so familiar and warming it felt like sunshine.

She threw her hands up dramatically, scoffing, "Ugh! See you never got less annoying!"

Catra just laughed again where a younger her woulda pushed back with a wicked but mean type of humor. Of course, that didn't mean she was going to pass up her chance any more than Glimmer had. "Now don't go hurtin' all three of my feelings before I even get a chance to say thank you properly!"

She couldn't help but cackle, slipping into their banter was easier than putting on her favorite skirt, "Oh land's sake, **three** whole

feelings? Look at you, all grown up ain'tcha!"

"Now see, you just went and hurt two of them three feelings." Catra scooped the tea and poured the water, only to glare before gingerly trying to hook her fingers around the two mugs. An awkward moment later she winced and asked, sounding fully defeated, "Can, dagnabbit, can you get one of these or the teapot? Muscles are still a little too weak to carry it all. Probably shoulda been working more on building the strength back for a while now."

With both of them settled at the table an awkward silence fell over them. Glimmer painstakingly counted the seconds and minutes before pouring them both a cup to help ward off the chill.

Sipping at her tea, it was kind of funny to watch Catra sitting so stiffly on the settee considering how much time she'd spent napping on it. Or maybe that was why? She grimaced slightly and played it off as needing some honey, but the motion only seemed to somehow set Catra off. The damn fool was bouncing her leg quick enough to shake the loose floorboards, fingers tapping on the side of her mug as she chewed her lower lip.

"Goodness sake woman, you are making *me* nervous!" Glimmer chuckled weakly, stuck between annoyed at her for being nervous and annoyed at herself for being annoyed.

Catra barked out a laugh, a small amount of the hot tea spilled over the edge and dribbled down the ceramic, which only drew her guilty gaze back to her hand. Even knowing she was here and well, knowing she survived something that easily could've killed her, it made her heart ache with fear. *C'mon, don't be rude about it! I just found out, I* ***just*** *found out I'm allowed- be nice damn it Moon, you know better than to stare like that!*

"Just tryin' ta figure out how to say this, 'cause, heh, I swear you've heard this one from me a few times…" Catra shook her head, "You saved my life then spared it. I owe it to you at least

twice. I can't, I can't ever make that up. But I- if there's anything I can do…?"

She kind of wanted to scream because gall dang it she was right, even if a strange roundabout manner. And Glimmer could say with confidence that she hated hearing it just as much now as she did almost 16 years ago. But this time she gave some effort to think on it, because it's the least she can do knowing how far she'd come to offer. Glimmer had done her own fair share of thanking and apologizing recently, and turning her away feels like the meanest thing she could say.

Was there anything Catra can do?

The idea of telling her to leave and never come back passed quicker than a sun shower. Maybe just a short month or two ago she would've liked it, but now...no. As much as it ruffled her feathers, Glimmer could admit to herself that with Catra here she was loath to let the woman go again. She doesn't know though. There's not really anything that can be done, and all things considered Glimmer would argue that she didn't save or spare Catra this time. She'd let her go after trying to kill her, and then almost got her killed after having accidentally gotten her declared dead. There was another spark of fury that those bastards *sold* Captain so quickly. He was a damn fine horse and he loved Catra something fierce! That was a rotten deal and if that had happened here? Hoo! She'd have had no problem coming down like a pallet of bricks on their heads. *Focus, what can we do, what do I want?* But the thoughts just swirled 'round and 'round, nothing really getting enough traction to be a good idea.

"You are making me mighty nervous," Catra's voice actually *shook* despite how much forced cheer she'd put in it.

Oh heaven's sake how long had she just been sitting there glaring at the table? A quick glance out the window and Glimmer was shocked to realize the sun had nearly set. She hopped up to light the lanterns, muttering to herself, "Oh lord, help your foolish child."

Catra snorted and the two stared at one another mortified over their own reactions.

“L-look you cain’t judge me D’riluth! I’ve been living alone, you hear?” Glimmer blustered, trying to reconcile the idea that she had gotten too used to speaking aloud to herself as the years passed with the fact that someone was now here to see her being batty as a bell tower.

Catra coughed, although she was sure it was to cover some chuckles, and assured, “I would never dream of it miss.”

“Then why in the whole of the heavens and the earth,” Glimmer started as she lit the last oil lamp to bring back to the table with her, “am I feeling judged?”

In the flickering, soft lamp light Catra’s sly little smile sent her heart racing. It was familiar again, so damn familiar and yet the new patches of gray hair at her temples caught the light differently. Which was unfair, because somehow she’d only gotten more handsome *and* prettier since she’d seen her last.

“Ma’am, that is between you and god and maybe yer pastor all things pending. Speaking of, how are the Archer’s? Thought I saw George when I was skirtin’ town.” Catra waved vaguely towards the forest but Glimmer could already picture it.

That stubborn old bastard.

“Bless his heart, I will kill him if that man was out hunting alone again." At Catra’s confused look, Glimmer rushed to clarify, “He went out a few years back alone and accidently shot a damn tree. Branch almost crushed him and he promised not to go alone no more!”

Catra winced, diplomatically (meaning she was lying) saying, “Can’t say Deputy, it was just in passin’. Maybe Bow was with him? Or one of the boys?”

“They better a been.” Glimmer mumbled, knowing full well that Bow was the only one this side of the country and he’d been helping Adora when she’d left. To spare herself an extra moment, she poured herself another cup from the quickly dwindling pot despite the hour. She was tired enough that it probably wouldn’t matter. Hopefully. “Besides that, they’ve been well. Lance is as aggressively kind as usual, that man keeps threatening to drag me to their house for a proper family supper.”

“Oh well this **has** been lovely,” Catra put her mug down and got up with an exaggerated stretch, “but I am afraid I have to leave. Right now!”

Glimmer grabbed her hand and tugged her back down. “If I have to suffer, so do you!”

And then the world froze again. In part because of the slip up, it weren’t like they were a couple no more when it came to things like that. In part because of the implication that she wanted Catra around, which was more fully true than she was ready to admit. And in part because Glimmer realized which hand she’d grabbed, and was gently lacing their fingers together with a lump in her throat. Oh that hurt something fierce, the way it felt so different now. But her hand was warm and Catra squeezed her’s back gently.

“I’m serious Glim, don’t go worrying about that. You can...well, you can only do what you can do, and that’s long done.”

What was wrong with her? Glimmer knew the answer even as she struggled with everything that was happening. From her exhaustion to Catra’s surprise appearance, to learning about how even more shit had rolled down hill on her once again. It was too much and all she really wanted to do was lean forward and kiss her knuckles.

“Hmm,” Glimmer hummed non-committedly but stood up all the same. “Well, you ain’t going nowhere in the dark. Best stay the

night at least, save ya from freezing t' death afore I get my favors."

"You don't have to-"

"D'riluth!" Glimmer took a slow breath to try and calm down after such a sudden flare of anger, unsure if she was actually annoyed or not, "I'm going to get you a quilt, and if I find you tryin' to leave I will drag you back here kicking and screaming."

Catra smirked, but her relief and hope were painfully obvious. So of course she just had to go and ruin it with another joke. But if that weren't them, then what was? "Oh? Kicking and screaming you say? You promise?"

"Oh good lord!" Glimmer growled, huffing and shoving at Catra's chest until she sat back down. "You tie a girl up **one time** -"

"It *was* very memorable miss."

"Shush yourself!" It was nice to hear her squeaky little laugh as she went upstairs to get the old quilt.

Even after she'd gotten Catra settled and was curled up in bed staring out at the clear winter skies, Glimmer already knew she was in trouble. Because she'd been lying to herself rather well recently. Did she pay that bounty? Yes, because she loved her still, because she forgave her in some manner even if it sat funny in her soul. It had just been easier to pretend it weren't true when Catra was a rose tinted memory, a way to exert some control over the whole situation. No escaping it now though, especially not with all the supportive voices of her family chiming in her mind.

I am a right fool. She snorted at the thought. *I am a fool and in lo- nopenopenope, not going there, nothing to be done there right now. Stop it right now Moon! Think in the morning, night's for sleeping!* It still took a while of Glimmer forcibly blanking her mind before the exhaustion swept her into an uneasy sleep and in the morning was no closer to any answers than she'd been the night before.

Chapter End Notes

We're getting the band back together boys! I mean, the couple's almost back together y'all!

Chapter 19: It Takes a Village

Chapter Summary

> "You gonna tell me what in the hell happened with you?" Lonnie asked brusquely towards her pocket watch, even though the train was supposed to leave five minutes ago, acting as if they'd spoken last week. Lonnie shot her a relieved, but unamused glare when Catra just stared at her mutely.
>
> Her secret had been kept. No one outside of their little circle knew the truth, and people were just happy to see her with no strings attached.
>
> She didn't know how to feel about that.
>
> Catra swayed lightly on her feet as she caught sight of Kyle waving at her so enthusiastically that he fell off the platform. Finally clearing her throat to answer, "Not just yet, I gotta tell Mrs. Moon first."
>
> "Hmph!" Lonnie adjusted her cap and clicked her watch shut. "Fair enough, but you try running again and ain't no place on heaven and earth you'll be safe, you hear?"

Chapter Notes

> As always, a very big thank you to dragonesdepapel for editing this and helping me stippy steppy through it all. I know I said I'd send it to you for one last double check, but then decided I wanted to post it enough that I should do that before another 30-60 days has passed :p

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Overall the reunion had gone far better than Catra thought it would, even if it hadn't gone quite as well as she'd hoped.

The next morning had actually been *worse* , which had killed her a little bit after such a good start. She'd sat nervously waiting for Glimmer to wake up for work, nervous enough that sleep had mostly eluded her and perhaps overly eager to see her again. When the woman clearly weren't gonna be getting up, Catra hadn't been sure if she should wake her or not. Would it be helpful or presumptuous, welcomed or detested? She just didn't know and desperately needed to. After hemming and hawing for nearly an hour past sunrise, according to the new grandfather clock, she'd decided to at least make herself useful in some other way. She'd found a small sack of coffee that was actually still fresh and after getting that done, she'd set to work on prepping breakfast. And when that was ready to just get cooked up in a few minutes, Catra decided to check on Glimmer. It was nearly ten in the morning and she'd been supposed to leave by seven.

Or, well, at least that *used* to be her schedule, Catra wasn't sure what hours a deputy of the law worked.

She'd tiptoed her way up the stairs, and softly knocked on the bedroom door to no response a few times before deciding to suck it up and just peek inside. If Glimmer was still asleep Catra would make her own breakfast and just...wait around? It felt uncomfortable to look around a home that weren't hers no more but the idea of sitting quietly and stewing in her own thoughts was torturous. *Don't get ahead of yourself, just look in and if there's a lump in the bed take care of Melog or something.* The door swung open with a gentle creak, which, for some damn reason, was the thing that had woken Glimmer up. Too bad it had been in a panic. Catra had barely ducked in time, letting the knife thunk into the wood behind her, and split it wide open instead of her damn skull.

She'd shrieked, head feeling strangely light. "JESUS FUCK!" Heart pounding away in her throat it took her a moment to focus her eyes again. And when she did it was to a sleepy eyed Glimmer with a revolver trained on her. She gripped the door harder and willed herself to not shake apart like some dumbass kid.

Not knowing what else to do, Catra had tried to offer in what she prayed was a humorous manner, "...I'll, uh, I'll just save you some breakfast then?"

"Get out of my room!"

That was all she'd needed to have permission to *not* get shot and scamper away.

Yeah, good fucking morning to me. I knew it was too good to be true, I knew it!

Hoo boy, that was a spiral if she'd ever seen one, so Catra refused to go down that line. Imagining Scorpia gently telling her to focus on something else for a while, advice she'd always delivered in the worst way possible but actually did some good. Breakfast. She'd started breakfast and needed to cook it. Right. Skillet, skillet was, uhm, bottom left? Step by step she found each tool and got to work, letting the sights and smells and sounds hold her up for a little bit.

Catra had almost calmed down and finished cooking when Glimmer somehow dragged her feet while stomping over to the table. Last night Glimmer had seemed, well, tired and stressed and not exactly well but friendly enough. This morning she seemed coldly furious, not even giving Catra a damned nod or thanks for the food and drink. Although she didn't refuse it either, so she'd take that as a win.

Unlike her companion, who ate mechanically, Catra had been living for months on all sorts of awful travelin' foods as she'd ridden from the Wastes all the way to Etheria. Luckily a day's travel no longer left her feeling beat to hell by the saddle, but she'd give up her core strength if it meant she could have sausage and eggs even once every other week. Good god, eggs and sausage and peppers with cheese- fuck this had to be heaven. Catra inhaled her food and only noticed when there was nothing left. She'd half expected some joke about how fast she was eating, but nothing came out of Glimmer's mouth.

It was awkward as hell to sit there quietly and wait, with the creeping feeling that any sort of sudden movement could end up with her dead pretty quickly the only thing to keep her occupied. *She wouldn't. Yeah, but she* ***could*** *.* The sound of the knife biting deep into wood from not thirty minutes prior was keeping her mighty alert and jumpy.

After finishing, Glimmer had glared at her for a long while before speaking, "So. You're still here, ain't running no more?"

"Uh...no?" She wasn't sure why Glimmer thought she'd be running *now* of all times, but again, she'd had a gun pointed at her face not too long ago and didn't care to test her own luck. She'd just gotten the shakes under control, no need to start them up again.

"...fine. I'm going into town, need to get some supplies for the winter. Make yourself useful would'ya, and fix that door jamb. Wood's in the barn." And with that Glimmer had stalked out of the house.

Catra sat with the used dishes for several minutes until she saw Glimmer ride past, and then let her head thunk onto the table with a groan. Not like she'd expected a welcome wagon or nothing, but it was still frustrating to realize how far she had to go. To go till what though? Catra certainly hoped she could win Glimmer over again, maybe at least be friends even if that was death by inches. Although even that didn't look likely considering how rough this morning had gone.

"Sometimes," Entrapta muttered, only seeming to be half aware she was even speaking, "you have to put a LOT of time into an experiment before you get preliminary results. That doesn't mean anything's gone wrong, it just takes time to see a change. And then you still need to do another iteration before adjustments can be made- which is such a pain let me tell you! Especially when you don't have the tools and then everyone wants you to publish and then you have to do it all over again! Patience is ***not*** *my strong suit- is that the saying? I think that's the saying. OOOOooooohhhh, that's a poker thing isn't it!?"*

"Sure is," Scorpia said, clearly not sure at all, "but, uh, you were sayin' about-"

"RIGHT, the point is that sometimes things just take waaaaaaaaaaaaaaAAAAAaaay longer than you'd think. And that just stinks. Pass me that wrench?"

Entrapta may have taken a while to get to her point, but Catra conceded it was decently made. Time was what she needed. It didn't look good right now but she wouldn't actually know nothing until this "experiment" ran its course. She'd been back for less than a day, little early to be predicting the future no matter how badly her racing heart and sweaty palms wanted her to.

Catra waited until her neck and back protested to being twisted for too long, took a slow deep breath, then she cleaned up best she could. Breakfast had been delicious but also a one meal type a thing, she needed something for lunch and dinner at least and poked around a bit to take better stock of Glimmer's stores. There was enough to make a decent stew to go low and slow, and she gratefully did that before going to collect the wood.

She had asked if there was anything she could do, and if right now that was not running and fixing a door jamb then so god damned be it.

Melog, of course, had other ideas. After spending almost every waking moment together he impatiently stamped his hooves until Catra stopped over to let him out of the stall seeing as he wouldn't go jumping the fence or nothing like that. Poor boy was used to more exercise in a day and getting hyper even if outside was colder than a well digger's ass. He'd probably just do a few loops before deciding the barn actually was comfier, but he was kind of like a cat. Things had to be *his* idea to be good. She snickered and did nothing to stop him from stealing her hat before he began to gallop and pronk about the yard, only stopping to stare at her before starting a slower trot. And, well, it felt good to feel wanted by someone, so Catra obligingly "chased" him for a few minutes. Melog eventually stopped and allowed her to catch

him, shaking his head a few times before letting her pry her hat back out from his teeth with a chuckle. He nearly knocked her over in a desperate bid to give her a little extra love and attention, and she managed to not cry over it. Melog just knew when she needed a little more affection.

"Good boy," she kissed his nose before turning to *finally* get the damned wood and was not surprised to find Melog lazing in his hay pile a few minutes later when she finally found the it.

And thank goodness, she'd been worried Glimmer meant firewood, but no. There were several planks of hardwood already aged and dried in the loft, plenty good enough for the job and probably higher quality than someone with her limited skills should be using. Well, that was her mistake then if this was meant for something nicer. Catra selected the smallest piece she could find and carefully hauled it back towards the porch, willing herself to take this as a good sign when everything felt like it was going a little wrong.

It wasn't until she was almost there that Catra noticed a new firewood shed along the side of the house. Curiosity got the better of her and a quick inspection found a little hatch cut into the house so you could just pull wood in without leaving. Huh, why hadn't they done that before? Useful as all get out.

Tasks to drag her feet with completed, Catra dropped the wood and went inside to take measurements. Without Glimmer in the house though, it felt a lot more like she was a home invader. It gave her the same sort of jitters she had when she was fourteen and burgling for the first time and everything. No matter that it made sense staying here now wouldn't be the same as her memories, it still hurt to see some of the changes as she walked quietly through the space.

Really taking the time to look around and take it in, it almost felt like the whole house had to have been replaced piece by piece. The wall paper was replaced with some purplish design, a tintype of a furious younger Glimmer glared at her from the wall and

judged her as Catra saw their little geode collection was gone. Upstairs found the second room converted into something between an office and a sitting room, although the bookshelves were reduced and the paintings Glimmer had bought to "brighten up this dreary space" were gone.

The bedroom had by far been the worst. It had been the one place that always felt good here, had always been safe. That was where she and Glimmer shared their secrets, held each other through good and bad, and where Catra would get to watch the daylight slowly light up Glimmer's face each morning. Her memories of the room were warm and gold tinted, more like she was looking in through a dusty window than being inside. Seeing it now...it was just so damned different...

Part of the room had been repurposed entirely, turned into an indoor bathroom and walled off into its own space. For what remained, the walls had been stripped down to the wood, the carpet gone leaving the space feeling cold and barren. Their old full mattress was replaced with a single to make room for a little workbench in the corner where Catra found a gun cleaning kit and not much else. She'd slumped into the chair at the bench and cried for a little while, it was *ridiculous* to be sad over not recognizing the place no more. She hadn't lived here in a good, what, five years? Six years? She'd just...she'd thought that Glimmer might've held onto something of *them* , but it was all gone.

The bed and frame were foreign and almost clinical looking. Nothing was personal to Glimmer, not even the dresser (the one thing that had survived it seemed), which her mother had dumped on them without warning. Heck, even the jewelry box that used to squat on top of it like a particularly fat and brooding hen was gone. The closet was filled with more practical clothes and not a single dress that she could recognize. There weren't one thing there with even a hint of their old life in it.

Somehow Glimmer seemed to have both completely moved on from Catra while obsessing about her enough to try and take her

in.

She'd known Glimmer hated her, but seeing it was something different. It hurt to know how much she'd changed. How much she'd just...throw away.

Catra eventually pulled herself together and measured, then cut, a new piece. Forcing herself to focus on the task, pretend she was in someone else's house while she worked. Hammer and nails were easy enough to find and she got the whole thing done and cleaned up right about the same time Glimmer got back with supplies.

"Bring this in," Glimmer more told than asked before turning around and leaving again, and Catra tried to not seethe as she put the vittles away. Sitting afterwards massaging the ache in her right hand, she realized Glimmer hadn't even said how long she'd be gone.

Catra looked around almost in a daze before deciding that she'd had her fill of sucker punches for the day, any desire she'd had to look around the house or property had cooled to ash and she simply stayed put. Watching herself look out the window and feeling a buzzing prickling feeling across her body. Pine needles danced, wind blew, and eventually the sun set. Hours passed and eventually she drifted back to the ground. She lit one of the oil lamps and set it to low with surprisingly steady hands, and then caved to the growling in her stomach and ate supper alone.

She pretended to be asleep on the settee when Glimmer finally stumbled back in, just to avoid hollering at her. But oh, how she felt her whole body tense with fury when she walked up the steps. It wasn't worth it, the fight wasn't worth being kicked out at night in the winter. It took a while to swallow the burning bile and sleep, but she got there eventually.

Just like hiking up a steep and stone slick mountain though, the frustration of sliding was met with a steadfast determination to do better and get further and climb higher.

They'd both been up and eaten breakfast before nine the next morning, and Glimmer's mood seemed vastly improved. Instead of a stone cold silence, it was more like an awkward coolness. Progress was progress though, even if the desired apology for the whole knife and gun show incident still didn't appear they was both on their best polite behavior. A please and a thank you here and there, how did you sleep, hope I didn't wake you and all. It was just barely enough to make it tolerable. But Catra still didn't push it past where Glimmer seemed comfortable. She was letting the woman she'd hurt set the pace here, and that was gonna mean a whole new world of patience from her.

It was rewarded when Glimmer packed up to leave. She had jerked her chin towards the barn and requested, "Since you already started, can you finish the fence? I'll be back about seven or eight this evening. And, uhm...leave the dishes? I'll get them tonight, not tryin' to make you my maid or something."

It was a bashful peace offering, and it kept Catra busy so she went ahead and replaced or tightened up anything she could. It was hard work, harder than she'd expected, but still gave her plenty to do without needing to think too much. That said, she'd eventually kicked Melog out into the forest to get a little quiet when he wouldn't stop pacing and huffing at her. One petulant stomp had finally pushed her frayed nerves over the edge and she all but shoved him out the gate. Melog would come back after all.

Once, Catra had been so tired one night she'd forgotten to tie him up for the night, and woke to see him missing. At the time she'd felt a numb panic take over as her brain unhelpfully whispered, " *You were the last one with hands on that rope. Don't act high and mighty when you sure as hell didn't check nothing!* " She sat there panicking for a while about what in the hell she was gonna do now, and was brought out of it when Melog practically pranced over to nuzzle and nip at her in concern. She had practically wailed into his withers the rest of the day and they ended up camping at that spot a second night. After that she'd nervously experimented with letting him roam more after tying some rope around the area to fence him in close. Not that it worked, Catra

turned around just in time to find him ducking under the rope before trying to look innocent. After that she'd stopped worrying as much, and he always came back.

Not that her plans to get some peace and quiet **today** amounted to a hill of beans. Melog had insisted on getting in her way at every turn, acting annoyed when she had to slap at his rump to reach her tools, and startling enough to fall over when she started hammering unexpectedly. Regardless of his antics, she managed to get the fence fixed by the evening, and after cleaning herself up a little with running water (inside even if it was freezing cold!) she even saved the stew enough to get one last round of it.

True to her word, Glimmer had stumbled in just before eight, having ridden practically in pitch blackness. For a moment she looked surprised that there was someone home before seeing a bowl of steaming stew, her stomach roared loud enough to make Catra laugh and the two ate quickly before separating to sleep.

And it just got a little easier and a little simpler every day after that.

Glimmer had asked if she could look at the broken steps on the porch, half a request and half an order, and Catra was more than happy to pretend she hadn't gotten scared by an angry chipmunk that had launched its way out from under the rotted wood. Although that didn't stop her from using it as a funny story to get a laugh when Glimmer came home looking like she might cry.

Then it had been cleaning the barn, a multi-day project more suited to the summer but still worked well enough in the biting cold when Melog let her *live* for one goddamn minute.

Cleaning, checking, chopping, there was always *something* to do.

Sure, they talked a bit in between and Glimmer warmed little by little, but every time Catra asked if there was anything she could do about *them* it set them back to a frosty silence. A few times she had the apparent gall to get upset by Glimmer shutting down

and shutting her out, and that only made it *worse* somehow. Two steps forward, one step back. Over and over as the weeks turned to months.

Frustrated as hell, she wished that Scorpia was here to help. Maybe brainstorm some talking points or at least be the muscle for all the damned projects. Entrapta probably would've figured out a better way to do just about everything she was while charming her way into Glimmer's heart. The three of them could spend the days working and spend the evening playing cards. God, she missed them something fierce as she found herself more isolated than ever, and that love only hurt worse the longer this limbo went on.

In a mortifying turn of events almost two months in, Glimmer got home early to find Catra sitting on the floor crying.

"S-sorry! I- I, uh, sorry, I c-can go." Catra had wiped furiously at her eyes as she pushed herself up, fully intending to take her pity party out to the barn where Melog would take care of her. She shoulda just sucked it up till then anyhow, he was always tolerant of her acting like a child, but she'd thought she was safe to stay inside where it was a bit warmer. God damned stupid mistake, but that was just her life wasn't it? She couldn't afford to make Glimmer mad again, she couldn't, she just couldn't, and being here like this was just so fucking manipulative of her too. So she wouldn't do it, she wasn't going to force anyone to take care of her being ridiculous and crying over literally nothing.

But instead of glaring or hissing, there was a gentle hand stopping her half dash to the door. Guiding her instead to sit on something soft. *Oh, yeah, cushions were nice* . How the hell had she forgotten about cushions? A moment later she was wrapped up in a blanket, with Glimmer kneeling in front of her. "You ain't gotta go. It's okay, you can stay here."

Catra tried to pull it together, to prove she was better now. That she didn't- didn't need everyone to drop everything for her. She was better and stronger and she could handle this on her own.

Don't piss her off over something stupid you awful little brat. So, she took a shaky breath and started off calmly enough, even if it ended up ruined in another heaving sob. "I don't, I don't wanna b-be a bother miss!"

"You ain't," Glimmer rubbed her thumbs back and forth over Catra's knees, and it was easier to look at them than at her. To sniffle and let the warmth and motion keep her together. "You ain't bothering me, I want you to stay. Okay? Do...do you want to talk about it?"

God did that make her wince. This was all too familiar. She wasn't doing any better (yes she was). And here they were again (it's okay). Her being worthless and Glimmer reaching out and- *I can do this, this is what matters, don't shut her out again D'riluth. Don't you dare shut her out again!*

"I miss my friends," She whispered, finally looking up just enough to see Glimmer's shocked face, "B-both here, but- but also, I- I miss Scorpia. I miss her *so much*!"

As Glimmer slowly shifted to sit next to her, Catra blabbered on, almost unable to stop. "Scorpia, she- she was out in the w-wastes, she was waiting for me to show up. She'd been waiting that whole time! And th-then I just? She, I just, and she, and- and I miss her! I didn't know how b-badly I would! And I wish she was **here**."

She gasped for air, pulled the blanket tighter around herself in a pale imitation of a hug and tried to smother her whimpering into the wool.

Glimmer gently stroked her hand up and down Catra's back, softly asking, "...because you're lonely?"

Ugh, and wasn't that the dumbest reason to be upset? She nodded anyways, clenched her jaw to stop another wave of useless blubbering, and only spoke when she was certain she

could do it clearly. “I got so used to being with her again. Her and Entrapta and-”

“You know Entrapta!?” Glimmer stared open-mouthed before snapping it closed and blushing. “Sorry!”

But the interruption helped, oddly enough breaking her out of her little sad sack state because there were only a few things constant in life. Death, taxes, and Entrapta doing something unexpected. There was just something funny about it, something that helped shake her just enough to snort and hastily wipe an embarrassing amount of snot off her face with her sleeve. “Ha! Y-yeah. Lived with her out there. She saved me after the damn car.”

Glimmer reached into her vest pocket and pulled out her handkerchief. She moved slowly like she expected Catra to have the damn energy left to flee before wiping her eyes and giving it to her to blow her nose. “...tell me about it? About them?”

It had been nice to just sit and talk about her time in the Crimson Waste as something that had gone right for her. Rambled a bit about the way they’d helped her back on her feet. About the way they helped her get the courage to come back here. And the more she talked, the more relaxed Glimmer seemed to get too. She talked and talked till she went hoarse and the next morning she woke up with Glimmer slumped onto her shoulder and drooling a bit. It was enough to almost make her cry in relief, she’d missed that, she’d missed this so much.

And after that things finally started to thaw with the spring.

They started talking more, and that led to joking more. They’d built their relationship on teasing and challenging one another, so getting back to it felt more like a homecoming that anything else had been. Not that it was probably the right thing to do, naw, not the mature thing to do. But after so much heartache and hardship, neither of them seemed willing to venture off this easy path.

Glimmer still deflected each and every time Catra tried to do more than help around the house, but that still didn't mean anything yet. They was creeping ever closer to being friends after all ("*cain't do nothing without a big hullabaloo"*), and that was good. It was gonna take time and by god she was gonna give that woman as much time as she needed. With something finally giving, Catra didn't feel trapped and alone, and that soothed her frustrations and upset more often than not. Besides, it's not like she didn't have her hands full with household chores.

Catra considered it something like retribution for how much she'd looked down on homemakers, especially considering how much she actually enjoyed it. It was nice to clean and cook and fix things, she could see the progress she made at each task and enjoy the fruits of her labors when done. Didn't even need to blank her mind or distract herself much, there was always something worth doing after all. One morning after mucking out the stalls early, she'd even mentioned it to Glimmer, who had made them a pot of coffee while something sizzled on the stove.

"Oh?" Glimmer smirked as she slid Catra a nice big mug of coffee, wiggling her eyebrows after her mumbled confession as she proudly declared, "Looks like I did finally make you a, what did you call it? A pretty little housewife?"

Catra snickered, wiping a hand over her exhausted face like that would hide her pleased flush. God it had been a long and sleepless night, and that was her only excuse for saying, "Woman, if you were my wife, I'd poison your tea!"

They both froze, staring at one another for an eternal moment. It was the sort of joke they would've made with one another before. But damn did it hit different now.

Glimmer smiled, soft and sad at once, before responding with a wink. "If I was your wife... I'd **drink** that tea."

Catra barked out a laugh, completely unprepared to have her just go along with it but so fucking grateful it was unreal. She really

had gotten easy to please these days, huh? Well, might as well keep them going then. “Miss, now you gone and hurt my feelings again, and I know we done talked about that.”

“Oh good! I *was* trying to,” Glimmer snickered in between bites, her smile growing into something more relaxed.

“See now you just took out the last of ‘em.” Catra sighed heavily, unsure how far she could push and desperate to keep going in this little bubble where Glimmer liked her again. She quickly shoveled away half her breakfast before stumbling over a weak retort. “Well, that settles that I suppose. Guess I’m evil again.”

“Oh please,” Glimmer smacked the back of her hand on Catra’s shoulder as she passed to drop her plate in the sink and get ready for her shift. “Check your ego D’riluth. You ain’t even been evil once, let alone twice.”

She grinned down into her coffee cup, tears pricking at her eyes. Wow, that was, that sure was almost nothing to get touched over. Damn! She took a gulp just to give herself something to do, and tried to focus on the flavor and heat. The beans had been decently roasted but Catra had to admit her taste had never been the best. Didn’t some folk say this was supposed to taste chocolatey or something? Another sip provided her no answer but was still a welcome distraction. Hmm. Maybe it was like a wine thing? Supposed to take it with air or something? She slurped and sure enough, it still tasted like coffee.

“What in the world are you doing?” Glimmer asked from behind her.

She almost spit her sip out, but instead managed to choke it down. “I was enjoying this wonderful drink, thinkin’ ‘bout how...coffee-y it tastes, thank you very much.”

Glimmer’s soft chuckle was a damn bullet through the heart. You’d think nearly seventeen years later something like that wouldn’t

get her blood pumping. “Well thank you kindly, I made it with coffee and love.”

“Oh, so that’s why it’s like that!” Catra tilted her head backwards, looking at Glimmer upside down as she slowly put on her holsters and boots. “Thank you kindly for the explanation, miss. Would’ve been bothered by that all day.”

“Oh you hush!” Glimmer glared but it didn’t do that much damage when her cheeks were puffed out like that. “Why don’t you make yourself useful and tighten up the floor today.”

Glimmer was already leaving, so Catra pushed it one more time. “So you admit you’re keeping me around for my physical assets? Scandalous!”

She laughed, waggling one finger at her as she tried, and failed, to authoritatively say, “D’riluth, I will **hurt** you.”

And then she was out the door.

Catra was still flying high on that high the next day, even knowing that she wouldn’t see Glimmer until at least that evening it felt almost normal. Or more normal. No, that wasn’t right. New normal? The months were passing and her efforts were paying off, and it was hard to not be a bit beyond elated by that. It was a long shift, but the sun was warm and the breeze was cool, and Glimmer Moon *liked her* .

Which is to say that she wasn’t really paying much attention when she’d stepped outside to update Melog on the situation while feeding him scraps. Which meant that when she went back into the house around noon to actually finish the damn floorboards, she didn’t even notice the horse tied sedately out front. Clearly in her view before she ducked in the back door.

Which was how she went back into the kitchen only to come face to face with Bow.

The two stared at one another in mute shock until he dropped the bag of flour in his hands, uncaring as it split open and spilled damn near everywhere while he all but ran at her. *I'm not ready! It's him, it's really him!* Catra couldn't decide which way she was feeling and locked herself up to prepare for a punch, reflexively closing her eyes just before he could reach her. She could bask in his presence afterwards, but dues need paying.

Instead of what she expected, the air was squeezed out of her lungs as he hugged her tight, lifting her high enough up that her boots barely even scraped the ground.

"You're back!" Bow half cheered through his crying. "I knew it! I knew something was different, and it's- and you're here! Good god almighty, I missed you!"

Lord, she'd forgotten what good hugs he gave and simply melted into him before remembering to hug him back. How many times had she imagined getting a hug from this sweet man to sooth herself over the last several years? How damn long had she thought she'd never get one again, and that she had wasted all her chances to return the favor? No more of that pretending to be annoyed thing, damn it all to hell! She was getting her wish and tired of letting good things slip through her fingers.

"And you're HuGGinG ME!?" Bow wailed as he held her even tighter. Clutching at her shoulders like she'd vanish if he loosened his grip at all.

Catra laughed wetly, burying her face into his neck in a bid to somehow be physically closer to him. Copper and paper and cloves. She didn't even care that his sideburn was scraping against her cheek painfully, this was the god damned *life* . "Hell yeah I am, I missed you Beauregard Archer!"

He whimpered and Catra quickly found herself the sole reason they didn't collapse to the ground. It took a while to drag him, and them him drag her, over to the table where they basically folded like a house of cards on top of each other. Just laughing

and sniffling and a litany of little ways to say *I love you, I missed you* . When they'd finally decided to let go (okay when Catra successfully convinced Bow that her going to make them some chamomile tea with honey was not too far away from him), it was practically only long enough to get tangled back up together. Bow had always been a touchy feely sort of person, and Catra was suddenly very aware of how it had been nearly a year since the last time someone had held her.

Like hell she was giving the opportunity up, so they half sat in each other's laps to start catching up properly.

That said, Catra would be eternally grateful that he took one look at her pale face, and cut her off before she could even start.

He talked about his dads and his brothers, the butcher shop and the ministry. Delicately dancing around Glimmer and Angella and even Adora as best he could. Once you got Bow going it was hard to get him to clap his trap, and she let herself sink into the sound of his voice.

"Wait, so what in the hell are you doing out here then?" She interrupted him while he lamented about George's stubbornness and Lance's cheerful over-estimation of his own eye sight.

"Oh!" Bow sat up a little straighter, jostling her enough that she almost *hissed* at him about moving. "Right, I always keep an eye out for Glimmer when she does these two or three day covers. It's uhm...it's to cover for Adora while she goes to spend time with Razz y'know."

No, no she did not know and barely bit her tongue to stop from asking after Madam Razz.

"She ain't been the best with taking care of herself on the long ones, so I've made it a point to come up and at least peak at the house. I didn't come in to leave any surprise foods for a while, since she's been better about stocking up these days."

Catra snorted and rolled her eyes, "Well that *would* be 'cause when she don't, I cain't eat and mister I don't know if you remember this, but-"

Bow laughed a little too hard considering she hadn't even told her joke yet. Rude. "Trust me, no way, no how can I forget what you're like when hungry."

"So, why today then?"

"Figured it had been long enough, wanted to make her something to eat and collapse with but I suppose I didn't need to now, did I?" He smiled hesitantly, clearly hoping for some sort of news on her side of things. But there really weren't nothing to tell so she tried her best to smile back, and that was answer enough.

"You know, she wasn't herself. While you were gone, I mean. I noticed that recently she seemed oddly chipper, more...I don't know, not carefree but less burdened? Didn't think much of it, she's been getting a bit brighter every month for a while now. Just, really seemed to come out of her shell!" He'd smiled so softly at her it hurt, "But this makes quite a bit of sense. ...if you don't mind me asking, what happened?"

Her joy had been tempered already, knowing the question would come, but it still made her wince. Catra cleared her throat and awkwardly started, "You, uhm, you remember when I told Glimmer about my past? Well, I- see, I didn't tell her everything. Her dad-"

"I know." Bow said, startling her. When he seemed to realize she had frozen up he quickly continued, "I mean, Glimmer told us. About, gosh, almost two years back now? She told us about the accident. About you, and going after you. I meant what changed for you to get here?"

Her chest felt hollow as a drum. It didn't make sense. How could he be this kindly towards her if he *knew* . "You knew? How could you- why would you be happy to see me after…?"

He shifted to sit up straight next to her, and she flinched as he pulled the empty cup clenched between her hands. “Catra...what you did back then? It weren’t right. But Micah was an accident, you didn’t mean to kill him right?”

It took a moment to unstick her tongue. “No.”

“It’s a tragedy, what happened. A tragedy. But you didn’t mean to hurt anyone and he made a choice to go into a burning barn-”

“But I did mean to hurt someone.” Catra whispered it but Bow went quiet all the same. She tried to say more, but her mouth only uselessly flapped open and closed as she tried to explain.

“The other body?” He prompted.

She nodded slowly, the burden of that truth half lifted and finally managed to say, “I lied about that, when Glimmer found me. I just didn’t want her to know that. But I meant that one.”

“Who was it?” He didn’t sound angry or accusing, just soft as he reached over to stop her picking at her arm hairs.

Catra didn’t answer him, the next question spilling out in fear, because as much as she’d like to tell Bow and have his kind but firm support, it weren’t right. “Does Mrs. Moon know?”

“Much as me and Adora do, yeah.”

He let her go as Catra pulled back, taking a slow breath in and out to get herself oriented again. She’d spent months hiding in this house, somewhat pretending there weren’t other people who she needed to apologize to. And if Glimmer was still another day from getting home...well, this had been inevitable really. “Then she deserves to know the whole truth before ya. Is she in today?”

It was a partial truth, she *did* deserve to know before Bow, maybe even Glimmer.

Catra wished Glimmer wouldn't just shut down each time she tried to bring it up so she could've at least had a little practice in it.

Bow squeezed her shoulders and helped her get ready, including forcing her to drink the last of the tea she'd made. He shooed her away from the kitchen, promising to clean up his own mess and be gone before either she or Glimmer got home. Catra thought it was rather sweet of him considering everything, and lingered for a moment to memorize the way he looked now. A little older and more mature, hair a little longer and face a little leaner. If Mrs. Moon told her to leave town and never come back she would. Much as she wanted to hide in the Archer's home again, she was taking her cues and this could be it. She owed her as much as she owed Glimmer, and that was about the only reason she managed to actually get Melog and go into town.

It had been surreal as she'd rode in, a ride so familiar to her and yet so foreign from expansion which only got stranger as she started to see a few familiar faces. Folks who lit up and smiled at her, waving as she passed as if she'd never left. Catra couldn't understand it, why would anyone here be happy to see her? Why weren't they chasing her out? That infernal question was only answered when she reached the station.

"You gonna tell me what in the hell happened with you?" Lonnie asked brusquely towards her pocket watch, even though the train was supposed to leave five minutes ago, acting as if they'd spoken last week. Lonnie shot her a relieved, but unamused glare when Catra just stared at her mutely.

Her secret had been kept. No one outside of their little circle knew the truth, and people were just happy to see her with no strings attached.

She didn't know how to feel about that.

Catra swayed lightly on her feet as she caught sight of Kyle waving at her so enthusiastically that he fell off the platform.

Finally clearing her throat to answer, "Not just yet, I gotta tell Mrs. Moon first."

"Hmph!" Lonnie adjusted her cap and clicked her watch shut. "Fair enough, but you try running again and ain't no place on heaven and earth you'll be safe, you hear?" Each word was punctuated with a strong poke to the chest, "I will find you Catra D'riluth, and when I do I will end your miserable life." Then instead of further bruising up her sternum, Lonnie gently punched her shoulder, "Mrs. Moon stayed home today, so you best go there if you need to talk."

She hadn't even realized how much she missed watching Miss Turon stomp about until she watched her hop on the train. Catra just stood rooted to the spot as the caboose rumbled by, where Rogelio had one arm wrapped around Kyle to wave again as the train departed. Like the more things changed, the more they stayed the same. She waved back in a haze of confusion and chuckled thoughtlessly when they both cheered like idiots. When the whistles and bells grew faint, she finally got back on Melog and turned towards Angella Moon's house.

What in the hell was even happening anymore? This had to be some strange fever dream. Had to be. With unreality firmly established, she wasn't even worried as she knocked on the door. Apparently Mister Pop would greet her and take her coat like she was supposed to be here for a meal, and then she could die from whatever ailment this was in peace.

As such, she had not been prepared for the woman herself to answer the door. Reality crashed back in with a blinding flash as Catra became rooted to the spot to stare.

Angella Moon didn't look a damn day older than when Catra had fled. Her strawberry blonde hair was immaculately styled and she was wearing her favorite housecoat. Much like her unexpected guest, Mrs. Moon seemed to have frozen. Her eyes had gone huge and a hand went to cover her mouth, eyes flitting here and there as if she was gonna vanish into thin air.

Do something idiot!

"Uh, hello Mrs. Moon. May I come in?"

Angella Moon had always been this stalwart, stiff upper lip type. Her affections were genuine and warm, but apparently this was too much for even her constitution. Angella *screamed* a wordless cry and wrapped her in a hug, physically rocking them both back and forth for a moment in the doorway before hauling Catra inside. She squinted at the wispy hand locked around her arm as she was marched to the parlor, huh. She'd always assumed Glimmer's strength was from her daddy, but apparently the Moon's just had a vice like grip when need be.

She was gently shoved into a seat and Angella sat down while staring into her god damned *soul* . "I want to know what happened. All of it, top to bottom."

That would mean everything. From being unsure if she wanted to climb the ranks of the Horde or flee with her only friend all the way through cowering in her daughter's house. It was admitting to all her crimes, even the violent ones, even the unintentional things like how she cost Scorpia both her hands. Lying to Glimmer, the drinking and hiding and avoiding and fighting. All of it.

For all that it was terrifying to consider, her heart unclenched and she gratefully nodded. "Okay. Okay."

And she did.

Haltingly. Hesitant and scared. But she did.

Unlike when she told Glimmer a rosier version, this time each word made it easier to speak. Until the truth had come gushing out uncontrollably. The Horde and the people and every little thing she wished she could take back but never could. All the way up to the barn itself, the plan. Her god awful, stupid fucking plan because she just *had* to have the upper hand.

And that's when Angella put a hand on her arm to stop her, ice in her eyes as she clarified, "When you say Shadow Weaver...a tall woman? Black hair and green eyes. Calculating. Was that her?"

Catra gulped, god how did that witch still manage to ruin her life? Maybe she should've gone back to Erlandia with her pardon and made sure Weaver was staked into her fucking grave. "Y-yes. How'd you- uh? She, well, she's the one who brought me into the Horde. Sort of...raised me I suppose?"

Angella roughly exhaled through her nose, pushing a little further, "Had she been in a fire before? Gone by another name?"

She wracked her brain a little, the fire was obvious but another name? "Y-yeah she was scared of it after an accident a some kind. I- I don't know about a name though."

What she could never have expected was Angella's firm response to this information. "Damn you Micah!"

"Pardon?" Catra asked, flabbergasted.

Angella had looked so hurt even though her voice was rough with anger. "There was a woman just like the one you've described, called Light Spinner, who 'mentored' my husband when he was too young and naive and desperate for her approval to see how she was using him. He did anything she asked without question, and so she asked for more and more. ...until she finally asked too much. She manipulated him into helping her try to ruin another rail line, and when Micah figured it out he refused to finish it."

Her heart was pounding away in her ears, but each word sounded loud and clear.

"It was too late though. Everything was set and she tried to detonate the charges on her own and the roundhouse went up in flames. Micah felt so guilty for having left her there when he saw...she left as soon as she was able to, without a doctor we thought she may have died from the injuries. It took him *years* to start understanding the way she'd hurt him." Angella's gaze had

drifted to look at her picture of Micah, before snapping back to Catra when she wheezed something awful.

Her head had been spinning, heart pounding away as she tried to fit this new bit of information away. Shadow Weaver had mentored Micah Moon, who betrayed her and left her to burn, and later she gave her "gifts" to Catra, who would go on to murder them both in a fire (because Weaver was afraid of them because Micah-), and then Catra fell in love with his daughter. This was too much. This was far too much, and too fantastical, and too horrible. She coughed violently, before finally managing to take a breath.

"Catra?"

"Shit." Catra blinked furiously, too busy trying to not cry to bother feeling embarrassed, because something finally clicked into place. One last question she'd always had. "He...before he went in he said he heard someone inside. I- I swear I told him not to do it, that it was coming down. But he s-said he thought he knew them."

Angella's eyes slid shut as she cried, one hand covering her mouth as she took in her husband's final words. That his final act on this planet had been to try and save the life of someone who had hurt him so. Her voice was rough but tender when she spoke. "Oh, that does sound just like my Micah. He never stopped having nightmares about what she'd done to him, and what he'd done to her. No wonder. God save his soul...no wonder!"

"It was kind of him. Very brave." Catra whispered, hands twisting together to stop them from breaking something. It would feel so good to just scream and holler and feel something snap beneath her fingers, but she didn't want to. She just wanted to understand. ...Micah hadn't been an idiot and he hadn't been awful either, he'd just...in a way he'd just chosen the other path. Trying to help instead of hurt. He **knew** Shadow Weaver. Fuck. Fuck!

"He was. Compassionate and brave, quick as a whip and sometimes a bit silly. I love him." Angella smiled and finally opened her eyes again, and they sparkled with her conviction. "I'll always love him, my sweet, foolish Micah."

It was like someone was driving railroad spikes through her chest. Catra could tell she was too close to a breakdown, far too close to floating away and having a damn fit. She nodded, trying to breathe and failing. She needed to leave. She couldn't be here with this and just sit here when she'd fucking-

"Would you like to hear about him?" Angella asked, leaning over to pull some fancy glasses and a cut crystal decanter from inside the side table. It looked old and a dusty and good god she would do just about anything for a drink right now. Catra nodded a little too fast, promising herself that she'd just have the one. Wait, fuck, no, Angella would never let her have less than two. She'd- she just needed something to keep her dumb ass in this chair.

No more running, no more running. Glimmer's soft smile and Bow's hugs and Lonnie's exasperated fondness flashed before her eyes. It wasn't that she didn't want to leave, but it wasn't an unstoppable drive anymore. *There you go, there you are. Do what you can do.*

Catra watched entranced by the way the late afternoon sunshine bounced through the brown liquid as Angella poured them both a healthy glass. She jerked in surprise when Angella spoke, "I've been saving this for a bit. Micah had a sweet tooth and fell in love with rum. It's made from sugar cane and tastes a bit like molasses."

Catra hesitantly took her glass, and scrunched up her nose at the smell of some over ripened fruit. When Angella laughed, Catra mindlessly mumbled. "Ma'am, if you want to kill me just tell me."

Good job, just absolutely stellar. But Angella only gave a water chuckle.

"I feel the same way, I keep hoping that someday I'll try it and enjoy it enough to sip at it like he did." She lifted her glass and slammed it back like the most skilled of bar flies before shivering and shaking her head. Sputtering, "Oh god damn, vile!"

Which really did not build her confidence in rum.

Catra took a slow breath and then quickly took her shot. Instead of an awful demise, she hummed thoughtfully. Alright, the smell was awful, but that was rather nice actually. It tasted like sweet fruit and had a mellow burn. Nothing like the home-brewed tequila and whiskey she'd been choking down in the Waste until Entrapta told her how much formaldehyde was in 'em. Huh. "You know, that smells a lot worse than it tastes."

"I don't know why I'm surprised, and have another dear." Angella laughed, quickly pushing the bottle closer to her, "You know, you remind me quite a bit of my Micah."

Catra focused on pouring her second and final glass just to avoid having to speak. She weren't nothing like Micah Moon.

"I wish you two could've met- erm!?" Angella looked mortified when Catra flinched. "Well, I mean, met a different way. Properly. He would've loved you."

"Please," she wound a hand into her hair, tugging until it hurt worse than her heart, "please, you ain't gotta lie."

Angella sighed, and stood up so suddenly that Catra just kind of went limp. Finally. Whatever Mrs. Moon was gonna do, she could do and this could all be over, but all she did was sit next to Catra, and threw an arm over her shoulders. The smell of her perfume and soap was *painfully* familiar and safe. She'd already been near tears when Angella gingerly kissed her head.

"I'm not."

She'd just started to tear up, and good god was she *sick* of crying, when she heard someone come into the room. She couldn't even

find it in herself to be upset to find Glimmer’s murderous glare fixed on her.

Chapter End Notes

> Now before anyone decides to come after me for that cliffhanger, don't worry! The next chapter is titled "Forgiveness" for a reason! :D

Chapter 20: Forgiveness

Chapter Summary

Glimmer didn’t forgive. She held grudges forever. She remembered every slight and every mistake. She told people she forgave them far more than she ever actually meant it, because that’s what was expected of her. If someone hurt her she wanted undeniable proof that they wouldn’t do that ever again before she’d even give them a snow ball’s chance in hell.

Catra would always have the ability to hurt her, and it scared her how badly she wanted to give her that chance.

Chapter Notes

As always, a very big thank you to dragonesdepapel for editing this!!!!! Please go read some of her fantastic fics :D

~

This chapter has a lot of angry discussions and a few fights in it, because these two knuckleheads are finally going to talk if it kills them. But if that's not something you can do right now, might be best to wait or skip this one! As always I'm happy to give you a summary run down if you'd like one. :) This is ultimately a happier/healthier chapter but to get anywhere near being close again first part is actually communicating a little lot.

CW for: suicidal ideation and planning, domestic abuse, alcohol misuse/abuse

If you would like to skip the section where Catra talks about her past suicidal ideation stop reading when Glimmer says, “What was your plan anyhow? I got word that you were going hither and yonder, and I couldn’t make heads nor tails of it!”

And pick it back up again with the paragraph starting: After those sort of days, Glimmer often found she needed to stay home or work less.

~

Previously on HtQY

After finally leaving the Crimson Wastes, Catra arrived back at Etheria to speak with Glimmer. Which went both much better than expected AND worse than she'd hoped! The two have started to talk a little more and grow a bit closer, but Catra has been unwilling to push too hard to talk and Glimmer has been somewhat desperate to avoid it all together. After a few months, Bow stopped by the house and found Catra there, after a brief reunion Catra finally leaves Glimmer's house to go back into town seeking Angella Moon out. Angella and Catra talk about most of what happened, the barn, Micah, Shadow Weaver- and Angella is far more forgiving than Catra thinks she should be. All seems to be going well when Deputy Moon bursts into the room looking furious…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She'd been half asleep on her feet when she decided to stop and visit her mother's house, both to let her know that the fiscal report for the rail would be done this week and to just see her. Glimmer had been getting better at going out and connecting again, or well, she *had* been until Catra. These days she'd been more interested in going home to see her, but it meant less time out with the people she'd been reconnecting with. To be fair, no one had said anything about it to her and they'd been treating her well, but the fear that she was somehow pushing them away again was enough to make an effort despite how her body ached. Her long shift was almost done anyways, and things had been nice and quiet, so Glimmer wasn't too worried about the town going to hell in a handbasket.

She hoped the visit would be good and decent, without a single interruption to be had, and that she'd perk up with a little tea in

her. It would be nice to spend some quality time with her mother, honestly.

Glimmer had almost got her foot on the porch steps when a horse nickered at her. She sighed, not spooked but annoyed that now she was gonna have to find someone to return their damn lost horse to and- Melog? Sure as sugar, *Melog* was somehow up on top of the brick wall that surrounded her mother's property, the door horses normally went through was still closed and locked.

For one moment she wondered if this was a dream. How in the world did he even get up there? Could horses climb? But when he huffed at her, reality crashed down around her ears. Melog meant Catra. Catra was here, at Glimmer's mother's house. The panic hit her like a freight train. *She shouldn't be here, it's not time, what if she- what if they- what if she- I have to save her!* Save who, Glimmer wasn't sure, the adrenaline was certainly keeping her upright now but her brain still felt half asleep.

Glimmer spun on her heels and rushed to the front door feeling like she was fighting through molasses as she twisted the knob and shoved it open. She paused for a moment before rushing towards the first bit of noise she heard and barreled through the doorway to the sitting room.

And there she found Catra curled up into her mother's side, both of them teary and holding glasses of something as they turned to look at her. *That's good right? This is good! Right?* The three of them stared at one another in shock and confusion before Glimmer got a good look at the bottle.

It was her dad's bottle, something he'd loved and they'd taken out once a year on his birthday to have a drink on his behalf. It was her daddy's bottle. And Catra was drinking it.

"Grief can be funny, you know," Lance spoke softly to her as Glimmer handed him more Christmas decorations. "The ebbs and flows of it are unpredictable. Sometimes it'll feel like we've

dammed it up and stopped the flow, only to be swept away in a flood."

Glimmer did her best to not growl at him in frustration. If she'd known agreeing to help the Archer's decorate was just a sneaky way for them to try and pry the truth out of her, they had another thing coming!

"You won't always know when it's heading your way, but you don't have to weather it alone."

She'd stomped out pretty quickly after that, hissing excuses through her teeth.

She was so damned mad it was almost frightening. Well, at least now she understood Lance's flood analogy. The fear and love she had running in here had vanished underneath the icy hot anger, something that crackled and popped inside her chest.

And it was stupid, she knew that, to be so upset about something like this. Knowing that couldn't stop the tide though because Catra was *here* and she was drinking from her daddy's bottle.

"The hell are you doing here?" She snarled, more accusation than question.

And Catra- her stupid, sweet, son of a bitch- that moron just blinked up at her and actually seemed to relax!

"I invited her in." Angella sat up straighter, arm still wrapped protectively around the smaller woman's shoulders. Her tone was firm, clear as crystal, even as a few more tears leaked from her eyes.

I didn't ask you! Glimmer clenched her jaw tight, and refused to yell at her mother again, too tired of fighting her. She'd promised herself, and even if her heart was pounding out of her chest, she weren't gonna do it. Eventually she ground out a terse, "That's not what I meant."

Angella, however, had made no such "no fighting" promises apparently considering how condescending she sounded. "Now you listen to me young lady-"

But Catra interrupted, one hand in the air and the other placing her glass on the table. "Ma'am, all due respect, I can speak for myself and it's a fair question."

Glimmer didn't quite know what to do with the twisting sensation in her heart. How in the world could she be deliriously furious with someone and also want to thank them? Why couldn't things just be simple? For months now she'd been trying to keep things clean and clear and simple between them. Stalling a conversation neither of them were ready to have until they were more cordial. More used to one another again. It had been working too! Mostly! They was getting better at not snapping at one another, even if Glimmer sometimes barked and Catra sometimes hissed. As soon as one of them was gearing up, the other was cooling down. It let them coexist again, even live together as they adjusted.

Sure, she'd known Catra was getting frustrated and was lonely, but to just come into town without warning?

She just… she thought Catra knew well enough to warn a girl.

Catra rubbed her hands together, speaking slowly like she was considering each word. "I didn't plan on doing it like this Glim."

"Don't call me that!" Dumb thing to get mad over, but oh well.

Catra paused, taking a slow deep breath like she was upset (like she had a right to that right now!) before continuing in that same gratingly slow manner, "A'ight, my apologies miss. I didn't mean to be here today, but Bow came by the house and-"

Glimmer's ears started ringing. Shit. *Shit!* Of course he had, she told him she had it handled and of course Bow would assume the worst of her. Always sticking his nose where it didn't belong and now he found Catra and- *Poppycock and you know it! Stop it, stop being like this!* No, no, Bow would never assume the worst, he

was trying to be friendly like. She wasn't mad at him. She had to get it together. Catra was still speaking but Glimmer weren't paying much attention, too busy being angry with herself over being angry. *You did this to yourself, you got greedy Moon.* Wait, no! She was being cautious with a plan- *You wanted her for yourself. Judge, jury, and executioner.* Glimmer shook her head. God everything was just spiraling out of her control!

"-told her. A-and, I know that's a lot but I...I have more I need to tell you too."

"More?" Glimmer blinked as the heartbroken, angry tears started to flow down her cheeks. The mere thought that there was something left unsaid between them grounded her. It shouldn't hurt that bad, knowing that a liar had lied to you. She'd even known, she'd even known Catra was still lying and yet she'd forgotten. Seeing her crooked little smiles and smug grins and hearing her laugh had washed it away. "You've had MONTHS to tell me and you were still lying to me!?"

Angella glanced between them, looking bewildered for a moment before seeming to understand.

But it was Catra who caught her attention. She was finally sat up straight and seemed to have found some fire and steel tucked away. Sure, Catra had made the occasional pointed comment at home, snapping on occasion, but she nearly always gave in first these days. The woman glaring up at her matched better with the memories.

"Gee, I wonder why? It's almost like every damned time I **tried** to talk to you about, oh, I don't know, the fire or, say, ***us*** , that you just shut me down and rode off into the sunset! You never wanted to hear nothing, so don't go acting all high and mighty now!" Catra opened her mouth again, closed it with a harsh click, and took a slow deep breath. When her eyes opened again she seemed steady. Which was quite rude considering the way Glimmer couldn't do the same. "And I know I stopped trying, and that wasn't right of me. I know. But you sure ain't made it easy."

Everything she'd said was true, and actually rather reasonable.

Glimmer hated it. Didn't want to listen, didn't want to admit or apologize or nothing like that. She almost yearned for the old Catra who would've bitten her head off, maybe gone to throw a punch like she would at the yard. It would've, Glimmer seethed even as she tried to reason with herself, it would've been easier if she had. Then Glimmer could respond and they could just have it out! It was such a stupid thought, she knew it was ridiculous and wrong and she just couldn't- *SAY SOMETHING* .

She was only vaguely aware that she'd raised her voice. "I have let you live in my home-"

Catra snapped, standing up properly to yell back, "I didn't ask you for that! And since that night I have been at your god damn beck and call, trying to take this at your pace! So pardon me **your majesty** , I told you I didn't want to be a burden and you kept insisting I stay until you pulled some divine inspiration out of your ass for what I could do, and guess what you hain't found yet? So make up your mind princess, am I taking advantage of you or not? I'm just- fuck! **What do you want from me!?** What do you... *fuck* !"

Isn't this what you wanted? Glimmer was heaving for air, like she'd been the one yelling. *Just wanted to make her fight back dintcha?* Sure, but it didn't feel as good as she'd hoped to drag her down into the mud. "...you're right. I'm- I'm sorry." She was about as surprised as Catra was that it came out at all. Dizzy. Oh, that weren't good. Lower to the ground, gotta sit so she wouldn't fall. Glimmer swayed on her feet, moving to collapse in the nearest chair as her mind covered the world in the quiet hiss of falling sand.

She looked at the glass in her hands and frowned, when did she get a glass of...rum? Looking up, Glimmer watched her mother hold both of Catra's shoulders as they had a quick whispered conversation, and decided she didn't want to know. She quickly threw her shot back and shivered violently at the taste, coughing

to stop herself from gagging as she leaned forward and put the glass on the table upside down in case her mother got any funny ideas. And she normally did.

When Glimmer had been thirteen, she'd had a strange spell of fainting. Micah had been the one who grabbed a bottle of port and made her take a sip. Angella had been angry for a moment about her child chugging hard liquor, but when Glimmer didn't faint she took to the cure like an over eager duck to water. Or well, that wasn't fair. More like a woman with a shockingly high alcohol tolerance who didn't know it. Peppermint schnapps had been the flavor of Glimmer's young teenage years, occasionally putting on airs of being faint to have a free drink. When her mother finally cottoned on it was a rather long talking to about being honest and moderation.

Funny that she always makes you have two these days.

Don't let 'em spiral with you, land's sake!

"Alright. I'm not, I don't- let's just focus on this for now? What did you want to tell me?" Glimmer gave herself a pat on the back, that seemed reasonable and she didn't sound like a raving fool.

Catra walked over slowly, kneeling down to get a good look. Her keen eyes were too knowing and Glimmer felt her stomach churn with nerves. "You sure?"

Nerves were what she was going to blame for squeaking, "D'riluth! I- tell me now or forever hold your damned peace!"

Catra chuckled softly before she rested her hands on Glimmer's knees. "Okay. There was someone else there. In the barn. I knew that. It *was* an insurance scam, but I was...well I planned out a murder to go with it. I lied to your dad hoping he'd listen better. Didn't work out."

It was nothing she didn't already know, a confirmation of her own fears. If she hadn't already exhausted her already exhausted emotions with a panic, maybe she'd be more upset. Instead she

nodded. “I found out about the second body. Paid your bounty, remember? I… Who was it?”

Catra’s eyes had a hollowness to them as she answered, “Shadow Weaver.”

Everything she knew of that vile woman, what she’d done to Catra, and even the look of broken not quite satisfaction on Catra’s face when she confirmed Weaver’s slow and horrible death all those years ago flashed through her mind. Glimmer had wondered for a while about the woman, even tried to learn a little about Weaver where she could, having believed Catra lied about her death. She might’ve hated Catra at the time, and it certainly hadn’t been to do the woman a favor, but if she could take down Shadow Weaver she could at least have part of the Horde’s former leadership actually taken out. But no one had seen hide or hair of her, it was like she was a ghost who’d vanished and Glimmer had eventually conceded that Weaver was possibly dead.

Well, this certainly explained why there were no records for Weaver’s death.

Explained a lot really.

It didn’t explain *why* though. She ached and hurt, and didn’t want to. Tried to find anger and only found resignation. “Why didn’t you tell him that? Maybe he’d-”

“We were just discussing that.” Angella cut in, and Catra shot her, somehow, both a grateful and annoyed look. “It wouldn’t have helped at all. My love, do you remember what we told you about Light Spinner?”

And what in the hell did that awful woman have to do with Weaver, besides them both dying in a fire?

Catra chuckled, a little weak and a little wet, as she stood back up. “Turns out we got something in common, me and Mr. Moon.”

No. She couldn't process that right now. Not now. Not yet. God damn it all to hell that awful woman had become the devil, had hurt two people she loved and- no no no. Not now!

"S-so what?" Glimmer was already falling, why not plummet instead? Her voice cracked and shook but she was grasping at straws and didn't care. "So she didn't just kill daddy, she killed that *bitch* so all's forgiven?"

And her mother was there, running her hands through Glimmer's hair as she sobbed. "No, it doesn't. There's no evening out the scales, a bad deed being outdone by a good one. Glimmer, you said it yourself, his death was an accident and I don't think any of us mind much about *her* . You don't have to forgive her, just because *I* don't see a need to."

She leaned in closer, hugging her mother around her waist as she rode out the waves. Glimmer had wondered, she had been wondering for a while now why everyone else forgave Catra. Maybe this was the secret, others didn't feel a *need* to forgive.

She knew it was an accident, she did, but hadn't let that truth sink in. Couldn't. Finding out had been like a violent rainstorm hitting the mesa, the top layer of sand and soil washing away in a rush but the water didn't get a chance to seep into the land before the rain clouds cleared leaving them high and dry.

Bow had always said that he'd forgive folks, as long as they meant it when they said they was sorry and tried better. Adora gave forgiveness as long as she saw someone change their behavior. Her mother only forgave when someone actually meant to hurt her, accepting apologies but quietly explaining it away in private.

Glimmer didn't. She didn't do any of those things. She held grudges forever. She remembered every slight and every mistake. She told people she forgave them far more than she ever actually meant it, because that's what was expected of her. If someone hurt her she wanted undeniable proof that they wouldn't do that

ever again before she'd even give them a snow ball's chance in hell.

Catra would always have the ability to hurt her, and it scared her how badly she wanted to give her that chance.

Angella whispered something about water before slipping away, leaving Glimmer to sit alone feeling like her heart had been scooped out. Aching so bad she didn't notice Catra slowly reaching for her until they were nearly touching. Glimmer flinched back and Catra snatched her hand back right quick.

"I can go. If you want me to. Leave here, or leave town right now if you want."

Like she fucking knew what she wanted!

"Just go home," she'd said, far more bitterly than she'd meant to for sure. She sighed at Catra's wince, the way her dipped and shoulders tensed. She couldn't comfort her and didn't want her comfort, she just wanted to be alone with her mother. Just for now. Just for now. "I can't look at you right now, but I don't want you to leave. I just need some damn time."

"Glim-" Catra had barely swayed a bit forward on the balls of her feet, and Glimmer instinctively pushed her back. It was hard enough to make her fall back on her ass, and for a moment she lingered and stared with this hurt and understanding and- and it was just too much!

"Just get out!"

It shouldn't hurt so bad to watch her leave, should it? *It's what I wanted.* Glimmer sniffled pathetically. This was the problem wasn't it? She didn't know what she wanted and when she did it weren't ever right.

Eventually she moved to the couch and her mother joined her, shoving a tall glass of water into her hands. Glimmer sipped at it

and glared at the open bottle of rum, the smell making her feel worse, until Angella began to put it away.

"See? Thank you!" Her mother laughed lightly and corked the bottle before taking Glimmer's free hand. "How those two *enjoy* rum, I will never understand it!"

She snorted into her water. She wouldn't have guessed it, but it certainly did track. "Of course she liked it."

"She does tend to be unpredictable," Angella squeezed Glimmer's hand and winked in the most painfully awkward way, "but I think we like that about her, hmm?"

" *Mother.* "

Angella sniffed a bit haughtily, "Well, at least *I* like that about her. Now, what's this about months?"

Glimmer squinted at her in confusion before finally understanding the question, and quickly downed her water even if it made her feel sicker. As she coughed and went green around the gills, Angella nodded like this non-verbal response was a highly detailed report instead of a bunch a nothing.

"I see. Well, better than I expected to hear honestly." Her mother was a horrible actress, shrugging stiffly and looking around the room as if she'd never seen it before. Honestly, Adora could practically give her lessons, and that was saying something.

Glimmer groaned, "You are not subtle."

"Well then, perhaps you should just tell me what's going on so I don't bother you with my theatrics?"

Maybe this was for the best, with the flood of emotions come and gone she was too drained to get worked up. "...Okay."

It was slow, methodical, and half way through Mister Pop had finally arrived for dinner and only needed to take one look before

vanishing and returning with tea. Something easy and light was put out for food, not that she could tell anyone what it was with how scattered she felt. And Glimmer slowly talked. How she'd just appeared one day out of the blue. The tenuous and precarious dance they'd locked themselves into, where one wrong step could ruin them both. How mad she still got sometimes, how happy she was other times. How wrong it felt to say the words, "I can't lose her again." and mean them.

The whole affair became a surreal blur of soft and round and comfort. Less substance and more feelings that had desperately clamored for her attention. Like voices sounding from underwater, sweetly calling, telling her this was the right thing to do.

At some point, she managed to leave. Barely able to stay in the saddle, and too tired to treat her poor horse right. Glimmer barely made it to her room, ignoring the bundle on the settee that was studiously ignoring her too, and slept.

When she finally woke half past eleven, Glimmer found Catra painstakingly reading an old hand me down novel Bow had lent her a few years back at the table. The image seemed to burn into her heart. Catra hunched over, hair falling like a curtain to block the sun that was streaming through the kitchen window. A small amount of dust drifted around her back, one hand playing idly with a mug and the other slowly running along the page. Catra's mouth moved, silently reading the words to herself with a furrowed brow. She was still in her sleep shirt, pants, and socks and generally looked a damn mess. She was just so beautiful that Glimmer had to look away.

"Uhm, g'morning." She mumbled to the floor, embarrassed and nervous as she carefully walked and sat down next to her, close enough to feel the heat from her body against her own. "Watcha reading?"

Catra sat tense, gaze sharp and searching before turning back to the book. "Fuck if I know. I'm pretty sure some of these words are made up."

Glimmer leaned a little closer to see where she was pointing and grinned a little. “Scrumdiddlyumptious is a real word, I promise.”

“I can *not* believe an officer of the law would lie to me like this.” Catra lifted her mug to take a sip only to glare when she realized it was empty.

While Catra pouted, Glimmer just watched her for a moment. Soaking her in. This was her trying, wasn’t it? It wasn’t that she didn’t take this all seriously, the way Glimmer had feared so badly, but that she was trying to follow Glimmer’s lead. That’s what she’d said last night, and finally it was sinking in. They were both trying, and she needed to reach back out.

“Hey?” Glimmer tried to speak, she really did, the words tangling up and refusing to budge until she chose something else to say. “Thank you, for telling me about...her.”

Catra had tensed up all over again, her eyes fixed to the book but they weren’t moving.

“A-and, I know I said it yesterday, but you were right. I’ve been...avoiding talking about, well, much of anything. Things were getting easier and I didn’t want to make them harder.”

“But you did.” Catra finally dropped her hand from the mug, curling it into a fist.

Glimmer tried to swallow the lump in her throat as she whispered. “I know. I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to.”

After a beat of silence, she reached over and grabbed Catra’s fist. It struck her like lightning that this was the first time they’d really touched since she’d come back, and her whole body ached.

A moment later it opened and turned as Catra laced their fingers together, whispering back, “Okay. …Thank you.”

They sat in the silence, in the words still unspoken and the warmth of one another’s hands. She wasn’t sure who scooted

closer first, but by the time they got up to eat lunch they'd been pressed up side to side silently enjoying the sunshine.

It was funny how quickly Catra fit back into her life after that.

News spread faster than wildfire, and by the time Glimmer went back into town it seemed like everyone knew Catra was back. Hell, most of them even knew that they were living together again, even if none of them understood the situation. So it was with an uneasy smile that she dealt with folks congratulating her on "getting her woman back home where she belongs" or the invasive question people asked to try and find out what happened. She just wanted to go home and never leave the woods again, and within three scant hours it was bad enough that *Double Trouble* had had to take pity on her.

"Always difficult when you see an ex," they'd tutted, tapping a nail against Glimmer's nose as they dropped off her "lunch", an ancient moldy sandwich that no one actually paid to eat but paid to have placed down for a second as an excuse to buy a drink. She might enforce the law, but dagnabbit, banning alcohol service without food had been a right stupid one to make. Even Adora had looked forlorn when the new liquor laws were announced, and this was just the best solution. "Then again, doesn't seem like she's much of an ex anything, does it? Do re-introduce us when she stops living a dreary hermit life."

She'd been blushing and stuttering too hard to explain how wrong they were to actually respond before they swanned away to take care of another customer. And that one little interaction felt like a spark to a long fuse, like they were both set on a path they couldn't return from and everybody had known but her.

Catra had even started coming into town on occasion, although she seemed stiff and nervous the whole time and often drifted to spend time with her when Bow or her mother when Glimmer weren't able to chat.

“I didn’t exactly see lots of folks while I was away,” she’d grumbled, kicking a tin can closer to where Glimmer was sweeping the street, “and when I did, well, it weren’t nobody you’d want to see. I don’t know, does that make sense?”

She’d snickered a little bit at the image? it conjured in her mind of a chubby cheeked child version of Catra pouting away, and Catra reached out to roll the can further away with the tip of her boot as punishment. Whoops. “It does, I might’ve been here still but...I didn’t exactly...uhhh…”

“Bow mentioned.” After a minute she kicked the can back over, far enough that Glimmer swept it up right away. When another group of folks turned the corner and waved a little too enthusiastically, Catra went pale and Glimmer took pity.

“OH DEAR!” She gasped, leaping up and startling the poor woman, “Catra I think I left the stove door open, can you go home and close it?”

Glimmer batted her eyelashes and Catra practically ran for the hills with a grateful smile. She rattled the trash into a better place and made her own quick escape down another road.

At home the two made sure to spend a little time actually talking each day, and Glimmer made particularly sure to not always have some arbitrary task for Catra to complete. Slowly inching their ways towards harder things, and actually talking them through when they came up. For Glimmer it was trying to explain herself more. Looking in and sharing the way she’d been wanting but unable to. Mostly she talked about her daddy, her memories of him, what she missed about him, how she loved him so much it hurt. When Catra had seemed ready to bolt over that, she talked about how she’d missed her too.

“You missed me?” Catra had asked with a cautious hope, eyes wide and searching while Glimmer nodded miserably.

It was the secret she'd tried to keep from herself. "I hated that I did, but I never stopped missing you."

That had been about the most either of them could take on *that* particular topic.

She talked about her work, the stress, anything she could think of to actually mend something between them. And Catra listened intently until she couldn't speak no more, and then she'd talk too. More about Scorpia and Entrapta, some about the life she'd been living even though that was often prompted, she answered all the same.

She'd finally broken down and just asked one day, "What was your plan anyhow? I got word that you were going hither and yonder, and I couldn't make heads nor tails of it!"

Catra had smiled weakly before looking back out at the chipmunks that were fighting each other on the trail. "Didn't have a plan. Not really. ...just, couldn't make up my mind if I wanted to keep going or not."

Her heart thumped painfully at that, and she asked hopefully, "Going where?"

"...Glimmer, you ain't stupid." Catra winced but her words were firm. "I wasn't...everyday I found new ways I could end it. Just stop hurting, stop feeling. Sometimes it felt like the best thing I could do for anyone, sometimes it just felt like the only real option. About a month or so after I left, I realized I was spending more and more time cleaning my pistol. Making sure it was smooth and easy to pull the trigger. Took better care of it than me and it scared me. I sold it. I needed the money, but I justified that it shouldn't be that easy."

Fuck. She'd know Catra to get depressed but hadn't considered suicide. Good god almighty.

Catra chuckled weakly and wetly, "So, yeah. No plan to *do* anything, just...plans."

It was a hard pill to swallow, but necessary.

Not all at once, but every so often, Catra would tell her about it. There'd been a cliff, a river, a train, a cold snap- each story given willingly without asking, and each one drove another nail in her very soul. Here Glimmer had been scared witless over Catra's hand, unaware how close and how often she'd almost lost her entirely because of what Glimmer had done. Sure there was more to it than that, but her reaction was a big part of it too.

After those sort of days, Glimmer often found she needed to stay home or work less. Bless Adora Gray, who never once asked why or pushed for information. Just like she did when Catra left, she became a bastion of neutrality even if she hung onto every word Glimmer did breathe about it. She'd stay home for a bit and spend her time with the woman who meant so damn much to her it hurt.

There were good stories too. She'd nearly pissed herself laughing about Melog sticking his nose into an icy lake, startling away and then creeping back over to do it again just in case it was different this time. Glimmer could picture that sweet lug doing just about anything after getting to know him. Melog had a certain talent for doing the strangest things after all. Some of the best stories had been from the wastes, all about blazing hot evenings around a card table or an evening spent looking up at the stars.

Just.

There weren't nearly as many good ones as bad ones.

And it helped get her to thinking. Thinking more about both of their pains.

What was she really hurt over? Because there was real hurt, Catra *had* hurt her too. The single best part about hearing Catra's side of the story, was realizing that things weren't as black or white as she'd assumed. No, things weren't as simple as she'd wanted. So why was Glimmer actually upset?

It was kinda obvious once she spent some time with it. She'd been hurt, mostly, by being locked out. Knowing something was wrong but being told all was well when they both knew it damn well wasn't. Feeling like she couldn't push or ask without Catra blowing up at her, that constant fear of hurting or being hurt had eaten her up from the inside. Someone else hurting didn't mean they had a right to take it out on her or keep her emotionally hostage. Sure, some of it was on her too for not speaking up or stepping back, but Glimmer should not have been put into a situation where she had to make that kind of choice anyways.

Next was the drinking. Good lord the drinking! Knowing Catra was getting herself sick and weren't sleeping while "hiding" it. She'd been scared for her fiancé and horribly angry at her too. Not that Glimmer ever brought *that* up either. She'd only helped fuel it by buying extra bottles while thinking about wanting to enjoy some for herself.

And, of course, there was The Lie. Which was something big and awful and had nothing to do with her own actions. It had been easier to be mad about the contents of the lie, and she had a right to be mad about that damn it all! It just- it wasn't really the issue. Glimmer had been fragile too. Tired and strung out and unwell, and it had been easier to get mad about her father's death than it was to try and help herself.

Not that she could've done much at the time. She'd been half killing herself to try and help Catra feel better, hoping that one miraculous day she would and then *Glimmer* could feel better too. Locked into her heading and wearing blinders, weren't much way she could've redirected anything at the time. So she didn't, instead she just got mad and stayed mad, and convinced herself that the smaller reason was the main one.

"Why didn't you tell me? About, well, any of it?" Glimmer asked nervously towards the floor. Catra had done a great job sanding and sealing it, and the new glossy surface shined up at her.

She wasn’t sure what she’d expected to happen, but Catra giving a full on belly laugh wasn’t one of them.

“S-sorry! I just, ha!” She ran her fingers through her hair, leaving a small trail of dust as she tugged a little at it until she was more under control. “God I was fucking stupid, s’all. I didn’t tell you nothing ‘cause I was afraid of losing you.”

Much as she wanted to argue that Catra wasn’t stupid, well, it was kinda stupid. Honestly, it was about as stupid as half the things she’d done back then too.

“Lying’s what did it.” Glimmer mumbled, feeling oddly embarrassed about it but desperate to let Catra know what she’d realized. “I knew you were lying about a lot of things and just thought, well, I wanted you to just tell me about what I already *knew* . …I just wanted you to trust me.”

Catra frowned, glancing to the side as she gripped her own arms. “I did trust you, but you’re smarter than me and I thought-”

“Shut up about that right now D’riluth, call yourself stupid one more time and see what I do!” Her threat was about as scary as an elder cow mosying down the fields, but she had to say something.

“It ain’t a bad thing!” Catra insisted, knocking their boots together playfully like that was gonna help. “You’re just educated and- OW!”

Glimmer pinched her side and glared. “I warned you!”

Catra glared back twice as hard, looking offended and pissed off. “Fucking god damn it, just listen for a minute!? You *are* smarter, and I knew if I told you about everything you’d use that big ol’ brain of yours and see which way the wind was blowing. But I get it, part of the problem was I didn’t tell you the truth about damn near anything.”

"If I was so damned smart, then why didn't I think things through to help you understand I wanted you to lean on me? Why didn't I tell you that I felt like you were just taking and taking? So I read some books and had a tutor. Well whoopty doo! Gosh it's almost like it didn't matter cuz it weren't about- about- I don't know! Trigonometry!"

Catra's face screwed up, clearly swallowing some choice words down which only made Glimmer seethe a little more. What in the world was she getting upset over!? Well fine, if she didn't want to tell her then let her stew in all her miserable little-

Hang on a minute.

"Why are we both getting so mad over this?" She asked, genuinely confused as she tried to pick the conversation apart.

"I'm not-" Catra cut herself off at Glimmer's unimpressed look, then huffed. "You're all caught up in some word choice, and you ain't...it feels like you're just trying to cheer me up instead of listening."

"Oh." Glimmer squinted and the pieces fell into place. "Okay. I just, I don't like hearing you put yourself down like that. You always act like you're lesser or, I don't know, not worthy or something. Makes my blood boil when you discount yourself."

Catra blinked at her slowly, then leaned back in her seat. "Oh."

It took a few moments of awkward silence for the strange twisting in her gut to pan out as guilt. "I didn't say sorry, did I? I'm sorry, you're right. I asked you a question and then wasn't listening. ...Was, god this is gonna sound bad, and I promise I'm not trying to- to be flippant or something, but, was that it? You clammed up because you thought I'd leave you?"

Because that hurt. She did her best to placate the screaming voice inside her heart that howled away, *Trust me, you didn't trust me. What did I do to make you think so damn little of me?* And instead Glimmer kept her mouth shut and ears open.

Little swirls of dust drifted around Catra's head, framed in the streaming evening sunlight as she finally nodded, like something was still bothering her. "Wasn't wrong neither."

For all she wanted to pull away, Glimmer leaned a little into Catra's side and did her best to manhandle her frustration. "You weren't *right* either though. When it finally...Catra I was holding on by a thread. I woulda been angry, not saying I wouldn't a been, but it wouldn't have gone so…"

The day after Catra had left, Glimmer's hands had been bruised and swollen. Tender in ways she hadn't known they could be. It was one more thing she'd been furious about at the time, that now she had to clean up the charred remains from the fire with aching hands. One more thing she'd been happy to blame on the woman she'd hurt.

"Shit, this is coming out wrong." Glimmer wiped hastily at her eyes before she could cry. "I would not have- I shouldn't have **attacked** you. That, that weren't right, and I know that was my choice a'ight? If you would told me sooner, I- I think I would've had more control. God damn me, that just sounds awful don't it?"

"Naw," Catra chuckled, shrugging it off, "that was a long time coming anyhow I think."

"No. This isn't semantics right now, and you should- I don't like- I shouldn't have done that. It was wrong. You didn't deserve it!" Maybe it was the years of breaking up fights or studying laws but now that she'd broken out of that far more violent mindset than she ever wanted to admit to, looking back into it was abhorrent. *Huh, is this what it's like for her?* They both had their reasons, awful and twisted as they were. "Catra...please, say something."

"I don't know what you want me to say. I think you're wrong and you think I'm wrong. Just the way it is." Oh lord, she was getting twitchy, fidgeting where she sat and clearly ready for a fight. "Let's just...I don't know. I'm tired."

Well, they'd see about revisiting that. Glimmer sighed trying to think of what to do next, when she finally realized Catra wasn't fidgeting but massaging out her right hand.

"You doin' alright?" Glimmer rolled her eyes as Catra shrugged. "Okay, tell me to go away if you want me to fuck off, but you mentioned it first. Your hand hurting?"

Catra grimaced, immediately stopping what she was doing before slowly starting again. "Just stiff, been cold at night and I overused it."

Cold? Glimmer frowned. It hadn't been that cold at night recently at all, so either she was literally lying after they *just* talked about how that wasn't good or she was getting sick. Neither option was good. "You been coughing or aching besides the hand? It ain't been that bad last few nights."

Catra gaped at her before almost hissing, "Big words from the lady *upstairs* with *shutters* and a heavy ass quilt, but down here lil miss, it's a bit cold!"

She blushed horribly, but at least Catra didn't sound actually upset with her stupidity. "W-well why haven't you- wow, that was gonna be stupid. See? Where's this big smart brain you were talking about? Good heavens! We are switching tonight, you get the quilt I'll take that blanket, and I'll get some shutters installed." She was on a roll now, rapidly thinking up more that they needed to do.

"No! Hang on now-"

"Oh shush."

"I'm serious, don't you dare Glimmer Moon!" There was a beat of silence as they glared at one another before Catra barked out a harsh laugh, "Why the *hell* are we fighting about this!?"

Good golly miss Molly, they were practically bruising one another with how hard they was gripping one another's arms. Mad and scared and mostly a mess.

"Okay. Let's list the facts then. We ain't been living equally here, and I have not been treating you right, so I want you to take the warm spot tonight and then I want to make things nicer for you."

Catra looked, for a moment, like she was gonna cry before she went back to looking pissed. "It ain't no thing! I'm just being a baby, and you don't need to sacrifice nothing over that."

Am I just stupid, or is she? Glimmer didn't mean to sound so sarcastically sweet, but oh well, "Well darlin', if it ain't no thing then what, pray tell, would I be sacrificing?"

"Are you-" Catra huffed, and then went a little limp with exhaustion. "See? Smart. Too damn smart! Just let me stay down here."

"...fine then I'm joining you. I call the floor for bed space."

And she finally laughed, just her normal real laugh. "Excuse you!?"

"Well you don't want to impose, and I don't want us doing things uneven like. So I'll come down here 'till we get this all sorted out, and I call the floor. It's got to be more comfortable than that old thing, asides, I'm not sure if you noticed this, but these here floors were recently renovated beautifully. So it's cleaner than the settee too." Glimmer smiled as Catra just laughed harder, and then gently pulled her hands apart to massage them herself. "And if'n you overworked one hand I don't need you busting the other one trying to help. How's that?"

It took one night for Glimmer to declare they would both sleep upstairs instead because it was cold as all get out downstairs!

But from there they worked together to get the downstairs nicer. And unfortunately it wasn't until part way through, when Catra mentioned wanting to fix the creak in the study, that Glimmer realized a much better solution.

"Lord, help your poor child," Glimmer dropped the hammer she'd been using and stomped upstairs to look at the space. Bookshelves could get moved downstairs and the sitting chairs could go down to the parlor as well, and that would leave enough space to make a little bedroom. Hell, it even already had a door to the bathroom and everything.

Catra peaked around her shoulder suspiciously before shooting her a questioning look.

Glimmer nodded slowly, still looking at the space as she pictured a set of drawers for Catra's clothes and did her best to not feel a twinge at it. There weren't no way they was ready to sleep in the same room and share a closet again. *Run that by me again?* She paused and blushed horribly at her own presumptuous thoughts. "Alright, we can get a bed and dresser for you in her for sure. Probably smart to still shutter downstairs to help keep some heat though."

"What?" Catra squeaked, for some reason blushing as badly as Glimmer knew she was.

"I will not abide by you sleeping on a settee any longer D'riluth, not when we could get you a room."

It was, luckily, not an awful sort of fight although it was the very dumb kind.

And it helped her to think, taking the time to work next to Catra day in and out for a while. It broke down the last few feeble shadow puppets she'd made, caricatures and assumptions about both of them until she realized some sort of truth.

Glimmer wasn't mad at Catra. Not anymore. She had forgiven Catra in her heart for a while. That last sputtering coal wasn't for *her* . Glimmer laid awake, listening to those aching familiar snores as she tried to not cry. She was mad at herself. For not listening. For not talking about it. For letting that hurt fester and rot long

before she found out. For taking things to such an extreme. She wasn't ever going to forgive herself for that.

She'd turned into a monster, nearly killed someone she loved so dearly, and for what? To avoid taking responsibility? How awful. How unforgivable.

"You okay?" Catra's voice was thick with sleep, creaking and rough in contrast to the gentle warmth of her hand as she slowly rubbed Glimmer's back. They might be technically in separate sleep rolls, but they'd certainly scooted closer as the bedroom project had gone along. And if she could've just kept it together for two more nights, she coulda just cried in her own room alone in peace.

Because if there was one question guaranteed to make her not feel okay, that had to be it. She tried to choke back a sob without any success, and covered her face as if that would hide her now free flowing tears.

"Wha- hey! Hey, c'mere." Catra didn't have to work hard to roll her over. She slowly pried Glimmer's hands away, revealing just how soft her eyes looked in the dim lighting. How worried and concerned. Catra smiled soft and sad at her, clearly trying to cheer them both up now. "Well howdy doody miss."

Catra was sweet and kind and soft, and Glimmer had certainly taken advantage of that. The thought just made her sob harder, and Catra wriggled out from under her covers to wrap Glimmer up in a hug.

"Yer alright, it's alright."

"N-no I'm not. I- I wanted to k-kill you over an *accident* . That's not alright! That's n-not alright at all!" Glimmer whispered harshly, her voice rough from all her crying. "An- and I just wanted someone to hurt!"

Catra hugged her tighter, resting her chin on top of Glimmer's head as she sighed heavily.

“It wasn’t right, it w-wasn’t right at all!” She whimpered lightly, sniffling away in the darkness and warmth. “I’m so sorry, Catra. I’m so sorry!”

There was a long pause as they clung to one another before Catra softly said, “Thank you, I forgive you.”

But that couldn’t be right, it was too simple. Too easy. Too perfect. “W-well I don’t.”

For one moment she was afraid Catra was pushing her away, before realizing that she actually just wanted to look at her. Glimmer’s eyes stung and ached, but she squinted back all the same.

“Well I do. You…do you forgive me? F-for the barn?”

She quickly cradled Catra’s face in her hands. “ *Of course* .”

Catra’s smile became strained and her eyes watered right up. “Well…I don’t.”

“Well,” Glimmer huffed, mad and relieved and something in between, “ain’t we just two peas in a pod.”

Catra gave a wet chuckle at that. “Did always say we made one helluva pair.”

“Pardon you.” Glimmer gracelessly turned her head to wipe her nose off on her own shoulder. “Well I think we still make a helluva pair, so there.”

“Sincerest apologies, miss.” Catra quickly bunched her sleeve up at the hand to wipe away Glimmer’s last few tears. “Guess we’ll just have to work on the accepting part.”

And it wasn’t a grand statement, it wasn’t a flashy moment. It was less dramatic and less traumatic than she thought it would be. To give that forgiveness, something she’d thought would be

like pulling her own teeth, had been simple. It was done and dusted.

She hadn’t even noticed when the whole world had righted itself, and now they could just…continue on instead of waiting on a knife’s edge. The work wasn’t finished by any means, but that didn’t matter as much as finally being able to see the trail again.

Glimmer swiped her thumbs across Catra’s cheek, brushing away a few errant tears as well. “Okay.”

The moonlight glinted off Catra’s teeth as she smiled back. “Okay.”

God it felt good.

Chapter End Notes

A brief exchange that didn't fit in the scene in the end, but I loved too much to let go.

“...honestly shoulda known something was wrong when you didn’t make no jokes about trigonometry.” When Catra looked bewildered, Glimmer tried to imitate her a little. “You did who and a what with a tree now?”

“That’s not how I sound.” But she said it with that soft, small little smile that said a thousand words.

Thanks for reading! Next up: Getting to Re-Know You

Chapter 21: These Things Come Around Again

Chapter Summary

> Catra hadn't known what to say when Glimmer saw her leaving the station, but the two rode home while chatting easily enough. Like…like it weren't no big thing at all. But it was a big deal. She'd gone to work, felt good about her work, spoke with several people, and got to watch the beautiful colors of the sunset paint the woman she loved in spectacular light.
>
> And if felt so damn nice to let it quietly be.
>
> Until it didn't.

Chapter Notes

> There is quite a bit of Catra having issues with negative self talk, the anniversary of the barn fire, and later on there is quite a bit of alcohol so please take care of yourselves if you aren't in the place to see that right now.
>
> Otherwise, happy birthday Catra??? You're welcome and I'm sorry?????

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After somehow the most dramatic showdown *and* most anticlimactic fight in her life at Mrs. Moon's house, Catra had gone home fearing the worst. She'd ridden slowly let herself sit in that moment under moonlight to rememorize it and keep it forever. Surely she wasn't ever gonna make this ride again, not after that debacle. Only the next day as she's waiting for the hangman's noose, Glimmer sheepishly sat down with her. Not Miss Moon, not Deputy Moon, not the girl from before, but Glimmer. Her Glimmer

now. The woman with a core of diamond, a deep well of love, someone hurt and loved and fighting each day.

And they were *talking* and it was making things better.

Not all at once, mind you, but slowly and hesitant like the first few drops of rain during a monsoon shower. Then, suddenly, all at once and it was just as terrifying as Catra imagined staring a flash flood down would be too. It was scary to seek Glimmer out to talk about anything and everything while wondering if she was still balanced on a knife's edge or not. But each time either of them misstepped, they both paused to breathe and think, and they'd move on. She often caught herself switching between frustration that things were moving so slow and anxiety that it was going too smoothly.

Glimmer had quickly found a solution that Catra loathed, "Well it ain't like you've been socialized much."

"Excuse me!? Sociali- I am not a horse that needs training!" Catra had sputtered, already seeing where this was heading.

"Oh *really* ?" Glimmer had smirked at her, that evil little smile that did funny things to her heart before snickering, "Then why, oh why do you always have such a long face?"

Catra had let her have her stupid laugh if only because the fake evil routine being demolished by her childlike glee was adorable beyond all reason.

"But I mean it, you need to go into town more. Get used to what it's like to, ya know, talk with folk normally? I don't know, just seems like it could help to practice it."

She didn't want to. She really didn't want to. Glimmer was here and Bow came by to visit, and Catra felt like she might explode if anyone else so much as said howdy do. Perhaps there was something to it though. Before this she'd been alone for a long time riding home and before that she'd been little more than a hermit lurking in Entrapta's office, and even further back she'd

isolated on purpose. Well damn, whaddya know? “Well, I suppose I should go and speak to some civilized folks.”

“That’s the spirit!”

Catra smiled politely and was more than pleased to wait until Glimmer caught up..

“...now hang on a cotton picking minute, I am civilized!”

Victory won she leaned back happily in her chair with a lazy shrug. “Says you.”

So the next day, Catra forced her sorry behind into town and started trying to break what seemed like an outrageous new fear of other human beings. She quickly learned something more; it wasn’t that there was other people in town, she’d lived in a bustling hive of scum and villainy, but rather it was the people who lived *in* the town that caused her heart to race and palms to sweat. Scared of their judgment, scared that they’d be right to do so, scared that somehow they’d convince Glimmer to cut her loose. So very, very angry at all of them for casting her aside a second time even though it was a fiction in her own mind.

But Catra was tired of being scared and even more tired of being angry, and so into town she marched herself a few times a week. Making herself do some very uncomfortable talking, and an equally uncomfortable kind of listening. Looking to prove her assumptions wrong rather than right. It was tiring but rewarding in its own way she supposed. Even if there were still people she did her damndest to avoid.

Despite the warm reconnection, she nervously both tried to see and avoid Mrs. Moon. Half convinced that their evening chat was some sort of fluke and also unwilling to overstay a welcome. So, from a healthy but still respectable distance, she would greet Mrs. Moon and find a reason to move along quickly. She was practicing after all, not sprinting to be put to the test.

Likewise, Catra saw Adora at the end of the street one day and ducked into the general store just to shake away while pretending to look for clothes. She hoped Adora hadn't seen her and not that the other woman learned some tact. Glimmer's friendship with her had only deepened in Catra's absence, and goodness knows what sort of things had been discussed. Nope, not ready there either.

And sure, she spoke with Bow with some regularity, but had done her level best to avoid his fathers and any siblings who might be stopping in. Her time living with the Archer's had been annoying when she was younger, and now filled her with a warm honey like feeling. She knew they'd be a bit too kind and understanding, Mister George would probably give her one stern talking to and then they'd call it even. She didn't quite like that considering she'd also cut and run on their son.

So, yes, there was plenty of people she probably **needed** to talk to, but couldn't bring herself to face. Between a rare streak of luck and her own raw determination Catra had managed to keep jumping through each hoop of her own making without fail or pause.

In some cruel twist of fate, despite her best efforts she'd still *not* been able to avoid Double Trouble.

"Darling!" They'd cooed at her, pulling her in to kiss both her cheeks as if she didn't lift her fists up thoughtlessly in case she was being jumped, before frowning deeply at her. "Is Deputy Moon not feeding you, or has your sense of fashion deteriorated while you were wherever you were? Doesn't matter, sit! Sit! Tell me everything."

It had been harder than hell to not drink the whiskey in front of her, and her request for a cider had only "deepened the mystery". Whatever that meant. She'd managed to be just surly enough for them to get bored. Ordering her to return when she was in a more personable mood, and promising to either enjoy her wagging tongue or loosen it themself. It was the sort of flirt that was just filthy enough to make her blush and flee as fast as

possible. Double Trouble was one of the most influential people in the whole damn town, between their saloon, hotel, and girls they certainly ensured people and cash flow. God save her soul, she knew there was no escaping that fate forever.

About the only good to come of that initial encounter was the knowledge that unless she wanted to risk similarly awkward and uncontrolled interactions around every damn corner, that she needed to stop being a baby. It had been months by that point, and despite her assertion that she wasn't some skittish horse, well, she certainly was acting like one.

A fact Glimmer was far too smug about even if she didn't say nothing, and that just wouldn't do. She was winning (maybe?) whatever weird obstacle course this was and she wasn't about to lose. Catra had barely begun to try and cook up a scheme to reach out to any of the people she'd been side stepping for far too long when fate took it right out of her damned hands. Had to be fate.

After all, it had to be some kind a miracle when Adora had knocked at the front door with an awkward smile, and then, as if this wasn't the first time they'd spoken in years but also somehow like this was the very first time they'd ever talked ever, Adora even more awkwardly failed to wave properly. Her voice sounded oddly unnatural like she didn't know what tone or pitch to use. "Howdy Miss D'riluth! Uhm, Catra. Miss. Uh, ma'am? …Mrs. Moon wanted me to ask why you ain't at work today!"

The whole situation made no sense, which, honestly? That tracked for her life. "...'cause I don't have a job?"

"She certainly seemed to think you do?" Adora nervously tapped her toes and then her fingers on her belt buckle as they stood just looking at one another. "Mind coming into town anyways to explain it? I'd be much obliged."

So, they left riding in the most uncomfortable silence in Catra's life, even overtaking that time Scorpia hadn't realized her life was

being threatened and instead had happily bounced in her chair while the bastard with the gun turned to look at Catra questioningly. She'd had to help the fucker out and then got front row seats to Scorpia beating his ass down, but it had still been tainted by the disquieting start.

"Soooooooo," Adora started, coughed, looked anywhere but towards Catra as she struggled to come up with a topic, "how's it all...been?"

Of all things, her inability to casually do something as simple as small talk put Catra at ease. Which in turn allowed her to answer truthfully. "I have no god damned idea t'be honest. Better than expected?"

Adora laughed even as she blushed with embarrassment, "Sorry, that was a dumb question, wasn't it?"

She had missed the absolute hell out of Adora Gray, and that made her dumb and too comfortable. All her fear of this encounter was thrown right out the window; a real baby with the bathwater moment.

"Makes sense, seeing as it's coming from you." Yup. Barely said two dozen words and Catra was already insulting the damned sheriff. Had she not promised herself to be nicer? What part of implying Adora was an idiot was nicer?

With a mock gasp and delighted smile Adora weakly kicked at her leg. "Excuse you Miss D'riluth, I'll have you know I am an educated woman of sophisti-CAAAaaH-sheon!"

"Excuse me!?" Catra laughed, unable to let the attack go unanswered, she pulled Melog over to flick Adora's ear. It was their sort of apology and thank you, some kind of acceptance that made her feel a little mushy inside. Still, if the woman wanted to play this game, then Catra was happy to play along. "You're a who in the what now?"

Adora held a hand up, palm towards the sky and fingers touching her thumb. “I am a skull-AR!”

“Yeah? Of what? Being annoying?”

Adora simpered, one hand over her heart and lower lip sticking comically far out, “I would never *dream* of infringing on your craft! You have such a mastery, I’d look a fool.”

It had been like some bizarre coupling of their friendship that first year and something better and stronger. As equally easy as it had been to reconnect with Bow, and just as deep as they talked on the rest of the ride. She didn’t understand but didn’t really care to either, perfectly willing to accept the reprieve from the guilt and discomfort she’d become more accustomed to over the last several years.

She spared perhaps one thought to the finger tingling way Glimmer was bound to smirk over the whole affair and wondered if, perhaps, she was losing because Glimmer was right? It came and went quickly enough as Adora continued to pester her with questions and tales and the occasional faux assault.

They had ended up joking and talking all the way into town, barely getting themselves under control before entering Angella’s office since they insisted on continuing to try and trip one another towards the station where Adora finally lost and stumbled away back towards the jail with a jaunty wave.

Which also served to help Adora escape and abandon her to her fate, like a coward. Had Catra thought they were friends again? She took it back. No she didn’t. She just really, really didn’t want to do this alone.

Catra stared at the familiar old door she walked through nearly every day for 10 years, and then with a slightly shaking hand she turned the doorknob and stepped inside. For a moment she just stood in some kind of awe, letting the memories wash over her,

before finally snapping to the present and going to Mrs. Moon's desk.

Angella had looked up as soon as the door opened, smiling and waiting until Catra actually walked inside to chirp, "There you are, excellent!"

What in the hell? Catra fidgeted a little, shifting her weight back and forth as she mostly mumbled at her former boss's oak desk. "Uh, Mrs. Moon? I don't exactly work here no more."

Angella ducked her head slightly to catch her eyes with a dry look, "Well I certainly didn't fire you, you didn't give me a resignation, and I didn't go looking for a replacement. So unless there is something pressing...?"

There was a horrible rush of embarrassment as the words, " *Well I'm afraid I got stupider so this won't work.* " almost came out of her mouth. Both from the impoliteness and the truth of it. But instead she meekly shook her head, uncomfortably letting herself be herded to work.

Catra slid into her old spot, her favored chair replaced by something far more comfortable and her old dip pen was replaced by a sturdy looking fountain pen. Each time her fingers tapped onto the wooden desktop for her blotter Catra would remember that this new ink seemed to dry faster. And she didn't walk away with black stains all over which was a decided bonus. Thank goodness for the little things because looking at the books made her heart pound a little too hard. She worked slowly, soundlessly muttering numbers and tracing her finger along the desktop when she needed to do her sums. She would be damned if she left with BMR's books looking like a *child* had gotten bored and marked all over them! No, she would not be caught dead with simple mathematics written on what used to be pristine pages. Each line was as neat and clean as she could make it, only having to pause a few times to turn a zero into an eight, or a seven into a four. There was one number she had to strike out and put in

completely from the start, and she glared hard at the ink as if it had personally offended her.

But get it done she did. Not nearly the amount she could've before, but two neat pages of sums were finished by the time the whistle blew for them to leave. It had been hard, a bit humiliating for how challenging it felt, but she still got it done and good lord did that feel nice. Real nice to have something to focus on now that the bedroom had been finished up at the house. She huffed softly as she massaged out her hand; it had certainly beat the pants off of her sitting around feeling useless.

So, despite how horrifically long it took her to make sense of the ever floating and shifting numbers, Catra promised Mrs. Moon she'd be back on time the next day. And Angella seemed pleased as punch to have someone handling it.

Catra hadn't known what to say when Glimmer saw her leaving the station, but the two rode home while chatting easily enough. Like…like it weren't no big thing at all. But it *was* a big deal. She'd gone to work, felt good about her work, spoke with several people, and got to watch the beautiful colors of the sunset paint the woman she loved in spectacular light.

And if felt so damn nice to let it quietly be.

Until it didn't.

Time continued on and suddenly on the horizon was an anniversary neither she nor Glimmer knew what to do about besides staunchly to avoid speaking about it with one another. T'weren't that they didn't communicate about it, Catra felt like she aged decades sometimes in a glance or from the way Glimmer's shoulders would slowly tighten up when the topic was broached. It wasn't a loss of progress, but it *felt* like it. Made worse by the sickly feeling swirling around in her damn gut the closer they got.

She woke up the morning of the anniversary of Shadow Weaver and Micah Moon's death feeling horrifically sick and wanting

nothing more than to hide away the whole day.

But it was Catra's fault there's even an anniversary in the first place, so instead she got up and got dressed. It took a little more time than usual, but there was still plenty enough for her to get some oatmeal going. Not enough to stay until it was soft enough to *eat* , but it wasn't really for her. This way Glimmer would have something gentle if she wanted it. Hopefully she wouldn't be offended by it, Catra could only wince as she realized it could be taken horribly far too late to do anything about it. Oatmeal weren't exactly new or nothing, but the idea of oats being fit for humans certainly was.

"She…she won't think I'm saying she's an animal, will she?" Catra asked Melog, who nipped at shoulder instead of answering, far too unhappy about still being at the house instead of in town. "Oh fuck you and yer routines too."

If she could blame Melog's temper over his day being upended, it was better than acknowledging that he might be upset because of how upset she was. Because that would mean acknowledging that she was upset.

Oh, and aren't you just the eternal victim? Catra gritted her teeth as she rode into town. Weaver's voice always was a little louder when the anniversary of her death rolled around. She firmly reminded herself: No I'm not. I'm going in. I'm not complaining. *And what a lofty goal you set for yourself, but you've always been entitled haven't you?* Catra focused on her breathing, letting Melog nervously trot along a bit faster than usual. The trees blurred into wood buildings and then into brick and stone.

As soon as she could, Catra made a break for Mrs. Moon's house from the main road. It had been Angella's request that she leave Melog at her home, somewhere he could be better taken care of than on any old hitching post and also less prone to getting himself in trouble. Honestly it was probably more for the trouble bit than the rest of it.

Catra almost managed to smile as she got him comfortable for the day while studiously ignoring the way the redbrick home felt like it was looming over her shoulder. The memory of his most memorable troublemaking was sweet indeed. It had been one helluva sight to watch a train come in with Melog proudly standing on the caboose along side a delighted Kyle and exhausted Lonnie. He'd apparently ridden with them to Mystacor and back *twice* before someone noticed him, which was either an amazing feat or a damning condemnation of the BMR workforce.

Considering what it had been like to work with some of them incompetents, Catra was inclined to believe it was a bit of both.

Regardless, she'd been banned from leaving him at the station, and Angella had been far too keen to have him stay at her home a short jaunt over. It never felt right, but today it felt outright *wrong* . She still did it because she'd said she would.

Catra gave Melog one more pat and the last of the dried oats she'd slipped into her pocket before going to the station. Trying to duck head and walk fast, get there and get it over with. She just had to get it over with and it would be fine! *We both know that isn't reality.* It would be, it would be just fine, she just had to get to the station now. That was it. Worry about the rest when she got there.

So, despite the way her hands shook, the lock opened smoothly and Catra quickly began her work day.

Weeks ago Angella had been the one to let Catra know she planned to be out the day of her husband's death, and that Glimmer was going to stay home too. Apparently even when the two had barely been on speaking terms, one or the other would be at the station to keep things orderly on the anniversary. Catra had been desperately trying to not have a breakdown at her desk as she realized what anniversary it was when Angella asked her, "Is there anything you need?" Catra had shook her head, offering to keep it running istead, hoping to stay busy and ignore it. And

that had been the end of that. But the question swirled around again and again as she lit the lamps and got the books ready.

Was there anything she needed?

Yeah, the ability to go back in time. Or a well aimed bullet. "Shut the fuck up." Catra grumbled to herself, too ready to go home when she'd barely gotten in and was exhausted.

Didn't help that last night she'd been too queasy to eat. It had been a tense, awful day between her and Glimmer. Their first time together knowing what Mr. Moon's death really was, and both were well aware of how easily they could tear one another to shreds. Catra had been waking up to hear Glimmer shouting most nights the whole week leading up, and after nearly getting into a fight on the way home from work they agreed to just…not talk about it right now. So dinner came 'round, and Catra pushed her food around a while before giving up and trying to sleep.

Her stomach rumbled and Catra ignored it. Served her right. She was halfway finished deciding to just not eat the whole day when Adora stepped in. The good sheriff smiled around a small beaten paper bag as she lifted two mugs with one hand, using her free one to shut the door.

"Ehy hotyu omin!"

"What are you, five?" It was supposed to be a light hearted joke but instead it dripped acidic from her tongue. *Yeah that seems about right.* She thought at the same time Weaver's voice sneered, *animal* .

Adora rolled her eyes, taking the bag from between her teeth to huff, "Well howdy to you too. You want some damn coffee or not?"

Coffee made her stomach hurt when she had it without food, so she easily reached out for the mug.

Adora, however, only held the mugs up higher. “Well good, but I know you better than you think missy. Eat up.” And with that she tossed the bag to Catra instead, revealing a freshly baked bread roll inside. Her throat felt tight as she looked up rather pitifully at Adora’s softly smiling face. “Come on D’riltuh, eat somethin’ afore Glimmer shoots me for letting your stomach get upset. Also for the coffee. I’m telling you, you best hurry or I will drink two mugs on my own.”

Catra was mortified to feel her eyes sting and nose clog up while she stared down at the roll, barely managing to not cry as Adora slurped loudly enough to wake the dead. So what if a few tears fell while she forced bites down? Weren’t like they counted. She managed to get halfway through it before she just couldn’t take another bite, hunger be damned as a half choked sob finally broke free.

She had good friends, real good friends.

In the Crimson Wastes, Scorpia had helped her up and Entrapta had worked quietly while Catra sat and stared sightlessly at the wall. They pleaded until she played a round of cards with them, and when she retired for the evening, despite the sun still being up, they’d both claimed exhaustion and tried to sleep too. It had been a somber companionship, and she’d resented them for pitying her.

Now, watching as Adora slid a mug of coffee over and then ate the rest of the roll in a single almost sickeningly large bite, Catra was able to look back a scant year ago and feel nothing but grateful. For then and now.

“Whellp,” Adora said, over exaggerating both her accent and her stretch, “I best be getting while the getting’s good. You know where to find me if ya need me.”

“Yeah,” she’d whispered roughly, wiping her eyes and nose with a handkerchief, “I know.”

"Well good." There was a pause before Adora awkwardly punched her shoulder, and then all but marched out as Catra weakly laughed at her.

Thanks to the short break and the caffeine, things picked up for a little while. Only to become oppressive as the silence dragged out. The hours ticked by while she struggled to finish just a half page of basic addition. Hard thing to do when the paper and even her desk looked like rippling water, which was probably not a great sign. She tried to glare down part of the desk drawers only for them to fade out of her vision, then pop back into place while she blinked. Yeah. That was not good.

Well too bad, so sad. Oh boo hoo! Suck it up D'riluth.

"Knock knock!" Bow called even as he opened the door, scaring her soul right outta her ass. "Hey Catra, I didn't sell enough of the elk sausage you liked last time, thought I'd bring it to you in case you couldn't get away for lunch."

Lunch? Catra slowly turned to stare at the clock. Good god, it felt like Adora left both five minutes ago and at least a month ago. And it was well past her regular lunch time. Her stomach gurgled with discomfort.

"Oh." She tried to get her brain out of the molasses it was in, remind him she couldn't do much good with some raw meat at the office, when her nose finally worked and reported back: *cooked elk sausage and biscuits, hot damn.*

Bow set their little indoor picnic up, making sure to give Catra a plate with more meat and buttery biscuits than she knew what to do with alongside some sassafras syrup he expertly mixed with water from his skin. He winked when he pulled the two glasses out to make their sodas, "Pre-boiled and everything!"

It was sweet. It was too much. Didn't they have better things to do? Better people to comfort?

“Y’all don’t have to do this.” She said, staring at the food and feeling her stomach twist itself up in knots.

“No, we don’t.” Bow nodded, nudging her arm until she drank a little something to settle herself back down. “But we wanna.”

She didn’t rightly know what to say to that.

Bow chattered incessantly but without any sort of expectation, and it was nice just to hear someone’s voice even if he did stop on occasion to remind her to eat something. In the end she finished less then half a single sausage and two bites of the biscuit.

“You want me to stay or you want me to go? My obligations are done today, so it isn’t a problem either way.” Bow grinned at her, waiting patiently until she looked up at the door. “You got it partner, let me wrap this all up for you first.”

He checked in on her twice more before finally leaving Catra to her half page of nonsensical markings. It had still been a nice reprieve, but it was one she couldn’t bounce back from like the intervention this morning. Instead she miserably sat sniffling on and off, feeling too much and then nothing at all. Starting to write only to forget half way through, Catra left a veritable star scape across the page of expanding black dots. Squinting more and more as she tried to get her pounding headache to let up an inch.

The sun had long gone down and lamps practically burned out before she realized the headache was probably a lot of damn straining to read in the darkness.

And even then, she only noticed because Lonnie opened the door before halfheartedly glaring at her. “You know, when I check that the doors are locked and folks are home safe I do expect the doors to be locked and folks to be home safe.”

Catra abandoned her station exactly as it was, barely remembering to grab the wax paper wrapped leftovers as she stumbled out the door. “My apologies.”

Lonnie sighed, “Don’t be sorry, just…go home D’riluth. You look like hell.”

With one very pointed look, Lonnie locked the door and Catra scuttled away down the dark streets to collect Melog. Good god, what time was it? The moon was high in the sky as she picked her way through the gloomy dirt roads. She just- she just wanted to get to Melog, go home, and sleep for a few years. Was that so much to ask? Then she remembered that’s where Glimmer would be and changed her mind. She’d get Melog and go sleep in the hay with him. It would be like old times. Her miserable and him nibbling her hair in a deranged attempt to cheer her up. Yup. That was the plan. Helluva a plan!

Woulda been a great plan if it were for that fact that Glimmer found her halfway to her mother’s house instead. They just stared at one another in the gloomy half light of the moon for a long moment, before Glimmer grabbed her hand and pulled her along. Her voice was hard as she all but growled, “We were getting worried!”

“What?” Catra asked, trying to get her head on straight. “I thought you was at home-”

“I was!” Glimmer snapped, then sighed, “Sorry. I just- we’ve been waiting up for you and I was just worried. So, yes, I was at home but it was too quiet. ‘Sides, we got traditions ‘round here.”

Catra made it in the front door, blinking away the too bright feeling lamp light as Glimmer ushered her along. “Glim, you ain’t got to worry about me today.”

They paused outside the sitting room as Glimmer looked her over critically. Her jaw worked before she sighed, almost sagging a little as she half whispered, “We gotta worry about one another sometimes.”

When she gently tugged at Catra’s hand, she managed to keep her mouth shut.

“Oh thank goodness!” Angella stood quickly from her seat, rushing over with glassy eyes as she fretted, “Are you alright? Is she alright? Where in the world have you been, it’s very late young lady!”

Where Glimmer seemed more distant than usual, Mrs. Moon looked fit to fly right out a window with all her nerves.

“Uh,” Catra looked between the two, “I was at the office. Just lost track a time, s’all.”

“Well that does it then- that does it! Next year, we just close the damn office!” Angella declared, “Which I can say as the owner and your boss. This day has just been one thing after another, I’ll tell you what! And there’s no need for us to add anything more to it! …Catra dear, why aren’t you sitting, you look fit to faint. Doesn’t she look fit to faint, Glimmer? Oh dear, I’m being a horrible host! Sit, sit!”

Catra basically collapsed onto the couch, accidentally dragging Glimmer down by their still linked hands. Glimmer didn’t look at her as she finally let go and stage whispered, “Best to just let her fret a little.”

“You hush!” Angella shot a dirty look at her daughter before she finished pouring- pouring? It was the rum bottle again, dangerously close to being out too.

Catra swallowed hard looking at her little shot glass full of sickly sweet smelling liquid, but a desperate glance at Glimmer solved nothing as she wouldn’t look back.

“Here we are, here we are, we have some traditions that we- Catra what in the world are you holding? Dear, put that down. Oh goodness, listen to me! Just rambling away,” Angella laughed almost frantically as she ripped the wax paper out of Catra’s had to throw onto a table before lifting her glass of run up high, “Here’s for Micah, and all those still on god’s green earth.”

And then Angella Moon slammed it back like the most practiced of bar flies. Glimmer sipped more sedately at hers, trying to drag it out a bit. Catra quickly threw hers back just to keep from spilling it with how bad she was trembling. The burn was nice even if she regretted it the second it reached her stomach. She just hoped the alcohol would do something for her quickly, otherwise she might do something foolish.

But this whole thing was foolish already! Here she was toasting to the man she'd murdered with his fucking wife and child, while drinking his liquor, inside his house! What the fuck was she doing here? She shouldn't be here. She should've refused to come along! She should just- just run. Just run, grab Melog and run. And then- and then, then she'd- what- what- she'd-

The slap was completely unexpected but certainly worked wonders.

"GLIMMAH!"

"What!? She weren't responding!"

Catra blinked owlishly, one hand cupping her cheek absently and finally noticed the tears on her own face.

"That's no reason to resort to *violence* !"

"It- well it worked and that's the damned point!"

" *Glimmer Moon* !"

"Mother!"

Catra chuckled weakly, somehow causing them both to clap their traps. Her whole breakdown not so much averted and transfigured into something broken but manageable. With all eyes on her, Catra managed to muster a soft, "Guess I *was* faint, wasn't I?"

"Yes! Thank you," Angella glared at her daughter again, "See, faint! Didn't I tell you she looked faint? I knew it. I knew it! This

day is just- just- oh!" And then she snarled, the same way Glimmer did when she was real mad but was being real cute too. "I need another drink. I'm getting another drink. Do you two want another drink? Let me just grab another-" And out the door she walked, taking long strides to vanish towards the kitchen.

Leaving them alone with the ticking grandfather clock.

Glimmer worked her jaw a few times before asking as kindly as she could, "Do you even want to be here? I didn't even ask."

She hadn't. Not when Glimmer dragged her inside, and if she'd known before they got here what was going to happen she would've declined and fled for the woods.

But the idea of being there. Alone in the quiet…no. No, that wouldn't be good a'tall. God damn she was so fucking stupid sometimes. *Oh I'll just go home and sleep in the hay, that'll fix all my problems!* Idiotic is what that plan was. This was better. Not good, but better. Maybe even for the best. She had been avoiding Angella since her last big breakdown. For all Catra hadn't wanted to be here she was pathetically grateful for it.

"Only if'n it's alright with you."

If looks could kill she'd have been dead on the spot. "We ain't talking about me right now. Do **you** want to be here?"

Catra nodded and Glimmer softened a bit again. Oh, she hadn't even noticed the way Glimmer had tensed up and pulled away so their legs weren't touching, until the warmth of her hip and thigh was back against her own. Her brain listlessly tried to come up with something to say and was interrupted by Mrs. Moon's return.

"-and that's why I mean it! I'm telling both of you right now that I won't have it!" Angella stormed back in and practically slammed a few bottles down before roughly pouring them all at least three shots worth of amber liquid a piece.

Catra felt equally excited and horrified by the amounts, barely managing to call out, “Ma’am, all due respect, there are easier ways to kill me!”

Glimmer snorted and then started to howl with laughter as Mrs. Moon stared at her bewildered before looking at their glasses again. “Pardon?”

Blushing horribly, Catra elbowed Glimmer in an attempt to rein her in but all it got was another snort as she started to cry from laughing too hard.

“Mrs. Moon,” Catra sighed heavily, scrubbing away at the half-dried tear tracks on her face as she struggled to find a polite way to decline. Land sake, she shouldn’t have even had the first one. “That is a *very* generous pour.”

“Oh!” And then to her amazement and horror, Angella Moon simply lifted one of the glasses and in two large gulps had emptied it. She filled it less than half of what it had been, before all but shoving it in Catra’s hands. “There. You should have said something sooner, I am not trying to pressure you! You don’t feel pressured do you? Oh no, are you- have I pressured you into this!?”

“No!” Catra lied.

“I’m pressuring you! Oh goodness, darling, please say something next time, this is the last day you should be feeling that way. I am being so horrible to you! I know, tea! Tea can fix anything!” Angella looked up with somewhat wild eyes before first ripping Catra’s glass away, dumping it into her own, and then slamming it all down and racing out again, her voice barely floating back, “Strawberry tea it is! Tea will fix this!”

“...what in the goddamned hells is happening?” Catra asked her empty hands as Glimmer weakly slapped the side of the couch, still caught in the throws of her laughing. She couldn’t help but snicker a little bit and asked, “How many deep are you, then?”

Glimmer shook her head wildly, covering her face before Catra realized she wasn't actually still laughing but instead crying. It was pure instinct to turn, pulling one leg up until her boot was on the upholstery, letting her pull Glimmer over to cry in her arms. She tipped over willingly, burying her face to sob away into Catra's shirt. She rocked them both back and forth until Angella came back.

"-yes, a grand cuppa, we should do this more often- have tea I mean! It's good for the…soul." She delicately put the tray with three thin little cups covered in swirling gold patterns and a teapot covered in roses down. Moving to swiftly kneel on the floor to rub at Glimmer's back. "That's it love."

Traitorous tears leaked out, only getting worse when Angella wrapped an arm around Catra's back. "There we are, we're all right darlings. We are all right."

It took far too long for her to calm down, still panting a little from her silent fight against her exhaustion and tears as Angella helped her stumble to her feet. When Glimmer still wouldn't move, Catra grit her teeth and picked her up, mindlessly going towards Glimmer's old bedroom. It was a bit of a blur as she got Glimmer seated on the bed, the small jug of water seeming to magically pop into existence along with a rag for them to clean up with.

Catra wasn't sure she'd ever been this wrung out in her life. It was a different kind of exhaustion and sadness, not as hollow as she'd been those few years back but somehow just floating over what she could tell would've been an impressive meltdown. Each choice took effort to conceive and make, but with Glimmer in her arms it was very much worth the effort.

"Hey," Catra cleared her throat as her voice cracked, "is it okay if I wash your face?" It took a while before Glimmer nodded, whining a little as Catra leaned back. "Shh, hush now darlin', I'm not goin' nowhere. No way, no how." She blindly dipped the rag, squeezing it out one handed, steadying her with a hand on her jaw before she started to gently wipe away the tear tracks. Glimmer flinched

at the cold before miserably leaning into Catra's hands. "There you go. There we go. Don't that feel better?" Glimmer sniffled but nodded, and Catra's heart nearly burst right out her ribs.

She wanted so badly, so damn badly to say, *"I love you. I love you, I love you, I'm right here, I love you."*

Instead she whispered, "Good, I'm glad. Almost done princess, then you can get some sleep a'ight?" But Glimmer shook her head. "No?"

"You too," Glimmer mumbled, "Gimme."

"You ain't gotta-"

"Stop that."

Catra let her arms drop, freezing as Glimmer softly cupped her cheek with one hand and the other began to wipe away. And then she melted. Eyes fluttering closed as Glimmer worked, speaking so softly as she went. "There now, see? I got you too. That's what we do 'round these parts." She huffed a half laugh that earned Glimmer's exhausted giggles. "Well it's true missy. Besides, least I can do after roping you into this."

Catra winced. "Rather think it's the other way around, ain't it?"

Glimmer's voice was soft, "I asked mother to wait for you. For tonight."

It took her a moment to realize that the rag had stopped a while back and that Glimmer was just holding her face. Catra gasped a bit as her eyes fluttered open, too tired, too hopeful, too horrifically sad to do much more.

Glimmer swiped her thumbs gently once more before scooting back a bit, uncaring of her boots or clothes getting the sheets dirty. "Bed."

"Oh," she didn't want to go yet, but it was more than fair.

She barely stood up when Glimmer grabbed her hand and shook her head.

“Just…come to bed? I don’t want to be alone right now.”

Catra paused as her whole body ached, and her heart yearned. She was pathetically grateful for how dark she knew the shadows were over her, it was the only thing saving her from Glimmer knowing the whole damned truth of it. “I…I don’t…”

“Catra, please.”

It was the way Glimmer’s voice broke, the gleam of tears in her eyes that made Catra move before she’d even realized what she was doing. She pulled Glimmer into her, tilting her head back as Glimmer burrowed into her neck.

She wasn’t powerless to stop it, but she weren’t no fool either. “Okay.”

Chapter End Notes

> Glimmer finally let me live for this chapter which is hilarious considering how little she's in it overall. She was very clear that the cost is snuggles and smooches so we should finally be getting back to that!
>
> (Also, hurray, I didn't take a whole year between updates, only 2/3rds of a year! :D)

Chapter 22: And so it goes

Chapter Summary

> After the anniversary of her daddy's death, Glimmer has a few revelations that are really only surprising to her and finally gets the gumption to do something about it.

Chapter Notes

> Why did I think I could out stubborn Glimmer? You'd think I'd've learned by now, but you would be very wrong about that :)

Glimmer dreamed of the flowing sands of time. Effective as any dribbling spring, which patiently cut away at the rocks that once blocked its path. The sand and water carved without pressure until it bubbled forth in spraying bursts; a right frightful geyser of time that was too beautiful to look away from even if the heat was unbearable. And then Catra was there, smiling that little boyish grin, and all calmed in her presence. Like mother nature made flesh, the danger passed, the damages done, and where she walked grass and creeping vines grew. Loathe to make her walk alone, Glimmer had jogged up to walk with her linked elbow to elbow, and smiled as the vines grew over her stone skin and softening her too.

They walked and walked until the sun set, the black outline of mountains rising to kiss the watery yellow stripe across the sky. Fading to a brilliant red and then purple and then black as they watched. They scattered as sand on the ground.

When she woke the morning after her daddy’s anniversary, she could not help but think it would not hurt to be sand.

She smiled muzzily to herself, her thoughts a constant lapping of waves. A soothing buzz of nothing followed by a wakeful crash, feelings and thoughts and memories overlapping one another

without competing before she'd slip nearly under once more. Peaceful. A slow and syrupy moment in time, where the soft early morning's light could barely be seen. Downstairs she could hear the faint sounds of Miss Baker and Mister Pop working in the kitchen, the soft clatter of hooves and feet on the street below creating a gentle buzzing noise. And when her eyes focused, she couldn't help but smile.

Catra was warm in her arms, soft and relaxed as she gently slept. Her wild hair seemed to invade everything except for her mouth which hung open slightly. Her nose scrunched up as if she would sneeze before her whole body began to twitch a little until she startled herself awake. God it was cute.

"Mornin'," Glimmer whispered, making sure to stay alert in case she scared the other woman into sleep fighting. She was good to avoid a punch first thing in the morning.

But instead, Catra barely opened her bleary eyes before closing them and snuggling closer with a grumble. "Mmm."

She snickered softly to herself and petted down Catra's arm. "That's all you got to say to me on this *fine* and *beautiful* morning?"

"Mmm." And there was the sleepy grin she loved.

"Mmm." Glimmer echoed.

"Mmm-hmm!" Catra nodded before stiffening up just a little, enough for her to know the day before was coming back.

Glimmer kept herself relaxed. "Don't do that, too early for that."

There was a pause and then Catra sunk once more into the bed, curling herself up into a ball. It didn't look comfortable at all in her opinion, but Catra's next grunt was more a purr than anything else so she supposed it must suit her needs at least. "Mmmmhmm."

“There we go sugar.” She easily shifted until she was semi curled around her.

Their breaths slowed again, the world grew brighter and louder but it felt so far away compared to the almost forgotten sensation of holding another so close. Glimmer drifted easily back to sleep that morning without dreams.

As she all but inhaled her breakfast of stewed prunes, bacon, eggs, and hoe cakes under the very amused gaze of her mother she couldn’t help but appreciate the food more. Nothing fancy or special, and considering the good home cooking she’d gotten to have with Catra living with her, Glimmer was able to understand her view on the matter much better now that she had a reminder of what hunger could taste like having been too upset to eat the day before.

“Miss, once you ain’t had nothing but pemmican and sailor’s biscuits for a month straight, you can judge me. Until that glorious day, you can say ‘thank you Catra for making me this delicious meal’ and button your damn lip.”

It was still a delight to tuck into foods they didn’t always get at the cabin, and better yet her mother was there to sit in a comfortable silence so she weren’t alone. The only sign of Catra had been the crumpled waistcoat Glimmer woke up clinging to like a beloved blanket, but that was alright too.

“Besides waking ravenous as a pack of wolves, how are you feeling?” Angella had eventually asked when the two sat sipping their teas.

Glimmer blushed, even opened her mouth to argue when she burped instead. After that she nodded as seriously and haughty as possible, “I’m not sure I know what you mean, my table manners were impeccable.”

Her mother never sneered but it was a near miss this time. “Quite. Regardless, neither I nor Catra put on such a display.”

All she could picture was her mother selecting a specific small fork to dine with while Catra literally brought her plate to her mouth to shovel the dregs of her meal down with her fingers. She couldn't help but snort a little. "Wait, wait, wait! Catra, not inhaling her food? My Catra? I think you may be confused, mother, that woman licks her plates clean."

"...perhaps I am. I suppose you would know **your** Catra better. Speaking of, she seemed much better this morning."

"I'm glad to hear that, but please, she's not my anything."

"You just called her 'my Catra', so I beg to differ."

No! She hadn't! Had she? "I don't remember that."

"It was just a minute ago!"

Well perhaps she did remember a smidge, but she was a rock. Or something along those lines? Wait, no, sand? Her dreams had been pleasant but were much faded by now. "So says you, the law is on my side."

Angella chuckled, tilting her head meaningfully as she asked, "Oh? Pray tell, which judge will you petition? I believe Cornelius will be doing his circuit in two months, but Flutterina might be more sympathetic if you could wait for eight."

Glimmer did her best not to grimace at the mention of the honorable judge Flutterina, who seemed to be two different people depending on if her robes were on or not. Adora might've fared well with the young woman but Glimmer preferred to not endure the whiplash thank you very much. "And risk it being thrown out? I think not. We'll address it to his honor when he arrives. Until then, can you tell me how Catra was doing? Honestly?"

Her mother leaned back slightly delicately placing her tea cup down, "As well as any of us can be right now. A lot more rested

than I expected her to be, and more pliant. She actually stayed and ate breakfast when I told her to before rushing to the office."

"I don't think she knows the meaning of that word let alone actually being pliant, but she has always been a bit more afraid of you than me I suppose."

It was like a lightning strike, her mother sat upright, her eyes wide and mouth open unbecomingly as she sputtered, "Afra- no! She's not afraid of me! I am not- I will have you know, I am **very** approachable!"

"Mother, I love you dearly," Glimmer started, while doing her best to not laugh outright, "but you are very tall, very confident, and have the commanding air of a queen. You also ain't a smiler first thing in the morning. Lotsa folks are intimidated by you, and poor Catra musta been spooked something fierce."

"Intimidated!?! No, no, no, that can't be right. I'm- if *anyone* is intimidating it was Catra when she first got here." Oh it wasn't often she got to see her mother in a full huff but it was as enjoyable as ever. "What with all the fist fighting when she first joined us, I was scared to death when I called her to the office to talk about her future with us. I thought she'd pull a knife or a gun on me. **I'm** intimidating? I think not!"

"You are looming over me and raising your voice, folks find that intimidating!"

"I am not!" Angella deflated into her seat. "I don't want her terrified to see me. Is that why she doesn't come around as often anymore?"

Oh dear. Glimmer wasn't even prepared or qualified to explain her own odd situation with the woman, the idea of trying to help either of them get talking was daunting.

"You'd have to ask her, I'm afraid."

With her meal finished Glimmer had spent the day mostly with Bow at the butcher shop seeing as Adora had literally locked the door to the office as she'd approached with a stern warning to take the day easy through the door. While she didn't work a knife, Glimmer was willing to sit and talk with him, chattering on without much thought once he was assured she was feeling better today. It had been another nice and hazy sort of slip in time, leading her to eventually sit down in an old worn rocking chair on the back porch. When she awoke in the late afternoon he had the grace to not tease her too mercilessly for it.

At six in the evening she waited at the station on Bright Wing, who was handling Melog's particular brand of sass rather well all things considered, and she smiled when Catra stepped out of the office with a tired small grin. It was a tense ride home, but not a bad ride for it.

Good lord above, but the time's were changing.

Riding in and out of town was all at once old and new, their bantering no less enjoyable but far less sharp as they made the trip.

The questions and prodding of the town was finally coming to rest and settle some, and all but Double Trouble themself seemed to let go of their questions. And goodness knew no one expected any different from them.

Work was good, but for the first time since Catra left Glimmer felt that home was better.

It was a new holding pattern for her and Catra together, one that was feeling much more tender and much less brittle as the months flew by.

Before either knew it winter had come again marking a full year since Catra came back and Glimmer could only be grateful that Catra had begun to practice her reading further by reading old

papers aloud at breakfast. Well, at least with some hindsight anyway.

"Mister E. Merriam reports winter storms across western and south western reaches of the nation. Huh, maybe we should stock up in case then. This is already yellow news, so maybe we can get something this week." Catra mused as she sipped at her coffee.

But Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Mark my words that man doesn't know his ass from his elbow on the matter. Weather forecasts! Might as well look into a crystal ball."

"I dunno, Glim. 'Trapta had a lot to say about it, some sorta doodad seems to measure just about everything these days. Give it another few years an' it'll pick up further."

"And to think you don't like magicians."

Catra had laughed at that. "Miss, there is a world a difference between some bull shitting poppycock struttin' around claiming magic powers and technology! Jus' cause **you** don't understand it don't make it mystical."

"At least a good magician is entertaining with the disappearing and reappearing, it provides a value is all!" There was a long pause as Catra's brows raised higher and higher while she bit her lip harder and harder and Glimmer huffed, "Oh, just get it outta yer system a'fore you hurt something."

"M-miss," Catra cleared her throat but couldn't stop her giggles as she spoke, "I know you thoroughly enjoy when I make things appear and disappear with you but-"

"EXCUSE ME!!" Glimmer blushed horribly as Catra cackled away at the table. "This is- you are- excuse ME!?"

"J-just takes some back strength and- and- HA!"

Glimmer had ripped the paper from her hands to hit her over the head with it but Catra refused to apologize for an objectively true

fact and Glimmer wanted to pretend the whole subject had just never come up at all. Not because she didn't want to think about sex with Catra, but instead quite the opposite problem.

"Fine! We'll go get supplies for your damn storm, now shut up and eat your damned food!"

"You kiss your mother with that mouth o'yours?" Catra held her hands up in defeat at whatever she saw in Glimmer's unhinged glare. "Apologies madam, my mistake!"

Provisions acquired, it took another two weeks before the snow started and Catra was insufferable about it. She was insufferable about that damn winter blow up right up until the next morning when they woke up snowed into the house.

They'd jumped from the second story window with some pans for a long and grueling day clearing the snow away from the window facing the barn and then the barn door itself. Melog and Bright Wing had simply stared placidly at them as they huffed and puffed and sweated away in the cold from their efforts, mostly grateful for them busting the ice that had formed on their water trough. The next day had been more of the same with a shovel helping make the effort easier.

The snowfall had lightened and eventually stopped, but the sun wasn't hot enough to melt the deepest drifts and they gave themselves up to making the best of a bad situation.

And Glimmer was not complaining, oh no. There was something undeniably captivating to her about the way Catra looked during these strange snowy days. Glimmer had always been smitten with her good looks, but she was being proven right about how damned handsome she looked with facial hair. It ain't too long, Catra herself carefully cut it down as soon as it was long enough to hack at, and sure as sugar, it was as patchy and scraggly a little thing as promised all those years ago. Thicker sideburns with gray in them, little bits here and there on the cheeks, a decent showing

on the right side of her jaw and while it wasn't growing thick, she did have a nice even grouping on her upper lip.

"Miss, you are developing a staring problem." Catra huffed one morning as she trimmed off a bit under her chin. "Just a'cause a train is crashing off the rails don't mean you gotta watch it!"

"Well I see one of us needs to make the effort to appreciate your beauty, so I suppose I'll bear that burden for us both." Glimmer was beyond pleased when Catra jerked, head whipping to the side to stare at her with a wide eyed blush. She was less pleased that Catra cut herself during the maneuver.

They agreed to not chat overly much while she was trimming after that.

But her staring problem only seemed to get worse.

It was the first day of hard winds that saw them scrambling just to keep a walkway open to the barn that Catra stumbled into the house after her. Both of them shivering and stomping snow off everything they could.

"Hell's bells." Catra had hissed causing Glimmer to turn and look at her more closely. "Do you see this Glim? This is awful!"

Her beard was short but she'd developed icicles in it regardless. Small little streaks of white at the tip of her chin and edge of her jaw with a couple of large chunks of clear ice hanging on next to her ear.

"Uhhh," Glimmer said intelligently and with great poise, "wow. Huh. Guess I like you homemaker *or* homesteader."

Catra had blushed horribly at that, stomping to the stove to warm up. "Miss, you cannot just go around saying things like that!"

Her stomach and heart were flipping and flapping and singing away as she elbowed her way into the ring of heat. That had not been a no, that had seemed like she enjoyed the flirting, and that

had, well now, that was interesting indeed. Mighty interesting. For no reason, really. “Well, why not?”

“It’s- because- I- it’s sinful, that’s what!” Catra paused for a moment before bursting into laughter. “Hang on, hang on! Give me a minute to warm up and I’ll have a damn good reason for you!”

“I think you just don’t know how to take a compliment,” Glimmer chuckled a little, too enamored with feeling returning to her fingers to care.

But Catra just smirked as if she’d stumbled right into her trap. “Well now, I can take a compliment, it’s the pretty girl giving it that ties me up in knots you see.”

Glimmer may, or may not, have squeaked at that. “Oh? You think I’m pretty?”

“Yup.” They stood pressed side to side in front of that fire where Catra affirmed without any hesitation, “Prettier and prettier everyday.”

“Oh heavens to Betsy.” Glimmer hoarsely whispered to herself but it set Catra off and that only set her off as well.

As their laughter died down, Glimmer couldn’t help but swallow heavily. They were so close. The tip of their noses practically brushed as she became aware of Catra’s warm breath puffing softly against her face. *I could kiss her. I want to kiss her.* It would be easy to tilt her head and just go for it, it was the afterwards that would be a mite complicated. *So what? I want to kiss her!*

And maybe they would have kissed, given a proper chance. Instead, Melog whinnied with fear as he slipped face first into the snow and began to thrash about. They were all lucky he didn’t sprain or break nothing, but she still made sure to corner him later and hissed, “That was my shot, you bastard!”

Sure, she knew he was a horse, but there was always a chance that Melog really could understand them and she wanted to ensure he understood what he'd just done.

Melog, for his part, nosed at her pockets in case she had a treat for him, having learned nothing of the sort.

"Can you focus for just a minute sir?" Glimmer sighed gently, patting his forehead to get his attention back. "Sir, please. I almost kissed her again. …oh good lord I almost kissed her again. Melog, I think- oh goodness."

She had not been prepared for such a revelation and was unsure what to do with it from there. So instead she gave Melog the dried apple rings she had brought for him and only had to swat his nose twice to prevent him from stealing Bright Wing's good horse treats.

Of course, with nothing more to do but wait for the sun to, as Catra put it so polite and kindly, "Do it's fucking damned JOB-piece of shit!" it left them cooped up together and Glimmer could feel the tension rising as cabin fever set in.

Glimmer was trapped in a sliver of immaterial hell mostly of her own making.

She glared out the small slice of the window that was fully clear of snow and begged the sun to penetrate the thick pine and pinon so that one or both of them could catch a damn break. Things weren't awful by any means. No, in fact, it put into stark contrast how horrible things had once been between them! They talked and cooled, and gave space and gave notice, and today was just one day where Glimmer knew she was in a mood.

See, sometimes she was struck by the feeling that she should be feeling angry or anxious, like a strange mirage of emotions she wasn't actually feeling. Glimmer caught herself looking for lies in Catra words, sometimes staying up late or waking early to try and catch her out somehow. She hadn't even noticed the new turn of

events until she'd snuck downstairs a week ago to see how much liquor was left, as if Catra was hiding a secret drunkenness by magic. The thought had shaken her up and now she was becoming hyper aware of these odd moods. The woman had done nothing to earn such mistrust, and Glimmer miserably didn't know why she was behaving so poorly.

"Am I a bad person?" She whispered to herself and frowned at the table, shaking her hands lightly as she grumped back (again, *at herself* , this had to be cabin fever!), "No no no! None of that, you know it's silly. Besides ain't like she isn't being strange either!"

And that was true. If Glimmer was being paranoid and frightful, well, so was Catra.

She'd caught her a few times clenching her hands on her belt like she was stopping herself from swinging a punch. More common was that *stupid little smile* . The one full of bitterness and anger, transforming Catra wholesale for just a split second before she'd grind her teeth and stomp off to whatever self imposed task she deemed fit. Her cold shoulder and sharp words never lasted long, usually followed with a tired sort of sheepishness showing she didn't mean it. But the cutting words and hard glares and general jumpiness wasn't any more pleasant to manage because of it.

Things weren't *mean* between them by any stretch of the imagination. But the enforced contact was certainly, well, enforcing the long term contact.

"Yeah," Catra chuckled grimly from **far closer** than Glimmer had expected, "it's one of them mornings for sure."

Glimmer turned and winced which only made Catra snicker more.

"You look- uh-" there was no polite way to say it and Glimmer was now very aware how she'd happily leapt headfirst into a lose-lose scenario with the woman she wanted to win.

Glimmer knew she didn't look like a damn posey herself, but Catra looked like she hadn't slept in days despite having slept a decent

amount more recently than she probably ever had. Her hair was oily and sticking a bit together, her beard had gotten long enough that the hair on her jaw was sticking out at what should have been comical angles. She looked thin and wane and ready to collapse if not for how steady she was on her feet.

"Hain't gotta say it, I think I looked better after being tossed off the damn train." Catra grimaced before quickly scuttling towards the pot for her bowl of plain oats.

And there it was. That feeling that she should be feeling something much worse. It had been a dig against her, mentioning the train that is. But Glimmer could also tell Catra hadn't meant to make it. Her hysterical giggle was a bit more of a wheeze as she half collapsed on the table and pulled her blanket closer around her shoulders.

"You alright?" Catra asked and Glimmer had to fight the insane double urge to, somehow, cackle and scream.

"...no. Not really. Are you?"

She turned her head just enough to watch Catra staring into her bowl like a man about to go to the gallows. "Mmmm, not in so many words. No."

"Did-" Glimmer cleared her throat and made sure to not be judgemental by assuming the worst, "Since the horses are taken care of, wanna huddle up down here?"

The cold had eaten up a large chunk of their firewood and they'd agreed to hang a few sheets up and block off the upstairs as best they could. Downstairs was more insulated with the snow on the windows and walls, and by staying in the single room it gave them a bit more wiggle room on the stove use.

"Still gotta shovel a bit on the west side."

Deep, slow breaths. Don't be angry over nothing. Wait, okay, you can feel angry but don't direct it? But don't bottle it up? But don't

explode? Fiddlesticks.

Glimmer pointed out, “It’ll be there tomorrow and if it ain’t then we saved the effort.”

But Catra just didn’t like to give herself an easy way out did she? No, everything had to be a little joke just in case.

“Miss if you want me to touch you all you gotta say is-”

Glimmer sat upright and turned just enough to face her full on. “Catra, I want you to hold me on the damn settee under some blankets. It’s cold, we’re going stir crazy, and you give great hugs. That clear enough for you, little lady?”

Catra stared at her long enough that her spoonful of oatmeal slowly emptied back out into the bowl. “Uhhhhh.”

That darn not feeling!

“I’m tired of feeling mad at you when I ain’t mad at you, so please do me a favor when you’re done eating and hold me damn it!”

Was it bossy and desperate and too forward of her? Yes. Yes it was. But the little miracles just kept piling.

Catra sighed but there was no malice or disappointment, just softness. “I knew you were mad at me.”

“I’m not really.” She felt an undying need to defend herself washed over by a desire to clarify. “I’m being paranoid an’ I don’t like it.”

“Me too.” Catra began to eat in earnest, only speaking again when Glimmer huffed at her. “Look- I- no. Let’s hash this while you get cuddled.”

Despite being the one to demand it, Glimmer blushed horribly at that. “Like you aren’t gonna get cuddled too.” With a little side

eye, she managed to snap her trap and wait as patiently as she could until Catra finished eating.

They both collapsed onto the abused springs covered in blankets and wearing at least two layers each as Catra scooted upright just enough to hold Glimmer against her chest. It was beyond nice. God be good, she could sleep here for the rest of her life and it would be well spent!

"Want me to start?" Catra eventually asked, and at her timid nod, continued, "I know you been checking up on me, seeing what I'm doing, making sure I'm where I said I'd be when I said I'd be. I *know* you been checking your drink too, I know what the scratch marks are for Glim, I ain't stupid. And it…I got real mad for a while about it, but then I started thinking maybe now you spent some time with me…maybe you realized you don't want me around no more. Looking for excuses to tell me to leave as soon as possible. 'Bout a week ago I climbed up one of the drifts to walk into town, figured I'd go before you could make me." Glimmer locked up, her heart squeezed. She couldn't breathe as she imagined realizing Catra ran. "I didn't make it more than five minutes slog before realizing I was being fucking stupid and came back. I told you I was done running. I am."

They lay there for a short eternity as Glimmer calmed herself back down. "I keep feeling like I'm missing something, like you're hiding something even though I know you aren't. I'm not checking up cause I don't trust you, I'm checking up cause I need to prove to myself it's foolish. I keep getting mad when I'm not and I hate it. I don't want to take it out on you but it's hard to figure out what to do when I get up in arms over nothing."

"Okay."

"But…?"

"I don't like that, but okay. I get it, it's not like you control- ha!" Catra stared at the ceiling wide eyed as she laughed again. "Those old bastards!"

“Excuse me!?”

“Them damn Archers! George all but hauled my ass back in September-”

“EXCUSE ME!?”

“- it’s fine, don’t worry about it, but that’s one of the things he was telling me and I thought it sounded like one of them fickle feelings things that I was hoping was true but also loathing the idea of it being true and here I fucking am. I hate those two.” Catra sighed wistfully.

Glimmer knew better, “No you don’t.”

“Yes I do! Sticking their noses in my business all the time, being all,” Catra fake gagged, “friendly like!”

“Hush yourself! And finish your story a’fore I lose my mind!”

She couldn’t even properly fake her petulance but at least picked her story back up, “I thought George was gonna threaten me somewhere quite or something, but instead it was this real insidiot-” (Glimmer bit her lip hard to not laugh or kiss her right then over the mispronunciation) “- thing about talking with you and being honest with myself and god. Asshole said something like you don’t control the feelings you get, you have to deal with them though. Hate that he was right.”

It wasn’t nearly as funny as she’d hoped. Just another pebble that life was insisting on chucking at her head. “I’ve been trying.”

Catra held her tighter, mumbling, “I know. Me too.”

“I know. …thank you.” Glimmer tilted her head just enough to kiss the corner of her jaw and scrunched her nose up. She’d kissed Bow on the cheek before, and her daddy back in the day. She knew facial hair was not normally all that soft when it was short, but Catra’s wiry curls were still a bit sharper than expected.

Catra slowly tucked her chin in to look down at her, like a lost little foal. It was the most darling she'd ever looked in probably her whole damn life. And then, cautious as can be, leaned down just enough to kiss her forehead.

Glimmer could feel the tears in her eyes on that one. Whoo boy. She shuffled up, grunting a little to get a better angle and once evenly face to face, she decided to tempt fate twice and leaned down to kiss her properly. Catra froze for only a moment, Glimmer pulled away feeling foolish right up until she watched her melt into the cushions with a dopey little smile.

"That's how you looked the first time we kissed, you know?" Glimmer grinned as Catra's eyes snapped back to hers. "I like it when you smile like that."

The smile only got a little brighter as Catra half taunted and half requested, "Well now, good thing you know how to get it out of me then."

So they kissed again, and again, and again.

Chapter 23: Never give up

Chapter Summary

> Having survived their winter snow in, having kissed, having given themselves the time- they're finally ready to move on.

Chapter Notes

> So, been a helluva year and a half. Started a master's degree program, had top surgery, bought my first house, lost my cat Ginger to cancer, dad had a heart aneurysm that they luckily found early so he had open heart surgery, then he had to go back to the hospital when his heart wasn't beating right to get a pacemaker, essentially got a new job within my team, and got so anxious and stressed out last may that my psoriasis flared hard enough to give me arthritis in my neck. I didn't even know it could do that!
>
> All this is to say, thank you for the patience and for sticking with this fic, especially those of you who have had to suffer the 5 years of waiting that none of us expected on it.
>
> Anyone remember when this was a one shot? : p
>
> Anyhow, thank you, and I hope you enjoy!
>
> (And I'm not sorry Catra got two shaves in the chapter, I am having the time of my life wet shaving and it's officially becoming every one else's problem :D)

Turned out that loving Glimmer Moon openly was much more different than she'd expected it would be. When she was younger it was like a dunk in a freezing lake, hidden it had felt like a dam ready to burst, and now it was like lowering into a hot spring. A rush of heat and a wave of tingling down her arms before the world rocked away. And it was like that every damn day too.

They'd already been closer than polite society would've preferred, trying to survive the snow in had only made it that much more extreme. Pressed up together nice and close, holding hands, kissing- It would've been a fairy tale like living, if not for the increasing anxiety about wood for fire and dwindling food.

Ultimately the snow had melted as the spring finally arrived with a strong enough sun to make it passable back into town. And while Catra sure wasn't feeling ready to see people, she'd been just as ecstatic as Glimmer to have actually survived the whole ordeal. She hadn't been thinking much about the change in them, at least not until they stumbled into the general store and it was pushed a bit more into her mind.

Juliette stared at them like ghosts, but it had Bow who was pursuing some tinned goods who shouted with excitement and relief, and that was only cut out at the knees when he looked between them with almost deep suspicion before smirking at them.

"What?" She'd huffed, exhausted and desperate for whatever food they could afford to have delivered since they'd run clean out of even salt pork and potted meat a week before.

He only gave a small squeal of excitement. She'd expected some relief, it was always nice when someone you were worried about came back into town, but this didn't seem to be about them living through that snowy hellscape. Catra stared at him trying to make sense of it before looking at Glimmer. They were both a little thinner, scraggly, exhausted, and generally looked like hell.

"Archer, what in the hell are you on about?"

It wasn't until he looked pointedly down that she remembered her and Glimmer were linked arm in arm, something they hadn't done in public in, well… damn! Near ten years now. Huh.

"Fuck you and the horse you rode in on." Catra barely managed to put a hint of bite into it, flushing as he laughed at her. "I'm

getting a haircut, you deal with him."

Catra loved the man, but she did not have it in her to deal with him in that sort of mood. Besides, they'd planned to part ways before meeting up again just to cover more ground with their limited daylight.

So, she gratefully stumbled into the Star Siblings and let Glimmer deal with the rest of that nonsense. Skipping past the sound of Tallstar's newfangled dental drill in use on some poor bastard and bee lining for the barber chair for a proper damn shave, Catra didn't even feel bad about it. The hot towels kept her calm, and the cream had felt luxuriously soft and fluffy. The scrape of the blade was music to her ears even if the after shave was an affront to humanity. Or maybe her skin was just dry as hell.

"Anything for your hair?" Jewelstar asked, tilting his head to see her with his good eye, and doing his level best to not sound too hopeful. Man could spot a lost cause when he saw one.

Catra stared into the mirror and bemoaned the greasy, matted rats nest she was faced with. She'd, perhaps, allowed it to get worse than she was sure it had ever been. Ice water was not exactly healthy to use in the winter and they'd had a good few months trapped like that. Considering how she'd been ignoring it for a few months before that, well. "How much can you salvage?"

He walked around her twice, thoughtfully looking at her. "Well, quite a bit I reckon. Up to your chin, and the rest a good comb and scrub could do. It would take a while though and I can't promise it wouldn't just bunch up again."

Jesus she did not have the patience for that, if she suffered that kind of gauntlet just to have it need a second swipe, she might just lose her damned mind. Exhaustion pulled at her as she huffed, "Just take it off. Leave something there, but just, take the damn thing."

"You sure?"

Catra did her best to not stare at his eyepatch the way she always wanted to. "Sir, it'll grow back if'n I hate it."

It was only after he'd already removed the back with his razor that she wondered if Glimmer was gonna pitch a fit. It still took some time, longer that she'd have liked but she had only really planned for the shave and a quick hack. When he finished there was just enough on top to pommade into a side part, and Catra sighed.

"Damn, those are big ass ears." She bemoaned.

Jewelstar had done his best to not laugh at her suffering, so she decided to pay him with minimal whining. She still grouchily accepted a tin of pommade as an apology considering how much else she was buying. *I will never sell you again,* Catra promised her new shaving kit as she cradled it close to her breast like a newborn babe.

If she thought she'd catch a break, she'd been dead wrong.

"Oh thank goodness, do you think they'll finally marry soon?" Double Trouble's voice bounced down the alley and Catra almost tripped over her own boots into the mud. "Oh this is fabulous! I need to order a few good kegs- do you think they'll let me design something for their clothes?"

She quickly altered course and ran all but ran as she tried to shove that thought out of her head. Her heart thumped and flopped and begged at the mere idea of it, they needed more time. Not too much, god willing, but more time than this! And Catra certainly did not need to be daydreaming like a child about marrying Mrs. Angella Moon's daughter while in her house, thank you very much.

The smell of food made her almost drool, and her stomach all but roared when she entered the dining room where an empty seat was left for her even if they'd nearly finished their own meals.

And then Glimmer screamed, scaring the ever loving hell out of her.

"Jesus!"

"Oh!!!" Glimmer rushed up, eyes taking in the hair cut and running her fingers along the freshly shorn sides, right before her gaze drifted to focus in the most distracting manner on her mouth. "Oh, but I loved that beard!"

"Miss, we all have to put our dogs down someday." Catra sighed but couldn't help smiling as Glimmer ran her fingers over her face now. "A'sides, I think I look rather good like this."

"Well, you've always had a pretty face."

She wanted to kiss her and never stop.

"OH!" Angella yelped, looking very pleased and not embarrassed at all as they jumped and turned to look at her. "Thank goodness you two reconciled, I thought I'd die of old age first!"

As if that sentiment didn't make Catra both want to jump off the nearest bridge and also make her weirdly float a foot off the ground. Still.

"Not you too! I heard DT out there, already saying we're getting married and such. We don't need you stoking that flame!"

"I'm not doing anything. Also, still not subtle dears." The way Mrs. Moon leaned back in her chair with an almost devilish grin as she failed to act like a normal human being did not instill her with much confidence.

It was like a siren's call after that, or the ringing of church bells from far away. Or maybe she was biased because she was getting to hear Glimmer speak with some of that old lighthearted silliness she'd been missing.

Time was moving real funny like, each day felt like an eternity only for the weeks to pass in the blink of an eye. They was talking again, and kissing again, and moving forward together again, and it just made life easier. Softer and sweeter too. Sure, they'd suffered their friends jovial teasing in public and quiet affirmations in private. They even made it out of the spring ball and danced on the puncheon floor, taking in the general joy of it all. Sure, some folks weren't pleased, Catra had long since accepted that Mrs. Juliette would rather drop her off a cliff than accept her back, but Glimmer cackled in her arms under the full moon as her feet caught on the uneven logs. That mattered a helluva lot more than anything else.

Catra was most pleased with how they could talk again though. Not just to hash something out, not just to apologize or explain. Just… shooting the shit, theorizing, perhaps even some philosophizing when the hour got late.

All the same, conversation tended to slow when Catra shaved at home. Mostly because she only answered sparingly, but Glimmer's (apparently) always had a staring problem. So she doesn't get any rest during it either, not that she's really complaining about it.

"You just gonna watch the whole time, huh?" Catra snickered as she waited for the oil to seep in a bit more.

Glimmer's smirk was wicked sharp in the mirror behind her. "Well you make such a grand show and exciting reveal, how'm I to stay away?"

She wanted to argue about it, but, well. It had been years since she had her own shaving kit. She'd gone in debt with the company for them back with Krytis and after her injury Entrapta had taken to helping out with it. Sure it had grown while she'd cowered in the cabin, but she'd barely cared at that point. No knock against Jewelstar, she'd just prefer to do it herself.

"Says you, miss." Catra grumbled back good naturedly as she loaded her brush and started lathering.

“Goodbye again my love, we’ll meet again soon,” Glimmer theatrically lamented from behind, shrieking when Catra flicked the brush at her. “Oh, that’s playing dirty!”

“Woman, you NEED help. Professionally, I fear.”

“You need help.” Glimmer grumbled back, but quieted down as the razor started to move.

Back before, she’d had a straight razor to do this. Thing was a pain in the ass, and she’d hated shaving regularly just due to how damn long it took. The new safety razor helped cut that down significantly in her opinion, although she doubted they’d ever find a way to shorten the whole process. First pass, lather, second pass, lather, third pass, wash, alum and a little witch hazel were enough to round the whole thing out.

Catra crossed one leg over the other at the knee, turned in her chair to lean back a little and fluttered her eyes. “Darlin’, I’m ready for my tin type.”

Glimmer only rolled her eyes as she stood and cradled Catra’s cheeks carefully in her hands. “Hmmm, suppose so, that does look like a face that launched a thousand ships.” And then she leaned down and kissed her softly.

“How can I love you more each day? There has to be an upper limit.” Catra sighed and she could tell Glimmer loved it from the way she grinned off to the side. Once upon a time that would’ve earned a teasing, maybe it would again in the future, but right now it took every ounce of willpower to not drop to her knees and beg Glimmer to marry her.

So instead, she kissed her again and then stood, freeing the vanity for Glimmer to put on a bit of makeup and fix her hair. Miss Hunga wasn’t the nicest of women, and certainly not the most patient, so they needed to look nice and presentable before she knocked on the door so the pictures could be taken quickly.

Angella had been the one to suggest it, get some professional pictures of the cabin while there was still some woods to appreciate. Etheria was booming again now that BMR had finished their direct connecting line to Plumeria, and thanks to Glimmer using most of the rest of her money on indoor plumbing folks were setting up on the water line towards them lickety-split. But once the picture of the house had been suggested, Glimmer had jumped on board to have a photo of them taken as well.

"It'll be better than going to the studio, it'll be more of the real us." Glimmer promised after Double Trouble had caught Catra's ear too long on the matter. "Just make yourself presentable, that'll do nicely."

"Catra?" Glimmer called almost nervously over her shoulder, fiddling with the buttons on the side of her dress before asking, "Do you think the bracelet would look good with this?"

She didn't know what in the hell Glimmer meant by it, not really. But that had to be a good sign, Glimmer hadn't worn the bracelet since- well, Catra could only assume since she'd left. Pretty much the only thing she'd kept, barely surviving the fire she'd admitted to in a bout of regrets and fear because it had been her daddy's. She couldn't assume it meant anything more than be willing to claw one more part of her life back, but god help her she did want to assume.

"I think it would look perfect."

Glimmer smiled at the vanity top as she put it on, letting it catch the light from the bedroom window beautifully. Catra was going to swallow her tongue, chew through her own arm, or explode right here on the spot. The first few gray hairs had sprouted in a cluster at the top of Glimmer's forehead, wrinkles starting to show around her eyes, and sitting there in her beautiful lilac dress and a light blue shawl, makeup on and hair done up…

When she'd been younger, Catra had never really pictured what their married life would look like down the road. Not really. She'd

pictured what they'd already had and had only proposed as it seemed the proper thing to do once she'd learned of it. Part of the downfall of their wedding had been her fear of the future. In the Horde your life was promised to be short, thinking on the future was for Hordak or Weaver, and it was always about the gang. Then the Moon's themselves made it even more frightening when it seemed the only option she had was to, somehow, become as good as Mr. Moon had been.

So, she'd proposed and been thrilled that Glimmer wanted to be with her, only with her, forever and ever, until the day they both died. That was a powerful feeling, and it had been enough.

Catra wished she could go back in time somehow, and show the younger her this very moment. The softness and contentedness, the feeling of being loved wholly good and bad. Get her to get moving a mite quicker. And maybe punch her about for a little until something got through that thick bullheadedness to speak up and stand her ground.

But seeing this, seeing it all happen now? Well, she could forgive herself for this. And maybe, just maybe they were really gonna be ready this time.

"We best get a move on," Catra mumbled as she stood up.

Glimmer stared at her before demanding, "What's got your bun in a twist all the sudden? Hunga won't be here for a little more yet!"

Catra felt the words burning at the tip of her tongue and forced them back. Soon, she promised herself, they could spill out all they damn well pleased very soon.

"Miss if I am left alone in this room with you looking like that for one minute more, I won't be responsible for how we would look in the damn picture."

When Glimmer followed her down a short thirty second later it was only to huff in a voice that had to be sinful, "You cannot just say something like that and run, D'riluth!"

Catra turned and smiled, “Oh yeah? That a law then missy?”

“Oh I’m boutta make it one!” Glimmer moved so damn fast, Catra couldn’t track her, and when she grabbed Catra’s lapels tight enough to test the stitching, she was ready to call the whole thing off. They’d had a few months to get reacquainted, but god damn it couldn’t hurt to do it so more!

When the door banged then both jumped before laughing too hard to explain themselves to the irate photographer, there a whole half hour early.

But it was like they were now moving to an invisible beat, the cogs turning, the sands of time certainly not slowing. Not even when her life got turned upside down again.

Catra had thought it odd when Adora told her that Glimmer went home early and sent her to tell Catra to just head home for a surprise when ready. It simply wasn’t anything normal, but when Mrs. Moon looked just as confused and let her go early, Catra figured it couldn’t be anything too big then.

Ha!

Outside their home was a wagon, small enough to not hold all that much, but definitely not something they owned. The next thing she knew there was a boisterous laugh from the barn, familiar and aching. Catra froze right up but Melog didn’t need her to trot happily into the yard towards it.

“-and miss I am telling you, I think he can read minds!” Scorpia was practically hooting. “He always knew when our Wildcat needed a little extra love.”

“He bonded with her, such behavior is to be expected from many different horses.” Entrapta cut in before asking, “Oooh, nice, is this gum heartwood?”

“I- don’t know?” Glimmer sounded hopelessly lost, which seemed about right.

“Am I dreaming?” Catra asked Melog who only tossed his head as he shoved his way into the barn.

“CATRA!” Scorpia ran forward and had scooped her off the saddle before she even knew what was happening, only to be swung around so Scorpia could tell *her horse* , “Oh, thank you Melog, you knew just when to bring her!”

Which was far too much credit to give a horse, and also would go right to his head if the bastard actually did understand English!

“Put me down big girl.” Catra wheezed and was placed delicately. “God damn good to see you too!”

It didn’t take long for them to head into the house for some coffee and bread, or for her two friends to apologize again for the delay. Turned out the gangs had not been too pleased when Entrapta tried to leave and things had gone to a near stand off. The whole powder keg got set off early by some bandit with a twitchy finger and they’d manage to slip away during the ensuing confusion. Then they’d had to circle back to rescue Entrapta’s work before they could actually begin their travel to Plumeria.

“It took a bit longer than expected to get fully set up and ready for us to leave again,” Entrapta explained much later as they ate a dinner of pork and beans with brown bread, “not to mention the whole Perfuma Thing.”

“W-what Perfuma thing? There is NO Perfuma thing! Not that I wouldn’t love it if there was.” Scorpia sighed heavily, and nearly tilted her modified spoon far enough to drop her food. “Gosh that would be nice!”

“Oh, I would say there *is* a Perfuma thing,” Glimmer smiled, “she’s written about someone who’s caught her eye, even chose to stay home instead of attend our last dance to catch up with me.”

It was nothing short of a pure delight to watch Scorpia half melt into her seat and squirm over her feelings. Not that Catra didn’t appreciate what they’d done for her, but it was quite a nice

surprise to be on the other side of the situation. “Well, someone once told me to just go for it and talk to the girl I loved. Maybe that someone should consider doing the same.”

Of course the kicker of the night had been when Entrapta finished their long tale over tea with a simple question, “And we weren’t sure when the wedding was, so we wanted to make sure we got here quick. So when are you getting married?”

Catra choked on her tea as Glimmer stammered a non-answer and fled for her bedroom.

“...wait seriously? You’re not even engaged yet?” Entrapta asked in a pained voice, which somehow only made Catra feel infinitely worse about that fact. If Entrapta was noticing and thought they were being painfully dumb, well, it was miracle Aunt Casta hadn’t taken them hostage for a shotgun arrangement then.

She needed to do damage control, she needed to speak it into creation so no one would kidnap her in the night for a second hand elopement. “We’re close, just- we had some things to work on first. Soon, though. I’m planning on it soon!”

Scorpia yawned loudly and blushed, “Sorry, sorry! Long ride today! Wow, guess it’s a good thing we couldn’t do a seance in the end, huh?”

“A- what in the world- ?” Catra asked as Entrapta flopped backwards on the settee and mumbled, “Ghosts aren’t real.”

The three looked at one another for a moment before Catra stood up, “Alright, I think let’s leave ‘er there and figure that out never. Got a single free bed upstairs for one of ya, should be a’right down here if you open the shutters though.”

She didn’t even think twice about it until she was shutting and locking Glimmer’s door with relief.

“Why, hello there Miss D’riluth, lovely evening isn’t it?” Glimmer drawled from the bed, already placing the book she was reading

aside.

"Yes ma'am, sure is. Got the ladies settled for the night, and I'm afraid I done gone and lost my bed in my hospitality. Is there any room in here for one more?"

Glimmer patted the bed next to her hip with a grin, "Why miss, what a fine thing to do! You are quite lucky that there does so happen to be a spot just here tonight you can rest them weary bones."

It didn't take long to strip down to her undergarments and then flop unceremoniously into the bed, making Glimmer laugh as she latched on to her hip, "Oh, well then, much obliged! Much better than sleeping with Melog."

Glimmer ran her fingers through Catra's hair, scratching at the back of her scalp before all but whispering, "You always got a spot here, you know?"

Catra rolled onto her back to look up, and couldn't help the warm smile that plastered over her face. But before she could think of what to say, Glimmer spoke again. "Hey, Catra?" She turned to slide off the bed, easily going to one knee to be at the same height as her. "Marry me?"

She froze, eyes going wide and breathing a little funny as she tried to process that. "W-what?"

Glimmer reached out gingerly and took her hands before looking back into her eyes. "I've been thinking. I think, I think we were meant to be, and darlin'? I'm so damn tired of being afraid of that. I… I love you. I don't see any good reason why we shouldn't. I can't stand to be apart from you, not for one second longer or I might die. So, well, will you marry me?"

She wasn't even aware she was crying until Glimmer reached up to brush them off her cheeks. "Are you serious? You ain't ready to quit dealing with me yet, huh?"

“Catra, I love you so much,” she grinned, “even if I knew what the hell ‘quitting’ was, I wouldn’t do it anyways! Not when it comes to you, I am not looking to quit you until I’m damn well dead.”

Catra laughed, sniffling as more and more tears fell.

“Those better be happy,” Glimmer chuckled weakly, “We can wait. As long as you want to, ain’t no rush, but god as my witness, I am gonna marry you.”

It was pure sunshine bursting out of her ribs, something too strong to feel delicate anymore. Just pure joy that swooped around in her stomach, before she started to laugh. “Glimmer Moon, you are a right fool- I already asked you first!”

Glimmer laughed bright and loud through her own tears. “I know! But I asked you second, and I’m still waiting on an answer D’riluth!”

“Of course I’ll marry you! I love you! You think I waited, what, twenty god damned years just to say no? Get off the damn floor!”

Catra pulled her up easily, moving to pull her into her lap only to end up half pinned under her as Glimmer hopped up too quickly. Glimmer framed her face between her hands and kissed her, kept kissing her, wouldn’t stop kissing her. Their voices twisting together so easily, lifting to the sky like pure sage smoke.

Chapter 24: Happily Ever After

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer finally, FINALLY, get married!

Chapter Notes

To celebrate finally finishing my master's degree, I'm also going to celebrate finishing my longest length and running fic, cheers!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Turned out that getting married was an awful lot of waiting around to be nervous.

Which was, frankly, just plain rude!

Glimmer smoothed the front of her dress for what the umpteenth time and stared hard at herself in the mirror. She looked fine. She looked good, even! Double Trouble had personally hunted down the silk and tulle from up north at a cost that had made Catra go a particularly concerning shade of pale when she'd found out about it. But it was real pretty, and Glimmer wanted to feel pretty wearing it; and yes it had cost a damned fortune, but she was only going to wear it this one time. As such she decided to not feel a lick of guilt about any of that.

"You're gonna knock some beads off if you keep doing that." Adora said from behind her, doing some last minute fussing with the small buttons along the back.

"I am not doing anything!"

"You've smoothed that about ten times since I started on these."

Glimmer huffed as that was more an indictment of Adora's buttoning abilities than it was her own nerves, but she chose to

let it go this time.

"I have not." She smoothed it again reflexively as she said that, and Adora said nothing with the specific kind of grace that came from twenty five years of friendship and a great deal of self preservation. "Is it straight?"

"It's perfect." And she meant it, which made Glimmer want to start crying right there, which was not going to happen, especially not over something so silly. She had absolutely refused and made a solemn oath to herself and all present that she was not going to cry until after the ceremony at least. Sure, she was going to fail miserably at that oath, but it was the thought that counted. Adora smiled at her in the mirror, "You look beautiful Glimmer."

"Oh hush." She swallowed hard. "Is she-"

"She's out there, yeah."

That settled the butterflies something fierce, only to set them right back up again in the other direction. "Oh Lord, help me."

"Hey." Adora came around to face her, hands gentle on both her shoulders. Her eyes were soft and a little wet around the edges and Glimmer was gonna kill her. "You alright?"

"Of course I'm alright! Why wouldn't I be alright?" She straightened up and tried not to let her voice wobble about it. "We've been practically married most our lives, we already did the hard bits, this is just, it's a formality really! Nothing to be worked up over."

Adora smiled at her in that way that meant she wasn't fooled even a little bit. "Right."

"I'm perfectly fine."

"Uh huh."

"Adora Gray I will shoot you where you stand."

Adora only laughed, and that was enough to shake loose the worst of the nerves. Enough that Glimmer could breathe right again, which she supposed had been the intention. She straightened her bracelet, the cool metal of it familiar and grounding against her wrist, and took a breath.

"Alright," she said. "Alright."

“Alright,” Adora agreed and held a hand out, “ready to get this show on the road, missy?”

Glimmer took the hand and maybe threw a few fingers at the same time, who was really to say, but nodded all the same. The ceremony wasn’t for a bit longer, but knowing Catra the last minute checks were really best handled by someone else.

Catra had, unsuccessfully, suggested eloping to avoid the whole rigmarole of a large wedding. Not that Glimmer hadn’t been interested in it, she’d given it some good and honest thought! It was more that once her mother, the first one they told this time, knew- well… Okay, so her mother learned, so her aunt learned, and that was that. All the work from another lifetime sprang back into action, as if it had laid in wait like a perfectly laid spring trap. There had been little they’d needed to really do, beyond adjusting the list of invitees to try and find Scorpia and Entrapta that is.

Which, ultimately, they really hadn’t needed to.

They’d been waiting to see if Perfuma happened to know anything about the two, seeing as they’d planned to go to Plumeria at some point by their letters with Catra, when they took matters into their own hands a scant month before the wedding was set.

“Salutations!” A stranger all but screamed as the door to the Sheriff’s Office banged open, startling her and Adora bad enough that they went tumbling to the floor alongside their cards and chairs (which they may or may not have been seeing who could balance more precariously).

Another woman laughed nervously, "Oh, wow! Sorry about that! That door just looked a LOT heavier than it was. If anything is damaged I can fix it. Probably."

Glimmer peaked back over her toppled chair to see the second woman had entered as well. Built like a damn brickhouse and tall enough to block the sun. She shook her head and refocused on the first woman, who was small by any and every measure except for the pile of deep auburn locks on her head. And that tickled at something old in the back of Glimmer's mind.

"I'm- we-" Adora coughed, standing up quickly as if she hadn't been doing nothing foolish a'tall. "I'm Sheriff Gray, and this is Deputy Moon, howdy. How can we help you ladies?"

"Oh I know." The short woman said, turning to stare at Glimmer before striking some sort of pose, "You don't remember me do you? It's me, Entrapta! We met at one of Perfuma's harvest balls several years back."

Entrapta? Oh goodness, it had been quite a while! But if Entrapta was *here* then that could only mean-

"I could never forget you, but you must admit you look quite different. And, my apologies if this is presumptuous miss, but does your name happen to be Scorpia?" Glimmer smiled as she stood up fully, excited beyond reason to be able to spring such a welcome surprise on her fiance.

Scorpia lit up with a brilliant smile, brighter than the noon day sun. "Yes it is! How did you know? Oh my goodness, are you psychic!? Can you communicate with the dead in like a seance or such? Oh this is so exciting!"

It was a little funny to picture Catra, dour and small, being carried under one of Scorpia's arms. Glimmer is pretty sure that is not how the two spent their time talking together, but it's the first thing that came to mind as they spoke.

“Ooooor maybe Catra did make it here and spoke about us.” Entrapta suggested.

Glimmer wasn’t sure why she broke into a bit of cold sweat when both women turned to await her answer. “Uhm, y-yes, Catra’s talked quite a bit about you both. Did you not get the-”

They both cheered and this time it was very endearing to her, even if she had a feeling today just got a lot more complicated. Scorpia suddenly stopped and grumbled, “Aw shoot, that means no on doing a seance then?”

“...no, I cannot hold a seance. Why are you wanting to hold a seance!?”

“Oh no!” Scorpia blanched a bit, “Gosh no, I don’t want to hold one! If I saw a ghost I’d die stone cold dead right there myself!”

Entrapta scoffed, “They aren’t real Scorpia.”

“You never saw the headless man! He would ride past the station every night at midnight! Or was it every full moon?” As if she wasn’t the one to bring up all these ideas, Scorpia’s head dipped in thought, one hook tapping at her chin thoughtfully. “Hmmmmm.”

Glimmer glanced at Adora for guidance but she seemed to be spooked herself before she jumped in, “Every night!? A real ghost? OH! This is just like the woman in white Madam Razz always talks about!”

“I’ve never heard of-” But apparently Glimmer wasn’t getting a say as Scorpia and Adora began speaking quickly over one another.

“Maybe it was just on the devil’s holiday? Pretty sure it was more frequent, but-”

“Legend goes that a woman was murdered by her husband-”

“Definitely was at night though, half the town would just die of fright if-”

“ And without her closure she now walks the earth-”

“I SAW HIM WITH MY OWN TWO EYES!”

Glimmer leapt closer to Entrapta simply because the woman seemed composed and a little deflated now. Nothing to do with being spooked. She was not spooked by some silly ghost tale, th-that would be silly! For Entrapta’s part she just sighed with a small tired smile before turning to ignore the two women as they chattered on.

“So, speaking logically, Catra made it I take it?”

Glimmer glanced over, wanting to listen in a little more, but duty came first she supposed. “Uhm, yes. Yes, she did. I take it you both didn’t get our invitation? We sent it to Perfuma to pass on when y’all mentioned going thataway to Catra.”

“Invitation? Hmm, no, no I don’t remember an invitation.” Entrapta pulled a few notebooks from her pocket, flipping through them like one of those moving picture flip books, “No, I don’t see any mention of an invitation.”

“Oh, well, you’re timing is fantastic then!” Glimmer chuckled, wondering how anyone could read at that sort of pace. Felt like a handy skill to have considering the back log of books she wanted to read some day. “We sent an invitation to the wedding. Our wedding that is. In a week?”

She already hadn’t known why she felt so nervous speaking with them, but the feeling only doubled up as Entrapta suddenly fully focused on her with an intensity that really could’ve rivaled her mother.

“You’re getting **MARRIED**!?!? AHHH!!!!!” Entrapta squealed as she rounded on Scorpia to jump, literally, into the woman’s arms.

“SCORPIA WE ARE SO WINNING, THEY’RE GETTING MARRIED IN A WEEK!!!!!”

It had certainly devolved from there into pure chaos. At some point they’d managed to leave to grab Catra, and that had mostly turned into a lot of loud, public, happy crying. It had helped to bolster Catra’s nerves in the process and been a wonderful distraction for them both being somewhat out of control over the wedding itself at this point. The resurrected behemoth temporarily forgotten as they’d reconnected for the first time in far too many years.

The nervousness came back like the bad habit it was though.

Catra had still found a way to make herself sick with nerves over the whole thing. Where Glimmer had just been damned well excited to finally marry the woman she loved, her beloved wanted this to be perfect for Glimmer. They talked on it, they had to, but age helped to temper some of the worst spots. No make ups, no do overs, they were just going for it. She still expected that Catra was either being shepherded around for her own sanity, or was being unwillingly distracted by Double Trouble who still seemed obsessed with her. Much in the same way Glimmer was being watched like a hawk to ensure she did not “over involve” herself.

Which turned out perfect seeing as it had all very nearly gone sideways before a single vow was spoken, which was, truthfully, about what Glimmer had expected.

The food had been the first thing she discovered going off the rails. Mr. Pop had come rushing past the back hallway with a silver tureen of some kind of meat broth she was pretty sure was supposed to have been a proper consommé, and the look on his face had her stomach dropping clean to her shoes. She'd been a heartbeat from going over to investigate when her Aunt Casta materialized out of nowhere and swept her back toward the waiting area with a vice grip on her elbow, back to Adora who was at least doing her best to not look like she’d either been panicking or laughing.

"Absolutely not."

"But the-"

"Not your concern."

"If the food has gone-"

"Glimmer." Casta leveled her with the look. The one that had survived intact all the way from Glimmer's childhood, the one that had made her freeze at seven years old and apparently still worked just fine now. "The food has not gone wrong. Mr. Pop is managing it beautifully. You are not going to stick your head into the kitchen on your wedding day, do you hear me?"

"…yes ma'am."

"Good." Casta's expression softened just slightly. She smoothed a piece of Glimmer's hair back, just gentle, the same way her mother used to do. Glimmer's throat went tight. "Your mother would have been beside herself."

She had to look at the ceiling for a moment. "Yeah."

"In the best way." Casta smiled. "Now, stay here."

The peace lasted for only a little while before the next emergency reared its head.

The particular sound of Bow attempting and failing to hide his absolute delight was unmistakable by this point in Glimmer's life. Twenty some odd years of it. She'd have known it blind in a thunderstorm.

From the back terrace she could hear him speaking quickly and only one glance at Adora meant they were both scurrying out to meet him.

"In what world," he was saying, with that tone he got, "would we celebrate this union without coffee?"

He was grinning wildly at Catra’s retreating back as she was being physically hauled away, and Glimmer eyed the campfire and coffee pot with great suspicion.

"Oh so you're saying you finally learned how to make it!" Glimmer huffed, and didn't quite manage to clamp down on it fast enough before Adora poked her sharply in the ribs.

"We are learnin' ma'am, don't you dare!"

She still huffed, "Oh my goodness, are we poisoning our guests!?"

"What?" Adora frowned, all joking aside as she looked out in confusion. "No, Catra made it."

Glimmer's mind helpfully supplied a vision of her mother, trembling and twitching from past experience. Only to swap it out for her aunt with a sharp smile and her knitting needles. Her family did not drink coffee for a damned reason, no matter how delightful a good cup could be. She also couldn’t pass up an opportunity like this. "Oh my goodness, we ARE poisoning our guests!"

There was a laugh from somewhere just past the doorway. Low and crooked and a little startled. Glimmer felt the whole of her chest ache with the sweetness of it.

"You be good, this thing cost a fortune!" Double Trouble's voice rang out with bright reproach as Catra half tugged and half pulled against their beautiful gigot sleeves to return on hearing Glimmer’s voice. Which may have done a few things to her jelly legs, but she wasn’t going to pay it no nevermind.

"And who's damn fault is that?" Catra said, half sneering, "Pretty little thing, but when are you gonna wear it after this?"

"After this? Darling, never, but still!"

"Jesus Christ! Once!? How much was-"

"Oh you do not want to know. Suffice to say, it's real satin and the lacework is divine, now stop being a brat and get back here properly!"

Catra made the classic mistake of entertaining their version of reality, turning to make some face that Glimmer would've died to see. Unfortunately it meant that Double Trouble was once again able to get a good enough grip to haul her bride away once more.

"You hush yourself D'riluth!"

"I ain't even SAID nothing!"

"Oh you don't have to." Double Trouble's voice dropped into something almost fond.

Bow snorted, one hand covering his mouth as he looked at Glimmer pointedly, but Glimmer only sighed back dreamily, "I'm gonna marry that woman."

"Yes you are, in about…" Adora squinted through the glass to see the clock, "oh, let's say ten minutes?"

And there were the nerves again, just in time too. Glimmer fanned her face with a hand, smile frozen in place before she managed to settle herself a bit. Ten minutes. Good lord, decades worth of knowing and lovin' and fightin' and planning were about to reach a head. In ten whole minutes.

"Don't faint. Please don't faint, I can catch you, but I fear what will be done to us in retaliation." Adora giggled but a little of her own anxiety dripped through. Poor thing loved a good plan, as long as things stuck with the plan.

"Then, darlin', please do me a favor and put me somewhere to sit for ten minutes where I won't be seeing nothing at all." Glimmer fluttered her lashes for good measure as Adora quickly walked her away inside to sit on the first seat she could find. Which in this case was actually a footrest, but it was clean so Glimmer sat and waited.

In an eternity and an instant, Adora was quietly herding her to the ceremony.

They'd decided together, quietly, to walk in separately and meet in the middle. It had seemed practical at the time. Bow had agreed with her mother in a way that she had not fully forgiven him for yet, but they'd already been living together for the better part of years now so the old tradition of not seeing each other seemed a little like closing the barn door after the horses were already gone. Yet walking in separately meant she had to stand there and wait, and she'd had a very brief moment alone before the room went loud and warm around her. Their guests may have been much fewer than they'd originally planned for, but the wait made the reception that much bigger.

Funny thing though. Glimmer didn't even realize she was holding her breath until she saw Catra.

And she thought, in some distant floaty part of herself that had apparently untethered from her body for the occasion, that this was how it must have felt the very first time. All that time ago on a dusty road with a horse that spooked at boots. The way the world had just narrowed down and there hadn't been anything else to look at. She couldn't quite remember the feeling, but knowing in her heart that there was only one person she *could* look at, well, that she felt quite a bit around Catra just generally speaking. Now it never felt old.

Catra looked terrified and like she was trying very hard not to show it and not quite managing. She was wearing a dark jacket that fit her right across the shoulders and she'd done something with her hair. She had a small nosegay of wildflowers that Scorpia had almost certainly cried putting together and was holding them so tight her knuckles were pale. She caught Glimmer's eye across the room.

Her whole face went soft.

Glimmer walked toward her and Catra smiled as she now strolled easily.

It was hard to listen to Bow, having earned a ministry license specifically for the occasion, when Catra was standing there looking so pretty like. They gray in her hair framed her face perfectly, making her eye colors pop even brighter. A small dusting of blush hadn’t been enough to cover the freckles or the light wrinkles, only making the apples of her cheeks stand out just a bit more. Glimmer could’ve eaten her right up, right there. Instead she broke her promise not to cry as the tears leaked regardless. Catra managed to scoot her boot forward just enough to tap at Glimmer’s shoe, a small smile and head tilt towards Bow reminded her to at least try and pay some attention. He'd have been gutted to know she wasn't listening for the beginning of it.

Good thing too, as the welcome and preamble was nearly done and also was more of a roast than a wedding speech, the traitor!

"And as we can't have y'all cross the entrance together for the first time-" Bow smirked as the crowd laughed, apparently finally gearing up to get to the good part but not before Catra and Glimmer had silently and jointly agreed to get him back for all of this. “We are oh so grateful that you could cross the aisle together for the first time instead.”

"And may I also be the first to say," Bow smiled, and his voice cracked just a little on it, as their guests stomped and whistled and carried on without a care in the world, "that we are all so relieved that you two have figured it out long enough to actually get here."

Catra snorted. Glimmer watched her turn and look at her and could see the exact moment it hit her again, same as it kept hitting Glimmer, this strange recurring surprise at their own luck.

"Do not go crying on me," Glimmer whispered, and could feel her own eyes burning something fierce, pretending the tears she’d already shed had been imagined over real.

Catra gave one loud hiccuping laugh, nearly sobbing as she absolutely went ahead and started crying anyways.

"Damn it D'riluth!"

"Now, now," Bow interrupted with the gentle desperation of a man who knew them very well, "let me at least marry you two before you go killing her. Goodness knows the rest of us can't take another twenty years for you two to figure this all out a third time!"

There were no vows, the ceremony itself was short once they got to it, the ruckus and rompous were really the main attractions for such large and well funded events after all. Most of it felt a blur, the feeling of the ring sliding onto her finger sat sharp against the rest along with the warmth of her love. Before Glimmer even knew it, the feast was starting and the band was playing.

And they were married. They were *married*. They *were finally* married!

She clutched at Catra’s arm and hand the whole time, refusing to be separated for even a moment as the celebration peaked and swayed and turned and dazzled and finally began to mellow.

The band was playing a slower tune, a waltz of some kind.

Catra didn't know how to waltz. She never had, and probably never would, and it hadn't stopped her for one second from pulling Glimmer out onto the floor anyways. They swayed more than anything, closer than was probably proper, and Glimmer thought the handful of people who might've had something to say about it probably needed no incentive to keep the peace beyond knowing them both so well. So they danced in the cool breeze.

Under the lanterns and the moon, Glimmer felt about as close to floating as a person could get with their feet still on the ground.

"Hey," she said softly.

"Hey yourself." Catra's voice had gone low and warm, like honey. "How can I love you more each day? There has to be an upper limit."

"I've been wondering that myself." Glimmer hummed. "I keep expecting to hit it and I never do."

Catra laughed, soft this time, and Glimmer tucked her face in against her shoulder and just let herself feel the weight of it. The whole of it. All the years and the miles and the ways they had found each other and lost each other and found each other again, like two creeks running apart and coming back to the same river anyways; they couldn't help it, it was just the way the land laid. Catra hummed thoughtfully, as if she could hear Glimmer’s thoughts.

"Here and now, dear," she murmured against the lapel of Catra's vest.

"Well yes ma'am." Catra sighed, that long easy sigh she only got when she'd put something down that had been heavy. She pressed her cheek to the top of Glimmer's head. "How can I say no to the purdiest person on this whole planet? Just wouldn't do."

Glimmer pulled back just enough to look at her. "My apologies, but you are dead wrong. I'm looking at the prettiest person on this whole planet right now."

Catra's expression did something complicated that ended up landing on unbearably fond. "Well now, my mistake. Purdiest person in the whole damn universe and creation. Easy mix up."

"Simple slip of the tongue."

"Glimmer Moon-" she stopped herself, eyes going just a little bright again. Her smile came crooked and wondering. "My beautiful wife, we are in public."

Glimmer felt the word like sunlight landing square on the back of her hand. She grinned wide enough it probably looked a little

unhinged. "Hush, why d'you always gotta make this so difficult."

"You'd leave me if I weren't." Glimmer's gaze went hard and Catra tagged on quickly, "Not that I'm any kind of curse, lord no. More like a headache, maybe."

"I've warned you for years." Glimmer reached to pinch at her sides with the most deliberately evil smile she could manage for a woman who had just gotten married.

Catra squirmed away with a sound that was very close to a squeak through all the layers of good cloth, which meant she had won. "Help, help! Someone call the Sheriff!"

"Bad news." Glimmer tugged her right back in, both arms locked around her waist with finality. "She ain't going nowhere tonight."

Catra laughed again. Glimmer was going to spend the rest of her life finding reasons to make that happen.

Later, when the dancing had fully wound down and the last of the guests had filtered out content into the night, Glimmer found Angella in the corner by the window.

She'd been keeping an eye on her all day, watching her mother move through the crowd with that quiet careful way she had, and waiting for the moment to get her alone. It had been surprisingly difficult between her mother’s natural need to be a good hostess and Glimmer’s bout of needing to stay stuck to her wife’s side. She came up beside her and they stood together for a minute just looking at the warm scatter of lights across the tables, the roses Double Trouble had spent three weeks sourcing still holding up beautifully.

The words she’d meant to say slipped from her mind, and instead she tucked into her mother’s side to watch as Catra, Bow, and Adora helped Mr. Pop and Mrs. Baker clean up some of the larger and heavier items. The barrels, now empty of beer and whiskey but still heavy as all get out, were the current contenders. She felt exhausted as she sheltered there.

“It was a beautiful day,” Angella eventually said, slipping into the silence more than breaking it, “you’re father would be so proud of you both.”

The lump in her throat grew and grew then shrank and shrank. “Yeah, he would.”

“He would’ve loved this, poor thing hated a proper wedding as my family did it.” Angella snickered lightly at the memory. “He did a lot for me that day, but he would’ve loved the chance to have someone call it pompous and shot gunned, or whatever joke would’ve been best.”

Glimmer grinned, watching as the barrel slipped for a moment before Adora managed to catch it again with a loud cheer and attempted bow. The barrel stopped the attempt, forcing her into an awkward curtsey that Catra and Bow returned with a good laugh. She could picture her daddy there as well, laughing along and helping out. He probably would’ve said something by now to make them all groan in misery while he laughed at his own joke.

“He would’ve.” She agreed simply, enjoying the last of this moment of peace.

The house was quiet when they finally got home. Melog raised his head from the yard and then put it back down when Catra made a small sound at him. Scorpia and Entrapta had gone back to the inn in town instead of coming out to theirs, Adora had stayed to help with the last of the clean up, and Bow had hugged them both for an unreasonable amount of time before Catra finally extracted him off them both.

Catra pushed the door open and then turned around with a look that was just barely a dare.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

"Well," Catra said, "y'gonna carry me over the threshold or not, Miss Moon?"

"That is not how that-" Glimmer stopped. Reconsidered. The look on Catra's face was going to be the death of her. "You know what, fine." She grabbed Catra's hand and pulled hard enough to catch her off balance, and Catra yelped and grabbed on as they stumbled through the door together laughing too hard to be graceful about any of it.

"This is not-" Catra wheezed, "this is not how that's supposed to-"

"Hush." Glimmer kicked the door shut behind them. The house was warm and dark and smelled like home, like wood smoke and leather and something faintly sweet she'd never been able to name. She looked up at Catra in the low light and felt the same thing she'd been feeling all day, just sitting behind her sternum warm and quiet and sure. Like a lamp turned low. Like it had always been there. Like it always would be. "We're home."

Catra looked around the house. Back at her. Something in her expression went very still and very soft all at once.

"Yeah," she said. "We are."

She felt Catra’s hand find hers in the dark.

They'd done this before too. Stood in this house, in this room, learning what it meant to choose each other and keep choosing. A thousand small times and a handful of big ones. All of it adding up to this. To here. To Glimmer Moon, who had found her on the side of a road and hadn't quit her yet. To Catra D’riluth who’d held onto their love and hope when she couldn’t, who hadn’t given up on her even when she should have. And they’d just stood up in front of every person either of them had ever loved and said, out loud, that neither of them intended to give up any time soon.

"Hey," Glimmer said softly.

"Hey."

"You happy?"

Catra thought about it for exactly as long as it deserved, which was not very long at all.

"Yeah," she said. "I really am."

Glimmer smiled as she leaned in to kiss her, soft and gentle and sweet. “Me too.”

Chapter End Notes

> While I didn't end up including it, please know that Entrapta's wedding gift was fireworks which she gleefully set off for them during the celebrations :)

Chapter 25: Epilogue - A Glimpse of the Future

Chapter Summary

> One of the first things I wrote for this fic once it became a multi-chapter fic can finally be officially released, just a brief moment in an epilogue :)

“Well, well, well, look what the cat dragged in!” Glimmer cackled as she turned the radio down low, “You look like hell woman.”

Catra grinned smugly, still beautiful as hell despite the sunburn, hands spread out wide on either side of her face, “It’s amazing the abuses the human body can handle!”

“Oh shut up,” Glimmer still got up to give her a kiss and a hard tug to get her to lean down further.

“Hey, hey, hey!” Catra grabbed Glimmer’s hips and shook her lightly. “Careful with the goods sweetheart, who’ll get your dishes from the shelf if you break my back?”

Glimmer playfully punched at her stomach, no power behind the throws to protect her aching fingers. “I ain’t that short!”

“Hain’t that tall neither, now if you’ll excuse me young lady I need to exercise my senior citizen privileges!” Catra slipped out of her grip to sit down heavily on the couch, with an exaggerated sigh.

Glimmer glared and pushed Catra’s feet off the coffee table as she went back to her rocking chair. “You also ain’t that much older than me.”

“Now one day, you’ll be as old as I am-”

“Oh yes in two whole years-”

“And you will have the wisdom that comes with age!”

“I will hurt you D’riluth.”

“Darlin’ my heart is stone.”

“And to think you’d lie to me after all these years,” Glimmer sniffed haughtily, "despicable."

Catra grinned at her and winced as the radio crackled. “You finally broke?” The static grew for a moment between broadcasts before clearing once more. “Damn it.”

Glimmer would never understand Catra’s hatred of radio, and decided that, like most crotchety old folk, it was actually that she was losing her hearing and hated that instead. “Will you hush? Showboat’s about to start and I’d like to listen in peace.”

Catra rolled her eyes, but she couldn’t complain as it was the show she tolerated the most. “You enjoy pretending to be on some fancy boat, I’ll make us some supper then.” She stood with a grunt but leaned over to give Glimmer a kiss before grinning wickedly and pinched her cheek. “Sit her and look pretty for me, will ya?”

“Oh go cook your food, and do ME a favor and look pretty while you do it!”

Catra laughed as she retreated to the kitchen and Glimmer turned the radio back up just in time to catch the captain and first mate do their little back and forth, the sound of steam and noise before the opening tune began. Wife privileges may have grown after so many decades of marriage, but she was still in love enough to leave the sound low to grant Catra a little peace in her cooking.

She drifted along quite happily to the music until she was called to supper.

End Notes

CHECK OUT THIS AMAZING ART DONE BY

THERODRIGATOR6:
Glimmer breaking everyone's heart

The good ol' catch and release

All domestic like, huh?

Deputy Moon's tin type

Shooting lessons!

WEEZELNESS:
Lesbians? In /my/ barn? It's more likely than you think!

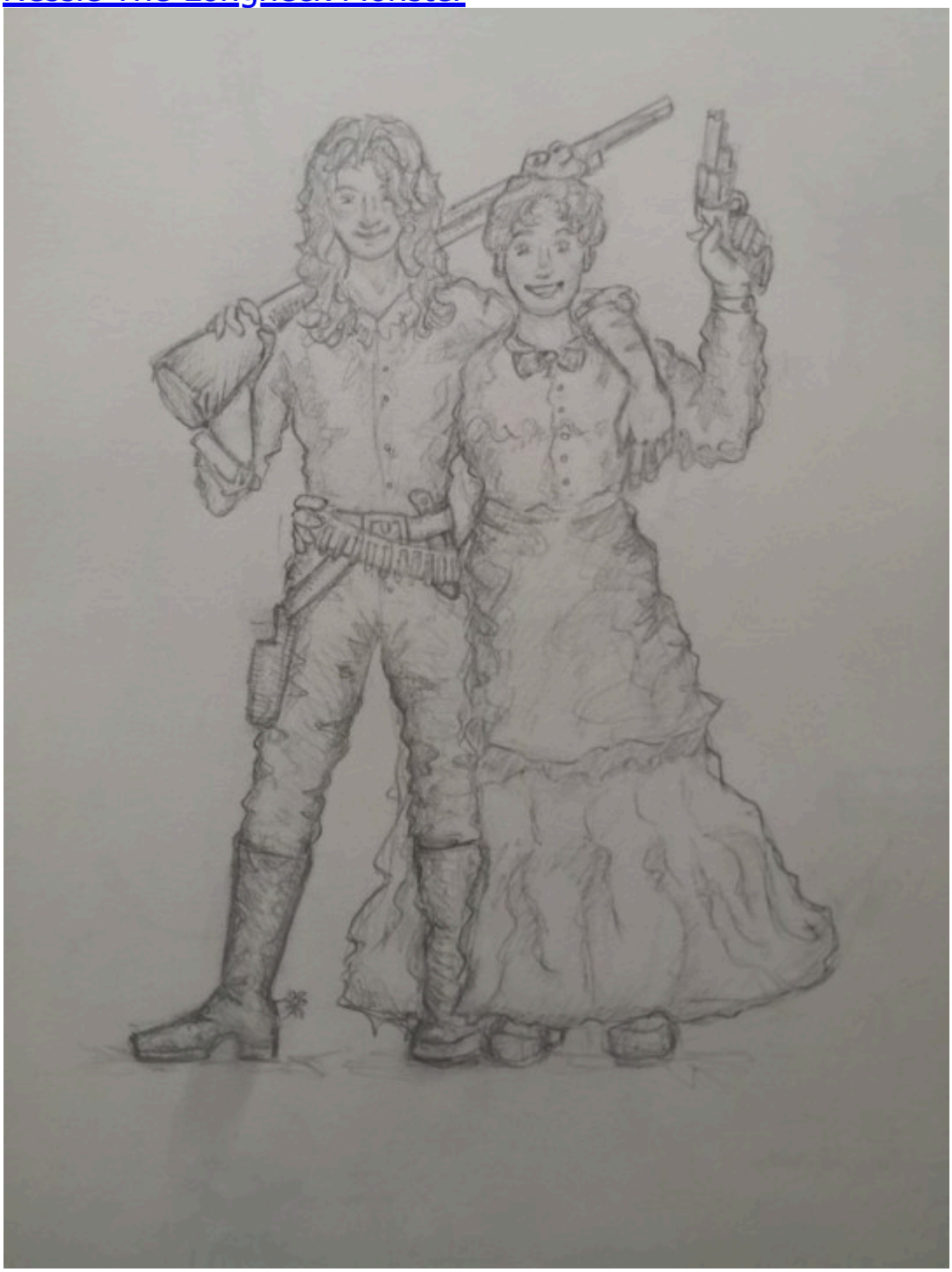
MAJORADORKUS:



BONPOP


LOVE YA TOO..

Nessie-The-Longneck-Monster



Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!